

WORLD CITY TRAVEL GUIDE

Europe · Asia · The Americas

182 cities from A to Z

Edition 2026

About This Guide

This guide describes 182 of the most popular travel destinations in Europe (62 cities), Asia including the Middle East (62 cities) and the Americas (58 cities). Cities are arranged alphabetically from A to Z, regardless of continent, and each city begins on a new page.

Every entry follows the same structure so that information is easy to find and compare: a short tagline, a key-facts box (country, region, population, languages, currency, main airport and best time to visit), followed by the sections Overview, Top Attractions, Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay, Food & Drink, When to Visit, Getting Around, Day Trips and Practical Tips.

Continents are colour-coded in the city headers: **blue** for Europe, **red** for Asia and **green** for the Americas. An index by continent and country is provided at the end of the book.

Important note: population figures are rounded approximations, and details such as opening hours, prices, ticketing rules, transport connections and entry requirements change frequently. Always verify practical information with official sources before travelling, and check your government's travel advisories for current safety information.

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Abu Dhabi

ASIA

United Arab Emirates · Middle East

The UAE's capital of grand mosques, world-class museums and desert adventures.

Country	United Arab Emirates
Region	Middle East
Population (approx.)	~1.6 million (city); ~3.8 million (emirate)
Language(s)	Arabic (English widely used)
Currency	UAE Dirham (AED)
Main airport	Zayed International Airport (AUH)
Best time to visit	November–March

■ Overview

Abu Dhabi is the capital of the United Arab Emirates and the largest of its seven emirates, built on an island in the Persian Gulf. Oil wealth transformed a small pearl-diving and fishing settlement into a modern city of skyscrapers, boulevards and cultural institutions within a few decades. Compared with neighbouring Dubai, Abu Dhabi feels calmer, greener and more focused on culture and heritage. Saadiyat Island is developing into a major cultural district with world-renowned museums. The emirate also includes the vast Empty Quarter desert and the oasis city of Al Ain.

■ Top Attractions

- **Sheikh Zayed Grand Mosque** – One of the largest mosques in the world, with 82 white marble domes, huge chandeliers and one of the world's largest hand-knotted carpets; entry is free but requires modest dress and online booking.
- **Louvre Abu Dhabi** – A museum designed by Jean Nouvel, known for its "rain of light" dome, presenting art from across civilisations.
- **Qasr Al Watan** – The Presidential Palace, open to visitors, with grand halls and exhibitions on Arab governance and science.
- **Yas Island** – Home to Ferrari World, Warner Bros. World, Yas Waterworld and the Yas Marina Formula 1 circuit.
- **Corniche** – An 8-kilometre waterfront promenade with beaches, parks and cycling paths.
- **Qasr Al Hosn** – The oldest stone building in the city, a former fort and royal residence, now a museum.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The Corniche and city centre offer convenient hotels near the beach and business districts. Saadiyat Island has luxury resorts and cultural attractions, while Yas Island is ideal for theme parks and families. Al Maryah and Al Reem Islands are modern districts with shopping malls and waterfront dining.

■ Food & Drink

Emirati cuisine includes machboos (spiced rice with meat or fish), harees (wheat and meat porridge) and luqaimat (sweet dumplings with date syrup). Arabic coffee (gahwa) with dates is a symbol of hospitality. The city has an enormous range of international restaurants, especially Indian, Lebanese and Pakistani. Alcohol is served mainly in hotel restaurants and licensed venues.

■ When to Visit

The best time to visit is from November to March, when temperatures are pleasant and outdoor activities are enjoyable. Summers are extremely hot and humid, often exceeding 40°C. The Formula 1 Abu Dhabi Grand Prix takes place in late November or December.

■ Getting Around

Taxis are affordable and the most common way to get around, and ride-hailing apps are widely used. Public buses are available, but the city is spread out and not very walkable in the heat. The drive to Dubai takes around 1.5 hours.

■ Day Trips

Al Ain, the "Garden City", has oases, forts, a zoo and Jebel Hafeet mountain. Desert safaris offer dune bashing, camel rides and dinners under the stars. The Liwa Oasis on the edge of the Empty Quarter has some of the world's highest sand dunes.

■ Practical Tips

- Dress modestly in public areas, especially at religious sites and government buildings.
- Public displays of affection and drinking alcohol in public are not allowed.
- During Ramadan, avoid eating or drinking in public during daylight hours.
- Carry water and use sun protection, even in winter.

Agra

India · South Asia

ASIA

Home of the Taj Mahal, the world's most famous monument to love.

Country	India
Region	South Asia
Population (approx.)	~1.8 million
Language(s)	Hindi
Currency	Indian Rupee (INR)
Main airport	Agra Airport (AGR) with limited flights; most visitors arrive via Delhi (DEL)
Best time to visit	October–March

■ Overview

Agra is a city in the northern Indian state of Uttar Pradesh, located on the banks of the Yamuna River. It was the capital of the Mughal Empire during the 16th and 17th centuries, when emperors built magnificent monuments. The city's star attraction is the Taj Mahal, built by Emperor Shah Jahan in memory of his wife Mumtaz Mahal. Agra has three UNESCO World Heritage Sites: the Taj Mahal, Agra Fort and nearby Fatehpur Sikri. Together with Delhi and Jaipur, it forms India's popular "Golden Triangle" route.

■ Top Attractions

- **Taj Mahal** – A white marble mausoleum completed in the mid-17th century, renowned for its symmetry and inlaid decorations; visit at sunrise for soft light and fewer crowds.
- **Agra Fort** – A massive red sandstone fortress and palace complex where Shah Jahan was imprisoned by his son, with views of the Taj.
- **Fatehpur Sikri** – A deserted Mughal city built by Emperor Akbar about 40 km from Agra, with palaces and the grand Jama Masjid.
- **Itmad-ud-Daulah's Tomb** – Often called the "Baby Taj", a delicate marble tomb that inspired the Taj Mahal.
- **Mehtab Bagh** – A garden across the river offering sunset views of the Taj Mahal.
- **Akbar's Tomb at Sikandra** – The mausoleum of Emperor Akbar, surrounded by gardens and deer.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Most visitors stay in the Taj Ganj area close to the Taj Mahal's eastern and southern gates, which has many budget and mid-range hotels with rooftop views. Luxury hotels are found along Fatehabad Road. The Sadar Bazaar area is a lively market district.

■ Food & Drink

Agra is famous for petha, a translucent sweet made from ash gourd, available in many flavours. Mughlai cuisine includes rich curries, kebabs and biryanis. Street foods like bedai (fried bread) with spicy potato curry and jalebi are popular breakfasts. Many rooftop restaurants in Taj Ganj offer views of the monument.

■ When to Visit

October to March offers the most comfortable weather for sightseeing. Summers (April-June) are extremely hot, while the monsoon (July-September) brings rain and humidity. Winter mornings can be foggy, sometimes obscuring the Taj Mahal at sunrise.

■ Getting Around

Auto-rickshaws, cycle-rickshaws and taxis are the main ways to get around. Electric vehicles are required near the Taj Mahal to reduce pollution. The Gatimaan Express and other trains connect Agra with Delhi in about two hours, and the Yamuna Expressway makes road travel fast.

■ Day Trips

Fatehpur Sikri is the most popular side trip. Mathura and Vrindavan, sacred Hindu towns associated with Lord Krishna, are about an hour away. Keoladeo National Park in Bharatpur is a renowned bird sanctuary.

■ Practical Tips

- The Taj Mahal is closed on Fridays.
- Buy tickets online and bring only essentials; large bags, food and tripods are not allowed.
- Hire licensed guides only and be cautious of touts.
- Foreign visitors pay higher entrance fees than Indian citizens.

Almaty

Kazakhstan · Central Asia

ASIA

Kazakhstan's green cultural capital at the foot of the snow-capped Tian Shan mountains.

Country	Kazakhstan
Region	Central Asia
Population (approx.)	~2.2 million
Language(s)	Kazakh and Russian
Currency	Kazakhstani Tenge (KZT)
Main airport	Almaty International Airport (ALA)
Best time to visit	May-June and September-October; December-March for skiing

■ Overview

Almaty is Kazakhstan's largest city and its former capital, set at the foot of the Trans-Ili Alatau range of the Tian Shan mountains. Its name is linked to apples, and the region is believed to be the ancestral home of the domestic apple. The city is leafy and spacious, with Soviet-era architecture, wide avenues, parks and a growing café and nightlife scene. Almaty is the gateway to spectacular mountain landscapes, canyons and lakes. It is one of Central Asia's most cosmopolitan cities.

■ Top Attractions

- **Medeu and Shymbulak** – A high-altitude ice-skating rink and a nearby ski resort reached by cable car, just 30 minutes from the city.
- **Kok-Tobe** – A hill with a cable car, amusement rides and panoramic views over the city.
- **Zenkov Cathedral** – A colourful wooden Orthodox cathedral in Panfilov Park, built without nails.
- **Green Bazaar** – A bustling market selling dried fruits, nuts, spices, horse meat and local cheeses.
- **Central State Museum of Kazakhstan** – Exhibitions on the country's history, from nomadic cultures to independence.
- **Big Almaty Lake** – A turquoise alpine lake in the mountains, about an hour's drive from the city.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The city centre around Panfilov Park, Arbat (Zhibek Zholy pedestrian street) and Abylai Khan Avenue is convenient. The Golden Square area has upscale hotels and restaurants. Areas to the south, closer to the mountains, are greener and quieter.

■ Food & Drink

Kazakh cuisine is meat-based and rooted in nomadic traditions: beshbarmak (boiled meat with noodles) is the national dish. Boursak (fried dough), plov (rice with meat) and manty (steamed dumplings) are common. Kumis (fermented mare's milk) and shubat (fermented camel's milk) are traditional drinks. Almaty also has good Korean, Uyghur and international restaurants.

■ When to Visit

Late spring and early autumn offer pleasant weather and colourful landscapes. Summers are warm and ideal for hiking. Winters are cold and snowy, great for skiing at Shymbulak.

■ Getting Around

Almaty has a metro line, buses and trolleybuses, but taxis and ride-hailing apps like Yandex Go are cheap and convenient. The city is laid out in a grid, making navigation easy. The mountains are clearly visible to the south, helping with orientation.

■ Day Trips

Charyn Canyon, often compared to a smaller Grand Canyon, is about three hours away. Kolsai and Kaindy lakes, including a lake with a submerged forest, are popular multi-day trips. Altyn-Emel National Park features the "Singing Dune".

■ Practical Tips

- Carry your passport, as police may ask for identification.
- Big Almaty Lake is a water reservoir; swimming is not allowed.
- Learn a few words of Russian, which is widely spoken.
- Check border zone permit requirements for some mountain areas.

Amman

Jordan · Middle East

ASIA

A hilly, welcoming capital of Roman ruins and the gateway to Petra and Wadi Rum.

Country	Jordan
Region	Middle East
Population (approx.)	~4 million (Greater Amman)
Language(s)	Arabic
Currency	Jordanian Dinar (JOD)
Main airport	Queen Alia International Airport (AMM)
Best time to visit	March–May and September–November

■ Overview

Amman, the capital of Jordan, is built on a series of hills (jebels) and is one of the oldest continuously inhabited cities in the world. Known in antiquity as Philadelphia, it was part of the Roman Decapolis, and ruins from that era still stand in the centre. The modern city is a mix of old souks, whitewashed buildings, trendy cafés and upscale districts. Jordanians are known for their hospitality. Amman is the starting point for exploring Petra, Wadi Rum, the Dead Sea and Jerash.

■ Top Attractions

- **Amman Citadel (Jabal al-Qal'a)** – A hilltop site with the Temple of Hercules, an Umayyad palace and views over the city.
- **Roman Theatre** – A 2nd-century theatre carved into the hillside, seating around 6,000 people.
- **Rainbow Street** – A lively street in Jabal Amman with cafés, restaurants and shops.
- **King Abdullah I Mosque** – A blue-domed mosque open to non-Muslim visitors.
- **Jordan Museum** – Home to some of the Dead Sea Scrolls and the ancient Ain Ghazal statues.
- **Downtown souks** – Markets for spices, gold, clothes and sweets.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Jabal Amman and Jabal al-Weibdeh are charming, walkable areas with cafés and galleries. Downtown (Al-Balad) is busy and budget-friendly. Abdoun and Sweifieh are upscale, modern districts.

■ Food & Drink

Jordan's national dish is mansaf, lamb cooked in fermented yoghurt sauce and served over rice. Falafel and hummus from Hashem restaurant downtown are legendary. Knafeh, a sweet cheese pastry soaked in syrup, is a favourite dessert. Tea with sage and Arabic coffee with cardamom are served everywhere.

■ When to Visit

Spring and autumn are the best seasons. Summers are hot but less humid than the Gulf, and winters can be cold, with occasional snow. Ramadan changes opening hours of restaurants.

■ Getting Around

Taxis are the most common way to get around; ride-hailing apps like Uber and Careem are widely used. The city is hilly and spread out, so walking between areas can be tiring. JETT buses connect Amman with Petra and Aqaba.

■ Day Trips

Jerash, one of the best-preserved Roman cities in the world, is under an hour away. The Dead Sea, the lowest point on Earth, offers floating in extremely salty water. Petra, Wadi Rum and Madaba (famous for Byzantine mosaics) are other key destinations.

■ Practical Tips

- The Jordan Pass waives the tourist visa fee for many nationalities (if you stay at least three nights) and includes entry to Petra and many sites.
- Dress modestly, especially outside upscale areas.
- Friday is the main day of rest, when many shops close.
- Check current travel advisories for the region before your trip.

Amsterdam

Netherlands · Western Europe

EUROPE

A city of canals, gabled houses, world-class museums and bicycles.

Country	Netherlands
Region	Western Europe
Population (approx.)	~930,000 (city); ~2.5 million (metro)
Language(s)	Dutch (English very widely spoken)
Currency	Euro (EUR)
Main airport	Amsterdam Airport Schiphol (AMS)
Best time to visit	April-May and September-October

■ Overview

Amsterdam is the capital of the Netherlands and one of Europe's most distinctive cities, built around a UNESCO-listed ring of 17th-century canals. The city grew rich during the Dutch Golden Age, when its merchants and the Dutch East India Company dominated global trade, and that wealth is still visible in the narrow, ornate canal houses. Today Amsterdam is known for its liberal culture, creative scene and relaxed pace of life. It is compact enough to explore on foot or by bike, and most major sights lie within or close to the canal belt. Visitors come for art, history, nightlife and the simple pleasure of wandering along the water.

■ Top Attractions

- **Rijksmuseum** – The national museum of the Netherlands holds masterpieces of the Dutch Golden Age, including Rembrandt's *The Night Watch* and several works by Vermeer.
- **Van Gogh Museum** – Home to the world's largest collection of Vincent van Gogh's paintings and letters, it traces his artistic development from dark early works to vivid late canvases.
- **Anne Frank House** – The canal-side building where Anne Frank and her family hid during the Second World War is now a moving museum; tickets are sold online only and sell out weeks ahead.
- **Canal Ring (Grachtengordel)** – The Herengracht, Keizersgracht and Prinsengracht are best explored on a canal cruise or on foot, especially at dusk when bridges are lit.
- **Jordaan** – A former working-class district of narrow streets, hidden courtyards (hofjes), independent shops, brown cafés and weekend markets.
- **Vondelpark** – The city's most popular park, perfect for cycling, picnics and people-watching on summer afternoons.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The Centrum and canal belt are the most convenient bases, though hotels there are expensive and small. De Pijp is lively and full of restaurants around the Albert Cuyp Market, while Oud-West and Amsterdam-Noord (reached by free ferry behind Centraal Station) offer a more local and creative atmosphere. The Museum Quarter is quieter and ideal for culture-focused travellers.

■ Food & Drink

Dutch classics include raw herring with onions, bitterballen (fried meat-ragout balls) served with mustard, stroopwafels and Dutch apple pie. Amsterdam's colonial history means Indonesian food is excellent here; try a rijsttafel, a feast of many small dishes. Brown cafés (bruine kroegen) serve local beer and jenever, the Dutch predecessor of gin. Food halls such as Foodhallen in Oud-West are good for casual meals.

■ When to Visit

Spring brings tulip season, with nearby Keukenhof gardens open from late March to mid-May, and King's Day on 27 April turns the city orange. Summer is busy and pleasant but crowded; autumn is quieter and often mild. Winters are grey and damp, but the Amsterdam Light Festival brightens the canals from December to January.

■ Getting Around

Trains connect Schiphol Airport to Amsterdam Centraal in about 15–20 minutes. Within the city, trams, metro, buses and ferries are run by GVB, and contactless bank cards can be used to tap in and out. Cycling is the local way to move around, but beginners should be careful of tram tracks and fast local riders.

■ Day Trips

Popular day trips include the windmills of Zaanse Schans, the historic fishing villages of Volendam and Marken, and the cities of Haarlem, Utrecht and Delft, all under an hour by train. In spring, Keukenhof and the flower fields around Lisse are a highlight.

■ Practical Tips

- Book the Anne Frank House, Van Gogh Museum and Rijksmuseum online well in advance.
- Never walk in the red-painted bike lanes; cyclists have priority and move fast.
- Consider staying in Haarlem or Utrecht to save money on accommodation.
- Tourist tax and hotel prices are high, so budget accordingly, especially in summer.

Antigua Guatemala

Guatemala · Central America

AMERICAS

A cobblestoned colonial gem surrounded by volcanoes.

Country	Guatemala
Region	Central America
Population (approx.)	~50,000
Language(s)	Spanish
Currency	Guatemalan Quetzal (GTQ)
Main airport	La Aurora International Airport (GUA) in Guatemala City, about 1 hour away
Best time to visit	November–April

■ Overview

Antigua Guatemala was the capital of the Spanish colonial Kingdom of Guatemala, which stretched across much of Central America, for over two centuries. After devastating earthquakes in 1773, the capital was moved to present-day Guatemala City, leaving Antigua's baroque churches and convents in picturesque ruins. The town's grid of cobbled streets, pastel-coloured houses and colonial architecture make it a UNESCO World Heritage Site. Three volcanoes – Agua, Fuego and Acatenango – dominate the skyline, and Fuego erupts regularly. Antigua is a popular base for Spanish-language schools, coffee tours and volcano hikes.

■ Top Attractions

- **Santa Catalina Arch** – A bright yellow arch with a clock tower framing Volcán de Agua, the town's most photographed landmark.
- **Central Park (Parque Central)** – The main square, surrounded by the cathedral, the Palace of the Captains General and colonial arcades.
- **La Merced Church** – An ornate yellow-and-white baroque church with a large fountain in its cloister.
- **Convent ruins** – Atmospheric ruins such as Las Capuchinas, Santo Domingo and San Francisco, partly damaged by earthquakes.
- **Cerro de la Cruz** – A hilltop viewpoint with a cross overlooking the town and Volcán de Agua.
- **Acatenango volcano hike** – A challenging overnight trek to camp opposite the erupting Volcán de Fuego.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Most hotels and guesthouses are within the central grid, a short walk from Central Park. Quieter areas lie on the outskirts, near coffee farms. Boutique hotels in restored colonial mansions offer atmospheric stays.

■ Food & Drink

Guatemalan dishes include pepián (a rich meat and vegetable stew), kak'ik (a spicy turkey soup) and tamales. Antigua has excellent cafés serving local coffee, one of the country's main exports. The local market offers cheap food and fresh produce. Chocolate workshops explain Mayan cacao traditions.

■ When to Visit

The dry season from November to April offers sunny days and clear volcano views. Semana Santa (Holy Week) is spectacular, with processions over colourful sawdust carpets (alfombras), but accommodation fills up fast. The rainy season (May–October) brings afternoon showers.

■ Getting Around

Antigua is small and walkable, but cobblestones can be uneven. Tuk-tuks and taxis are available for short trips. Shuttles connect Antigua with Guatemala City, Lake Atitlán and other destinations.

■ Day Trips

Lake Atitlán, surrounded by volcanoes and indigenous villages, is about 2.5–3 hours away. The Chichicastenango market is famous for its colourful textiles. Pacaya volcano offers an easier hike, and coffee farms around Antigua offer tours.

■ Practical Tips

- Hire a reputable guide for volcano hikes and bring warm clothes for Acatenango.
- Book Holy Week accommodation months in advance.
- Walk carefully on uneven cobblestones.
- Use registered shuttles and avoid travelling at night between cities.

Arequipa

Peru · South America

AMERICAS

Peru's "White City" of volcanic stone, set beneath snow-capped volcanoes.

Country	Peru
Region	South America
Population (approx.)	~1.1 million
Language(s)	Spanish
Currency	Peruvian Sol (PEN)
Main airport	Rodríguez Ballón International Airport (AQP)
Best time to visit	April–November

■ Overview

Arequipa, in southern Peru, is the country's second-largest city and is known as the "White City" because many of its colonial buildings are made of sillar, a white volcanic stone. The historic centre is a UNESCO World Heritage Site, with elegant churches, mansions and plazas. The city is framed by three volcanoes: El Misti, Chachani and Pichu Pichu. Arequipa has a strong regional identity and a proud culinary tradition. It is the gateway to the Colca Canyon, one of the deepest canyons in the world.

■ Top Attractions

- **Plaza de Armas** – One of Peru's most beautiful main squares, with the cathedral and arcades.
- **Santa Catalina Monastery** – A vast, colourful convent that functioned like a small city within the city for over 400 years.
- **Museo Santuarios Andinos** – Home to "Juanita", the Inca Ice Maiden, a mummy discovered on Mount Ampato.
- **Yanahuara viewpoint** – Sillar arches framing views of El Misti.
- **San Camilo Market** – A traditional market with fruit juices and local foods.
- **Mundo Alpaca** – A free exhibition on alpaca wool and weaving.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The historic centre is the best base. Yanahuara and Cayma are quieter residential districts nearby.

■ Food & Drink

Arequipa's picanterías serve rocoto relleno (stuffed spicy peppers), chupe de camarones (shrimp chowder), adobo arequipeño and queso helado, a local ice cream. Chicha de jora, a fermented corn drink, is traditional.

■ When to Visit

The dry season from April to November is best, with sunny days. The rainy season is mild but affects trips to Colca Canyon.

■ Getting Around

The centre is walkable. Taxis are cheap. Buses connect Arequipa with Puno, Cusco and Lima.

■ Day Trips

Colca Canyon, home to Andean condors, is a popular two-day trip. Hikers climb El Misti or Chachani with guides.

■ Practical Tips

- Adjust gradually to the altitude (about 2,300 m).
- Wear sun protection.
- Book Colca tours with reputable agencies.
- Try a traditional picantería for lunch.

Athens

Greece · Southern Europe

EUROPE

The cradle of Western civilisation, where ancient ruins meet a buzzing modern capital.

Country	Greece
Region	Southern Europe
Population (approx.)	~640,000 (city); ~3.7 million (metro)
Language(s)	Greek
Currency	Euro (EUR)
Main airport	Athens International Airport Eleftherios Venizelos (ATH)
Best time to visit	April-June and September-October

■ Overview

Athens is one of the oldest continuously inhabited cities in the world and the birthplace of democracy, philosophy and theatre. Its skyline is dominated by the Acropolis, a rocky hill crowned by the Parthenon, which has watched over the city for nearly 2,500 years. Around the ancient monuments lies a sprawling, energetic modern capital with rooftop bars, street art, lively markets and excellent food. Athens is also the main gateway to the Greek islands through the port of Piraeus. Many travellers spend two or three days here before heading to the Aegean, but the city rewards a longer stay.

■ Top Attractions

- **Acropolis and Parthenon** – The most important ancient site in Greece, including the Parthenon, the Erechtheion with its Caryatid porch, and the Temple of Athena Nike; arrive at opening time to avoid heat and crowds.
- **Acropolis Museum** – A modern museum at the foot of the hill displaying original sculptures from the Acropolis, with a top-floor gallery aligned with the Parthenon.
- **Ancient Agora** – The heart of ancient Athenian public life, featuring the remarkably preserved Temple of Hephaestus and the reconstructed Stoa of Attalos.
- **Plaka and Anafiotika** – The old neighbourhood beneath the Acropolis, with neoclassical houses, tavernas and the island-like whitewashed lanes of Anafiotika.
- **National Archaeological Museum** – One of the world's great museums of ancient art, home to the Mask of Agamemnon and the Antikythera Mechanism.
- **Lycabettus Hill** – The highest point in central Athens, reached on foot or by funicular, offers the best sunset views over the city and the sea.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Plaka and Monastiraki are central and atmospheric, ideal for first-time visitors. Koukaki, just south of the Acropolis, is quieter and popular with travellers who want a local feel. Psyrri and Exarchia are known for nightlife, street art and alternative culture, while Kolonaki is upscale, with boutiques and cafés.

■ Food & Drink

Greek cuisine in Athens ranges from simple street food to refined modern restaurants. Souvlaki and gyros are cheap and delicious, while tavernas serve moussaka, grilled fish, horiatiki (Greek salad) and meze with ouzo or local wine. The Central Market (Varvakios Agora) is a vivid place to see meat, fish and spice stalls. For dessert, try loukoumades, small fried dough balls with honey.

■ When to Visit

Spring and autumn offer warm, sunny weather ideal for sightseeing. July and August can be extremely hot, sometimes over 40°C, and archaeological sites may close at midday during heatwaves. Winters are mild and quiet, with lower prices, though some days are rainy.

■ Getting Around

The metro connects the airport to the city centre in about 40 minutes and serves most key sights, including Acropoli, Monastiraki and Syntagma stations. Central Athens is walkable, and a pedestrian promenade links many ancient sites. Taxis are relatively affordable, and ride-hailing apps work well.

■ Day Trips

The Temple of Poseidon at Cape Sounion is famous for sunsets over the Aegean. Delphi, the ancient sanctuary of Apollo, is about three hours away, and the island of Aegina can be reached by ferry from Piraeus in around an hour. The Peloponnese sites of Mycenae, Epidaurus and Nafplio make a great full-day tour.

■ Practical Tips

- A combined ticket covers the Acropolis and several other ancient sites and is valid for several days.
- Carry water and wear good shoes; marble paths on the Acropolis are slippery.
- Dinner in Athens is late; locals rarely eat before 9 pm.
- Many museums offer free entry on certain days in the low season.

Austin

AMERICAS

United States (Texas) · North America

The "Live Music Capital of the World", with barbecue, tech and a laid-back vibe.

Country	United States (Texas)
Region	North America
Population (approx.)	~980,000 (city); ~2.5 million (metro)
Language(s)	English
Currency	US Dollar (USD)
Main airport	Austin-Bergstrom International Airport (AUS)
Best time to visit	March-May and October-November

■ Overview

Austin, the capital of Texas, is known for its live music scene, creative culture and motto "Keep Austin Weird". The city has grown rapidly into a major technology hub, attracting companies and young professionals. Austin hosts major events such as South by Southwest (SXSW) and the Austin City Limits Music Festival. It combines Texan traditions with a liberal, outdoorsy lifestyle. The Colorado River and nearby Hill Country provide swimming, kayaking and hiking.

■ Top Attractions

- **Texas State Capitol** – A grand granite capitol building taller than the US Capitol, with free tours.
- **Sixth Street and Rainey Street** – Entertainment districts with bars and live music.
- **Lady Bird Lake** – A river reservoir for kayaking, paddleboarding and walking trails.
- **Congress Avenue Bridge bats** – The largest urban bat colony in North America emerges at dusk from spring to autumn.
- **Barton Springs Pool** – A spring-fed swimming pool at a constant temperature of around 20°C.
- **LBJ Presidential Library** – A museum on President Lyndon B. Johnson and the civil rights era.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Downtown is central to nightlife and sights. South Congress (SoCo) has boutiques, food trucks and music venues. East Austin is trendy, with bars and restaurants.

■ Food & Drink

Austin is famous for Texas barbecue, especially brisket; Franklin Barbecue is known for long queues. Tex-Mex, breakfast tacos and food trucks are everywhere.

■ When to Visit

Spring and autumn are ideal. Summers are very hot. SXSW takes place in March.

■ Getting Around

Austin is car-oriented, but downtown is walkable. Buses, scooters and ride-hailing apps are common.

■ Day Trips

The Texas Hill Country, with wineries and small towns like Fredericksburg, is nearby. San Antonio and its River Walk are about 1.5 hours away.

■ Practical Tips

- Book accommodation early during SXSW and ACL.
- Arrive early for popular barbecue spots.
- Stay hydrated in summer.
- Check event calendars for live music.

Baku

Azerbaijan · Caucasus

ASIA

The "City of Winds", mixing a medieval walled city with futuristic skyscrapers on the Caspian Sea.

Country	Azerbaijan
Region	Caucasus
Population (approx.)	~2.3 million
Language(s)	Azerbaijani
Currency	Azerbaijani Manat (AZN)
Main airport	Heydar Aliyev International Airport (GYD)
Best time to visit	April-June and September-October

■ Overview

Baku, the capital of Azerbaijan, lies on the western shore of the Caspian Sea. Its fortunes were transformed by oil, first in a boom in the late 19th century and again after independence. The walled old city, Icherisheher, is a UNESCO World Heritage Site, while the skyline features bold modern architecture such as the Flame Towers. Baku is known for its strong winds, seaside boulevard and hospitality. It blends Persian, Russian, Turkic and European influences.

■ Top Attractions

- **Icherisheher (Old City)** – Narrow lanes, caravanserais, mosques and the Palace of the Shirvanshahs within medieval walls.
- **Maiden Tower** – A mysterious 12th-century tower with a museum and views over the Old City.
- **Flame Towers** – Three flame-shaped skyscrapers that light up at night with LED displays.
- **Heydar Aliyev Center** – A flowing, futuristic building designed by Zaha Hadid, hosting exhibitions.
- **Baku Boulevard** – A long seaside promenade with parks, cafés and the Carpet Museum.
- **Yanar Dag and Ateshgah** – A hillside with natural gas flames burning continuously and a fire temple used by Zoroastrians and Hindus.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Staying in or near the Old City and Fountain Square is best for sightseeing. The boulevard area offers sea views and luxury hotels. Nizami Street is the main shopping and pedestrian street.

■ Food & Drink

Azerbaijani cuisine includes plov (saffron rice with meat and dried fruit), dolma, kebabs and qutab (thin stuffed flatbreads). Tea culture is strong, often served with jam and sweets. Pakhlava and shekerbura are traditional pastries. Local wines and brandies are available.

■ When to Visit

Spring and autumn are the most pleasant seasons. Summers are hot and windy, while winters are cold and windy. The Formula 1 Azerbaijan Grand Prix takes place on a street circuit around the Old City.

■ Getting Around

Baku has a metro, buses and cheap taxis; use ride-hailing apps like Bolt or Uber. The Old City and boulevard are walkable. The airport express bus connects with the city centre.

■ Day Trips

Gobustan National Park has prehistoric rock carvings and mud volcanoes. The Absheron Peninsula has fire temples and beaches. Sheki, with its Khan's Palace, is a longer trip into the Caucasus foothills.

■ Practical Tips

- Apply for an e-visa online before travelling if required.
- Check current border and travel conditions if planning to visit neighbouring countries.
- Dress modestly when visiting mosques.
- Bring a jacket for the strong winds.

Bali (Denpasar)

Indonesia · Southeast Asia

ASIA

The "Island of the Gods", famous for temples, rice terraces, surf and spiritual culture.

Country	Indonesia
Region	Southeast Asia
Population (approx.)	~730,000 (Denpasar); ~4.4 million (Bali province)
Language(s)	Indonesian and Balinese
Currency	Indonesian Rupiah (IDR)
Main airport	I Gusti Ngurah Rai International Airport (DPS)
Best time to visit	April–October (dry season)

■ Overview

Bali is an Indonesian island east of Java, and Denpasar is its capital and main urban centre. Unlike most of Indonesia, Bali is predominantly Hindu, and daily life revolves around temples, offerings and ceremonies. The island offers a remarkable variety of experiences, from surfing and beach clubs to yoga retreats, volcano hikes and rice terraces. Areas like Ubud, Seminyak, Canggu and Uluwatu each have distinct atmospheres. Tourism has grown enormously, so choosing the right base is important.

■ Top Attractions

- **Ubud** – The cultural heart of Bali, with art markets, the Sacred Monkey Forest Sanctuary, traditional dance performances and nearby rice terraces.
- **Tegallalang and Jatiluwih rice terraces** – Stunning terraced landscapes; Jatiluwih is part of a UNESCO-listed subak irrigation system.
- **Uluwatu Temple** – A clifftop temple with sunset Kecak fire dances.
- **Tanah Lot** – A temple on a rock in the sea, especially popular at sunset.
- **Mount Batur** – An active volcano with a popular sunrise trek.
- **Besakih Temple** – The "Mother Temple", Bali's most important Hindu temple, on the slopes of Mount Agung.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Seminyak is upscale, with boutiques and beach clubs, while Canggu is popular with surfers and digital nomads. Ubud suits culture lovers and wellness seekers, Uluwatu offers dramatic cliffs and surf, and Sanur and Nusa Dua are quieter and family-friendly.

■ Food & Drink

Balinese dishes include babi guling (suckling pig), bebek betutu (slow-cooked duck), sate lilit and lawar. Nasi campur, rice with a variety of small dishes, is everywhere. Warungs (small local eateries) offer cheap, tasty meals. Bali also has a large café culture with smoothie bowls and specialty coffee.

■ When to Visit

The dry season from April to October is best for beaches and hiking. The wet season (November–March) brings heavy showers, but fewer crowds. Nyepi, the Balinese Day of Silence, shuts down the entire island, including the airport, for 24 hours.

■ Getting Around

Traffic is heavy, and there is limited public transport. Private drivers, taxis and ride-hailing apps such as Grab and Gojek are common. Many visitors rent scooters, but this is risky without experience and an appropriate licence.

■ Day Trips

The Nusa Islands (Nusa Penida, Lembongan) are reached by fast boat and feature dramatic cliffs and snorkelling. The Gili Islands and Lombok are further by boat. Munduk and the north coast offer waterfalls and quieter villages.

■ Practical Tips

- Bali charges a tourist levy for foreign visitors; pay it online before arrival.
- Dress respectfully at temples, wearing a sarong and sash.
- Do not step on offerings placed on the ground.
- Drink bottled or filtered water.

Banff

Canada (Alberta) · North America

AMERICAS

A mountain town in Canada's first national park, surrounded by turquoise lakes.

Country	Canada (Alberta)
Region	North America
Population (approx.)	~8,300 (town)
Language(s)	English (French also official in Canada)
Currency	Canadian Dollar (CAD)
Main airport	Calgary International Airport (YYC), about 1.5 hours away
Best time to visit	June–September; December–March for skiing

■ Overview

Banff is a resort town in Banff National Park, Canada's first national park, established in 1885 in the Canadian Rockies. The park is part of the Canadian Rocky Mountain Parks UNESCO World Heritage Site. Banff is famous for glacier-fed turquoise lakes, dramatic peaks, hot springs and wildlife such as elk, bears and bighorn sheep. It is a year-round destination for hiking, skiing and scenic drives. The town has shops, restaurants and hotels, including the historic Fairmont Banff Springs.

■ Top Attractions

- **Lake Louise** – A turquoise lake beneath the Victoria Glacier.
- **Moraine Lake** – A stunning lake in the Valley of the Ten Peaks, accessible by shuttle.
- **Banff Gondola** – A gondola up Sulphur Mountain.
- **Banff Upper Hot Springs** – Natural hot spring pools.
- **Icefields Parkway** – One of the world's most scenic drives.
- **Johnston Canyon** – A canyon walk to waterfalls.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Staying in Banff town is convenient. Canmore, just outside the park, is cheaper.

■ Food & Drink

Banff offers Canadian dishes like Alberta beef, bison burgers and poutine.

■ When to Visit

Summer is ideal for hiking. Winter brings skiing at Sunshine Village and Lake Louise.

■ **Getting Around**

Roam Transit buses and Parks Canada shuttles are available. Private vehicles cannot drive to Moraine Lake.

■ **Day Trips**

Jasper, Yoho National Park and Kootenay National Park are nearby.

■ **Practical Tips**

- Buy a Parks Canada pass.
- Book shuttles to Moraine Lake and Lake Louise.
- Carry bear spray on hikes.
- Book accommodation early.

Bangkok

Thailand · Southeast Asia

ASIA

A dazzling, chaotic capital of golden temples, street food and river life.

Country	Thailand
Region	Southeast Asia
Population (approx.)	~10.5 million (city); ~17 million (metro)
Language(s)	Thai
Currency	Thai Baht (THB)
Main airport	Suvarnabhumi Airport (BKK); Don Mueang International Airport (DMK)
Best time to visit	November–February

■ Overview

Bangkok, the capital of Thailand, is one of the world's most visited cities. Its Thai name, Krung Thep, means "City of Angels", and the full ceremonial name is one of the longest place names in the world. The city combines ornate temples and royal palaces with shiny skyscrapers, floating markets, rooftop bars and legendary street food. Bangkok is chaotic, hot and exciting, but also efficient and welcoming. It is the gateway to Thailand's beaches, islands and northern mountains.

■ Top Attractions

- **Grand Palace and Wat Phra Kaew** – The former royal residence and the Temple of the Emerald Buddha, Thailand's most sacred temple.
- **Wat Pho** – Home to a 46-metre reclining Buddha and a traditional Thai massage school.
- **Wat Arun** – The Temple of Dawn on the Chao Phraya River, decorated with porcelain.
- **Chatuchak Weekend Market** – One of the world's largest markets, with thousands of stalls.
- **Chao Phraya River** – Ride the river express boats to see temples and riverside life.
- **Chinatown (Yaowarat)** – A bustling district famous for street food at night.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Sukhumvit is modern, with hotels, restaurants and nightlife, and well served by the BTS Skytrain. Silom and Sathorn are business districts with rooftop bars, while Riverside offers luxury hotels. The old town (Rattanakosin) and Banglamphu, including Khao San Road, are close to the main temples.

■ Food & Drink

Bangkok is one of the world's great food cities. Try pad thai, tom yum goong, green curry, som tam (papaya salad) and mango sticky rice. Street food stalls are everywhere, and some have Michelin recognition. Night markets and food courts in malls offer affordable options.

■ When to Visit

The cool, dry season from November to February is the most pleasant. March to May is extremely hot, and the rainy season runs from June to October. Songkran, the Thai New Year in mid-April, is celebrated with a huge water fight.

■ Getting Around

The BTS Skytrain and MRT subway avoid traffic jams. River boats and canal boats are cheap and scenic. Taxis and ride-hailing apps (Grab, Bolt) are affordable, and the Airport Rail Link connects Suvarnabhumi with the city.

■ Day Trips

Ayutthaya, the former capital with temple ruins, is about 1.5 hours away. Floating markets such as Damnoen Saduak and the Maeklong Railway Market are popular. Kanchanaburi has the Bridge on the River Kwai and waterfalls.

■ Practical Tips

- Dress modestly at temples (cover shoulders and knees).
- Beware of scams, such as people claiming the Grand Palace is closed.
- Show respect for the monarchy; criticising the royal family is illegal.
- Drink bottled water and stay hydrated.

Barcelona

Spain · Southern Europe

EUROPE

Gaudí's masterpieces, Mediterranean beaches and a vibrant Catalan culture.

Country	Spain
Region	Southern Europe
Population (approx.)	~1.65 million (city); ~5.6 million (metro)
Language(s)	Catalan and Spanish
Currency	Euro (EUR)
Main airport	Josep Tarradellas Barcelona-El Prat Airport (BCN)
Best time to visit	May-June and September-October

■ Overview

Barcelona, the capital of Catalonia, is one of Europe's most visited cities and a unique blend of Gothic history, modernist architecture and seaside lifestyle. The city is famous for the work of Antoni Gaudí, whose extraordinary buildings define its skyline. It has a strong Catalan identity, with its own language, festivals and cuisine.

Barcelona combines a walkable old town, a grid-planned 19th-century district called the Eixample, and several kilometres of urban beaches. Its food, nightlife and football club FC Barcelona draw visitors all year round.

■ Top Attractions

- **Sagrada Família** – Gaudí's monumental basilica, under construction since 1882, is the city's defining landmark; its forest-like interior and stained glass are unforgettable.
- **Park Güell** – A whimsical hillside park designed by Gaudí, with colourful mosaic benches, gingerbread-like pavilions and views over the city.
- **Gothic Quarter (Barri Gòtic)** – A maze of medieval streets around Barcelona Cathedral, with Roman remains, hidden squares and small bars.
- **Casa Batlló and Casa Milà (La Pedrera)** – Two of Gaudí's most famous houses on Passeig de Gràcia, known for their organic shapes and rooftop terraces.
- **La Rambla and La Boqueria** – The famous boulevard leads to the Boqueria market, a riot of fruit, ham and seafood stalls, though the area is very touristy.
- **Montjuïc** – A hill with gardens, the Olympic stadium, the Joan Miró Foundation, the National Art Museum of Catalonia and a castle overlooking the port.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The Eixample is central, elegant and well connected, while El Born is trendy, with boutiques, cocktail bars and the Picasso Museum. Gràcia has a village-like atmosphere with lively squares, and Barceloneta is the traditional beach neighbourhood. Poblenou is a former industrial area turned creative district, close to quieter beaches.

■ Food & Drink

Catalan cuisine includes *pa amb tomàquet* (bread rubbed with tomato and olive oil), *escalivada*, *fideuà* and *crema catalana*. Tapas bars are everywhere, and seafood *paella* is best eaten near the sea at lunchtime. Vermouth (*vermut*) before lunch on weekends is a local ritual. Lunch is usually eaten between 2 and 4 pm, and dinner rarely before 9 pm.

■ When to Visit

Late spring and early autumn offer warm weather and swimmable sea without the peak summer crowds. July and August are hot, humid and very busy. The *Festa de la Mercè* in late September features human towers (*castells*), fire runs and concerts, while *Sant Joan* on 23 June is celebrated with fireworks and beach parties.

■ Getting Around

The metro is fast and covers the city well, and the *Aerobús* and train link the airport to the centre. The city is walkable, and the Bicing bike-share is for residents, but many private rental shops exist. Taxis are plentiful and reasonably priced.

■ Day Trips

Montserrat, a mountain monastery with dramatic rock formations, is about an hour away by train and cable car. Girona offers a beautiful medieval old town, and the seaside town of Sitges is famous for beaches and festivals. The Dalí Theatre-Museum in Figueres is a must for fans of surrealism.

■ Practical Tips

- Book Sagrada Família, Park Güell and Casa Batlló tickets online in advance with a timed slot.
- Pickpocketing is common on La Rambla, the metro and beaches; keep valuables secure.
- Respect residents: many neighbourhoods are sensitive about mass tourism.
- Visit the Sagrada Família in the late afternoon for the best light through the stained glass.

Bariloche

Argentina · South America

AMERICAS

Argentina's alpine lake district of chocolate shops, forests and ski slopes.

Country	Argentina
Region	South America
Population (approx.)	~135,000
Language(s)	Spanish
Currency	Argentine Peso (ARS)
Main airport	San Carlos de Bariloche International Airport (BRC)
Best time to visit	December–March for summer; July–September for skiing

■ Overview

San Carlos de Bariloche sits on the southern shore of Nahuel Huapi Lake in the foothills of the Andes, in Argentina's Patagonian Lake District. Founded by European immigrants, especially from Switzerland, Germany and Italy, it has an alpine-style architecture of stone and wood. The town is the gateway to Nahuel Huapi National Park, Argentina's oldest national park. Bariloche is famous for chocolate, craft beer, hiking in summer and skiing in winter. It is one of Argentina's most popular domestic destinations.

■ Top Attractions

- **Cerro Campanario** – A chairlift to a viewpoint rated among the best in the world, overlooking lakes and mountains.
- **Circuito Chico** – A scenic 60-kilometre loop drive or bike ride past lakes, forests and the Llao Llao Hotel.
- **Cerro Catedral** – One of South America's largest ski resorts, with summer hiking and mountain biking.
- **Centro Cívico** – The town's main square with stone buildings in alpine style.
- **Isla Victoria and Bosque de Arrayanes** – A boat trip to an island and a forest of cinnamon-coloured myrtle trees.
- **Refugio Frey** – A popular hike to a mountain hut surrounded by granite spires.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The town centre is convenient for restaurants and shops. Hotels and cabins along the road to Llao Llao offer lake views and nature.

■ Food & Drink

Bariloche is famous for chocolate shops such as Rapa Nui and Mamuschka. Patagonian lamb (cordero patagónico), trout and smoked meats are specialities. The region has many craft breweries.

■ When to Visit

Summer (December–March) is best for hiking and lakes. Winter (July–September) brings skiing. Autumn offers beautiful colours.

■ Getting Around

Local buses reach major sights, but renting a car or bike is convenient. Flights connect Bariloche with Buenos Aires.

■ Day Trips

The Route of the Seven Lakes leads to San Martín de los Andes. El Bolsón is a hippie town with a craft market. Cerro Tronador offers glaciers.

■ Practical Tips

- Book ski season accommodation early.
- Weather changes quickly in the mountains.
- Carry cash; exchange rates in Argentina fluctuate.
- Try chocolate from several shops.

Beijing

China · East Asia

ASIA

China's imperial capital, home to the Forbidden City and the Great Wall.

Country	China
Region	East Asia
Population (approx.)	~21.8 million
Language(s)	Mandarin Chinese
Currency	Chinese Yuan Renminbi (CNY)
Main airport	Beijing Capital International (PEK); Beijing Daxing International (PKX)
Best time to visit	April-May and September-October

■ Overview

Beijing, the capital of China, has been the political heart of the country for most of the past eight centuries. It was the seat of the Ming and Qing dynasties, which left behind palaces, temples and gardens of extraordinary scale. The city blends ancient traditions with modern development, from narrow hutong alleys to futuristic architecture. Beijing is the best base for visiting the Great Wall. It hosted the Summer Olympics in 2008 and the Winter Olympics in 2022.

■ Top Attractions

- **Forbidden City (Palace Museum)** – The vast imperial palace complex with nearly 1,000 buildings; tickets must be booked online with a passport.
- **Great Wall of China** – Sections such as Mutianyu and Badaling are within easy reach, while Jinshanling and Jiankou offer wilder hiking.
- **Temple of Heaven** – A beautiful complex where emperors prayed for good harvests.
- **Summer Palace** – A royal garden with lakes, pavilions and the Long Corridor.
- **Tiananmen Square** – One of the largest public squares in the world; security checks and advance registration may be required.
- **Hutongs** – Traditional alleyways, best explored by bike or rickshaw, especially around Nanluoguxiang and Shichahai.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Dongcheng is central and close to the Forbidden City and hutongs. Chaoyang is modern, with the Central Business District, embassies and nightlife in Sanlitun. Xicheng is historic, with lakes and hutongs.

■ Food & Drink

Peking duck, served with pancakes, spring onions and sweet sauce, is Beijing's most famous dish. Other favourites include zhajiangmian (noodles with fermented soybean paste), jiaozi (dumplings) and jianbing (a savoury crepe for breakfast). Hot pot and food from across China are widely available. Street food snacks are found in markets.

■ When to Visit

Spring and autumn are the most pleasant seasons. Summers are hot and humid, and winters are cold and dry. Avoid national holidays like the Golden Week in early October, when crowds are enormous.

■ Getting Around

Beijing has an extensive subway system. Taxis are available, and ride-hailing apps like DiDi work well. Airport express trains connect both airports with the city. Mobile payment apps like Alipay and WeChat Pay are essential; both now accept many foreign cards.

■ Day Trips

The Great Wall is the most popular day trip. The Ming Tombs are often combined with the Great Wall. Tianjin is 30 minutes away by high-speed train.

■ Practical Tips

- Carry your passport at all times; it is needed for tickets and security checks.
- Set up Alipay or WeChat Pay before travelling.
- Many foreign websites and apps are blocked; plan for internet access.
- Book popular attractions several days in advance.

Belgrade

Serbia · Southeastern Europe

EUROPE

A gritty, energetic Balkan capital famed for its fortress and legendary nightlife.

Country	Serbia
Region	Southeastern Europe
Population (approx.)	~1.2 million (city); ~1.7 million (metro)
Language(s)	Serbian
Currency	Serbian Dinar (RSD)
Main airport	Belgrade Nikola Tesla Airport (BEG)
Best time to visit	May-June and September-October

■ Overview

Belgrade sits at the confluence of the Sava and Danube rivers and is one of the oldest cities in Europe, having been destroyed and rebuilt dozens of times over its long history. As the capital of Serbia, it mixes Ottoman, Austro-Hungarian, socialist and modern architecture in a chaotic but charming way. The city is famous for its hospitality, café culture and energetic nightlife, including floating river clubs known as splavovi. Prices are lower than in Western Europe, making it popular with budget travellers. Belgrade is increasingly a hub for digital nomads and creative industries.

■ Top Attractions

- **Belgrade Fortress and Kalemegdan Park** – A vast fortress complex above the river confluence with walls, gates, museums and superb sunset views.
- **Knez Mihailova Street** – The main pedestrian street, lined with 19th-century buildings, shops and cafés, linking the fortress with Republic Square.
- **Church of Saint Sava** – One of the largest Orthodox churches in the world, with a spectacular gold-mosaic interior.
- **Skadarlija** – A cobbled bohemian quarter with traditional kafanas (taverns), live folk music and hearty Serbian food.
- **Museum of Yugoslavia and House of Flowers** – The mausoleum of Josip Broz Tito and exhibitions on the history of Yugoslavia.
- **Zemun** – A former Austro-Hungarian town on the Danube with fish restaurants, riverside walks and the Gardoš Tower.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Stari Grad (Old Town) is the most convenient base, close to Knez Mihailova and the fortress. Dorćol has trendy cafés and bars, while Savamala is a former warehouse district known for nightlife. Vračar is residential and pleasant, near the Church of Saint Sava.

■ Food & Drink

Serbian food is meat-heavy and generous: try ćevapi (grilled minced-meat sausages), pljeskavica (a large spiced patty), sarma (stuffed cabbage leaves) and kajmak, a rich dairy spread. Burek is the classic breakfast, often with drinking yoghurt. Rakija, a fruit brandy, is offered as a welcome drink. Kafanas provide an authentic dining experience with live music.

■ When to Visit

Spring and early autumn are ideal for walking and river activities. Summers are hot, but the river islands and beach at Ada Ciganlija offer relief, and the floating clubs are at their best. Winters are cold, though the city's cafés and restaurants remain lively.

■ Getting Around

Buses, trams and trolleybuses cover the city, and central areas are walkable. Taxis are affordable, but use official taxis or apps such as CarGo or Yandex to avoid overcharging. The airport is about 30 minutes from the centre by bus or taxi.

■ Day Trips

Novi Sad, Serbia's second city with the Petrovaradin Fortress, is about an hour away by high-speed train. The monasteries of Fruška Gora and the wine town of Sremski Karlovci make a good combined trip. The Golubac Fortress and Iron Gates gorge on the Danube are further but spectacular.

■ Practical Tips

- Cash is still widely used, although cards are accepted in most restaurants.
- Smoking is still common in some cafés and bars.
- Nightlife starts late; clubs rarely fill up before midnight.
- Carry your passport, as police may ask for identification.

Bengaluru

India · South Asia

ASIA

India's "Silicon Valley", a garden city of pubs, palaces and a mild climate.

Country	India
Region	South Asia
Population (approx.)	~13 million (metro)
Language(s)	Kannada (English widely spoken)
Currency	Indian Rupee (INR)
Main airport	Kempegowda International Airport (BLR)
Best time to visit	October–February

■ Overview

Bengaluru (Bangalore), the capital of Karnataka in southern India, is the country's leading technology hub. Its elevated location on the Deccan Plateau gives it a pleasant climate year-round compared with most Indian cities. Known as the "Garden City" for its parks and tree-lined avenues, Bengaluru has grown rapidly into a sprawling metropolis. It has a cosmopolitan, young population and India's best craft beer scene. The city is also a gateway to Mysuru, Hampi and the hills of Coorg.

■ Top Attractions

- **Bangalore Palace** – A Tudor-style palace inspired by Windsor Castle, with ornate interiors.
- **Lalbagh Botanical Garden** – A historic garden with a glasshouse and flower shows around Independence Day and Republic Day.
- **Cubbon Park** – A large green space in the centre, surrounded by colonial buildings.
- **Tipu Sultan's Summer Palace** – A teak palace of the 18th-century ruler of Mysore.
- **ISKCON Temple** – A large, modern Hindu temple complex dedicated to Krishna.
- **Vidhana Soudha** – The grand neo-Dravidian building housing the state legislature, beautifully lit on Sundays and holidays.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

MG Road and Brigade Road are central shopping and nightlife areas. Indiranagar and Koramangala are trendy, with restaurants, cafés and breweries. Malleswaram and Basavanagudi are traditional, with temples and South Indian eateries.

■ Food & Drink

Bengaluru is famous for South Indian breakfasts like masala dosa, idli, vada and filter coffee, served at institutions such as MTR and Vidyarthi Bhavan. Bisi bele bath and ragi mudde are local dishes. The city has dozens of microbreweries. Street food lanes such as VV Puram Food Street are popular in the evenings.

■ When to Visit

The weather is pleasant most of the year, but October to February is especially comfortable. The monsoon brings rain from June to September. Summers are warm but milder than in northern India.

■ Getting Around

The Namma Metro network is expanding and helps avoid notorious traffic jams. Auto-rickshaws and ride-hailing apps like Uber, Ola and Rapido are widely used. The airport is far from the centre, so allow at least an hour.

■ Day Trips

Mysuru, with its spectacular palace, is about three hours away. Nandi Hills is popular for sunrise views. Hampi, Coorg (Kodagu) and the temples of Belur and Halebidu make longer trips.

■ Practical Tips

- Traffic is heavy; plan travel outside rush hours.
- Pubs and bars often close relatively early.
- Carry cash for small vendors, although UPI mobile payments dominate.
- Dress modestly in temples and remove shoes.

Bergen

Norway · Northern Europe

EUROPE

Norway's colourful harbour city and the gateway to the western fjords.

Country	Norway
Region	Northern Europe
Population (approx.)	~290,000
Language(s)	Norwegian
Currency	Norwegian Krone (NOK)
Main airport	Bergen Airport Flesland (BGO)
Best time to visit	May–September

■ Overview

Bergen is Norway's second-largest city, surrounded by seven mountains and located on the country's rugged west coast. It was once a major trading post of the Hanseatic League, and its colourful wooden warehouses on the Bryggen wharf are a UNESCO World Heritage Site. The city has a lively student population, a strong music and art scene and a reputation as one of the rainiest cities in Europe. Bergen is the main starting point for trips into the fjords, including the Sognefjord and Hardangerfjord. Despite its small size, it offers a rich mix of culture and nature.

■ Top Attractions

- **Bryggen** – The historic Hanseatic wharf with narrow wooden alleys, craft shops and the Hanseatic Museum.
- **Mount Fløyen** – A funicular (Fløibanen) climbs to a viewpoint above the city, with hiking trails and forest lakes at the top.
- **Mount Ulriken** – The highest of Bergen's mountains, reached by cable car, with spectacular views and a popular ridge hike to Fløyen.
- **Fish Market (Fisketorget)** – A harbour-side market selling seafood, fish soup and snacks, especially lively in summer.
- **KODE Art Museums** – A group of museums with works by Edvard Munch and Norwegian artists, and exhibitions dedicated to composer Edvard Grieg.
- **Troldhaugen** – The former home of Edvard Grieg, with a museum and concert hall overlooking a lake.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The area around Bryggen and Vågen harbour is central and scenic. Nordnes is a quiet peninsula with old wooden houses and the Bergen Aquarium, while Sandviken offers charming streets further along the harbour. Most visitors stay within walking distance of the centre.

■ Food & Drink

Seafood dominates Bergen's cuisine, especially salmon, shrimp, cod and the creamy Bergen fish soup (Bergensk fiskesuppe). Skillingsboller, large cinnamon buns, are a local favourite. Eating out is expensive, so many travellers mix restaurant meals with market snacks and supermarket picnics.

■ When to Visit

Summer offers long days, mild temperatures and the best conditions for fjord trips and hiking. Rain is common year-round, so a waterproof jacket is essential. Winter is dark and wet in the city but magical in December with the world's largest gingerbread town exhibition.

■ Getting Around

The city centre is compact and walkable, and a light rail line (Bybanen) connects the centre with the airport in about 45 minutes. Ferries and express boats run to fjord destinations. The Bergen Line railway to Oslo is one of the most scenic train journeys in Europe.

■ Day Trips

The Norway in a Nutshell route combines the Bergen Line, the Flåm Railway and a cruise on the narrow Nærøyfjord in one day. Hardangerfjord is known for orchards, waterfalls and the Trolltunga hike. Boat trips to the Osterfjord and Mostraumen are shorter alternatives.

■ Practical Tips

- Pack rain gear regardless of the season.
- Buy the Bergen Card for discounts on museums and public transport.
- Book Norway in a Nutshell tickets in advance in summer.
- Alcohol is expensive and sold in supermarkets only until evening; stronger drinks are sold in state-run Vinmonopolet shops.

Berlin

Germany · Central Europe

EUROPE

A creative, historic capital where 20th-century history is written on every street.

Country	Germany
Region	Central Europe
Population (approx.)	~3.8 million (city); ~6 million (metro)
Language(s)	German
Currency	Euro (EUR)
Main airport	Berlin Brandenburg Airport (BER)
Best time to visit	May–September

■ Overview

Berlin is Germany's capital and largest city, a place shaped by Prussian grandeur, the tragedy of the Nazi era, the division of the Cold War and the euphoria of reunification in 1990. Today it is one of Europe's most creative and tolerant cities, known for its art, music, clubs and alternative culture. The city is spread out and green, with many lakes, parks and distinct neighbourhoods, each with its own character. History is everywhere, from the remains of the Berlin Wall to thoughtful memorials. Berlin is relatively affordable for a Western European capital and rewards visitors who explore beyond the main sights.

■ Top Attractions

- **Brandenburg Gate** – The neoclassical gate is the symbol of German reunification and stands at the end of Unter den Linden boulevard.
- **Reichstag Building** – The German parliament features a glass dome by Norman Foster; entry to the dome is free but must be booked online.
- **Museum Island** – A UNESCO-listed complex of five museums, including the Pergamon Museum and the Neues Museum with the bust of Nefertiti.
- **East Side Gallery** – The longest surviving section of the Berlin Wall, covered with murals by international artists.
- **Memorial to the Murdered Jews of Europe** – A field of 2,711 concrete slabs near the Brandenburg Gate, with an information centre beneath.
- **Berlin Wall Memorial (Bernauer Strasse)** – The best place to understand how the Wall divided the city, with a preserved border strip and viewing tower.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Mitte is central and full of major sights. Kreuzberg and Neukölln are multicultural and known for nightlife, street food and alternative culture. Prenzlauer Berg is leafy and family-friendly, with cafés and restored buildings, while Charlottenburg in the west is elegant and home to Charlottenburg Palace.

■ Food & Drink

Berlin's signature snack is currywurst, a sliced sausage with curry ketchup, while the döner kebab was popularised here by Turkish immigrants. The city has an outstanding international food scene, including many vegetarian and vegan restaurants. Beer gardens and weekend markets like Markthalle Neun are popular. Breakfast and brunch culture is strong, often served until late afternoon.

■ When to Visit

Late spring and summer are the best time, with long evenings, open-air cinemas, lake swimming and beer gardens. Winters are cold and grey, but Christmas markets bring festive charm in December. Major events include the Berlin International Film Festival (Berlinale) in February and the Berlin Marathon in September.

■ Getting Around

Berlin has an extensive U-Bahn, S-Bahn, tram and bus network, and the airport is connected by train in about 30 minutes. Tickets must be validated before travel. The city is flat and bike-friendly, with many rental options.

■ Day Trips

Potsdam, with the Sanssouci Palace and gardens, is under an hour away. The Sachsenhausen Concentration Camp Memorial offers a sobering history lesson. The Spreewald, a network of canals and forests, is popular for boat and kayak trips.

■ Practical Tips

- Some shops and cafés still accept cash only, although cards are increasingly common.
- Most shops are closed on Sundays, except at major stations.
- Famous clubs like Berghain have strict and unpredictable door policies.
- A Welcome Card combines public transport and museum discounts.

Bogotá

Colombia · South America

AMERICAS

Colombia's high-altitude capital of gold, graffiti and colonial charm.

Country	Colombia
Region	South America
Population (approx.)	~7.9 million (city); ~11 million (metro)
Language(s)	Spanish
Currency	Colombian Peso (COP)
Main airport	El Dorado International Airport (BOG)
Best time to visit	December–March and July–August

■ Overview

Bogotá, the capital of Colombia, sits on a plateau in the Andes at around 2,640 metres above sea level. Founded by the Spanish in 1538, it has a historic centre, La Candelaria, with colonial houses, churches and museums. Bogotá has transformed in recent decades into a dynamic, cultural city with a strong arts scene, cycling culture and excellent restaurants. The climate is cool year-round, often described as "eternal autumn". The city is the gateway to Colombia's diverse regions.

■ Top Attractions

- **Gold Museum (Museo del Oro)** – One of the world's largest collections of pre-Hispanic gold.
- **La Candelaria** – The historic centre, with colourful houses, street art and museums.
- **Monserate** – A mountain with a church and views over the city, reached by cable car or funicular.
- **Botero Museum** – A free museum showing works by Fernando Botero.
- **Plaza de Bolívar** – The main square with the cathedral and government buildings.
- **Graffiti tours** – Guided tours of the city's vibrant street art.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

La Candelaria is historic but quiet at night. Chapinero and Zona G are trendy, with restaurants, while Zona T and Parque 93 are upscale nightlife areas. Usaquén has a Sunday flea market.

■ Food & Drink

Ajiaco, a chicken and potato soup, is Bogotá's signature dish. Arepas, empanadas and tamales are common. Colombian coffee is excellent. Andrés Carne de Res, outside the city, is a famous party restaurant.

■ When to Visit

Bogotá has a mild climate year-round, with rainy seasons in April–May and October–November. Ciclovía closes main roads to cars on Sundays for cyclists.

■ Getting Around

TransMilenio buses are extensive but crowded. Taxis and ride-hailing apps are common. The first metro line is under construction.

■ Day Trips

The Salt Cathedral of Zipaquirá is an underground church in a salt mine. Villa de Leyva is a colonial town. Guatavita Lake is linked to the El Dorado legend.

■ Practical Tips

- Allow time to adjust to the altitude.
- Use ride-hailing apps rather than hailing taxis on the street.
- Bring layers for the changeable weather.
- Keep valuables secure.

Bologna

Italy · Southern Europe

EUROPE

Italy's culinary capital, with medieval towers and endless porticoes.

Country	Italy
Region	Southern Europe
Population (approx.)	~390,000 (city); ~1 million (metro)
Language(s)	Italian
Currency	Euro (EUR)
Main airport	Bologna Guglielmo Marconi Airport (BLQ)
Best time to visit	April-June and September-October

■ Overview

Bologna, the capital of the Emilia-Romagna region, is nicknamed "la dotta, la grassa, la rossa" – the learned, the fat and the red. It is home to the oldest university in the Western world, founded in 1088, has a legendary food culture, and features red-brick buildings and historically left-wing politics. The city's nearly 40 kilometres of porticoes, covered walkways, are a UNESCO World Heritage Site. Bologna is less crowded than Florence or Venice, making it a relaxed and authentic Italian city break. It is also an excellent base for exploring the food towns of the region.

■ Top Attractions

- **Piazza Maggiore** – The main square, surrounded by the Basilica of San Petronio, Palazzo d'Accursio and the Fountain of Neptune.
- **Two Towers (Asinelli and Garisenda)** – Medieval leaning towers that symbolise Bologna; access to Asinelli has been restricted during stabilisation works, so check before visiting.
- **Archiginnasio** – The historic seat of the university, with an anatomical theatre carved in wood and walls covered with coats of arms.
- **Portico di San Luca** – The world's longest portico climbs about 3.8 km to the Sanctuary of the Madonna di San Luca, with views over the hills.
- **Quadrilatero** – A medieval market district full of delis, fresh pasta shops and wine bars.
- **Basilica of Santo Stefano** – A complex of interconnected churches known as the Seven Churches, among the oldest in the city.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The historic centre is compact, and staying near Piazza Maggiore puts everything within walking distance. The university quarter around Via Zamboni is lively and student-filled, while Santo Stefano is elegant and calm. The Bolognina area north of the station is more local and affordable.

■ Food & Drink

Bologna gave the world mortadella, tortellini in broth and tagliatelle al ragù, the true version of what outsiders call "spaghetti bolognese". Lasagne verdi and crescentine (fried dough) with cured meats are also local favourites. The region produces Parmigiano Reggiano, Prosciutto di Parma and traditional balsamic vinegar of Modena. Aperitivo with a glass of Lambrusco or Pignoletto is a daily ritual.

■ When to Visit

Spring and autumn are the most pleasant seasons for walking and eating. Summers are hot and humid, and some restaurants close in August. Winters are foggy and cold but perfect for hearty pasta dishes.

■ Getting Around

The centre is best explored on foot, with buses for longer trips. The Marconi Express monorail connects the airport and central station in about 7 minutes. Bologna is a major rail hub, with fast trains to Florence (around 35 minutes), Milan and Venice.

■ Day Trips

Modena (balsamic vinegar and Ferrari), Parma (ham and cheese) and Ravenna (Byzantine mosaics) are all easy train trips. Food tours visiting Parmigiano Reggiano dairies are very popular. Florence is close enough for a day trip by high-speed train.

■ Practical Tips

- Many restaurants close on Sunday evenings or Mondays; check opening hours.
- Book food tours to cheese and balsamic producers in advance.
- The historic centre has limited traffic zones (ZTL) where driving is restricted.
- Walk under the porticoes to stay dry in rain and cool in summer.

Bordeaux

France · Western Europe

EUROPE

An elegant riverside city at the heart of the world's most famous wine region.

Country	France
Region	Western Europe
Population (approx.)	~260,000 (city); ~1 million (metro)
Language(s)	French
Currency	Euro (EUR)
Main airport	Bordeaux-Mérignac Airport (BOD)
Best time to visit	May-June and September-October

■ Overview

Bordeaux is a graceful port city on the Garonne River in southwestern France, renowned for its 18th-century architecture and its wine. Much of the city centre, known as the Port of the Moon, is a UNESCO World Heritage Site. Over the past two decades, Bordeaux has transformed its riverfront, cleaned its limestone façades and introduced trams, becoming one of France's most liveable cities. It is the gateway to famous wine appellations such as Saint-Émilion, Médoc and Pessac-Léognan. The city also offers excellent museums, restaurants and shopping.

■ Top Attractions

- **Place de la Bourse and the Water Mirror** – An elegant 18th-century square facing a shallow reflecting pool, the most photographed spot in the city.
- **La Cité du Vin** – A striking modern museum dedicated to wine cultures worldwide, including a tasting at the panoramic top floor.
- **Saint-André Cathedral and Pey-Berland Tower** – A Gothic cathedral with a separate bell tower offering views over the rooftops.
- **Rue Sainte-Catherine** – One of Europe's longest pedestrian shopping streets.
- **Grand Théâtre** – A neoclassical opera house considered one of the finest in France.
- **Bassins des Lumières** – A former submarine base turned into a large digital art centre with immersive projections.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The historic centre around Saint-Pierre and the Golden Triangle is elegant and convenient. Chartrons, the former wine merchants' district, has antique shops, cafés and a Sunday market. Saint-Michel is multicultural and lively, while Bastide on the right bank offers views back to the old city.

■ Food & Drink

Bordeaux cuisine includes entrecôte à la bordelaise (steak in red wine sauce), oysters from nearby Arcachon Bay and canelés, small caramelised pastries flavoured with rum and vanilla. The Marché des Capucins is the city's main food market. Wine bars offer tastings of local reds, dry whites and sweet Sauternes.

■ When to Visit

Spring and early autumn are ideal, and the grape harvest usually takes place in September and October. The Bordeaux Wine Festival is held in June in some years. Summers are warm and sunny, but August can be quiet as locals go on holiday.

■ Getting Around

The tram network is modern and efficient, and the centre is pleasant to explore on foot or by bike. The high-speed TGV connects Bordeaux with Paris in about 2 hours. Buses and shuttles link the airport to the city centre.

■ Day Trips

The medieval village of Saint-Émilion, surrounded by vineyards, is a UNESCO site and easy to reach by train. The Médoc wine route passes famous châteaux such as Margaux and Pauillac. Arcachon Bay and the Dune of Pilat, the tallest sand dune in Europe, are about an hour away.

■ Practical Tips

- Many châteaux require advance booking for tours and tastings.
- Rent a bike and ride along the riverside quays.
- Oysters with white wine at the Marché des Capucins is a classic Saturday morning experience.
- Consider the Bordeaux CityPass for transport and museum entry.

Boston

AMERICAS

United States (Massachusetts) · North America

A historic city of revolutionary history, universities and sports passion.

Country	United States (Massachusetts)
Region	North America
Population (approx.)	~650,000 (city); ~4.9 million (metro)
Language(s)	English
Currency	US Dollar (USD)
Main airport	Logan International Airport (BOS)
Best time to visit	May–October

■ Overview

Boston, the capital of Massachusetts, is one of the oldest cities in the United States, founded in 1630 by Puritan settlers. It played a central role in the American Revolution, with events such as the Boston Tea Party and the battles of Lexington and Concord. Boston is a leading centre of education and research, home to Harvard and MIT in neighbouring Cambridge. The city is compact and walkable, with brick streets, historic neighbourhoods and waterfront views. Bostonians are passionate about sports, especially the Red Sox.

■ Top Attractions

- **Freedom Trail** – A 4-kilometre walking trail linking 16 historic sites.
- **Boston Common and Public Garden** – America's oldest public park and a garden with swan boats.
- **Fenway Park** – The oldest Major League Baseball stadium, home of the Red Sox.
- **Museum of Fine Arts** – One of the largest art museums in the US.
- **Harvard University** – Tours of the campus in Cambridge.
- **Faneuil Hall and Quincy Market** – A historic market with food stalls.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Back Bay is elegant, with brownstones and shopping on Newbury Street. Beacon Hill is historic, with gas lamps, and the North End is Boston's Little Italy. Seaport is modern.

■ Food & Drink

New England clam chowder, lobster rolls and oysters are must-tries. Cannoli from the North End are famous. Boston cream pie originated here.

■ When to Visit

Summer and autumn are ideal, with fall foliage in October. Winters are cold and snowy.

■ Getting Around

The "T" subway system covers the city. The city is walkable.

■ Day Trips

Salem, Cape Cod, Plymouth and Lexington/Concord are popular.

■ Practical Tips

- Book hotels early during university graduations.
- Walk the Freedom Trail with a guide.
- Try a lobster roll.
- Check the Red Sox schedule.

Bratislava

Slovakia · Central Europe

EUROPE

A compact Danube capital with a charming old town and a hilltop castle.

Country	Slovakia
Region	Central Europe
Population (approx.)	~480,000
Language(s)	Slovak
Currency	Euro (EUR)
Main airport	M. R. Štefánik Airport (BTS); Vienna International Airport (VIE) is about 1 hour away
Best time to visit	May–September

■ Overview

Bratislava, the capital of Slovakia, lies on the Danube River close to the borders of Austria and Hungary. For centuries it was known as Pressburg or Pozsony and served as the coronation city of Hungarian kings. Its small, pedestrian-friendly old town is full of pastel buildings, quirky bronze statues and cafés. Bratislava is often visited as a day trip from Vienna, but staying overnight lets you enjoy its relaxed atmosphere and lower prices. The city combines historic charm with bold socialist-era architecture.

■ Top Attractions

- **Bratislava Castle** – A rectangular white castle with four corner towers sits on a hill above the Danube, housing a museum and offering wide views.
- **Old Town (Staré Mesto)** – Cobbled streets, the Main Square, the Old Town Hall and statues such as Čumil, a bronze worker peering out of a manhole.
- **St. Martin's Cathedral** – The Gothic coronation church of Hungarian kings, topped by a gilded replica of the crown.
- **Blue Church (Church of St. Elizabeth)** – An Art Nouveau church painted entirely in pale blue, one of the city's most photographed buildings.
- **UFO Tower (Most SNP)** – A bridge with a flying-saucer-shaped observation deck and restaurant high above the Danube.
- **Devín Castle** – Dramatic ruins on a cliff at the confluence of the Morava and Danube rivers, a short bus or boat ride from the centre.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Staying in or near the Old Town is best for first-time visitors. The riverside Eurovea and Sky Park areas are modern, with shopping and new apartments. Petržalka, across the river, is a huge socialist housing estate offering cheaper accommodation.

■ Food & Drink

Slovak cuisine is hearty; the national dish is bryndzové halušky, potato dumplings with sheep's cheese and bacon. Kapustnica, a sauerkraut soup, is popular in winter. The Small Carpathians wine region produces good white wines, and local beers are inexpensive. Bratislava rožky, crescent-shaped pastries filled with walnut or poppy seed, make a good souvenir.

■ When to Visit

Late spring through early autumn is ideal for walking and riverside cafés. Summer brings open-air concerts and festivals. December's Christmas markets on the Main Square are charming and less crowded than those in Vienna.

■ Getting Around

The Old Town is compact and walkable. Trams and buses cover the rest of the city, and tickets must be validated. Frequent trains, buses and summer boats connect Bratislava with Vienna in about an hour.

■ Day Trips

The Small Carpathian wine towns of Pezinok and Modra are easy to reach. Čachtice Castle and Trenčín further north offer medieval history. Vienna and Győr in Hungary are both close enough for a day trip.

■ Practical Tips

- One or two days are enough to see the main sights.
- Take the Danube boat from Vienna for a scenic arrival in summer.
- Many restaurants in the Old Town are geared towards tourists; walk a few streets away for better value.
- The Bratislava City Card includes public transport and a walking tour.

Bruges

Belgium · Western Europe

EUROPE

A fairy-tale medieval city of canals, belfries and chocolate shops.

Country	Belgium
Region	Western Europe
Population (approx.)	~120,000
Language(s)	Dutch (Flemish)
Currency	Euro (EUR)
Main airport	Brussels Airport (BRU), about 1.5 hours by train
Best time to visit	April-June and September; December for Christmas markets

■ Overview

Bruges is one of Europe's best-preserved medieval cities, a UNESCO World Heritage Site in the Flanders region of Belgium. In the Middle Ages it was one of the richest trading cities in Europe thanks to the cloth trade, before its access to the sea silted up and the city fell into a long sleep. That decline froze its streets in time, leaving cobbled lanes, canals and brick gables almost untouched. Today Bruges is a romantic destination famous for chocolate, beer, lace and Flemish Primitive art. It is small and very popular, so staying overnight lets you enjoy it after day-trippers leave.

■ Top Attractions

- **Markt and Belfry** – The central square is dominated by the 83-metre Belfry; climb its 366 steps for views across the rooftops.
- **Burg Square** – Home to the Gothic City Hall and the Basilica of the Holy Blood, which houses a revered relic.
- **Canal boat tour** – Short boat trips through the canals offer the classic views of Bruges.
- **Groeninge Museum** – A collection of Flemish Primitive masterpieces by Jan van Eyck and Hans Memling.
- **Begijnhof and Minnewater** – A tranquil 13th-century beguinage with white houses and a lake known as the Lake of Love.
- **Church of Our Lady** – Its brick spire is one of the tallest in Belgium, and it holds Michelangelo's Madonna and Child.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Almost all visitors stay inside the old town ring, which is small and walkable. The area around Markt is central but busy, while the St. Anna quarter to the east is quieter and more residential. Guesthouses and B&Bs are plentiful.

■ Food & Drink

Bruges is famous for Belgian chocolate, with dozens of chocolatiers in the centre. Moules-frites (mussels and fries), Flemish beef stew (stoofvlees) and waffles are local staples. The De Halve Maan brewery produces the local Brugse Zot beer and even pumps beer through an underground pipeline. Frites from a stand near the Markt are a classic snack.

■ When to Visit

Spring and early autumn offer pleasant weather and fewer crowds than summer. Weekends and summer holidays can be extremely busy. December brings Christmas markets and an ice-skating rink, creating a festive atmosphere.

■ Getting Around

Bruges is best explored on foot or by bike. The train station is a 15–20 minute walk from the Markt, with frequent buses. Direct trains connect Bruges with Brussels, Ghent and Brussels Airport.

■ Day Trips

Ghent, a lively university city with its own impressive medieval centre and the Ghent Altarpiece, is just 25 minutes away. The seaside town of Knokke-Heist and the fishing village of Damme, reachable by bike along a canal, are other options. The First World War battlefields around Ypres (Ieper) are about an hour away.

■ Practical Tips

- Visit early in the morning or in the evening to enjoy the city without crowds.
- Buy chocolate from smaller artisan shops rather than chains.
- Rent a bike to ride along the canals to Damme.
- Wear comfortable shoes; cobblestones are uneven.

Brussels

Belgium · Western Europe

EUROPE

The capital of Europe, famous for the Grand-Place, comics, beer and chocolate.

Country	Belgium
Region	Western Europe
Population (approx.)	~1.2 million (Brussels-Capital Region)
Language(s)	French and Dutch
Currency	Euro (EUR)
Main airport	Brussels Airport (BRU); Brussels South Charleroi Airport (CRL)
Best time to visit	April-June and September-October

■ Overview

Brussels is the capital of Belgium and the de facto capital of the European Union, hosting the European Commission, Council and Parliament. It is a bilingual, multicultural city where French and Dutch are both official. Beyond its political role, Brussels is known for its stunning Grand-Place, Art Nouveau architecture, comic-strip culture and exceptional food and beer. The city can seem chaotic at first, but it rewards visitors with a relaxed, quirky charm. It is also an excellent base for day trips to Bruges, Ghent and Antwerp.

■ Top Attractions

- **Grand-Place** – One of the most beautiful squares in the world, surrounded by ornate guildhalls and the Gothic Town Hall; every two years it is covered in a flower carpet.
- **Manneken Pis** – A tiny bronze statue of a urinating boy, often dressed in costumes, and a beloved symbol of the city's humour.
- **Atomium** – A giant model of an iron crystal built for the 1958 World's Fair, with exhibitions and a panoramic viewing sphere.
- **Royal Museums of Fine Arts and Magritte Museum** – Collections ranging from Flemish masters to Belgian surrealism.
- **Comic Strip Route and Belgian Comic Strip Center** – Murals across the city and a museum celebrating Tintin, the Smurfs and other Belgian comics.
- **European Quarter and Parliamentarium** – A free visitor centre explaining how the European Parliament works.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The area around the Grand-Place and Sainte-Catherine is central and lively. Ixelles and Saint-Gilles are popular for Art Nouveau buildings, bars and restaurants, while the Sablon is elegant, with antique shops and chocolatiers. The Marolles district has a daily flea market on Place du Jeu de Balle.

■ Food & Drink

Brussels is a paradise for food lovers: try moules-frites, waffles (the lighter Brussels waffle or the sweeter Liège waffle), stoemp and carbonnade flamande, a beef and beer stew. Frites are served with a wide choice of sauces from friteries. The city has hundreds of Belgian beers, from Trappist ales to sour lambics and gueuzes brewed nearby. Chocolate houses such as Pierre Marcolini, Neuhaus and Wittamer are world-famous.

■ When to Visit

Spring and early autumn are the most pleasant times, though rain is possible year-round. The Flower Carpet takes place in August of even-numbered years. Winter brings the Winter Wonders Christmas market and light shows on the Grand-Place.

■ Getting Around

Metro, trams and buses are run by STIB/MIVB, and contactless cards can be used. The centre is walkable, though hilly between the lower and upper town. Trains from the airport reach Brussels Central in about 20 minutes, and Eurostar and high-speed trains link Brussels with Paris, London, Amsterdam and Cologne.

■ Day Trips

Bruges, Ghent, Antwerp and Leuven are all within an hour by train. The Waterloo battlefield, site of Napoleon's defeat in 1815, lies just south of the city. Dinant and the Ardennes offer castles and nature.

■ Practical Tips

- Avoid overpriced restaurants on Rue des Bouchers near the Grand-Place.
- Visit Delirium Café or a traditional estaminet to sample Belgian beers.
- Watch your belongings around major stations.
- The Brussels Card offers entry to many museums.

Bucharest

Romania · Southeastern Europe

EUROPE

A city of grand boulevards, belle époque villas and monumental communist architecture.

Country	Romania
Region	Southeastern Europe
Population (approx.)	~1.7 million (city); ~2.3 million (metro)
Language(s)	Romanian
Currency	Romanian Leu (RON)
Main airport	Henri Coandă International Airport (OTP)
Best time to visit	April-June and September-October

■ Overview

Bucharest is the capital and largest city of Romania, once nicknamed the "Little Paris of the East" for its elegant boulevards and belle époque buildings. Its history is layered, from Ottoman-era inns and Orthodox churches to the enormous projects of dictator Nicolae Ceaușescu. After the 1989 revolution, the city has become a dynamic, creative capital with a thriving café and nightlife scene. Bucharest is affordable compared with most European capitals. It is also a gateway to Transylvania and the Carpathian Mountains.

■ Top Attractions

- **Palace of the Parliament** – One of the largest administrative buildings in the world, built under Ceaușescu; guided tours require identification and advance booking.
- **Old Town (Lipscani)** – A historic district of narrow streets packed with bars, restaurants and churches.
- **Stavropoleos Monastery** – A small, exquisite 18th-century church with ornate carvings and a peaceful courtyard.
- **Romanian Athenaeum** – A beautiful domed concert hall and home of the George Enescu Philharmonic.
- **Village Museum** – An open-air museum in Herăstrău (King Michael I) Park with traditional houses, churches and windmills from across Romania.
- **Calea Victoriei** – The city's most elegant avenue, lined with palaces, museums and the Revolution Square.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The Old Town and University area are central but can be noisy at night. Cotroceni and the areas around Dorobanți and Floreasca are leafy and upscale. Piața Romană and the area around Calea Victoriei offer a convenient balance of location and atmosphere.

■ Food & Drink

Romanian food includes sarmale (cabbage rolls with minced meat), mici (grilled skinless sausages), ciorbă (sour soups) and mămăligă (polenta). Papanasi, fried doughnuts with sour cream and jam, are a must-try dessert. Caru' cu Bere, a historic beer hall, is famous for its décor. Romanian wines, such as Fetească Neagră, are increasingly well regarded.

■ When to Visit

Spring and autumn are pleasant and colourful. Summers can be very hot, while winters are cold and sometimes snowy. The George Enescu Festival, a major classical music event, takes place in late summer of odd-numbered years.

■ Getting Around

Bucharest has a metro network and many buses and trams. The airport is about 30–45 minutes from the centre by train, bus or taxi. Use ride-hailing apps such as Bolt or Uber to avoid taxi scams.

■ Day Trips

Snagov Monastery, said to be Vlad the Impaler's burial place, lies on a lake north of the city. Mogoșoaia Palace is a beautiful Brâncovenesc-style palace nearby. Longer trips reach Brașov, Bran Castle and Peleș Castle in the Carpathians, about 2.5–3 hours away.

■ Practical Tips

- Book the Palace of the Parliament tour in advance and bring your passport.
- Traffic is heavy; the metro is often the fastest option.
- Stray dogs are now rare, but be cautious in outlying areas.
- Tipping around 10% is customary in restaurants.

Budapest

Hungary · Central Europe

EUROPE

The "Pearl of the Danube", famed for thermal baths, grand architecture and ruin bars.

Country	Hungary
Region	Central Europe
Population (approx.)	~1.7 million (city); ~3 million (metro)
Language(s)	Hungarian
Currency	Hungarian Forint (HUF)
Main airport	Budapest Ferenc Liszt International Airport (BUD)
Best time to visit	April-June and September-October

■ Overview

Budapest, the capital of Hungary, is one of Europe's most beautiful cities, split by the Danube into hilly Buda and flat, bustling Pest. The city was officially formed in 1873 by uniting Buda, Óbuda and Pest, and its golden age during the Austro-Hungarian Empire produced grand boulevards and landmarks. Budapest is famous for its natural hot springs, which feed historic bathhouses. It combines imperial architecture, a dramatic riverside panorama and a vibrant nightlife. Budapest is excellent value compared with Western European capitals.

■ Top Attractions

- **Hungarian Parliament Building** – A Gothic Revival masterpiece on the Danube and one of the largest parliament buildings in the world; guided tours show the Holy Crown.
- **Buda Castle and Castle District** – The royal palace houses the Hungarian National Gallery, while the medieval district includes Matthias Church and Fisherman's Bastion.
- **Széchenyi and Gellért Baths** – Iconic thermal baths; Széchenyi is known for its huge outdoor pools and Gellért for its Art Nouveau interiors.
- **St. Stephen's Basilica** – The largest church in Budapest, with a dome offering panoramic views.
- **Ruin bars** – Bars in abandoned buildings of the Jewish Quarter, led by Szimpla Kert, the most famous.
- **Danube cruise and Chain Bridge** – Evening river cruises reveal the illuminated Parliament and castle.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

District V (Belváros-Lipótváros) is central and close to the Parliament and river. District VII, the Jewish Quarter, is the nightlife hub. District VI around Andrásy Avenue is elegant, while Buda offers quieter streets and views.

■ Food & Drink

Hungarian cuisine is rich and paprika-flavoured: try goulash (gulyás) soup, chicken paprikash, lángos (fried dough with sour cream and cheese) and stuffed peppers. The Great Market Hall is a good place for local products. Chimney cake (kürtőskalács) and Dobos torte are popular sweets. Hungary produces famous wines, including sweet Tokaji, and pálinka, a fruit brandy.

■ When to Visit

Spring and autumn are the best times for sightseeing. Summer brings festivals such as Sziget, one of Europe's largest music festivals, held on an island in the Danube in August. Winter is cold, but Christmas markets and steaming outdoor baths are memorable.

■ Getting Around

Budapest has an extensive metro, tram and bus network; tram line 2 along the Danube is especially scenic. The 100E bus connects the airport with the city centre. Tickets must be validated, and inspectors are strict.

■ Day Trips

The Danube Bend towns of Szentendre, Visegrád and Esztergom are reachable by train, bus or boat. Lake Balaton, Central Europe's largest lake, is about 1.5 hours away. The Gödöllő Royal Palace was a favourite residence of Empress Elisabeth (Sisi).

■ Practical Tips

- Check prices before ordering in tourist-area restaurants.
- Bring flip-flops and a towel to the baths, or rent them on site.
- Some places accept euros, but the exchange rate is poor; pay in forints.
- Validate public transport tickets to avoid fines.

Buenos Aires

Argentina · South America

AMERICAS

The "Paris of South America", a city of tango, steak and passionate nightlife.

Country	Argentina
Region	South America
Population (approx.)	~3.1 million (city); ~15 million (metro)
Language(s)	Spanish
Currency	Argentine Peso (ARS)
Main airport	Ministro Pistarini International (EZE); Aeroparque Jorge Newbery (AEP)
Best time to visit	March–May and September–November

■ Overview

Buenos Aires, the capital of Argentina, sits on the Río de la Plata estuary. Its European-style architecture, grand boulevards and café culture reflect waves of Spanish and Italian immigration. The city is famous for tango, football, steak and late-night living. Each neighbourhood (barrio) has its own character, from colourful La Boca to elegant Recoleta. Buenos Aires is a cultural powerhouse with theatres, bookshops and museums.

■ Top Attractions

- **Recoleta Cemetery** – An elaborate cemetery with mausoleums, including Eva Perón's tomb.
- **Plaza de Mayo and Casa Rosada** – The political heart of Argentina, with the pink presidential palace.
- **La Boca and Caminito** – A colourful street with tango dancers, next to the Boca Juniors stadium.
- **San Telmo** – A historic area with a Sunday antiques market.
- **Teatro Colón** – One of the world's greatest opera houses.
- **El Ateneo Grand Splendid** – A bookshop in a former theatre.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Palermo is trendy, with restaurants and nightlife. Recoleta is elegant, and San Telmo is bohemian.

■ Food & Drink

Argentine steak at parrillas, empanadas, choripán and dulce de leche are staples. Malbec wine is the national favourite. Dinner is late, often after 10 pm.

■ When to Visit

Spring and autumn are best. Summers are hot and humid.

■ **Getting Around**

The Subte (subway), buses and taxis serve the city. The SUBE card works on public transport.

■ **Day Trips**

Tigre and the Paraná Delta, Colonia del Sacramento in Uruguay and estancias (ranches) are popular.

■ **Practical Tips**

- Exchange rates fluctuate; check current options for paying by card or cash.
- Watch belongings in crowded areas.
- Take a tango class or show.
- Dinner starts late.

Busan

South Korea · East Asia

ASIA

South Korea's vibrant port city of beaches, seafood and hillside temples.

Country	South Korea
Region	East Asia
Population (approx.)	~3.3 million
Language(s)	Korean
Currency	South Korean Won (KRW)
Main airport	Gimhae International Airport (PUS)
Best time to visit	April-June and September-November

■ Overview

Busan is South Korea's second-largest city and largest port, on the southeastern tip of the Korean Peninsula. It is surrounded by mountains and sea, giving it beaches, hiking trails and dramatic coastal scenery. During the Korean War, Busan served as a temporary capital and refuge for millions. Today it is famous for its seafood markets, colourful hillside villages and the Busan International Film Festival. The city is more relaxed than Seoul and easy to reach by high-speed train.

■ Top Attractions

- **Haeundae Beach** – Korea's most famous beach, lined with hotels and restaurants.
- **Gamcheon Culture Village** – A colourful hillside village of painted houses, murals and art installations.
- **Jagalchi Fish Market** – Korea's largest fish market, where you can choose seafood and have it cooked upstairs.
- **Haedong Yonggungsa Temple** – A picturesque Buddhist temple set on seaside rocks.
- **Taejongdae** – A coastal park with cliffs, lighthouses and views.
- **Gwangalli Beach** – Popular for views of the illuminated Gwangan Bridge at night.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Haeundae is ideal for beaches and resorts. Seomyeon is a busy shopping and nightlife district, and Nampo-dong is close to the markets and old town. Gwangalli offers cafés and bridge views.

■ Food & Drink

Busan is famous for seafood, including raw fish (hoe), grilled clams and eomuk (fish cakes). Dwaengi gukbap, a pork and rice soup, is a local speciality. Milmyeon, cold wheat noodles, originated here. Ssiat hotteok, sweet pancakes filled with seeds, is a popular street snack.

■ When to Visit

Spring and autumn are pleasant, while summer is hot, humid and the beach season. The Busan International Film Festival is held in October. Winters are mild compared with Seoul.

■ Getting Around

Busan has an efficient subway system. KTX trains connect Busan with Seoul in about 2.5 hours. The T-money card works on buses and subways.

■ Day Trips

Gyeongju, the ancient capital of the Silla kingdom, is under an hour away by train. The Geoje and Tongyeong areas offer islands and coastal scenery. Ferries connect Busan with Fukuoka in Japan.

■ Practical Tips

- Download Naver Map or KakaoMap, as Google Maps is limited in Korea.
- Use a T-money card for public transport.
- Tipping is not customary.
- Many restaurants serve dishes for a minimum of two people.

Cancún

AMERICAS

Mexico · North America (Caribbean coast)

Mexico's Caribbean resort capital of turquoise water, white sand and nightlife.

Country	Mexico
Region	North America (Caribbean coast)
Population (approx.)	~950,000
Language(s)	Spanish (English widely spoken in tourist areas)
Currency	Mexican Peso (MXN); US Dollars widely accepted
Main airport	Cancún International Airport (CUN)
Best time to visit	December–April

■ Overview

Cancún, on the northeastern tip of the Yucatán Peninsula, was developed in the 1970s as a planned resort. It is now one of the world's most popular beach destinations, known for its Hotel Zone, a 22-kilometre strip of beaches and resorts. Cancún is also a gateway to the Riviera Maya, Mayan ruins and cenotes (natural sinkholes). The city has lively nightlife and all-inclusive resorts. Beyond the Hotel Zone, downtown Cancún offers a more local experience.

■ Top Attractions

- **Hotel Zone beaches** – Playa Delfines, Playa Chac Mool and others with turquoise water.
- **Isla Mujeres** – An island with beaches and snorkelling, reached by ferry.
- **Underwater Museum of Art (MUSA)** – Underwater sculptures for snorkelling and diving.
- **Chichén Itzá** – A famous Mayan site and one of the New Seven Wonders of the World.
- **Cenotes** – Natural swimming holes along the Ruta de los Cenotes.
- **Mayan Museum of Cancún** – Artefacts and the San Miguelito ruins.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The Hotel Zone is resort-focused. Downtown is more affordable, and Playa del Carmen is south.

■ Food & Drink

Yucatecan dishes like cochinita pibil and sopa de lima are popular. Seafood tacos and ceviche are everywhere.

■ When to Visit

December to April is the dry season. Hurricane season runs from June to November. Sargassum seaweed can affect beaches in summer.

■ Getting Around

Buses run along the Hotel Zone. ADO buses connect with other towns. Taxis are expensive.

■ Day Trips

Chichén Itzá, Tulum, Isla Mujeres and Holbox are popular.

■ Practical Tips

- Use reef-safe sunscreen.
- Check sargassum reports.
- Agree taxi fares in advance.
- Pay in pesos for better rates.

Cartagena

AMERICAS

Colombia · South America (Caribbean coast)

A romantic walled city of colourful colonial streets on the Caribbean.

Country	Colombia
Region	South America (Caribbean coast)
Population (approx.)	~1 million
Language(s)	Spanish
Currency	Colombian Peso (COP)
Main airport	Rafael Núñez International Airport (CTG)
Best time to visit	December–April

■ Overview

Cartagena de Indias, on Colombia's Caribbean coast, was one of the most important ports of the Spanish Empire, through which gold and silver from the Americas were shipped to Spain. To defend it from pirates and rival powers, the Spanish built massive walls and fortresses, now part of a UNESCO World Heritage Site. The old walled city is a maze of colourful colonial houses with flower-draped balconies, plazas and churches. Cartagena is also known for its Afro-Caribbean culture, lively music and nearby islands. It is Colombia's most visited destination.

■ Top Attractions

- **Walled City (Ciudad Amurallada)** – Colonial streets, plazas and churches, best explored on foot in the early morning or evening.
- **Castillo San Felipe de Barajas** – The largest Spanish fortress in the Americas, with tunnels and views.
- **City walls** – Walk along the walls at sunset, with bars like Café del Mar offering sea views.
- **Getsemaní** – A vibrant neighbourhood with street art, bars and salsa, centred on Plaza de la Trinidad.
- **Rosario Islands** – A coral archipelago with beaches and snorkelling, reached by boat.
- **Palace of the Inquisition** – A museum on the history of the Inquisition and the city.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The Walled City is atmospheric, with boutique hotels in colonial mansions. Getsemaní is lively and more affordable, and Bocagrande has high-rise hotels and beaches.

■ Food & Drink

Caribbean-Colombian cuisine includes fried fish with coconut rice and patacones (fried plantains), arepas de huevo and ceviche. Street vendors sell tropical fruits. Cartagena has many excellent restaurants, from street food to fine dining.

■ When to Visit

December to April is the dry season, though it is hot and humid year-round. October and November are the rainiest months. Holidays attract large crowds.

■ Getting Around

The old town is walkable. Taxis are inexpensive but agree fares first. Boats to the islands depart from the Muelle de la Bodeguita.

■ Day Trips

The Rosario Islands, Playa Blanca on Barú and the mud volcano El Totumo are popular. Palenque de San Basilio, the first free African town in the Americas, is a UNESCO cultural site.

■ Practical Tips

- Carry water and sun protection.
- Negotiate prices with street vendors.
- Book island tours with reputable operators.
- Beware of overcharging in tourist areas.

Cebu

Philippines · Southeast Asia

ASIA

The Philippines' oldest city and a gateway to islands, reefs and waterfalls.

Country	Philippines
Region	Southeast Asia
Population (approx.)	~960,000 (city); ~3 million (Metro Cebu)
Language(s)	Cebuano (Filipino and English widely spoken)
Currency	Philippine Peso (PHP)
Main airport	Mactan-Cebu International Airport (CEB)
Best time to visit	December-May

■ Overview

Cebu City, on the island of Cebu in the Visayas region, is the oldest city in the Philippines, where Ferdinand Magellan arrived in 1521. It is the country's second-most important economic centre and a major transport hub. The city has Spanish colonial landmarks, a strong Catholic heritage and lively festivals. Nearby Mactan Island has beach resorts, while the rest of Cebu offers waterfalls, diving and whale sharks. English is widely spoken, making travel easy.

■ Top Attractions

- **Magellan's Cross** – A cross planted by Spanish explorers in 1521, housed in a small chapel.
- **Basilica Minore del Santo Niño** – The oldest Roman Catholic church in the Philippines, home to a revered statue of the Christ Child.
- **Fort San Pedro** – A Spanish-era triangular fort in the old city.
- **Temple of Leah** – A Roman-inspired temple in the hills with city views.
- **Taoist Temple** – A colourful temple in the Beverly Hills area.
- **Mactan Island** – Beach resorts, island hopping and diving.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Cebu IT Park and Cebu Business Park are modern areas with hotels and restaurants. Mactan Island is best for beaches and resorts. The downtown area is historic but busy.

■ Food & Drink

Cebu is famous for lechon, whole roasted pig with crispy skin, often considered the best in the Philippines. Seafood, puso (rice cooked in woven palm leaves) and dried mangoes are local favourites. Larsian is a popular barbecue food area. Filipino dishes like adobo and sinigang are everywhere.

■ When to Visit

The dry season from December to May is best. The Sinulog Festival in January is one of the country's biggest festivals. The rainy season brings typhoons from June to November.

■ Getting Around

Taxis, ride-hailing apps (Grab) and jeepneys are common. Traffic can be heavy. Ferries connect Cebu with Bohol and other islands.

■ Day Trips

Moalboal offers the sardine run and turtles. Kawasan Falls is famous for canyoneering. Bohol, with the Chocolate Hills and tarsiers, is a ferry ride away.

■ Practical Tips

- Avoid Oslob whale shark tours if you are concerned about animal welfare.
- Book ferries in advance during holidays.
- Carry cash for small shops and rural areas.
- Check typhoon forecasts during the rainy season.

Charleston

AMERICAS

United States (South Carolina) · North America

A gracious Southern city of pastel houses, cobblestones and Lowcountry cuisine.

Country	United States (South Carolina)
Region	North America
Population (approx.)	~155,000 (city); ~850,000 (metro)
Language(s)	English
Currency	US Dollar (USD)
Main airport	Charleston International Airport (CHS)
Best time to visit	March–May and September–November

■ Overview

Charleston, founded in 1670, is one of the oldest cities in the United States and a jewel of the American South. Its historic district features antebellum mansions, cobblestone streets, church steeples and gardens. The city's wealth was built on plantations and the slave trade, and museums address this history. Charleston is known for Southern hospitality and an acclaimed food scene. It regularly ranks among the best small cities in the US.

■ Top Attractions

- **Historic District and The Battery** – Pastel houses on Rainbow Row and a waterfront promenade.
- **Fort Sumter** – Where the first shots of the Civil War were fired in 1861.
- **International African American Museum** – A museum on the site of a former slave-trade wharf.
- **Charleston City Market** – Historic market with sweetgrass baskets.
- **Plantations** – Magnolia, Middleton Place and McLeod Plantation, with tours on the lives of the enslaved.
- **King Street** – A shopping and dining street.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The historic district is best. Mount Pleasant and the beaches of Folly and Sullivan's Island are nearby.

■ Food & Drink

Lowcountry cuisine includes shrimp and grits, she-crab soup, Hoppin' John and fried green tomatoes.

■ **When to Visit**

Spring and autumn are ideal. Summers are hot and humid, with hurricane risk.

■ **Getting Around**

The historic district is walkable. Free DASH trolleys serve downtown.

■ **Day Trips**

Beaches, plantations and Savannah (2 hours) are nearby.

■ **Practical Tips**

- Book popular restaurants in advance.
- Visit plantations that present the history of slavery.
- Wear comfortable shoes.
- Check hurricane forecasts.

Chengdu

China · East Asia

ASIA

The laid-back home of giant pandas, teahouses and fiery Sichuan cuisine.

Country	China
Region	East Asia
Population (approx.)	~21 million (municipality)
Language(s)	Mandarin Chinese (Sichuanese dialect)
Currency	Chinese Yuan Renminbi (CNY)
Main airport	Chengdu Tianfu International (TFU); Chengdu Shuangliu International (CTU)
Best time to visit	March–June and September–November

■ Overview

Chengdu, the capital of Sichuan Province in southwestern China, is known for its relaxed lifestyle, spicy food and giant pandas. The city has over 2,000 years of history and was the capital of the Shu kingdom during the Three Kingdoms period. Chengdu is a UNESCO City of Gastronomy. Locals love teahouses, mahjong and leisurely afternoons in parks. The city is also a gateway to Tibet, Jiuzhaigou and the mountains of western Sichuan.

■ Top Attractions

- **Chengdu Research Base of Giant Panda Breeding** – The best place to see giant pandas, especially in the morning when they are active.
- **Wenshu Monastery** – A peaceful Buddhist temple with a vegetarian restaurant and teahouse.
- **Jinli Ancient Street** – A restored street with snacks, crafts and traditional architecture.
- **Kuanzhai Alley** – Historic lanes with courtyard houses, teahouses and shops.
- **People's Park** – A lively park with teahouses, dancing and a matchmaking corner.
- **Sichuan opera** – Performances featuring the famous "face-changing" art.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Chunxi Road and Taikoo Li are central shopping areas. Kuanzhai Alley and Wenshu are historic. The southern districts are modern, with business hotels.

■ Food & Drink

Sichuan cuisine is famous for the numbing heat of Sichuan pepper and chilli. Try hot pot, mapo tofu, kung pao chicken, dan dan noodles and twice-cooked pork. Street snacks include chuan chuan (skewers dipped in broth). Teahouses serve jasmine and green teas.

■ When to Visit

Spring and autumn are pleasant. Summers are hot and humid, and winters are cool and grey. Avoid the Golden Week holiday in early October.

■ Getting Around

Chengdu has an extensive metro network. DiDi and taxis are widely available. High-speed trains connect Chengdu with Chongqing, Xi'an and other cities.

■ Day Trips

Leshan Giant Buddha, the world's largest stone Buddha, is about an hour away by train. Mount Emei is a sacred Buddhist mountain. Dujiangyan, an ancient irrigation system, and Mount Qingcheng are UNESCO sites.

■ Practical Tips

- Visit the panda base early in the morning.
- Ask for "wei la" (mild spice) if you are not used to spicy food.
- Set up mobile payment before arrival.
- Carry your passport for train tickets and hotels.

Chiang Mai

Thailand · Southeast Asia

ASIA

Northern Thailand's cultural capital of temples, markets and mountain adventures.

Country	Thailand
Region	Southeast Asia
Population (approx.)	~130,000 (city); ~1.2 million (metro)
Language(s)	Thai (Northern Thai dialect)
Currency	Thai Baht (THB)
Main airport	Chiang Mai International Airport (CNX)
Best time to visit	November–February

■ Overview

Chiang Mai is the largest city in northern Thailand, founded in 1296 as the capital of the Lanna Kingdom. Its old city is surrounded by a moat and remnants of ancient walls, containing more than 30 temples. The city is known for its relaxed pace, crafts, night markets and cooking classes. Chiang Mai is surrounded by mountains, making it a base for trekking, elephant sanctuaries and visits to hill-tribe villages. It is also a popular hub for digital nomads.

■ Top Attractions

- **Wat Phra That Doi Suthep** – A golden temple on a mountain overlooking the city.
- **Old City temples** – Wat Chedi Luang, Wat Phra Singh and many others.
- **Sunday Walking Street** – A large night market along Ratchadamnoen Road.
- **Night Bazaar** – A market selling handicrafts and souvenirs.
- **Elephant sanctuaries** – Ethical sanctuaries where visitors observe elephants without riding them.
- **Doi Inthanon National Park** – Thailand's highest mountain, with waterfalls and pagodas.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The Old City is central and walkable. Nimmanhaemin is trendy, with cafés and co-working spaces. The Riverside area offers quieter hotels.

■ Food & Drink

Khao soi, a curry noodle soup with crispy noodles, is Chiang Mai's signature dish. Sai oua (northern sausage), nam prik ong (a chilli dip) and gaeng hang lay (pork curry) are local dishes. Cooking classes are very popular. Markets offer cheap, delicious street food.

■ When to Visit

The cool season from November to February is best. Loy Krathong and Yi Peng lantern festivals in November are spectacular. The burning season (February–April) causes poor air quality.

■ Getting Around

Songthaews (red shared trucks) and ride-hailing apps are common. Renting a scooter is popular but requires caution. The Old City is walkable.

■ Day Trips

Chiang Rai's White Temple and Blue Temple are about three hours away. Pai is a mountain town popular with backpackers. Doi Inthanon and elephant sanctuaries are nearby.

■ Practical Tips

- Choose elephant sanctuaries that do not allow riding.
- Check air quality forecasts during the burning season.
- Dress modestly at temples.
- Book Yi Peng lantern events in advance.

Chicago

AMERICAS

United States (Illinois) · North America

The "Windy City" of bold architecture, deep-dish pizza, blues and lakefront beaches.

Country	United States (Illinois)
Region	North America
Population (approx.)	~2.7 million (city); ~9.4 million (metro)
Language(s)	English
Currency	US Dollar (USD)
Main airport	O'Hare International (ORD); Midway International (MDW)
Best time to visit	May–October

■ Overview

Chicago, on the shores of Lake Michigan, is the third-largest city in the United States. After the Great Chicago Fire of 1871, the city rebuilt with innovative architecture and became the birthplace of the skyscraper. It is known for its world-class museums, blues and jazz, comedy and sports teams. Chicago has miles of lakefront parks and beaches. The city is a Midwestern hub with a friendly, down-to-earth atmosphere.

■ Top Attractions

- **Chicago Architecture Center river cruise** – The best way to see the city's famous buildings.
- **Millennium Park and Cloud Gate ("The Bean")** – A park with public art and concerts.
- **Art Institute of Chicago** – One of the world's great art museums, with works like Nighthawks and A Sunday on La Grande Jatte.
- **Willis Tower Skydeck and 360 Chicago** – Observation decks with glass ledges.
- **Navy Pier** – A pier with rides, restaurants and boat tours.
- **Wrigley Field** – The historic home of the Chicago Cubs.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The Loop is the downtown core. River North and the Magnificent Mile have hotels and shopping, while Wicker Park, Logan Square and West Loop are trendy.

■ Food & Drink

Deep-dish pizza, Chicago-style hot dogs and Italian beef sandwiches are local classics. The West Loop's Restaurant Row has acclaimed dining.

■ When to Visit

Summer is ideal for festivals like Lollapalooza. Winters are very cold and windy.

■ **Getting Around**

The "L" trains and buses cover the city. Divvy bikes are popular along the lakefront.

■ **Day Trips**

Milwaukee, Indiana Dunes National Park and Oak Park (Frank Lloyd Wright) are nearby.

■ **Practical Tips**

- Take the architecture river cruise.
- Dress warmly in winter.
- Use the Ventra card or app for transit.
- Book museum tickets in advance.

Cologne

Germany · Central Europe

EUROPE

A lively Rhine city crowned by one of the world's greatest Gothic cathedrals.

Country	Germany
Region	Central Europe
Population (approx.)	~1.1 million
Language(s)	German
Currency	Euro (EUR)
Main airport	Cologne Bonn Airport (CGN); Düsseldorf Airport (DUS) is nearby
Best time to visit	May–September; Carnival in February

■ Overview

Cologne (Köln) is Germany's fourth-largest city and one of its oldest, founded by the Romans nearly 2,000 years ago. Its twin-spired cathedral, a UNESCO World Heritage Site, dominates the skyline beside the Rhine. Although heavily bombed in the Second World War, Cologne has rebuilt itself into a cheerful, open-minded city known for its carnival, beer culture and art museums. Locals are famously sociable, and the city has a strong LGBTQ+ scene. Cologne is well connected and an easy stop on a Rhine or Germany itinerary.

■ Top Attractions

- **Cologne Cathedral (Kölner Dom)** – A monumental Gothic cathedral that took over 600 years to complete; climb 533 steps to the top of the south tower.
- **Museum Ludwig** – A major collection of modern art, including Pop Art and one of Europe's largest Picasso collections.
- **Old Town (Altstadt)** – Colourful houses along the Rhine promenade and small squares packed with breweries.
- **Hohenzollern Bridge** – A railway bridge covered with thousands of love locks, offering views of the cathedral.
- **Chocolate Museum** – A popular museum on the Rhine covering the history of chocolate, with a chocolate fountain.
- **Romano-Germanic Museum** – Roman artefacts including the Dionysus mosaic.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The Altstadt and area near the cathedral are convenient for sightseeing. The Belgian Quarter is trendy, with independent shops and bars, while Ehrenfeld is multicultural and creative. Deutz, across the river, offers views and trade-fair hotels.

■ Food & Drink

Cologne's beer is Kölsch, a light top-fermented beer served in small 0.2-litre glasses called Stangen; waiters keep refilling until you cover the glass with a coaster. Traditional brewhouses serve dishes such as Halve Hahn (a rye roll with cheese, not chicken), Himmel und Ääd (mashed potatoes with apples and black pudding) and sauerbraten. Reibekuchen, potato pancakes, are popular at markets.

■ When to Visit

Summer is ideal for Rhine walks and beer gardens. Cologne Carnival reaches its peak between Weiberfastnacht and Rose Monday, usually in February, with parades and costumes. December brings some of Germany's best Christmas markets.

■ Getting Around

Cologne Hauptbahnhof is right next to the cathedral and is one of Germany's busiest rail hubs. Trams and buses cover the city, and the airport is connected by S-Bahn in about 15 minutes. The old town is walkable.

■ Day Trips

Bonn, the former West German capital and Beethoven's birthplace, is just 20–30 minutes away. Aachen, with Charlemagne's cathedral, and Düsseldorf are also close. Rhine cruises through the Middle Rhine Valley past castles are reachable from Koblenz.

■ Practical Tips

- Say "Kölsch" at a brewhouse, not "beer", and put your coaster on the glass when you are done.
- Book hotels well ahead during Carnival and major trade fairs.
- The KölnCard gives transport and museum discounts.
- Many museums are closed on Mondays.

Colombo

Sri Lanka · South Asia

ASIA

Sri Lanka's bustling commercial capital of colonial buildings and ocean views.

Country	Sri Lanka
Region	South Asia
Population (approx.)	~750,000 (city); ~5.6 million (metro)
Language(s)	Sinhala and Tamil (English widely spoken)
Currency	Sri Lankan Rupee (LKR)
Main airport	Bandaranaike International Airport (CMB)
Best time to visit	December–March (west coast)

■ Overview

Colombo is Sri Lanka's largest city and commercial capital, on the west coast of the island. Its natural harbour made it an important trading port for Arab, Portuguese, Dutch and British traders. The city blends colonial architecture, Buddhist temples, markets and modern developments. Many travellers pass through quickly, but Colombo has excellent restaurants, museums and seaside promenades. It is the main gateway to Sri Lanka's beaches, tea country and ancient cities.

■ Top Attractions

- **Galle Face Green** – An oceanside promenade popular at sunset, with street food stalls.
- **Gangaramaya Temple** – An eclectic Buddhist temple with a museum.
- **Pettah Market** – A bustling market district.
- **National Museum of Colombo** – Sri Lanka's largest museum, with royal regalia and artefacts.
- **Seema Malaka** – A temple on a lake designed by Geoffrey Bawa.
- **Independence Memorial Hall** – A monument commemorating Sri Lanka's independence.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Colombo 3 (Kollupitiya) and Colombo 7 (Cinnamon Gardens) are upscale. Fort is the historic business district, and Mount Lavinia offers beachfront hotels.

■ Food & Drink

Rice and curry, kottu roti (chopped flatbread stir-fried), hoppers (bowl-shaped pancakes) and string hoppers are staples. Seafood is excellent, and crab curry is a speciality. Ceylon tea is served everywhere.

■ When to Visit

The west coast is best from December to March. The southwest monsoon brings rain from May to September. Sri Lanka has different weather patterns on each coast.

■ Getting Around

Tuk-tuks and ride-hailing apps (PickMe, Uber) are common. Trains connect Colombo with Kandy and the south coast. Traffic can be heavy.

■ Day Trips

Galle, a Dutch fort town, is about two hours away. Negombo is a beach town near the airport. Kandy and the hill country are reachable by train.

■ Practical Tips

- Apply for the Electronic Travel Authorization (ETA) before arrival.
- Dress modestly at temples.
- Negotiate tuk-tuk fares or use metered ones.
- Carry cash for rural areas.

Copenhagen

Denmark · Northern Europe

EUROPE

A stylish, bike-friendly capital of design, hygge and New Nordic cuisine.

Country	Denmark
Region	Northern Europe
Population (approx.)	~660,000 (city); ~2.1 million (metro)
Language(s)	Danish (English widely spoken)
Currency	Danish Krone (DKK)
Main airport	Copenhagen Airport, Kastrup (CPH)
Best time to visit	May–September

■ Overview

Copenhagen, the capital of Denmark, regularly ranks among the world's most liveable cities. It combines colourful harbourfront houses, royal palaces and cutting-edge architecture with a relaxed, human-scale atmosphere. The city is a global leader in cycling, sustainability and gastronomy, having been home to Noma and other highly acclaimed restaurants. Danes are known for "hygge", a sense of cosy wellbeing. Copenhagen is expensive, but its compact size makes it easy to enjoy on foot, by bike and even by swimming in the clean harbour.

■ Top Attractions

- **Nyhavn** – A 17th-century canal lined with brightly painted townhouses, bars and old wooden ships.
- **Tivoli Gardens** – One of the world's oldest amusement parks, opened in 1843, with gardens, rides and concerts.
- **The Little Mermaid** – A small bronze statue inspired by Hans Christian Andersen's fairy tale, located on the waterfront.
- **Christiansborg Palace** – Home to the Danish parliament and royal reception rooms, with a free tower offering views.
- **Rosenborg Castle and Amalienborg Palace** – Rosenborg displays the Crown Jewels, while Amalienborg is the royal residence with a daily changing of the guard.
- **Freetown Christiania** – A self-governing alternative community with colourful houses and art; photography is restricted in some areas.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Indre By (the inner city) is central and close to most sights. Vesterbro, the former meatpacking district, is trendy with bars and restaurants, and Nørrebro is multicultural and creative. Christianshavn has canals and a laid-back vibe, while Østerbro is residential and upmarket.

■ Food & Drink

Smørrebrød, open-faced rye sandwiches with toppings like herring, roast beef or shrimp, is the classic Danish lunch. Danish pastries (wienerbrød), cinnamon buns and hot dogs from street stands are popular. Copenhagen has many Michelin-starred restaurants, but street food markets like Reffen offer cheaper options. Craft beer and natural wine bars are everywhere.

■ When to Visit

Summer brings long days, harbour swimming and outdoor festivals such as Copenhagen Jazz Festival in July. Spring and early autumn are cooler but pleasant. Winter is dark and cold, though Tivoli's Christmas season and cosy cafés create a hygge atmosphere.

■ Getting Around

The metro runs 24 hours and connects the airport with the city centre in about 15 minutes. Cycling is the best way to get around, with dedicated lanes everywhere. Harbour buses (boats) are part of the public transport system.

■ Day Trips

Kronborg Castle in Helsingør, the setting of Shakespeare's Hamlet, and the Louisiana Museum of Modern Art in Humlebæk are both easy train trips. Roskilde has a Viking Ship Museum and a cathedral with royal tombs. Malmö in Sweden is just 35 minutes away across the Øresund Bridge.

■ Practical Tips

- The Copenhagen Card includes transport and entry to many attractions.
- Follow cycling etiquette and signal when turning or stopping.
- Tap water is excellent; carry a reusable bottle.
- Card payments are accepted almost everywhere; cash is rarely needed.

Cuenca

Ecuador · South America

AMERICAS

A colonial Andean city of blue domes, rivers and Panama hats.

Country	Ecuador
Region	South America
Population (approx.)	~600,000
Language(s)	Spanish
Currency	US Dollar (USD)
Main airport	Mariscal Lamar Airport (CUE)
Best time to visit	June–September

■ Overview

Cuenca, in Ecuador's southern highlands, is one of the most beautiful colonial cities in South America. Its historic centre, a UNESCO World Heritage Site, features cobblestone streets, colonial houses and the striking blue-domed New Cathedral. The city is built along four rivers. Cuenca is famous for the production of toquilla straw hats, known worldwide as Panama hats. It is popular with retirees from abroad because of its mild climate and low cost of living.

■ Top Attractions

- **New Cathedral (Catedral de la Inmaculada Concepción)** – A massive cathedral with blue domes.
- **Parque Calderón** – The main square.
- **Tomebamba River** – Riverside walks.
- **Pumapungo Museum** – Inca ruins and ethnographic exhibits.
- **Panama hat workshops** – Learn how toquilla straw hats are woven.
- **Mirador de Turi** – A viewpoint over the city.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The historic centre is the best base.

■ Food & Drink

Local dishes include cuy (guinea pig), hornado (roast pork) and mote pillo (hominy with eggs). Markets like Mercado 10 de Agosto are good for local food.

■ When to Visit

Cuenca has a spring-like climate year-round. June to September is drier.

■ Getting Around

The centre is walkable. A tram crosses the city.

■ Day Trips

Cajas National Park offers lakes and hiking. Ingapirca is Ecuador's largest Inca site.

■ Practical Tips

- Adjust to the altitude (around 2,500 m).
- Ecuador uses the US dollar.
- Carry small bills.
- Bring layers.

Cusco

Peru · South America

AMERICAS

The ancient Inca capital and gateway to Machu Picchu.

Country	Peru
Region	South America
Population (approx.)	~450,000
Language(s)	Spanish and Quechua
Currency	Peruvian Sol (PEN)
Main airport	Alejandro Velasco Astete International Airport (CUZ)
Best time to visit	April–October (dry season)

■ Overview

Cusco, high in the Andes of southern Peru, was the capital of the Inca Empire, the largest empire in pre-Columbian America. The Spanish built colonial churches and palaces on top of Inca foundations, creating a unique blend of cultures. The city is a UNESCO World Heritage Site and the main base for visiting Machu Picchu and the Sacred Valley. At around 3,400 metres above sea level, altitude is a factor for visitors. Quechua culture remains strong in the region.

■ Top Attractions

- **Plaza de Armas** – The main square with the cathedral and the Church of La Compañía.
- **Qorikancha** – The Inca Temple of the Sun, with a Dominican convent built on top.
- **Sacsayhuamán** – A massive Inca fortress with huge stone walls above the city.
- **San Blas** – A bohemian neighbourhood of artisans.
- **San Pedro Market** – A market for food and crafts.
- **Machu Picchu** – The iconic Inca citadel, reached by train or the Inca Trail.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The historic centre and San Blas are convenient.

■ Food & Drink

Andean cuisine includes alpaca, cuy (guinea pig), quinoa and lomo saltado. Coca tea helps with altitude.

■ When to Visit

April to October is the dry season. Inti Raymi, the Inca Festival of the Sun, takes place on 24 June.

■ Getting Around

The centre is walkable but hilly. Taxis are cheap. Trains to Machu Picchu depart from Poroy or Ollantaytambo.

■ Day Trips

The Sacred Valley, Rainbow Mountain and Moray are popular.

■ Practical Tips

- Rest on arrival to acclimatise to the altitude.
- Book Machu Picchu tickets and Inca Trail permits well in advance.
- Buy the Boleto Turístico for multiple sites.
- Bring layers.

Da Nang

Vietnam · Southeast Asia

ASIA

A modern beach city between the mountains and the sea in central Vietnam.

Country	Vietnam
Region	Southeast Asia
Population (approx.)	~1.2 million
Language(s)	Vietnamese
Currency	Vietnamese Dong (VND)
Main airport	Da Nang International Airport (DAD)
Best time to visit	February–August

■ Overview

Da Nang is a fast-growing coastal city in central Vietnam, located between the ancient capital of Hue and the historic town of Hoi An. It has long sandy beaches, modern bridges and a relaxed atmosphere. The city is a gateway to UNESCO sites and the scenic Hai Van Pass. Da Nang is clean, well organised and popular with families and digital nomads. It combines urban life with beaches and mountains.

■ Top Attractions

- **My Khe Beach** – A long sandy beach with resorts and seafood restaurants.
- **Marble Mountains** – Limestone hills with caves, temples and viewpoints.
- **Dragon Bridge** – A bridge shaped like a dragon that breathes fire and water on weekend nights.
- **Ba Na Hills and the Golden Bridge** – A mountain resort with a bridge held by giant stone hands.
- **Son Tra Peninsula** – A nature reserve with the Lady Buddha statue and monkeys.
- **Han Market** – A local market for food and souvenirs.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

My Khe Beach area is popular for hotels. The city centre along the Han River has restaurants and nightlife. Son Tra is quieter.

■ Food & Drink

Mi Quang (turmeric noodles), banh xeo (crispy pancakes) and fresh seafood are local favourites. Bun cha ca (fish cake noodle soup) is a Da Nang speciality. Coffee culture is strong.

■ When to Visit

February to August is dry and sunny. The rainy season (September–December) brings typhoons. The Da Nang International Fireworks Festival takes place in summer.

■ **Getting Around**

Grab and taxis are affordable. Motorbike rental is common. The airport is close to the city centre.

■ **Day Trips**

Hoi An is 30–45 minutes away. Hue, the former imperial capital, is reached via the Hai Van Pass. My Son Sanctuary has ancient Cham temples.

■ **Practical Tips**

- Check typhoon forecasts in autumn.
- Visit Ba Na Hills early to avoid crowds.
- Carry cash for small vendors.
- Negotiate prices in markets.

Delhi

India · South Asia

ASIA

India's sprawling capital of Mughal monuments, bustling bazaars and political power.

Country	India
Region	South Asia
Population (approx.)	~33 million (metro)
Language(s)	Hindi and English
Currency	Indian Rupee (INR)
Main airport	Indira Gandhi International Airport (DEL)
Best time to visit	October–March

■ Overview

Delhi, India's capital territory, is one of the oldest continuously inhabited cities in the world. It has been the capital of numerous empires, including the Delhi Sultanate, the Mughals and the British Raj. Old Delhi is a maze of narrow lanes, markets and mosques, while New Delhi, designed by the British, features wide boulevards and government buildings. The city is chaotic and intense but rich in history and food. It is the starting point of the Golden Triangle with Agra and Jaipur.

■ Top Attractions

- **Red Fort** – A Mughal fortress and UNESCO World Heritage Site built by Shah Jahan.
- **Qutub Minar** – A 73-metre minaret from the early 13th century.
- **Humayun's Tomb** – A garden tomb that inspired the Taj Mahal.
- **Jama Masjid** – One of India's largest mosques.
- **India Gate** – A war memorial on the ceremonial Kartavya Path.
- **Lotus Temple and Akshardham** – A lotus-shaped Bahá'í house of worship and a vast Hindu temple complex.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Connaught Place is central. Paharganj is a budget backpacker area near the station, and South Delhi neighbourhoods like Hauz Khas and Defence Colony are upscale. Old Delhi is historic.

■ Food & Drink

Delhi is famous for street food like chaat, parathas in Paranthe Wali Gali, butter chicken and kebabs. Karim's near Jama Masjid serves Mughlai food. Chole bhature is a popular breakfast. Try lassi and masala chai.

■ When to Visit

October to March is the most pleasant. Summers are extremely hot, and the monsoon brings humidity. Winter smog can be severe, especially in November.

■ Getting Around

The Delhi Metro is efficient and connects the airport. Auto-rickshaws and ride-hailing apps are widely used. Traffic is heavy.

■ Day Trips

Agra and the Taj Mahal are a popular day trip by train. Jaipur is about 4–5 hours away. Rishikesh and Haridwar are further north.

■ Practical Tips

- Check air quality in winter.
- Dress modestly at religious sites.
- Beware of touts at railway stations.
- Use prepaid taxis or apps from the airport.

Denver

AMERICAS

United States (Colorado) · North America

The "Mile High City", a gateway to the Rocky Mountains with craft beer and sunshine.

Country	United States (Colorado)
Region	North America
Population (approx.)	~720,000 (city); ~3 million (metro)
Language(s)	English
Currency	US Dollar (USD)
Main airport	Denver International Airport (DEN)
Best time to visit	June–September; December–March for skiing

■ Overview

Denver, the capital of Colorado, sits exactly one mile (1,609 metres) above sea level at the eastern edge of the Rocky Mountains. Founded during the 1858 gold rush, it grew into the largest city in the Mountain West. Denver enjoys around 300 days of sunshine a year and a strong outdoor culture, with skiing, hiking and cycling close by. The city has a thriving craft beer scene, art districts and professional sports teams. It is the main gateway to Colorado's national parks and ski resorts.

■ Top Attractions

- **Red Rocks Park and Amphitheatre** – A natural open-air amphitheatre between giant red sandstone formations, famous for concerts.
- **Denver Art Museum** – A striking building with Native American and Western art collections.
- **Union Station** – A restored historic railway station with restaurants and bars.
- **Larimer Square and LoDo** – Historic Victorian buildings, restaurants and nightlife.
- **Colorado State Capitol** – Its steps mark the elevation of one mile above sea level.
- **RiNo Art District** – Street art, galleries and breweries.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

LoDo (Lower Downtown) is lively and central. RiNo is trendy, while Capitol Hill is eclectic, and Cherry Creek is upscale.

■ Food & Drink

Denver's food scene includes Southwestern and Mexican influences, green chile, bison burgers and Rocky Mountain oysters. Craft breweries are everywhere.

■ **When to Visit**

Summer is ideal for hiking and concerts; winter for skiing. Weather can change quickly.

■ **Getting Around**

The A Line train connects the airport with Union Station. Light rail, buses and bike-share are available.

■ **Day Trips**

Rocky Mountain National Park, Boulder, Colorado Springs (Garden of the Gods) and ski resorts are nearby.

■ **Practical Tips**

- Drink water and take it easy on alcohol at altitude.
- Use sunscreen; UV is strong.
- Check road conditions in winter.
- Book Red Rocks concert tickets early.

Doha

Qatar · Middle East

ASIA

A futuristic Gulf capital of striking museums, souks and desert adventures.

Country	Qatar
Region	Middle East
Population (approx.)	~1.2 million (city); ~2.7 million (Qatar)
Language(s)	Arabic (English widely used)
Currency	Qatari Riyal (QAR)
Main airport	Hamad International Airport (DOH)
Best time to visit	November–March

■ Overview

Doha, the capital of Qatar, sits on the eastern coast of the Qatar peninsula on the Persian Gulf. In just a few decades, natural gas wealth has transformed it from a pearl-fishing town into a modern city of skyscrapers and cultural landmarks. Doha hosted the FIFA World Cup in 2022, which brought major investment in transport and infrastructure. The city is known for its world-class museums, restored traditional souks and luxury hotels. Hamad International Airport, one of the world's best, makes Doha a popular stopover destination.

■ Top Attractions

- **Museum of Islamic Art** – A landmark building by I. M. Pei housing one of the world's finest collections of Islamic art, with a waterfront park.
- **National Museum of Qatar** – Designed by Jean Nouvel to resemble a desert rose crystal, it tells the story of Qatar's people and land.
- **Souq Waqif** – A restored traditional market with spices, textiles, falcons, restaurants and shisha cafés.
- **Corniche** – A seven-kilometre waterfront promenade with views of the West Bay skyline.
- **Katara Cultural Village** – A cultural district with an amphitheatre, galleries, mosques and a beach.
- **The Pearl-Qatar** – An artificial island with marinas, luxury apartments, shops and restaurants.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

West Bay is the business district with high-rise hotels and beaches. The area around Souq Waqif and Msheireb Downtown is historic yet modern and walkable. The Pearl and Lusail offer upscale waterfront living and newer attractions.

■ Food & Drink

Qatari dishes include machboos (spiced rice with meat), harees and balaleet (sweet vermicelli with eggs). Karak tea, a sweet spiced milk tea, is a local favourite sold everywhere. Souq Waqif offers Middle Eastern, Persian and Indian restaurants. Alcohol is only served in licensed hotel venues.

■ When to Visit

November to March offers pleasant temperatures for outdoor sightseeing. Summers are extremely hot and humid, often above 40°C. Ramadan changes opening hours, but evenings are festive.

■ Getting Around

The Doha Metro is modern and connects the airport, West Bay, Souq Waqif and Lusail. Taxis and ride-hailing apps (Uber, Careem) are widely used. Walking is pleasant only in the cooler months.

■ Day Trips

Desert safaris to Khor Al Adaid (the Inland Sea), where dunes meet the sea, are popular. The Zubarah Fort, a UNESCO site, is in the north. Mangroves at Al Thakira can be explored by kayak.

■ Practical Tips

- Dress modestly in public places, covering shoulders and knees.
- Many nationalities receive visa-free entry; check requirements before travelling.
- Friday is the weekly holy day, with limited morning opening hours.
- Use sun protection and carry water.

Dubai

ASIA

United Arab Emirates · Middle East

A glittering city of record-breaking skyscrapers, luxury shopping and desert adventures.

Country	United Arab Emirates
Region	Middle East
Population (approx.)	~3.8 million
Language(s)	Arabic (English widely used)
Currency	UAE Dirham (AED)
Main airport	Dubai International Airport (DXB); Al Maktoum International (DWC)
Best time to visit	November–March

■ Overview

Dubai is the most populous city in the United Arab Emirates and one of the world's fastest-growing destinations. Once a small fishing and pearling village, it has transformed through trade, tourism, aviation and real estate into a global hub. Dubai is famous for its superlatives, including the world's tallest building, huge shopping malls and artificial islands. Beyond the glamour, it also has traditional souks, historic districts and desert landscapes. The city is multicultural, with most residents coming from abroad.

■ Top Attractions

- **Burj Khalifa** – The world's tallest building, with observation decks on levels 124, 125 and 148.
- **Dubai Mall and Dubai Fountain** – A giant mall with an aquarium and an ice rink, and a choreographed fountain show every evening.
- **Palm Jumeirah and Atlantis** – A palm-shaped artificial island with luxury resorts and a water park.
- **Dubai Creek, Al Fahidi and the souks** – The historic district with wind-tower houses, abra boat rides and Gold and Spice Souks.
- **Museum of the Future** – A striking torus-shaped building dedicated to future technologies.
- **Desert safari** – Dune bashing, camel rides and dinner at a desert camp.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Downtown Dubai is central, near Burj Khalifa. Dubai Marina and JBR offer beaches and waterfront dining, while Deira and Bur Dubai are traditional and budget-friendly. Palm Jumeirah hosts luxury resorts.

■ Food & Drink

Dubai offers cuisine from around the world, from street shawarma to celebrity-chef restaurants. Emirati dishes such as machboos and luqaimat are served in heritage restaurants. Friday brunches are a local institution. Indian and Pakistani restaurants in Deira and Karama offer excellent value.

■ When to Visit

November to March has warm, sunny weather. Summers are extremely hot and humid. The Dubai Shopping Festival (December–January) offers discounts and events.

■ Getting Around

The Dubai Metro connects the airport, Downtown and Marina, and trams serve the Marina area. Taxis and ride-hailing apps are widely used. Abras (water taxis) cross Dubai Creek for a tiny fare.

■ Day Trips

Abu Dhabi, with the Sheikh Zayed Grand Mosque and Louvre Abu Dhabi, is about 1.5 hours away. Hatta offers mountain scenery and kayaking. Sharjah has museums and a heritage area.

■ Practical Tips

- Dress modestly outside beaches and pools.
- Public drinking is not allowed; alcohol is served in licensed venues.
- Book Burj Khalifa tickets in advance for sunset slots.
- During Ramadan, avoid eating in public during daylight.

Dublin

Ireland · Northern Europe

EUROPE

A friendly literary capital of Georgian squares, pubs and live music.

Country	Ireland
Region	Northern Europe
Population (approx.)	~590,000 (city); ~1.5 million (Greater Dublin)
Language(s)	English and Irish
Currency	Euro (EUR)
Main airport	Dublin Airport (DUB)
Best time to visit	May–September

■ Overview

Dublin is the capital of Ireland, located on the east coast at the mouth of the River Liffey. Founded by Vikings, the city became a centre of British rule and later the birthplace of the Irish state. Dublin has an outstanding literary heritage, producing writers such as James Joyce, Oscar Wilde, W. B. Yeats and Samuel Beckett. Today it is a youthful, international city and a European hub for tech companies. Its pubs, music and warm hospitality make it a popular city break.

■ Top Attractions

- **Trinity College and the Book of Kells** – Ireland's oldest university displays the 9th-century illuminated manuscript and the stunning Long Room library.
- **Guinness Storehouse** – A seven-floor visitor experience about Ireland's famous stout, ending with a pint in the rooftop Gravity Bar.
- **Temple Bar** – A lively cobbled area full of pubs, live music and street performers; prices are higher here.
- **Dublin Castle and Chester Beatty Library** – The seat of British rule for centuries, and a free museum with remarkable manuscripts and art from around the world.
- **Kilmainham Gaol** – A former prison central to Irish revolutionary history, visited by guided tour.
- **St. Patrick's Cathedral and Christ Church Cathedral** – Two medieval cathedrals; Jonathan Swift was dean of St. Patrick's.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The area around St. Stephen's Green and Grafton Street is central and elegant. Temple Bar is convenient but noisy, while Smithfield and Stoneybatter are more local and trendy. Ballsbridge is upscale and quiet, south of the centre.

■ Food & Drink

Traditional Irish food includes Irish stew, boxty (potato pancakes), soda bread and a full Irish breakfast. Seafood is excellent, including oysters and Dublin Bay prawns. Pubs serve Guinness, Irish whiskey and craft beers. Dublin has a growing modern food scene with many international restaurants.

■ When to Visit

Late spring and summer bring the mildest weather and longest days, though rain is possible year-round. St. Patrick's Day on 17 March is celebrated with a festival and parade, drawing large crowds. Bloomsday on 16 June celebrates James Joyce's Ulysses.

■ Getting Around

Central Dublin is very walkable. The Luas tram, buses and DART coastal trains cover the wider area. There is no metro to the airport; express buses and taxis take 30–45 minutes.

■ Day Trips

The coastal villages of Howth and Dalkey offer cliff walks and seafood. Glendalough, a monastic site in the Wicklow Mountains, is very scenic. The prehistoric passage tombs of Newgrange in the Boyne Valley are older than the pyramids of Giza.

■ Practical Tips

- Book Trinity College and the Guinness Storehouse online in advance.
- Accommodation is expensive; book early.
- Pack a waterproof jacket in every season.
- Take a traditional music session in a pub outside Temple Bar for a more authentic experience.

Dubrovnik

Croatia · Southeastern Europe

EUROPE

The walled "Pearl of the Adriatic", a limestone old town above turquoise sea.

Country	Croatia
Region	Southeastern Europe
Population (approx.)	~41,000
Language(s)	Croatian
Currency	Euro (EUR)
Main airport	Dubrovnik Airport (DBV)
Best time to visit	May-June and September-October

■ Overview

Dubrovnik is a walled city on the southern Dalmatian coast of Croatia and one of the Mediterranean's most spectacular destinations. For centuries it was the capital of the independent Republic of Ragusa, a maritime power that rivalled Venice. Its massive stone walls, marble streets and red-tiled roofs form a UNESCO World Heritage Site. The city gained new fame as a filming location for Game of Thrones, representing King's Landing. Because of cruise ships and summer crowds, careful timing makes a big difference to the experience.

■ Top Attractions

- **City Walls** – A nearly 2-kilometre walk along the medieval walls offers stunning views of the old town and the sea; go early or late to avoid heat.
- **Stradun (Placa)** – The polished limestone main street running through the old town between the Pile and Ploče gates.
- **Rector's Palace** – The Gothic-Renaissance seat of the Ragusan government, now a museum.
- **Mount Srđ Cable Car** – A cable car to the summit above the city, with sunset views and a museum about the 1990s siege.
- **Lokrum Island** – A short ferry ride away, with botanical gardens, peacocks, rocky swimming spots and a monastery.
- **Fort Lovrijenac** – A fortress on a cliff outside the walls, used for summer theatre performances.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Staying inside the old town is atmospheric but expensive and involves many steps. Ploče offers views of the old town and access to Banje Beach, while Lapad and Babin Kuk have beaches, promenades and resort hotels. Gruž, near the ferry port, is practical for island hopping.

■ Food & Drink

Dalmatian cuisine focuses on seafood, olive oil and fresh vegetables: try black risotto made with squid ink, grilled fish and oysters from nearby Ston. Peka, meat or octopus slow-cooked under an iron bell, often needs to be ordered in advance. Local wines include Plavac Mali reds from the Pelješac peninsula. Rozata, a custard pudding similar to crème caramel, is a local dessert.

■ When to Visit

Late spring and early autumn offer warm sea and fewer crowds. July and August are hot, crowded and expensive, though the Dubrovnik Summer Festival brings theatre and music to historic venues. Winters are mild and quiet, with many businesses closed.

■ Getting Around

The old town is pedestrian-only. Local buses connect the old town with Lapad, Gruž and the airport. Parking is scarce and expensive, so avoid driving into the centre.

■ Day Trips

Boat trips visit the Elaphiti Islands, and ferries reach Mljet National Park and Korčula. The fortified town of Ston has the longest walls in Europe and famous oysters. Kotor in Montenegro and Mostar in Bosnia and Herzegovina are popular cross-border day trips.

■ Practical Tips

- Check the cruise ship schedule and avoid the old town when several ships are in port.
- Buy the Dubrovnik Pass, which includes the city walls and several museums.
- Wear water shoes on rocky beaches.
- Carry water and sun protection on the walls; there is little shade.

Edinburgh

EUROPE

United Kingdom (Scotland) · Northern Europe

Scotland's dramatic capital of castles, closes and the world's largest arts festival.

Country	United Kingdom (Scotland)
Region	Northern Europe
Population (approx.)	~530,000
Language(s)	English (Scots and Scottish Gaelic also used)
Currency	Pound Sterling (GBP)
Main airport	Edinburgh Airport (EDI)
Best time to visit	May–September; August for festivals

■ Overview

Edinburgh, the capital of Scotland, is built on ancient volcanic hills and dominated by a castle on a rocky crag. The medieval Old Town and the elegant Georgian New Town together form a UNESCO World Heritage Site. The city was a centre of the Scottish Enlightenment and is associated with writers such as Sir Walter Scott, Robert Louis Stevenson and J. K. Rowling. Every August it hosts the Edinburgh Festival Fringe, the world's largest arts festival. With its narrow alleys, cosy pubs and dramatic views, Edinburgh is one of Europe's most atmospheric cities.

■ Top Attractions

- **Edinburgh Castle** – A fortress with the Scottish Crown Jewels, the Stone of Destiny and the One O'Clock Gun.
- **Royal Mile** – The historic street connecting the castle to the Palace of Holyroodhouse, full of closes, shops and pubs.
- **Arthur's Seat** – An extinct volcano in Holyrood Park offering a short but steep hike with panoramic views.
- **Palace of Holyroodhouse** – The official Scottish residence of the British monarch, associated with Mary, Queen of Scots.
- **National Museum of Scotland** – A free museum covering Scottish history, natural history and world cultures, with a rooftop terrace.
- **Calton Hill** – A hill with monuments and one of the best views of the city, especially at sunset.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The Old Town is atmospheric and central, while the New Town offers elegant streets, shops and restaurants. Stockbridge has a village feel, with a Sunday market, and Leith, the port area, is known for seafood restaurants and the Royal Yacht Britannia. Bruntsfield and Marchmont are residential and pleasant.

■ Food & Drink

Scotland's national dish is haggis, served with neeps and tatties (turnips and potatoes). Scottish salmon, Cullen skink (smoked haddock soup) and a full Scottish breakfast are popular. Whisky bars offer hundreds of single malts, and the Scotch Whisky Experience introduces the basics. Leith has several highly rated seafood restaurants.

■ When to Visit

Summer brings the longest days and the Edinburgh International Festival, Fringe and Royal Military Tattoo in August, when prices peak. Spring and autumn are quieter. Hogmanay, the New Year celebration, is one of the world's biggest street parties.

■ Getting Around

The city centre is walkable but hilly. Trams connect the airport with the city centre and Leith, and Lothian buses cover the rest of the city. Trains reach Glasgow in under an hour and London in about 4.5 hours.

■ Day Trips

Stirling Castle, Loch Lomond and the Scottish Highlands are popular day trips, with organised tours to Loch Ness and Glencoe. The Forth Bridges at South Queensferry and the seaside town of North Berwick are close by. St Andrews, the home of golf, is about 1.5 hours away.

■ Practical Tips

- Book accommodation many months ahead for August.
- Weather changes quickly; dress in layers.
- Many museums, including the National Museum and Scottish National Gallery, are free.
- Take a ghost or underground vaults tour for Edinburgh's dark history.

Florence

Italy · Southern Europe

EUROPE

The cradle of the Renaissance, filled with masterpieces of art and architecture.

Country	Italy
Region	Southern Europe
Population (approx.)	~360,000 (city); ~1 million (metro)
Language(s)	Italian
Currency	Euro (EUR)
Main airport	Florence Airport, Peretola (FLR); Pisa International Airport (PSA)
Best time to visit	April-June and September-October

■ Overview

Florence (Firenze), the capital of Tuscany, was the birthplace of the Renaissance and home to the powerful Medici family. The city nurtured geniuses such as Leonardo da Vinci, Michelangelo, Botticelli, Brunelleschi and Dante. Its historic centre is a UNESCO World Heritage Site packed with churches, palaces and museums holding some of the world's greatest art. Florence is compact and walkable, but also very crowded in peak season. Beyond art, it is famous for leather, gold jewellery, Tuscan cuisine and wine.

■ Top Attractions

- **Florence Cathedral (Duomo)** – The Cathedral of Santa Maria del Fiore with Brunelleschi's dome, Giotto's Bell Tower and the Baptistry; climbing the dome requires a timed ticket.
- **Uffizi Gallery** – One of the world's greatest art museums, with Botticelli's Birth of Venus and works by Leonardo, Raphael and Caravaggio.
- **Galleria dell'Accademia** – Home to Michelangelo's original David.
- **Ponte Vecchio** – A medieval bridge lined with jewellery shops over the Arno River.
- **Palazzo Pitti and Boboli Gardens** – A vast Medici palace with several museums and formal Renaissance gardens.
- **Piazzale Michelangelo** – A hilltop square with the classic panoramic view of Florence, best at sunset.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The Duomo and Santa Croce areas are central and full of sights. Oltrarno, across the river, is more authentic, with artisan workshops, piazzas and restaurants, especially around Santo Spirito. San Lorenzo, near the central market and station, is practical and good value.

■ Food & Drink

Tuscan food is simple and ingredient-focused: bistecca alla fiorentina (a huge T-bone steak served rare), ribollita (bread and vegetable soup), pappa al pomodoro and lampredotto (tripe sandwiches) from street stalls. The Mercato Centrale has a lively food hall upstairs. Gelato was reportedly developed in Florence, and Chianti wine comes from the hills just south of the city.

■ When to Visit

Spring and autumn are the best seasons, although crowds are present most of the year. Summer is hot and packed, and many locals leave in August. Winter is quieter and cheaper, making it ideal for museum visits.

■ Getting Around

The historic centre is best explored on foot, and much of it is closed to private cars (ZTL). A tram connects the airport and the main station, Santa Maria Novella. High-speed trains link Florence with Rome, Milan, Bologna and Venice.

■ Day Trips

Pisa and its Leaning Tower, Siena with its shell-shaped Piazza del Campo, and the medieval towers of San Gimignano are classic day trips. The Chianti wine region offers vineyard tours and tastings. Lucca, with intact Renaissance walls you can cycle on, is about an hour away.

■ Practical Tips

- Book the Uffizi, Accademia and Duomo climbs well in advance.
- Dress modestly in churches, covering shoulders and knees.
- Avoid driving into the ZTL zones, which result in automatic fines.
- Eat away from the main squares for better prices and quality.

Florianópolis

Brazil · South America

AMERICAS

"Magic Island", a relaxed city of 40+ beaches, lagoons and surf.

Country	Brazil
Region	South America
Population (approx.)	~540,000
Language(s)	Portuguese
Currency	Brazilian Real (BRL)
Main airport	Hercílio Luz International Airport (FLN)
Best time to visit	December–March for beaches; April–May for fewer crowds

■ Overview

Florianópolis, the capital of the southern Brazilian state of Santa Catarina, is mostly located on Santa Catarina Island. Nicknamed "Floripa" or "Ilha da Magia", it is known for its beaches, lagoons and relaxed lifestyle. The island blends Azorean Portuguese heritage with a modern surf and tech culture. Florianópolis has a high quality of life and is one of Brazil's safest capitals. It is a popular summer destination for Brazilians and Argentinians.

■ Top Attractions

- **Lagoa da Conceição** – A lagoon with restaurants, bars and water sports.
- **Joaquina Beach** – Famous for surfing and sand dunes for sandboarding.
- **Praia Mole** – A popular surf beach.
- **Santo Antônio de Lisboa** – A historic Azorean village known for oysters.
- **Hercílio Luz Bridge** – The city's iconic suspension bridge.
- **Campeche Island** – An island with clear water and rock carvings.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Lagoa da Conceição is lively. Jurerê Internacional is upscale, and Campeche is relaxed.

■ Food & Drink

Oysters are the local speciality. Seafood, sequência de camarão (shrimp tasting menu) and Brazilian barbecue are popular.

■ When to Visit

Summer is the high season. Winters are cool.

■ Getting Around

Buses and ride-hailing apps are common. Renting a car helps explore beaches.

■ Day Trips

Guarda do Embaú, Garopaba and Praia do Rosa are nearby beaches, with whale-watching season from July to November.

■ Practical Tips

- Book accommodation early for Carnival and New Year.
- Traffic is heavy in summer.
- Use sunscreen.
- Try fresh oysters.

Gdańsk

Poland · Central Europe

EUROPE

A Hanseatic port city of colourful gabled houses where the Second World War began.

Country	Poland
Region	Central Europe
Population (approx.)	~470,000 (city); ~1 million (Tricity metro)
Language(s)	Polish
Currency	Polish Złoty (PLN)
Main airport	Gdańsk Lech Wałęsa Airport (GDN)
Best time to visit	May–September

■ Overview

Gdańsk is a historic port city on the Baltic coast of Poland and the largest city of the Pomerania region. As a wealthy member of the Hanseatic League, it developed a rich merchant culture reflected in its ornate facades. The Second World War began here in 1939 at Westerplatte, and the Solidarity movement, which helped bring down communism, was born in the Gdańsk Shipyard in 1980. The city was heavily destroyed in 1945 and carefully rebuilt. Together with Sopot and Gdynia, it forms the Tricity, combining history, beaches and nightlife.

■ Top Attractions

- **Long Market and Long Lane (Długi Targ and Ulica Długa)** – The Royal Route lined with colourful townhouses, the Neptune Fountain and Artus Court.
- **St. Mary's Basilica** – One of the largest brick churches in the world, with a tower offering sweeping views.
- **European Solidarity Centre** – A modern museum telling the story of the Solidarity movement and the fall of communism.
- **Museum of the Second World War** – A large, powerful museum covering the war from a global and Polish perspective.
- **Motława riverfront and the Crane (Żuraw)** – A medieval port crane and a lively riverside promenade.
- **Westerplatte** – The site where the first shots of the Second World War were fired, with a monument and ruins.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The Main Town (Główne Miasto) is the most convenient area, close to all main sights. Granary Island (Wyspa Spichrzów) has new hotels and restaurants on the riverside. Oliwa, further north, is green and quiet, with a beautiful cathedral and park.

■ Food & Drink

Polish classics such as pierogi, żurek (sour rye soup) and bigos are widely available. Being on the Baltic, Gdańsk offers smoked and fried fish, especially herring and cod. Goldwasser, a herbal liqueur with gold flakes, originated here. Local craft beer is popular in pubs along the Motława.

■ When to Visit

Summer is the best time for beaches and outdoor events such as St. Dominic's Fair, one of Europe's largest open-air trade and culture fairs, held from late July to mid-August. Spring and early autumn are pleasant but cooler. Winters are cold and windy, though the Christmas market is charming.

■ Getting Around

Gdańsk has trams and buses, and the SKM commuter train links Gdańsk, Sopot and Gdynia. The main sights are walkable. The airport is connected by train (PKM) and bus.

■ Day Trips

Sopot, with its long wooden pier and beaches, is just 15–20 minutes away. Malbork Castle, the world's largest brick castle and former seat of the Teutonic Knights, is about 40 minutes by train. The Hel Peninsula and Słowiński National Park, with shifting sand dunes, are further options.

■ Practical Tips

- Amber is sold everywhere; buy from reputable shops with certificates.
- Visit museums early, as the Second World War Museum can take several hours.
- The Baltic Sea is cool even in summer.
- Card payments are accepted almost everywhere.

Geneva

Switzerland · Western Europe

EUROPE

An elegant international city on a lake, home to diplomacy, watchmaking and Alpine views.

Country	Switzerland
Region	Western Europe
Population (approx.)	~205,000 (city); ~1 million (cross-border metro)
Language(s)	French
Currency	Swiss Franc (CHF)
Main airport	Geneva Airport (GVA)
Best time to visit	May–September

■ Overview

Geneva sits at the southwestern tip of Lake Geneva (Lac Léman), surrounded by the Alps and the Jura mountains. It is one of the world's centres of international diplomacy, hosting the European headquarters of the United Nations, the Red Cross and dozens of international organisations. The city was a centre of the Protestant Reformation under John Calvin and is known for its precision watchmaking and private banking. Geneva is compact, clean and very expensive. Its lakefront, old town and nearby mountains make it a pleasant stop in any season.

■ Top Attractions

- **Jet d'Eau** – A giant fountain shooting water about 140 metres into the air, the symbol of Geneva.
- **Old Town and St. Pierre Cathedral** – Cobbled streets, antique shops and a cathedral whose towers offer views of the lake and Alps.
- **Palais des Nations** – The UN's European headquarters, open for guided tours with identification.
- **International Red Cross and Red Crescent Museum** – An engaging museum about humanitarian action.
- **Reformation Wall** – A monumental wall in Parc des Bastions depicting leaders of the Protestant Reformation.
- **CERN** – The European particle physics laboratory near the city offers free exhibitions and some guided tours.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The Pâquis area near the station is multicultural and has more affordable hotels and restaurants. The Old Town is historic and charming, while Carouge, a separate town with Italianate architecture, has artisan shops and bistros. The lakeside Quai du Mont-Blanc has luxury hotels.

■ Food & Drink

Swiss specialities such as cheese fondue and raclette are widely available, along with perch fillets from the lake. Geneva's own dishes include longeole (a spiced pork sausage) and cardon gratin. Swiss chocolate shops are everywhere, and the vineyards around Geneva produce good white wines. Eating out is expensive, so lunch menus offer better value.

■ When to Visit

Summer is ideal for lake swimming and outdoor cafés, with the Fêtes de Genève festival in some years. Spring and autumn are pleasant. Winter is cold but provides quick access to Alpine ski resorts, and the Escalade festival in December commemorates a 1602 victory.

■ Getting Around

Public transport is excellent, and hotel guests receive a free Geneva Transport Card. The airport is only about 7 minutes by train from the city centre. Yellow water taxis (Mouettes) cross the lake.

■ Day Trips

Chamonix and Mont Blanc in France are about an hour away. Lausanne, Montreux and the Château de Chillon lie along the lake, reachable by train or boat. Annecy, a French lakeside town with canals, is a popular trip.

■ Practical Tips

- Ask your hotel for the free public transport card.
- Budget carefully; Switzerland is among the most expensive countries in Europe.
- Swim in the lake at Bains des Pâquis, a local institution.
- Carry your passport for trips to nearby France.

George Town (Penang)

ASIA

Malaysia · Southeast Asia

A multicultural heritage city famous for street art and some of Asia's best street food.

Country	Malaysia
Region	Southeast Asia
Population (approx.)	~800,000 (city area); ~1.8 million (Penang state)
Language(s)	Malay, Hokkien, English, Tamil
Currency	Malaysian Ringgit (MYR)
Main airport	Penang International Airport (PEN)
Best time to visit	December–March

■ Overview

George Town, the capital of the Malaysian state of Penang, was founded by the British East India Company in 1786 as a trading port. Its historic centre, a UNESCO World Heritage Site, reflects centuries of Malay, Chinese, Indian and European influences. Shophouses, clan houses, mosques, temples and churches stand side by side. George Town is renowned for its street food, considered among the best in Asia. Its street art, including murals by Ernest Zacharevic, attracts visitors from around the world.

■ Top Attractions

- **Street art** – Murals and wrought-iron caricatures throughout the historic centre.
- **Khoo Kongsi** – An ornate Chinese clan house with intricate carvings.
- **Cheong Fatt Tze Mansion (The Blue Mansion)** – A restored 19th-century mansion.
- **Penang Hill** – A hill station reached by funicular, with cool air and views.
- **Kek Lok Si Temple** – One of the largest Buddhist temples in Southeast Asia.
- **Clan Jetties** – Waterfront villages on stilts built by Chinese clans.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The heritage zone is the best place to stay, with boutique hotels in shophouses. Gurney Drive offers modern hotels and food courts, while Batu Ferringhi is the beach area.

■ Food & Drink

Penang is famous for char kway teow (fried flat noodles), assam laksa (sour fish noodle soup), nasi kandar, cendol and Hokkien mee. Hawker centres like Gurney Drive and New Lane are great for sampling dishes. Nyonya (Peranakan) cuisine blends Chinese and Malay flavours.

■ When to Visit

December to March is the driest period. Chinese New Year and Thaipusam are colourful festivals. Rain is possible year-round.

■ Getting Around

The heritage centre is walkable, and bicycles or trishaws are fun. Grab is widely used. Free CAT buses serve the central area.

■ Day Trips

Penang National Park offers jungle trails and beaches. Langkawi is reachable by ferry or plane. The Cameron Highlands and Ipoh are on the mainland.

■ Practical Tips

- Hawker stalls often have specific opening hours; check before going.
- Dress modestly in mosques and temples.
- Bring an umbrella for sudden rain.
- Carry cash for hawker stalls.

Granada

Spain · Southern Europe

EUROPE

The last Moorish kingdom of Spain, crowned by the magnificent Alhambra.

Country	Spain
Region	Southern Europe
Population (approx.)	~230,000
Language(s)	Spanish
Currency	Euro (EUR)
Main airport	Federico García Lorca Granada Airport (GRX); Málaga Airport (AGP) is 1.5 hours away
Best time to visit	March–June and September–November

■ Overview

Granada lies at the foot of the Sierra Nevada mountains in Andalusia and was the last stronghold of Muslim rule in Spain until 1492. Its greatest treasure is the Alhambra, a breathtaking palace and fortress complex that is one of the most visited monuments in Europe. The city combines Moorish heritage, Christian Renaissance architecture and a lively student population. Granada is also known for its tradition of free tapas served with drinks. The views of the Alhambra against the snow-capped Sierra Nevada are unforgettable.

■ Top Attractions

- **Alhambra** – A UNESCO-listed complex including the Nasrid Palaces with intricate stucco work, the Alcazaba fortress and the Generalife gardens.
- **Albaicín** – The old Moorish quarter of whitewashed houses and narrow lanes on a hill facing the Alhambra.
- **Mirador de San Nicolás** – The most famous viewpoint for the Alhambra, especially at sunset.
- **Granada Cathedral and Royal Chapel** – The Royal Chapel holds the tombs of Ferdinand and Isabella, the Catholic Monarchs.
- **Sacromonte** – A neighbourhood of cave houses associated with the Roma community and flamenco performances.
- **Carrera del Darro** – A picturesque street along the Darro River beneath the Alhambra.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The Centro around the cathedral is convenient for sightseeing and tapas bars. The Albaicín offers charming guesthouses with views but involves steep climbs. Realejo, the former Jewish quarter, has street art and a local feel.

■ Food & Drink

In many Granada bars, ordering a drink comes with a free tapa, making tapas-hopping a local tradition. Try habas con jamón (broad beans with ham), tortilla del Sacromonte and piononos, small pastries from nearby Santa Fe. Moroccan-style tea houses (teterías) line Calle Calderería. Plaza Bib-Rambla is known for churros with chocolate.

■ When to Visit

Spring is the best season, with blooming gardens and mild temperatures. Summers are very hot, while winters are cold but sunny, and skiing is possible in the Sierra Nevada. Holy Week (Semana Santa) and the Corpus Christi fair are major festivals.

■ Getting Around

The centre is walkable, though the Albaicín and Alhambra are uphill; small minibuses serve these areas. The metro-tram links the city with suburbs. Buses and trains connect Granada with Seville, Córdoba and Málaga.

■ Day Trips

The Sierra Nevada offers hiking in summer and skiing in winter. The Alpujarras, a region of white villages on the southern slopes of the mountains, is very scenic. The Costa Tropical beaches are about an hour south.

■ Practical Tips

- Alhambra tickets sell out weeks or months ahead; book only through the official website.
- Your Nasrid Palaces ticket has a fixed entry time that is strictly enforced.
- Bring your passport or ID to the Alhambra, as names are checked.
- Order drinks at the bar to receive free tapas.

Guadalajara

Mexico · North America

AMERICAS

The birthplace of mariachi and tequila, with colonial plazas and a creative spirit.

Country	Mexico
Region	North America
Population (approx.)	~1.4 million (city); ~5.3 million (metro)
Language(s)	Spanish
Currency	Mexican Peso (MXN)
Main airport	Miguel Hidalgo y Costilla Guadalajara International Airport (GDL)
Best time to visit	October–May

■ Overview

Guadalajara, the capital of Jalisco, is Mexico's second-largest city. It is considered the heart of Mexican traditions such as mariachi music, tequila and charrería (Mexican rodeo). The historic centre features grand plazas, colonial buildings and murals by José Clemente Orozco. Guadalajara is also a growing technology hub, sometimes called Mexico's "Silicon Valley". It will host matches of the 2026 FIFA World Cup.

■ Top Attractions

- **Hospicio Cabañas** – A UNESCO-listed building with Orozco's murals, including "Man of Fire".
- **Guadalajara Cathedral** – A cathedral with twin spires.
- **Tlaquepaque** – A colourful neighbourhood with crafts and mariachi.
- **Mercado San Juan de Dios** – One of Latin America's largest indoor markets.
- **Plaza de los Mariachis** – Live mariachi performances.
- **Chapultepec Avenue** – Nightlife and restaurants.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Centro Histórico, Colonia Americana and Chapultepec are popular.

■ Food & Drink

Birria (spiced meat stew), torta ahogada (a sandwich drowned in sauce) and tejuino (fermented corn drink) are local specialities.

■ When to Visit

October to May is dry and pleasant. The International Mariachi Festival takes place in late August/September.

■ **Getting Around**

Light rail, buses and ride-hailing apps are available.

■ **Day Trips**

Tequila, the town, offers distillery tours. Lake Chapala is nearby.

■ **Practical Tips**

- Take the Jose Cuervo Express train to Tequila.
- Use ride-hailing apps.
- Try birria for breakfast.
- Check travel advisories.

Guilin

China · East Asia

ASIA

A dreamlike landscape of karst peaks, winding rivers and rice terraces.

Country	China
Region	East Asia
Population (approx.)	~5 million (prefecture); ~2 million (urban area)
Language(s)	Mandarin Chinese (Zhuang and local dialects also spoken)
Currency	Chinese Yuan Renminbi (CNY)
Main airport	Guilin Liangjiang International Airport (KWL)
Best time to visit	April-May and September-November

■ Overview

Guilin, in the Guangxi Zhuang Autonomous Region of southern China, is famous for its dramatic karst scenery of limestone peaks rising abruptly from rivers and rice fields. The landscape has inspired Chinese painters and poets for over a thousand years, and a view of the Li River appears on the back of the 20-yuan banknote. The city itself is pleasant and green, built around rivers and lakes, but most visitors come for the countryside. Guilin is the gateway to the Li River cruise, the backpacker town of Yangshuo and the Longji rice terraces. The region is home to ethnic minorities such as the Zhuang, Yao and Dong, whose villages and traditions add cultural depth to a visit.

■ Top Attractions

- **Li River cruise** – A four- to five-hour cruise from Guilin to Yangshuo through some of China's most famous scenery, passing peaks with evocative names such as Nine Horses Fresco Hill.
- **Reed Flute Cave** – A limestone cave filled with stalactites and stalagmites, illuminated by colourful lights, with visitor inscriptions dating back more than 1,200 years to the Tang dynasty.
- **Elephant Trunk Hill** – The symbol of Guilin, a rock formation that resembles an elephant drinking from the Li River.
- **Longji (Dragon's Backbone) Rice Terraces** – Spectacular terraced fields carved into the mountainsides by Zhuang and Yao farmers, with villages such as Ping'an and Dazhai.
- **Two Rivers and Four Lakes** – A scenic loop in the city centre with the Sun and Moon Pagodas, beautifully lit at night and explored by boat.
- **Yangshuo** – A lively town surrounded by karst peaks, ideal for cycling, rock climbing, bamboo rafting and the Impression Liu Sanjie outdoor light show.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Central Guilin near Zhengyang pedestrian street and the Shan and Rong lakes is convenient for sightseeing, dining and transport. Yangshuo, about 1.5 hours away, offers both lively West Street and quiet countryside guesthouses among the peaks. Many travellers spend one night in Guilin and several in Yangshuo or at the rice terraces.

■ Food & Drink

Guilin rice noodles (mifen) served with braised meat, peanuts and pickles are the city's signature breakfast. Beer fish, cooked with local beer, tomatoes and chillies, is Yangshuo's famous dish. Stuffed dishes (niang), such as stuffed snails or tofu, are typical of the region. In minority villages, try oil tea (youcha), a savoury tea soup, and bamboo-tube rice.

■ When to Visit

Spring and autumn offer the most pleasant temperatures and clear views. Summer is hot and rainy, but the rivers are full and the terraces are green. The rice terraces look most spectacular when flooded in spring (May–June) and golden before the harvest in late September and October.

■ Getting Around

Guilin is connected by high-speed rail to Guangzhou, Shenzhen, Guiyang and other cities, and Yangshuo has its own station on the high-speed line. Within the city, taxis, buses and DiDi ride-hailing are convenient. In Yangshuo, bicycles and electric scooters are the best way to explore the countryside.

■ Day Trips

The Longji Rice Terraces are a full-day trip or an overnight stay. Bamboo rafting on the Yulong River near Yangshuo is a peaceful alternative to the Li River cruise. The ancient towns of Xingping and Huangyao offer traditional architecture and fewer crowds.

■ Practical Tips

- Book Li River cruise tickets in advance during holidays, and bring your passport.
- Mobile payments (Alipay, WeChat Pay) are essential; set them up before arrival.
- Pack rain gear and insect repellent in summer.
- Avoid Chinese national holidays, when the Li River and Yangshuo become extremely crowded.

Hamburg

Germany · Central Europe

EUROPE

Germany's gateway to the world, a maritime city of canals, warehouses and music.

Country	Germany
Region	Central Europe
Population (approx.)	~1.9 million (city); ~5.4 million (metro)
Language(s)	German
Currency	Euro (EUR)
Main airport	Hamburg Airport (HAM)
Best time to visit	May–September

■ Overview

Hamburg is Germany's second-largest city and one of Europe's biggest ports, located on the Elbe River. A former Hanseatic city-state, it still has a proud, independent character and considerable wealth. Hamburg has more bridges than Venice and Amsterdam combined, and its canals, lakes and harbour give it a maritime atmosphere. The city is known for its music scene, where the Beatles played in the early 1960s, its famous red-light district, and the spectacular Elbphilharmonie concert hall. It combines elegance with an edgy nightlife.

■ Top Attractions

- **Elbphilharmonie** – A concert hall built on top of an old warehouse, with a free public viewing platform (Plaza) offering harbour views.
- **Speicherstadt** – The world's largest warehouse district, built on oak piles, is a UNESCO World Heritage Site.
- **Miniatur Wunderland** – The world's largest model railway exhibition, beloved by adults and children.
- **Port of Hamburg and Landungsbrücken** – Harbour boat tours depart from the historic piers.
- **Reeperbahn and St. Pauli** – Hamburg's famous nightlife district with bars, clubs, theatres and Beatles-Platz.
- **Alster Lakes** – Two lakes in the city centre, surrounded by elegant buildings, perfect for walks and boat trips.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The Altstadt and Neustadt are central, with shopping and sights. St. Pauli and the Schanzenviertel are alternative and lively, while Ottensen is trendy with cafés. HafenCity is a modern waterfront district near the Elbphilharmonie, and Blankenese is an upscale riverside village.

■ Food & Drink

Hamburg's signature dishes include Fischbrötchen (fish sandwiches), Labskaus (corned beef, beetroot and potatoes, often with a fried egg) and Franzbrötchen, a cinnamon pastry. The Sunday morning Fischmarkt in St. Pauli is an institution, with market criers and live music. The city has excellent seafood and international restaurants.

■ When to Visit

Summer is the most pleasant season, with outdoor events like the Hamburger DOM funfair (held three times a year) and harbour festivals. Rain is common year-round. December brings many Christmas markets.

■ Getting Around

U-Bahn, S-Bahn, buses and harbour ferries are well integrated; ferry line 62 is a cheap alternative to a harbour tour. The S-Bahn connects the airport with the centre in about 25 minutes. Trains reach Berlin in under two hours.

■ Day Trips

Lübeck, the medieval "Queen of the Hanseatic League", is about 45 minutes away and famous for marzipan. The seaside resort of Travemünde and the Baltic coast are close. Lüneburg, with its brick architecture and salt history, is another easy trip.

■ Practical Tips

- Book Elbphilharmonie concerts well ahead; the Plaza can be visited with a free timed ticket.
- Arrive early at the Fischmarkt on Sunday (around 5-9:30 am in summer).
- Buy tickets for Miniatur Wunderland online to avoid long queues.
- Pack a light raincoat.

Hangzhou

China · East Asia

ASIA

A poetic city of West Lake, tea plantations, temples and pagodas.

Country	China
Region	East Asia
Population (approx.)	~12.5 million (municipality)
Language(s)	Mandarin Chinese (Wu dialect locally)
Currency	Chinese Yuan Renminbi (CNY)
Main airport	Hangzhou Xiaoshan International Airport (HGH)
Best time to visit	March–May and September–November

■ Overview

Hangzhou, the capital of Zhejiang Province, is one of China's most beautiful and historic cities, located at the southern end of the Grand Canal. It served as the capital of the Southern Song dynasty in the 12th and 13th centuries, when it was among the largest and richest cities in the world. A traditional Chinese saying claims "Above there is heaven, below there are Suzhou and Hangzhou." The city's highlight is West Lake, a UNESCO World Heritage Site surrounded by hills, gardens, temples and causeways. Today Hangzhou is also a modern technology hub, home to Alibaba, and hosted the 2023 Asian Games.

■ Top Attractions

- **West Lake (Xi Hu)** – A scenic lake with the Su and Bai causeways, islands, willow-lined paths and classic views such as "Three Pools Mirroring the Moon".
- **Lingyin Temple** – One of China's largest and most important Buddhist temples, founded in 328 AD, with hundreds of rock carvings at nearby Feilai Feng.
- **Longjing tea villages** – Hills of tea terraces where the famous Dragon Well green tea is grown; visit villages like Meijiawu and Longjing for tastings.
- **Leifeng Pagoda** – A rebuilt pagoda linked to the Legend of the White Snake, with views over the lake at sunset.
- **Hefang Street and Qinghefang** – Historic streets with traditional shops, snacks, herbal pharmacies and teahouses.
- **Grand Canal** – The world's longest artificial waterway, with preserved canal-side neighbourhoods such as Qiaoxi and boat rides.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Staying around West Lake, especially the Hubin area, puts you close to the main sights, shopping and restaurants. Wulin Square is a central commercial area with good transport connections. Quieter hotels are found in the hills west of the lake and near the tea villages.

■ Food & Drink

Hangzhou cuisine is known for fresh, delicate and slightly sweet flavours. Famous dishes include West Lake vinegar fish, Dongpo pork (braised pork belly named after the poet Su Dongpo), beggar's chicken baked in clay, and Longjing shrimp stir-fried with tea leaves. Pian'erchuan noodles and scallion pancakes are popular everyday foods. Drinking freshly picked Longjing tea in spring is a highlight.

■ When to Visit

Spring brings blooming peach blossoms and the first tea harvest, and autumn offers osmanthus scent and clear weather. Summers are hot and humid, with lotus flowers covering parts of West Lake. Winters are cold and damp, but "broken bridge in snow" is a celebrated scene.

■ Getting Around

Hangzhou has a modern metro network, a large public bike-share system and plentiful DiDi taxis. The area around West Lake is best explored on foot or by bike. High-speed trains reach Shanghai in about an hour, and the airport is connected by metro.

■ Day Trips

The water towns of Wuzhen and Xitang, with canals and stone bridges, are easy trips. Qiandao Lake (Thousand Island Lake) offers scenic islands, and Moganshan is a mountain retreat with bamboo forests. Shanghai and Suzhou are also close by high-speed rail.

■ Practical Tips

- Rent a bike or walk around West Lake early in the morning to avoid crowds.
- Avoid visiting during national holidays, when the lake becomes extremely crowded.
- Carry your passport for train tickets, some attractions and hotel check-in.
- Buy tea directly from farmers in the tea villages, but check quality and price.

Hanoi

Vietnam · Southeast Asia

ASIA

Vietnam's atmospheric capital of lakes, French colonial architecture and street food.

Country	Vietnam
Region	Southeast Asia
Population (approx.)	~8.5 million
Language(s)	Vietnamese
Currency	Vietnamese Dong (VND)
Main airport	Noi Bai International Airport (HAN)
Best time to visit	October–December and March–April

■ Overview

Hanoi, the capital of Vietnam, celebrated its 1,000th anniversary in 2010 and blends Vietnamese, Chinese and French influences. The city is built around lakes, with tree-lined boulevards from the French colonial era and a bustling Old Quarter whose streets were once named after the goods sold there. Hanoi is more traditional and reserved than Ho Chi Minh City, yet full of energy, with motorbikes, street vendors and pavement cafés everywhere. It is one of the best street food cities in the world. Hanoi is also the starting point for trips to Ha Long Bay, Ninh Binh and the mountains of Sapa.

■ Top Attractions

- **Hoan Kiem Lake** – The heart of the city, with the red Huc Bridge leading to Ngoc Son Temple; on weekend evenings, surrounding streets become pedestrian zones.
- **Old Quarter** – A maze of narrow streets with tube houses, temples, markets and countless food stalls.
- **Ho Chi Minh Mausoleum and Complex** – The embalmed body of Vietnam's revolutionary leader, his stilt house and the One Pillar Pagoda; strict dress codes apply.
- **Temple of Literature** – Built in 1070 and dedicated to Confucius, it housed Vietnam's first national university.
- **Hoa Lo Prison** – A museum in a French colonial prison later used for American POWs, nicknamed the "Hanoi Hilton".
- **Vietnam Museum of Ethnology** – An excellent museum about Vietnam's 54 ethnic groups, with traditional houses in the garden.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The Old Quarter is lively and ideal for first-time visitors, with many budget and boutique hotels. The French Quarter, south of Hoan Kiem Lake, is elegant, with the Opera House and upscale hotels. Tay Ho (West Lake) is quieter and popular with expats, with lakeside cafés and restaurants.

■ Food & Drink

Pho originated in northern Vietnam, and Hanoi's clear-broth beef pho is famous. Bun cha, grilled pork with rice noodles and herbs, became internationally known after Barack Obama and Anthony Bourdain ate it here. Cha ca La Vong (turmeric fish with dill), banh cuon (steamed rice rolls) and bun rieu (crab noodle soup) are local favourites. Egg coffee (ca phe trung), invented in Hanoi, is a must-try.

■ When to Visit

Autumn and spring are the most pleasant times. Summers (May–September) are hot, humid and rainy, while winters (December–February) can be surprisingly cool and grey. Tet, the Lunar New Year, is a festive but quiet time when many businesses close.

■ Getting Around

Walking is ideal in the Old Quarter, but crossing the street requires a slow, steady pace. Grab and other ride-hailing apps offer cheap cars and motorbike taxis. Hanoi's metro lines are expanding, and buses are cheap but can be confusing.

■ Day Trips

Ha Long Bay and the quieter Lan Ha Bay, with thousands of limestone islands, are best experienced on an overnight cruise. Ninh Binh, called "Ha Long Bay on land", offers boat rides through karst landscapes at Trang An and Tam Coc. Sapa, in the northern mountains, is famous for trekking through rice terraces and ethnic minority villages.

■ Practical Tips

- Cross streets slowly and predictably so motorbikes can steer around you.
- Check e-visa requirements before travelling.
- Carry small cash notes for street food and markets.
- Dress modestly at the mausoleum, temples and pagodas.

Havana

Cuba · Caribbean

AMERICAS

A time-capsule city of colonial architecture, vintage cars and music.

Country	Cuba
Region	Caribbean
Population (approx.)	~2.1 million
Language(s)	Spanish
Currency	Cuban Peso (CUP); foreign currency and cards are accepted in some places
Main airport	José Martí International Airport (HAV)
Best time to visit	November–April

■ Overview

Havana, the capital of Cuba, is famous for its crumbling colonial architecture, 1950s American cars and vibrant music scene. Founded by the Spanish in 1519, it was a key port of the Spanish Empire. Old Havana (La Habana Vieja) and its fortifications are a UNESCO World Heritage Site. The city has faced economic hardship, shortages and power outages in recent years. Visitors should be prepared for limited infrastructure, but the atmosphere remains unique.

■ Top Attractions

- **Old Havana** – Restored plazas, colonial buildings and museums.
- **Malecón** – An 8-kilometre seafront promenade.
- **El Capitolio** – A grand building resembling the US Capitol.
- **Plaza de la Revolución** – A square with images of Che Guevara and Camilo Cienfuegos.
- **Fusterlandia** – A neighbourhood decorated with mosaics by artist José Fuster.
- **Morro Castle** – A fortress guarding the harbour entrance.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Old Havana, Centro Habana and Vedado are popular. Casas particulares (private homestays) are common.

■ Food & Drink

Cuban dishes include ropa vieja (shredded beef), moros y cristianos (black beans and rice) and tostones. Paladares (private restaurants) offer the best meals. Mojitos and daiquiris are classic cocktails.

■ When to Visit

November to April is the dry season. Hurricane season runs from June to November.

■ Getting Around

Taxis, including classic cars, are common. The city is walkable.

■ Day Trips

Viñales, with tobacco farms, and Varadero's beaches are popular.

■ Practical Tips

- Bring enough cash in euros or US dollars; ATMs may be unreliable, and many foreign cards (especially US) do not work.
- US citizens face travel restrictions.
- Expect power and internet outages.
- Stay in casas particulares.

Helsinki

Finland · Northern Europe

EUROPE

A seaside capital of design, saunas and neoclassical squares.

Country	Finland
Region	Northern Europe
Population (approx.)	~680,000 (city); ~1.6 million (metro)
Language(s)	Finnish and Swedish
Currency	Euro (EUR)
Main airport	Helsinki-Vantaa Airport (HEL)
Best time to visit	June–August; December–March for winter experiences

■ Overview

Helsinki, the capital of Finland, sits on a peninsula surrounded by the Baltic Sea and hundreds of islands. Founded by the Swedish king in 1550 and later rebuilt under Russian rule, it has an elegant neoclassical centre and a wealth of Art Nouveau and modern architecture. Finland is known for design, education and consistently ranking among the happiest countries in the world. Saunas are central to Finnish culture, and Helsinki has several spectacular public ones. The city is calm, clean and easy to navigate, with nature always close by.

■ Top Attractions

- **Senate Square and Helsinki Cathedral** – The white, green-domed Lutheran cathedral towers over a neoclassical square.
- **Suomenlinna** – A UNESCO-listed sea fortress spread across several islands, reached by a 15-minute public ferry.
- **Market Square and Old Market Hall** – Harbour-side stalls selling fish, berries and souvenirs, and a historic indoor food hall.
- **Temppeliaukio Church (Rock Church)** – A church carved directly into solid rock with a copper dome.
- **Oodi Central Library** – A striking modern library with maker spaces, cafés and a terrace.
- **Löyly and Allas Sea Pool** – Modern public saunas where you can dip into the sea, even in winter.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Kluuvi and Kamppi are central and convenient for shopping and transport. Punavuori and the Design District are packed with boutiques and galleries, while Kallio is a bohemian former working-class area with bars. Töölö is residential and close to parks and museums.

■ Food & Drink

Finnish cuisine features salmon, reindeer, rye bread and wild berries. Try salmon soup (lohikeitto), Karelian pies (rice-filled rye pastries) and cinnamon buns (korvapuusti). Salmiakki, a salty liquorice, divides opinions. Helsinki has a growing New Nordic restaurant scene and many cosy cafés.

■ When to Visit

Summer brings very long days, open-air cafés and island trips. Winter is dark and cold but offers ice-swimming, saunas and a magical atmosphere, especially around Christmas. Spring and autumn are cooler and quieter.

■ Getting Around

Helsinki has trams, buses, a metro and ferries operated by HSL, and a train connects the airport with the centre in about 30 minutes. The centre is walkable. Ferries link Helsinki with Tallinn and Stockholm.

■ Day Trips

Tallinn in Estonia is about two hours away by fast ferry. Porvoo, Finland's second-oldest town with red riverside warehouses, is an hour by bus. Nuuksio National Park offers forests and lakes close to the city.

■ Practical Tips

- Bring a swimsuit for public saunas, although some traditional saunas are nude and gender-separated.
- Buy transport tickets using the HSL app.
- Tap water is excellent.
- Tipping is not expected, but rounding up is appreciated.

Hiroshima

Japan · East Asia

ASIA

A city of peace and resilience, and the gateway to the sacred island of Miyajima.

Country	Japan
Region	East Asia
Population (approx.)	~1.2 million
Language(s)	Japanese
Currency	Japanese Yen (JPY)
Main airport	Hiroshima Airport (HIJ)
Best time to visit	March–May and October–November

■ Overview

Hiroshima is a city in western Japan on the Seto Inland Sea, founded as a castle town in 1589. On 6 August 1945, it became the first city in the world to be destroyed by an atomic bomb, killing tens of thousands instantly and many more in the following months. Rebuilt as a "City of Peace", Hiroshima today is a lively, green city with wide boulevards, rivers and a warm, welcoming atmosphere. The Peace Memorial Park and Museum are among the most moving places in Japan. Nearby Miyajima Island, with its famous "floating" torii gate, is one of the country's three most scenic views.

■ Top Attractions

- **Peace Memorial Park** – A large park with memorials, including the Cenotaph, the Flame of Peace and the Children's Peace Monument, decorated with thousands of paper cranes.
- **Atomic Bomb Dome (Genbaku Dome)** – The skeletal ruin of a building near the hypocentre, preserved as a UNESCO World Heritage Site.
- **Hiroshima Peace Memorial Museum** – A powerful museum documenting the bombing, its victims and the effects of nuclear weapons.
- **Hiroshima Castle** – A reconstructed castle with a museum on samurai culture and the city's history.
- **Shukkeien Garden** – A beautiful traditional garden with a pond, bridges and teahouses, designed in 1620.
- **Itsukushima Shrine on Miyajima** – A shrine built over the water with a large vermilion torii gate that appears to float at high tide.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The area around Hiroshima Station is convenient for Shinkansen travellers. Staying near the Peace Park, Hondori shopping arcade or Nagarekawa entertainment district puts you close to restaurants and sights. On Miyajima, traditional ryokan inns offer a peaceful overnight experience once the day-trippers leave.

■ Food & Drink

Hiroshima-style okonomiyaki is a layered savoury pancake with cabbage, noodles, pork and egg, cooked on a griddle in front of you; Okonomimura is a building filled with okonomiyaki stalls. The region is famous for oysters, served grilled, fried or raw. Tsukemen with spicy dipping sauce is a local noodle favourite. On Miyajima, try grilled conger eel on rice (anago-meshi) and momiji manju, maple-leaf-shaped cakes.

■ When to Visit

Spring cherry blossoms and autumn leaves make these seasons the most beautiful. Summer is hot and humid, and the Peace Memorial Ceremony on 6 August, followed by a lantern-floating ceremony, draws many visitors. Winter is mild and a good time for oysters.

■ Getting Around

Hiroshima's tram network is the easiest way to get around the city. The Shinkansen connects Hiroshima with Osaka in about 1.5 hours and Tokyo in about four hours. JR trains and ferries link the city with Miyajima in under an hour.

■ Day Trips

Miyajima is the essential day trip, with hiking or a ropeway up Mount Misen. Onomichi, a hillside port town, is the starting point of the Shimanami Kaido cycling route across islands. Kurashiki, with its preserved canal district, and Okunoshima, known as "Rabbit Island", are other options.

■ Practical Tips

- The JR Pass covers the JR ferry to Miyajima.
- Miyajima charges a small visitor tax to all visitors.
- Check tide times to see the torii gate both "floating" and at low tide.
- Allow at least two hours for the Peace Memorial Museum.

Ho Chi Minh City

Vietnam · Southeast Asia

ASIA

Vietnam's dynamic economic hub, still widely known as Saigon.

Country	Vietnam
Region	Southeast Asia
Population (approx.)	~9.5 million (city); over 13 million (metro)
Language(s)	Vietnamese
Currency	Vietnamese Dong (VND)
Main airport	Tan Son Nhat International Airport (SGN)
Best time to visit	December–April

■ Overview

Ho Chi Minh City, still commonly called Saigon, is Vietnam's largest city and its economic powerhouse, located in the south near the Mekong Delta. It was the capital of French Cochinchina and later of South Vietnam until the end of the Vietnam War in 1975, after which it was renamed after the revolutionary leader. The city is fast-paced and entrepreneurial, with gleaming skyscrapers, French colonial landmarks, rooftop bars and buzzing markets. Millions of motorbikes fill the streets, creating a vivid, noisy atmosphere. It is also a good base for exploring the Mekong Delta and the Cu Chi Tunnels.

■ Top Attractions

- **War Remnants Museum** – A sobering museum about the Vietnam War, with photographs and military equipment.
- **Independence Palace** – The former presidential palace of South Vietnam, preserved as it was in 1975, including bunkers and war rooms.
- **Notre-Dame Cathedral Basilica and Central Post Office** – French colonial landmarks built in the late 19th century; the cathedral has been undergoing restoration.
- **Ben Thanh Market** – A busy market selling food, textiles and souvenirs, with food stalls inside and a night market nearby.
- **Nguyen Hue Walking Street** – A pedestrian boulevard leading to the People's Committee Building, lively in the evenings.
- **Bitexco Financial Tower and Landmark 81** – Skyscrapers with observation decks and bars offering views over the city.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

District 1 is the central tourist area, with most sights, hotels, restaurants and nightlife, including the backpacker hub of Bui Vien Street. District 3 has leafy streets, local restaurants and cafés. Thao Dien, now part of Thu Duc City, is popular with expats and has riverside restaurants and boutiques.

■ Food & Drink

Southern Vietnamese cuisine is sweeter and richer in herbs than northern food. Try com tam (broken rice with grilled pork), banh mi, hu tieu (noodle soup), banh xeo (crispy pancakes) and fresh spring rolls. Pho is also everywhere. Vietnamese coffee, especially iced coffee with condensed milk (ca phe sua da), is a daily ritual.

■ When to Visit

The dry season from December to April is the best time to visit. The rainy season (May–November) brings short but heavy afternoon downpours. Tet, the Lunar New Year, is festive, though many businesses close for several days.

■ Getting Around

Grab and other ride-hailing apps offer cheap car and motorbike rides. The city's first metro line, from Ben Thanh to Thu Duc, opened in December 2024. Traffic is intense, so walking requires care, especially when crossing streets.

■ Day Trips

The Cu Chi Tunnels, used by Viet Cong fighters, are about 1.5 hours away. The Mekong Delta offers floating markets, canals, fruit orchards and river life around towns like Can Tho and Ben Tre. Vung Tau is a beach town reachable by fast boat or road.

■ Practical Tips

- Keep phones and bags secure; snatch theft from motorbikes happens.
- Cross streets slowly and steadily.
- Carry small cash for markets and street food.
- Check Vietnamese e-visa rules before travelling.

Hoi An

Vietnam · Southeast Asia

ASIA

A lantern-lit ancient trading port of yellow houses, tailors and riverside charm.

Country	Vietnam
Region	Southeast Asia
Population (approx.)	~120,000
Language(s)	Vietnamese
Currency	Vietnamese Dong (VND)
Main airport	Da Nang International Airport (DAD), about 45 minutes away
Best time to visit	February–July

■ Overview

Hoi An is a small city on the Thu Bon River in central Vietnam, once one of Southeast Asia's busiest trading ports between the 15th and 19th centuries. Merchants from China, Japan, India and Europe settled here, leaving behind a remarkable blend of architecture. When the river silted up and trade moved to Da Nang, Hoi An was left largely untouched, preserving its old town, now a UNESCO World Heritage Site. Today its mustard-yellow houses, wooden shopfronts and silk lanterns make it one of Vietnam's most atmospheric destinations. Hoi An is also famous for its tailors, cooking classes and nearby beaches.

■ Top Attractions

- **Ancient Town** – A beautifully preserved district of merchant houses, assembly halls and temples; an entrance ticket covers access to several historic buildings.
- **Japanese Covered Bridge** – A 16th-century bridge and the symbol of Hoi An, recently restored.
- **Assembly halls** – Ornate Chinese community halls such as the Fujian Assembly Hall, decorated with dragons and incense coils.
- **Lantern-lit riverside** – In the evening, silk lanterns illuminate the streets and visitors float candles on the river from small boats.
- **An Bang and Cua Dai beaches** – Sandy beaches a short bike ride from the old town, with beach bars and seafood restaurants.
- **Tra Que Vegetable Village** – A farming village where visitors can join gardening and cooking experiences.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Staying in or near the Ancient Town gives easy access to sights and restaurants but can be busy. Riverside homestays and villas in Cam Thanh or among the rice fields offer quiet surroundings. An Bang Beach is ideal for travellers who want a beach base with the old town nearby.

■ Food & Drink

Hoi An has several unique dishes: cao lau, thick noodles with pork and herbs traditionally made with water from a local well; white rose dumplings (banh bao vac); and com ga, Hoi An chicken rice. Banh mi from famous shops such as Banh Mi Phuong is a must. The central market offers cheap, delicious meals, and cooking classes often include a market tour and basket-boat ride.

■ When to Visit

February to July is generally dry and sunny, with the hottest months in June and July. The rainy season from September to December can bring floods to the old town. The full-moon lantern festival, held monthly, turns off electric lights in favour of lanterns.

■ Getting Around

The Ancient Town is pedestrian-friendly and restricted for vehicles at certain times. Bicycles are the best way to reach beaches and rice fields. Da Nang Airport is about 45 minutes away by taxi or Grab.

■ Day Trips

My Son Sanctuary, a complex of ancient Hindu temples built by the Champa kingdom, is about an hour away. The Cham Islands offer snorkelling and diving. Da Nang, the Marble Mountains and Ba Na Hills are close by.

■ Practical Tips

- Order tailored clothes early in your stay to allow time for fittings.
- Buy the Ancient Town ticket; checkpoints may ask for it.
- Check flood warnings in October and November.
- Bargain politely at markets and shops.

Hong Kong

ASIA

China (Hong Kong SAR) · East Asia

A dazzling skyline, dim sum, harbour views and surprisingly wild mountains.

Country	China (Hong Kong SAR)
Region	East Asia
Population (approx.)	~7.5 million
Language(s)	Cantonese and English (Mandarin widely understood)
Currency	Hong Kong Dollar (HKD)
Main airport	Hong Kong International Airport (HKG)
Best time to visit	October–December

■ Overview

Hong Kong is a Special Administrative Region of China, located on the southern coast next to Shenzhen. It was a British colony for over 150 years until its handover to China in 1997, and it retains a distinctive mix of Chinese and Western influences. Hong Kong is famous for its spectacular skyline, busy harbour, shopping and food. Beyond the skyscrapers, around three-quarters of its territory is countryside, including mountains, beaches and islands with excellent hiking. It is efficient, safe and easy to navigate.

■ Top Attractions

- **Victoria Peak** – Reached by the historic Peak Tram, it offers the city's most famous skyline view.
- **Victoria Harbour and Star Ferry** – A cheap ferry ride across the harbour, with the Symphony of Lights show in the evening.
- **Tian Tan Buddha (Big Buddha)** – A giant bronze Buddha on Lantau Island, reached by the Ngong Ping 360 cable car.
- **Temple Street Night Market** – A lively market with street food, fortune tellers and stalls.
- **M+ and the West Kowloon Cultural District** – A world-class museum of visual culture and the Hong Kong Palace Museum.
- **Dragon's Back trail** – A popular ridge hike ending at Big Wave Bay beach.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Central and Sheung Wan are the business and nightlife core, with bars in Lan Kwai Fong and Soho. Tsim Sha Tsui offers harbour views and shopping, while Mong Kok is dense and local. Causeway Bay is a shopping hub, and Sai Kung offers seafood and access to beaches.

■ Food & Drink

Dim sum, including har gow and siu mai, is best enjoyed at traditional teahouses and budget spots like Tim Ho Wan. Cantonese roast meats such as char siu and roast goose, wonton noodles and egg tarts are classics. Cha chaan tengs, local cafés, serve milk tea and pineapple buns. Hong Kong has many Michelin-starred restaurants, from street food to fine dining.

■ When to Visit

October to December offers clear skies and comfortable temperatures. Summer is hot, humid and the typhoon season. Chinese New Year brings fireworks and festivities.

■ Getting Around

The MTR subway is excellent, and the Octopus card works on transport and in shops. Trams, ferries and buses are cheap and scenic. The Airport Express reaches Central in about 25 minutes.

■ Day Trips

Macau is about an hour away via ferry or the Hong Kong-Zhuhai-Macau Bridge. Lamma Island and Cheung Chau have seafood restaurants and hiking. Shenzhen is reachable by high-speed train.

■ Practical Tips

- Use an Octopus card or contactless payment for transport.
- Check typhoon signals during the summer.
- Carry a light jacket; air conditioning is strong indoors.
- Check entry requirements for mainland China if planning side trips.

Honolulu

AMERICAS

United States (Hawaii) · Oceania / North Pacific

Hawaii's capital, home to Waikiki Beach, Pearl Harbor and volcanic landscapes.

Country	United States (Hawaii)
Region	Oceania / North Pacific
Population (approx.)	~350,000 (city); ~1 million (O'ahu)
Language(s)	English and Hawaiian
Currency	US Dollar (USD)
Main airport	Daniel K. Inouye International Airport (HNL)
Best time to visit	April-June and September-October

■ Overview

Honolulu, on the island of O'ahu, is the capital of Hawaii and its largest city. It blends Native Hawaiian heritage, Asian and American influences. Waikiki Beach is famous for surfing and resorts, while Diamond Head crater offers hiking. Pearl Harbor is a historic site of the 1941 attack that brought the US into the Second World War. The island offers beaches, mountains and culture.

■ Top Attractions

- **Waikiki Beach** – A world-famous beach for surfing and relaxing.
- **Diamond Head** – A volcanic crater with a hiking trail; reservations required.
- **Pearl Harbor National Memorial** – Including the USS Arizona Memorial.
- **'Iolani Palace** – The only royal palace in the US.
- **Hanauma Bay** – A nature preserve for snorkelling; reservations required.
- **Bishop Museum** – Hawaiian and Pacific history.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Waikiki is the tourist hub. Kaka'ako has street art, and Chinatown has restaurants.

■ Food & Drink

Poke, loco moco, spam musubi, shave ice and plate lunches are local favourites.

■ When to Visit

The weather is warm year-round. Winter brings big waves on the North Shore.

■ Getting Around

TheBus covers the island, and a new rail line (Skyline) is opening in stages. Renting a car helps explore.

■ Day Trips

The North Shore, Kailua and the Polynesian Cultural Center are popular.

■ Practical Tips

- Book Diamond Head and Hanauma Bay in advance.
- Use reef-safe sunscreen.
- Respect Hawaiian culture and sacred sites.
- Beware of strong currents.

Istanbul

EUROPE

Türkiye · Southeastern Europe / Western Asia

A city on two continents, where Byzantine and Ottoman empires left their magnificent mark.

Country	Türkiye
Region	Southeastern Europe / Western Asia
Population (approx.)	~15.7 million
Language(s)	Turkish
Currency	Turkish Lira (TRY)
Main airport	Istanbul Airport (IST); Sabiha Gökçen Airport (SAW)
Best time to visit	April-June and September-November

■ Overview

Istanbul straddles the Bosphorus Strait, with neighbourhoods in both Europe and Asia. As Byzantium, Constantinople and then Istanbul, it served as the capital of the Roman, Byzantine and Ottoman empires for over 1,500 years. The skyline of domes and minarets, the vibrant bazaars and the constant ferry traffic create an unforgettable atmosphere. Istanbul is Türkiye's largest city and its cultural and economic heart. It offers a remarkable mix of history, food, shopping and nightlife.

■ Top Attractions

- **Hagia Sophia** – Built as a cathedral in 537, later a mosque, museum and again a mosque, it is one of the world's great buildings; visitors must dress modestly.
- **Blue Mosque (Sultan Ahmed Mosque)** – Famous for its six minarets and blue İznik tiles, it is still an active place of worship.
- **Topkapı Palace** – The residence of Ottoman sultans, with courtyards, the Harem and treasury.
- **Grand Bazaar** – One of the largest and oldest covered markets in the world, with thousands of shops.
- **Basilica Cistern** – A vast underground Byzantine water reservoir supported by hundreds of columns, including two Medusa heads.
- **Bosphorus cruise** – Ferries sail between Europe and Asia, past palaces, fortresses and wooden mansions.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Sultanahmet is the historic core with major sights but fewer local restaurants. Beyoğlu, around İstiklal Avenue and Galata, is lively and cosmopolitan. Karaköy is trendy with cafés and galleries, while Kadıköy and Moda on the Asian side offer a relaxed local vibe.

■ Food & Drink

Istanbul's cuisine is outstanding: try kebabs, meze, lahmacun, pide and fish sandwiches (balık ekmek) by the Galata Bridge. Breakfast (kahvaltı) is a lavish spread of cheeses, olives, eggs and breads. Baklava, Turkish delight (lokum), Turkish coffee and tea are everywhere. The Spice Bazaar is a colourful place to buy spices and sweets.

■ When to Visit

Spring brings tulip season in April, and autumn is warm and pleasant. Summers are hot and busy, and winters are cool and rainy with occasional snow. During Ramadan, some restaurants have different hours, but evenings are festive.

■ Getting Around

Istanbul has a growing metro network, trams, funiculars, buses and ferries, and the Istanbulkart card works on all of them. Traffic is heavy, so rail and ferries are often faster. Both airports are far from the centre; allow over an hour.

■ Day Trips

The Princes' Islands, where cars are banned, are a relaxing ferry trip away. Bursa, the first Ottoman capital, and the Black Sea villages are other options. Many visitors fly or take a bus onwards to Cappadocia.

■ Practical Tips

- Women should carry a scarf to cover their hair in mosques; everyone should cover shoulders and knees.
- Mosques close to tourists during prayer times.
- Haggle politely in bazaars.
- Use the Istanbulkart for all public transport.

Jaipur

India · South Asia

ASIA

Rajasthan's "Pink City" of palaces, forts and colourful bazaars.

Country	India
Region	South Asia
Population (approx.)	~4 million
Language(s)	Hindi and Rajasthani
Currency	Indian Rupee (INR)
Main airport	Jaipur International Airport (JAI)
Best time to visit	October–March

■ Overview

Jaipur, the capital of Rajasthan, was founded in 1727 by Maharaja Sawai Jai Singh II as one of India's first planned cities. Its old city was painted pink in 1876 to welcome the Prince of Wales, earning it the nickname "Pink City". Jaipur is a UNESCO World Heritage City, known for its palaces, forts, bazaars and crafts such as gemstones, textiles and blue pottery. It forms part of the Golden Triangle with Delhi and Agra. The city is a lively mix of royal heritage and everyday Rajasthani life.

■ Top Attractions

- **Amber Fort** – A hilltop fort-palace with mirror-decorated halls, courtyards and views over Maota Lake.
- **Hawa Mahal (Palace of Winds)** – A honeycomb-like facade with hundreds of small windows built for royal women to observe street life.
- **City Palace** – The royal residence, with museums, courtyards and decorated gates.
- **Jantar Mantar** – An 18th-century astronomical observatory with giant instruments, a UNESCO site.
- **Nahargarh Fort** – A fort on the ridge above the city, famous for sunset views.
- **Bazaars** – Johari Bazaar for jewellery, Bapu Bazaar for textiles and Tripolia Bazaar for crafts.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The old city is central to the sights but crowded. The C-Scheme and Bani Park areas offer comfortable hotels, while heritage havelis and palace hotels provide a royal experience. Luxury options include the Rambagh Palace.

■ Food & Drink

Rajasthani cuisine includes dal baati churma (lentils with baked wheat balls), laal maas (a fiery mutton curry) and ghevar, a honeycomb-like sweet. Pyaaz kachori and lassi at Lassiwala are popular. Many rooftop restaurants offer views of the old city. Vegetarian food is widely available.

■ When to Visit

October to March is the best time, with pleasant temperatures. Summer is extremely hot, and the monsoon brings humidity. The Jaipur Literature Festival in January and colourful festivals like Diwali and Holi are major events.

■ Getting Around

Auto-rickshaws, taxis and ride-hailing apps (Uber, Ola) are the main ways to get around. The Jaipur Metro has a limited network. Trains and highways connect Jaipur with Delhi (around 4–5 hours) and Agra.

■ Day Trips

Abhaneri, with the stepwell Chand Baori, is on the way to Agra. Ranthambore National Park offers tiger safaris. Pushkar, a holy town with a lake and camel fair, is about 2.5 hours away.

■ Practical Tips

- Buy a composite ticket covering several monuments.
- Bargain in bazaars and be wary of commission-driven shopping tours.
- Dress modestly at temples.
- Avoid elephant rides at Amber Fort for animal welfare reasons.

Jakarta

Indonesia · Southeast Asia

ASIA

Indonesia's sprawling megacity of colonial heritage, malls and diverse food.

Country	Indonesia
Region	Southeast Asia
Population (approx.)	~11 million (city); over 30 million (Greater Jakarta)
Language(s)	Indonesian
Currency	Indonesian Rupiah (IDR)
Main airport	Soekarno-Hatta International Airport (CGK)
Best time to visit	May–September

■ Overview

Jakarta, on the northwest coast of Java, is Indonesia's largest city and its economic centre. Founded as Sunda Kelapa, it became the Dutch colonial capital of Batavia in the 17th century. Jakarta is a vast, energetic metropolis with skyscrapers, shopping malls and notorious traffic. Although Indonesia is moving its capital to Nusantara in Borneo, Jakarta remains the country's economic and cultural hub. Visitors find a diverse food scene, museums and a lively nightlife.

■ Top Attractions

- **Kota Tua (Old Town)** – The Dutch colonial district around Fatahillah Square, with the Jakarta History Museum and cafés.
- **National Monument (Monas)** – A 132-metre tower symbolising independence, with an observation deck.
- **Istiqlal Mosque** – One of the largest mosques in Southeast Asia, located opposite the Jakarta Cathedral.
- **National Museum of Indonesia** – A collection of artefacts from across the archipelago.
- **Taman Mini Indonesia Indah** – A park showcasing the culture and architecture of Indonesia's provinces.
- **Sunda Kelapa Harbour** – An old port with traditional wooden schooners (pinisi).

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Central Jakarta (Menteng, Thamrin) is convenient. South Jakarta (Kemang, Senopati, SCBD) is trendy, with restaurants and nightlife. Kota Tua is historic.

■ Food & Drink

Jakarta is a melting pot of Indonesian cuisines: try nasi goreng, satay, soto Betawi, gado-gado and kerak telur, a traditional Betawi egg dish. Street food is everywhere, and malls have large food courts. Padang restaurants serve dishes from West Sumatra.

■ When to Visit

The dry season from May to September is best. The rainy season (November–March) can cause flooding. Traffic is heavy all year round.

■ Getting Around

The MRT, LRT and TransJakarta bus rapid transit help avoid traffic. Ride-hailing apps (Grab, Gojek) are widely used. The airport train connects Soekarno-Hatta with the city.

■ Day Trips

The Thousand Islands (Kepulauan Seribu) offer beaches and snorkelling. Bogor has botanical gardens. Bandung, a cool highland city, is reachable by high-speed train in under an hour.

■ Practical Tips

- Allow extra time for traffic.
- Dress modestly at mosques.
- Drink bottled water.
- Use apps to avoid taxi scams.

Jerusalem

ASIA

Israel / Palestinian territories (status disputed) · Middle East

A holy city for Judaism, Christianity and Islam, layered with 3,000 years of history.

Country	Israel / Palestinian territories (status disputed)
Region	Middle East
Population (approx.)	~990,000
Language(s)	Hebrew and Arabic (English widely spoken)
Currency	Israeli New Shekel (ILS)
Main airport	Ben Gurion International Airport (TLV), about 45 minutes away
Best time to visit	March–May and September–November

■ Overview

Jerusalem is one of the oldest cities in the world and holds deep religious significance for Jews, Christians and Muslims. Its walled Old City, a UNESCO World Heritage Site, contains the Western Wall, the Church of the Holy Sepulchre and the Al-Aqsa Mosque compound with the Dome of the Rock. The city's political status is disputed, and it remains at the centre of the Israeli–Palestinian conflict. Beyond the Old City, Jerusalem has museums, markets and neighbourhoods reflecting many cultures. Visitors should check current travel advisories before planning a trip.

■ Top Attractions

- **Western Wall** – The holiest place where Jews can pray, part of the retaining wall of the Second Temple.
- **Church of the Holy Sepulchre** – Revered by many Christians as the site of Jesus's crucifixion, burial and resurrection.
- **Temple Mount / Haram al-Sharif** – Home to the Dome of the Rock and Al-Aqsa Mosque; access for non-Muslims is limited to certain hours.
- **Via Dolorosa** – The path believed to have been followed by Jesus to his crucifixion.
- **Yad Vashem** – Israel's national Holocaust memorial and museum.
- **Mount of Olives** – A hill with churches, a Jewish cemetery and panoramic views of the Old City.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The Old City is divided into Jewish, Christian, Muslim and Armenian Quarters. West Jerusalem includes Mahane Yehuda Market and modern areas, while East Jerusalem is predominantly Palestinian. The German Colony has restaurants and cafés.

■ Food & Drink

Try hummus, falafel, shakshuka and sabich. Mahane Yehuda Market is a food destination by day and nightlife spot by night. Knafeh and ka'ak (sesame bread) are popular. Kosher restaurants close for Shabbat.

■ When to Visit

Spring and autumn are pleasant. Summers are hot, and winters can be cold and rainy. Religious holidays affect opening hours.

■ Getting Around

The light rail and buses serve the city. The Old City is walkable. Trains connect Jerusalem with Tel Aviv and the airport.

■ Day Trips

The Dead Sea and Masada are popular. Bethlehem, in the West Bank, requires crossing a checkpoint. Tel Aviv is less than an hour away.

■ Practical Tips

- Check current travel advisories.
- Dress modestly at religious sites.
- Public transport stops during Shabbat.
- Respect local customs.

Kandy

Sri Lanka · South Asia

ASIA

Sri Lanka's cultural capital and home of the Temple of the Sacred Tooth Relic.

Country	Sri Lanka
Region	South Asia
Population (approx.)	~125,000
Language(s)	Sinhala and Tamil
Currency	Sri Lankan Rupee (LKR)
Main airport	Bandaranaike International Airport (CMB), about 3 hours away
Best time to visit	December–April

■ Overview

Kandy, set among forested hills in central Sri Lanka, was the capital of the last Sinhalese kingdom until the British took control in 1815. It is a UNESCO World Heritage City and the island's cultural and spiritual heart. The city centres on a picturesque lake and the Temple of the Sacred Tooth Relic, which houses a tooth believed to be the Buddha's. Kandy is known for its traditional dance, botanic gardens and the Esala Perahera festival. It is also the gateway to Sri Lanka's tea country.

■ Top Attractions

- **Temple of the Sacred Tooth Relic (Sri Dalada Maligawa)** – The most sacred Buddhist site in Sri Lanka, with daily rituals (puja).
- **Kandy Lake** – An artificial lake built in 1807, ideal for walks.
- **Royal Botanic Gardens, Peradeniya** – Gardens with orchids, palms and giant trees.
- **Kandyan cultural dance show** – Performances featuring drumming, dance and fire walking.
- **Bahiravokanda Vihara Buddha Statue** – A large white Buddha overlooking the city.
- **Udawattakele Forest Reserve** – A forest with walking trails and birdlife.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Staying near Kandy Lake is convenient. Hillside hotels offer views and quiet.

■ Food & Drink

Rice and curry, hoppers and kottu roti are common. Kandy has many bakeries. Ceylon tea is served everywhere.

■ **When to Visit**

December to April is best. The Esala Perahera, a grand procession with decorated elephants, takes place in July or August.

■ **Getting Around**

Tuk-tuks are the main transport. The train from Kandy to Ella is one of the world's most scenic journeys.

■ **Day Trips**

Sigiriya, Dambulla and the tea plantations of Nuwara Eliya are popular. The Pinnawala Elephant Orphanage is controversial for animal welfare.

■ **Practical Tips**

- Book train seats in advance.
- Dress in white or modest clothing at the temple.
- Remove shoes and hats in temples.
- Accommodation fills up during the Perahera.

Kathmandu

Nepal · South Asia

ASIA

The gateway to the Himalayas, a valley of temples, stupas and ancient squares.

Country	Nepal
Region	South Asia
Population (approx.)	~1.5 million (Kathmandu Valley ~3 million)
Language(s)	Nepali
Currency	Nepalese Rupee (NPR)
Main airport	Tribhuvan International Airport (KTM)
Best time to visit	October–November and March–April

■ Overview

Kathmandu, the capital of Nepal, lies in a valley surrounded by the Himalayan foothills. The Kathmandu Valley contains seven UNESCO World Heritage monuments, including ancient royal squares, Hindu temples and Buddhist stupas. The city is chaotic, colourful and spiritual, where cows wander the streets and incense fills the air. It was badly damaged by the 2015 earthquake, but many monuments have been restored. Kathmandu is the starting point for trekking to Everest and the Annapurnas.

■ Top Attractions

- **Boudhanath Stupa** – One of the largest stupas in the world, surrounded by monasteries.
- **Swayambhunath (Monkey Temple)** – A hilltop stupa with views over the city.
- **Kathmandu Durbar Square** – A historic royal square with temples and palaces.
- **Pashupatinath Temple** – A sacred Hindu temple on the Bagmati River, with open-air cremations.
- **Patan and Bhaktapur Durbar Squares** – Beautiful medieval towns in the valley.
- **Garden of Dreams** – A neoclassical garden in the city centre.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Thamel is the tourist hub, with hotels, restaurants and trekking shops. Boudha and Patan are quieter options.

■ Food & Drink

Dal bhat (lentils and rice) is the national dish. Momos (dumplings) are everywhere. Newari cuisine includes spicy snacks and rice beer.

■ When to Visit

October to November offers clear mountain views. Spring (March–April) brings rhododendron blooms. The monsoon (June–September) brings rain.

■ Getting Around

Taxis and ride-hailing apps (Pathao, InDrive) are available. Traffic and dust are heavy.

■ Day Trips

Nagarkot offers Himalayan sunrise views. Bhaktapur and Patan are close. Chitwan National Park and Pokhara are further.

■ Practical Tips

- Wear a mask on dusty days.
- Get trekking permits in Kathmandu.
- Walk clockwise around stupas.
- Be respectful at cremation sites.

Kochi

India · South Asia

ASIA

Kerala's historic spice port, where Chinese fishing nets line the waterfront.

Country	India
Region	South Asia
Population (approx.)	~2.1 million (metro)
Language(s)	Malayalam
Currency	Indian Rupee (INR)
Main airport	Cochin International Airport (COK)
Best time to visit	October–March

■ Overview

Kochi (Cochin), in the southern state of Kerala, has been a major spice trading port for centuries, attracting Arab, Chinese, Portuguese, Dutch and British traders. Fort Kochi, the historic district, has colonial buildings, churches, synagogues and art galleries. The city is known for its Chinese fishing nets, Kathakali dance performances and the Kochi-Muziris Biennale. Kochi is a gateway to Kerala's backwaters and hill stations.

■ Top Attractions

- **Chinese fishing nets** – Large cantilevered nets operated on the waterfront.
- **St. Francis Church** – The burial site of Vasco da Gama.
- **Mattancherry Palace (Dutch Palace)** – Murals depicting Hindu epics.
- **Paradesi Synagogue** – A 16th-century synagogue in Jew Town.
- **Kathakali performances** – Traditional dance-drama.
- **Kochi-Muziris Biennale** – A major contemporary art festival.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Fort Kochi and Mattancherry are historic and charming. Ernakulam is the modern commercial centre.

■ Food & Drink

Kerala cuisine includes seafood curries, appam with stew and Karimeen pollichathu (pearl spot fish). Banana chips and coconut dishes are common.

■ When to Visit

October to March is best. The monsoon brings heavy rain.

■ Getting Around

Ferries connect Fort Kochi with Ernakulam. Auto-rickshaws and taxis are common. The metro serves Ernakulam.

■ Day Trips

Alleppey (Alappuzha) backwaters are popular for houseboat stays. Munnar has tea plantations.

■ Practical Tips

- Book houseboats in advance.
- Dress modestly.
- Try an Ayurvedic massage.
- Carry insect repellent.

Kolkata

India · South Asia

ASIA

India's intellectual and cultural capital of colonial grandeur, literature and sweets.

Country	India
Region	South Asia
Population (approx.)	~15 million (metro)
Language(s)	Bengali (Hindi and English widely spoken)
Currency	Indian Rupee (INR)
Main airport	Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose International Airport (CCU)
Best time to visit	November–February

■ Overview

Kolkata (formerly Calcutta), the capital of West Bengal, was the capital of British India until 1911. The legacy of that era is visible in grand colonial buildings, wide avenues and institutions such as museums, universities and libraries. Kolkata is often called India's cultural capital, home to Nobel laureate Rabindranath Tagore, filmmaker Satyajit Ray and a passionate literary, theatre and film scene. The city is crowded, humid and chaotic, yet warm and full of character, with yellow Ambassador taxis, hand-pulled rickshaws and trams. Its Durga Puja festival is one of the largest cultural events in the world.

■ Top Attractions

- **Victoria Memorial** – A white marble monument and museum dedicated to Queen Victoria, surrounded by gardens.
- **Howrah Bridge** – A massive cantilever bridge over the Hooghly River, one of the busiest bridges in the world.
- **Dakshineswar Kali Temple and Belur Math** – Important Hindu temples on opposite banks of the river, connected by ferry.
- **Indian Museum** – The oldest and one of the largest museums in India, with archaeological and natural history collections.
- **College Street** – A street of bookshops and home to the historic Indian Coffee House, a meeting place for intellectuals.
- **Kumartuli** – The potters' quarter where artisans sculpt clay idols for festivals.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Park Street is central, with restaurants, bars and colonial-era hotels. The area around BBD Bagh has colonial architecture, while Ballygunge and Salt Lake are more residential. Sudder Street is popular with budget travellers.

■ Food & Drink

Bengali cuisine is famous for fish, especially macher jhol (fish curry) and shorshe ilish (hilsa in mustard sauce). Kolkata is known for kathi rolls, puchka (spicy water-filled puffs) and Kolkata biryani with potato. Sweets such as rasgulla, sandesh and mishti doi (sweet yoghurt) are a local passion. Chinese-Indian cuisine in Tangra, the city's Chinatown, is also popular.

■ When to Visit

November to February is pleasant and dry. Summers are hot and humid, and the monsoon brings heavy rain. Durga Puja in September or October transforms the city with elaborate pandals (temporary temples) and celebrations.

■ Getting Around

Kolkata has India's oldest metro, as well as buses, trams, taxis and ferries on the Hooghly. Ride-hailing apps are widely used. Traffic can be heavy, so the metro is often the fastest option.

■ Day Trips

The Sundarbans, a mangrove forest and home to the Bengal tiger, is a UNESCO site reached on multi-day boat trips. Shantiniketan, Tagore's university town, is about three hours away. Darjeeling and Sikkim can be reached by overnight train or flight.

■ Practical Tips

- Visit during Durga Puja for a unique cultural experience, but expect crowds.
- Ride the historic tram while it still operates.
- Carry cash for small vendors.
- Try sweets from famous shops like K.C. Das and Balaram Mullick.

Kraków

Poland · Central Europe

EUROPE

Poland's royal capital, with a magnificent medieval square and a rich Jewish heritage.

Country	Poland
Region	Central Europe
Population (approx.)	~800,000
Language(s)	Polish
Currency	Polish Złoty (PLN)
Main airport	Kraków John Paul II International Airport (KRK)
Best time to visit	April-June and September-October

■ Overview

Kraków was the capital of Poland for over five centuries and remains its cultural heart. Unlike Warsaw, it survived the Second World War largely intact, preserving an exceptional old town that was among the first UNESCO World Heritage Sites. The city is home to Jagiellonian University, one of the oldest universities in Europe, where Copernicus studied. Kraków combines royal history, a lively student population, affordable prices and vibrant nightlife in historic cellars. It is also the base for visiting Auschwitz-Birkenau and the Wieliczka Salt Mine.

■ Top Attractions

- **Main Market Square (Rynek Główny)** – One of the largest medieval squares in Europe, with the Cloth Hall and St. Mary's Basilica, where a bugle call sounds every hour.
- **Wawel Castle and Cathedral** – The former royal residence and coronation cathedral on a hill above the Vistula River.
- **Kazimierz** – The historic Jewish quarter with synagogues, cafés, bars and street art.
- **Schindler's Factory** – A museum on Kraków under Nazi occupation, housed in Oskar Schindler's former enamel factory.
- **Rynek Underground** – A museum beneath the Main Square displaying medieval archaeological finds.
- **Planty Park** – A green belt surrounding the old town where the city walls once stood.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The Old Town is central and atmospheric but can be noisy. Kazimierz is lively and trendy, with great restaurants and nightlife. Podgórze, across the river, is quieter and home to the former ghetto and Schindler's Factory.

■ Food & Drink

Polish classics include pierogi, żurek served in a bread bowl, bigos and kiełbasa. Obwarzanek, a braided bread ring sold from street carts, is Kraków's signature snack. Zapiekanka, a long open-faced baguette with toppings, is popular in Kazimierz's Plac Nowy. Milk bars (bar mleczny) serve cheap, traditional meals.

■ When to Visit

Spring and early autumn offer pleasant weather. Summer is busy with tourists and festivals, including the Jewish Culture Festival in late June/early July. Winters are cold, but the Christmas market on the Main Square is charming.

■ Getting Around

The old town is walkable, and trams cover the city well. A train connects the airport with the main station in about 20 minutes. Kraków is well connected by train with Warsaw, Wrocław and Gdańsk.

■ Day Trips

The Auschwitz-Birkenau Memorial and Museum, about 1.5 hours away, requires advance booking. The Wieliczka Salt Mine features underground chapels carved from salt. Zakopane, in the Tatra Mountains, offers hiking and skiing.

■ Practical Tips

- Book Auschwitz and Wieliczka tickets well in advance, especially in summer.
- Beware of overpriced exchange offices in the old town.
- Many museums offer free entry on one day a week.
- Bars and clubs in cellars can be crowded on weekends.

Kuala Lumpur

Malaysia · Southeast Asia

ASIA

A modern, multicultural capital of twin towers, street food and tropical greenery.

Country	Malaysia
Region	Southeast Asia
Population (approx.)	~2 million (city); ~8.8 million (Greater KL)
Language(s)	Malay (English widely spoken; Chinese and Tamil also common)
Currency	Malaysian Ringgit (MYR)
Main airport	Kuala Lumpur International Airport (KUL)
Best time to visit	May–July and December–February

■ Overview

Kuala Lumpur, the capital of Malaysia, grew from a tin-mining settlement at the confluence of the Klang and Gombak rivers in the 19th century. Today it is a modern city of skyscrapers, including the iconic Petronas Twin Towers, once the world's tallest buildings. KL is a melting pot of Malay, Chinese and Indian cultures, reflected in its mosques, temples, festivals and food. The city is affordable, with excellent shopping, street food and green spaces. It is a major transport hub for Southeast Asia.

■ Top Attractions

- **Petronas Twin Towers** – The 88-storey towers with a skybridge and observation deck; KLCC Park below has fountain shows.
- **Batu Caves** – A Hindu temple complex in limestone caves, reached by 272 colourful steps, with a giant golden statue of Lord Murugan.
- **Merdeka Square** – The site where Malaysian independence was declared, surrounded by colonial buildings.
- **Central Market and Chinatown (Petaling Street)** – Markets for crafts, food and souvenirs.
- **KL Tower (Menara KL)** – A telecommunications tower with an observation deck and skybox.
- **Islamic Arts Museum Malaysia** – A museum with Islamic art from around the world.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

KLCC is central and upscale, near the Petronas Towers. Bukit Bintang is the shopping and nightlife district, and Chinatown offers budget hotels and street food. Bangsar is trendy, with restaurants and cafés.

■ Food & Drink

Nasi lemak, coconut rice with sambal, anchovies and peanuts, is Malaysia's national dish. Street food includes satay, char kway teow, roti canai and laksa. Jalan Alor is famous for night food stalls. Mamak restaurants, run by Indian Muslims, are open late.

■ When to Visit

KL is hot and humid year-round, with frequent afternoon rain. Festivals such as Hari Raya, Chinese New Year, Thaipusam and Deepavali are colourful. Malaysia has two monsoon seasons, but rain rarely lasts long in KL.

■ Getting Around

KL has an integrated rail network (LRT, MRT, monorail and KTM). The KLIA Ekspres train connects the airport with KL Sentral in about 30 minutes. Grab is widely used and affordable.

■ Day Trips

Batu Caves is easy to reach by train. Putrajaya, the administrative capital, has impressive mosques and bridges. Malacca, a UNESCO heritage city, and the Cameron Highlands are longer trips.

■ Practical Tips

- Dress modestly at mosques and temples.
- Carry an umbrella for sudden showers.
- Use Grab to avoid taxi overcharging.
- Visit the Petronas Towers skybridge early and book tickets online.

Kyoto

Japan · East Asia

ASIA

Japan's former imperial capital of temples, gardens and geisha districts.

Country	Japan
Region	East Asia
Population (approx.)	~1.4 million
Language(s)	Japanese
Currency	Japanese Yen (JPY)
Main airport	Kansai International Airport (KIX), about 75 minutes away; Osaka Itami (ITM)
Best time to visit	March–May and October–November

■ Overview

Kyoto served as Japan's imperial capital for more than 1,000 years, from 794 until 1868. It is the country's cultural heart, with around 1,600 Buddhist temples, 400 Shinto shrines, traditional wooden townhouses and exquisite gardens. Seventeen sites in and around Kyoto are UNESCO World Heritage Sites. The city is famous for its geisha (geiko and maiko), tea ceremonies, kaiseki cuisine and seasonal beauty, especially cherry blossoms and autumn leaves. Kyoto is very popular, so planning helps avoid crowds.

■ Top Attractions

- **Fushimi Inari Taisha** – A shrine famous for thousands of vermilion torii gates winding up a mountain; visit early morning.
- **Kinkaku-ji (Golden Pavilion)** – A Zen temple covered in gold leaf, reflected in a pond.
- **Kiyomizu-dera** – A wooden temple on a hillside with a large terrace offering views.
- **Arashiyama** – A district known for its bamboo grove, Tenryu-ji temple and monkey park.
- **Gion** – The traditional geisha district with wooden teahouses and lantern-lit streets.
- **Ryoan-ji and Ginkaku-ji** – A famous rock garden and the Silver Pavilion along the Philosopher's Path.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Downtown Kyoto near Shijo and Kawaramachi is convenient for shopping and dining. Gion and Higashiyama are atmospheric, with traditional inns, while the area around Kyoto Station is practical for transport. Staying in a ryokan (traditional inn) is a memorable experience.

■ Food & Drink

Kyoto cuisine includes kaiseki (multi-course seasonal dining), yudofu (tofu hot pot), obanzai (Kyoto-style home cooking) and matcha sweets. Nishiki Market, "Kyoto's Kitchen", offers pickles, snacks and street food. Kyoto is also known for sake from the Fushimi district. Vegetarian Buddhist cuisine (shojin ryori) is served at temples.

■ When to Visit

Spring cherry blossoms (late March–early April) and autumn leaves (November) are the most beautiful but crowded seasons. Summer is hot and humid, with the Gion Matsuri festival in July. Winter is cold but quiet.

■ Getting Around

Kyoto has buses, two subway lines and trains, but buses can be crowded. Walking and cycling are good options. The Shinkansen connects Kyoto with Tokyo in just over two hours.

■ Day Trips

Nara, with its deer and giant Buddha, is under an hour away. Osaka is 15–30 minutes by train. Uji is known for matcha tea and the Byodo-in temple, and Himeji Castle is reachable by Shinkansen.

■ Practical Tips

- Visit major sights early in the morning.
- Respect geisha and do not photograph them without permission; photography is banned on some private streets in Gion.
- Use an IC card (ICOCA) for transport.
- Book accommodation early for peak seasons.

La Paz

Bolivia · South America

AMERICAS

The world's highest seat of government, set in a dramatic Andean canyon.

Country	Bolivia
Region	South America
Population (approx.)	~760,000 (city); ~2.3 million with El Alto
Language(s)	Spanish, Aymara and Quechua
Currency	Bolivian Boliviano (BOB)
Main airport	El Alto International Airport (LPB)
Best time to visit	May–October (dry season)

■ Overview

La Paz is Bolivia's seat of government (Sucre is the constitutional capital) and, at around 3,650 metres, one of the highest cities in the world. It fills a deep canyon, with the city of El Alto on the plateau above and the snow-capped peak of Illimani on the horizon. La Paz has a strong indigenous Aymara culture, visible in markets, festivals and the traditional dress of cholitas. The city is chaotic and fascinating, with steep streets and colourful markets. It is a base for trips to Lake Titicaca, the Death Road and the Uyuni salt flats.

■ Top Attractions

- **Mi Teleférico** – The world's largest urban cable car network, offering spectacular views across the city.
- **Witches' Market (Mercado de las Brujas)** – Stalls selling herbs, potions and llama foetuses used in Aymara rituals.
- **Plaza Murillo** – The main square with the cathedral and government palace.
- **Calle Jaén** – A well-preserved colonial street with museums.
- **Valle de la Luna** – Eroded clay formations on the edge of the city.
- **Cholita wrestling** – A popular show in El Alto featuring Aymara women wrestlers.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The historic centre near Sagárnaga Street is popular with travellers. Sopocachi is a pleasant area with cafés, and the Zona Sur is lower, warmer and more upscale.

■ Food & Drink

Salteñas, juicy baked empanadas, are a morning favourite. Api (a hot purple corn drink) with buñuelos, and sandwiches de chola are street foods. Restaurant Gustu helped launch Bolivia's modern gastronomy.

■ When to Visit

The dry season from May to October brings clear skies but cold nights. The rainy season (November–March) affects some roads.

■ Getting Around

The cable car network is the best way to get around. Minibuses and taxis are common.

■ Day Trips

The Death Road mountain bike ride, Lake Titicaca and Tiwanaku ruins are popular.

■ Practical Tips

- Acclimatise to the altitude slowly.
- Choose reputable Death Road operators.
- Carry cash.
- Dress in layers.

Las Vegas

AMERICAS

United States (Nevada) · North America

The entertainment capital of the world, with casinos, shows and desert adventures.

Country	United States (Nevada)
Region	North America
Population (approx.)	~660,000 (city); ~2.3 million (metro)
Language(s)	English
Currency	US Dollar (USD)
Main airport	Harry Reid International Airport (LAS)
Best time to visit	March–May and September–November

■ Overview

Las Vegas, in the Mojave Desert of Nevada, is famous for its casinos, resorts, entertainment and nightlife. Founded as a railway town in 1905, it boomed after gambling was legalised in 1931 and the Hoover Dam was built nearby. The Las Vegas Strip is lined with themed mega-resorts replicating Paris, Venice, New York and ancient Egypt. Beyond gambling, Las Vegas offers world-class shows, dining and concerts. It is also a gateway to the Grand Canyon and other national parks.

■ Top Attractions

- **The Strip** – A four-mile boulevard of resorts, casinos and attractions.
- **Bellagio Fountains** – A free choreographed water show.
- **Sphere** – A giant spherical venue with immersive concerts and shows.
- **Fremont Street Experience** – Downtown's LED canopy and historic casinos.
- **Shows** – Cirque du Soleil productions, magic shows and residencies by top musicians.
- **High Roller** – One of the world's tallest observation wheels.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The Strip is the heart of the action. Downtown is more affordable, with a retro feel.

■ Food & Drink

Las Vegas has celebrity-chef restaurants and legendary buffets.

■ When to Visit

Spring and autumn are pleasant. Summers are extremely hot.

■ **Getting Around**

The Monorail, buses and ride-hailing apps are available. Walking the Strip takes longer than it looks.

■ **Day Trips**

The Grand Canyon, Hoover Dam, Red Rock Canyon and Valley of Fire are popular.

■ **Practical Tips**

- Check for resort fees when booking.
- Stay hydrated.
- Set a gambling budget.
- Book shows in advance.

Lima

Peru · South America

AMERICAS

South America's gastronomic capital, perched on cliffs above the Pacific.

Country	Peru
Region	South America
Population (approx.)	~10 million (metro)
Language(s)	Spanish
Currency	Peruvian Sol (PEN)
Main airport	Jorge Chávez International Airport (LIM)
Best time to visit	December–April

■ Overview

Lima, the capital of Peru, was founded by Francisco Pizarro in 1535 as the "City of Kings" and became the centre of Spanish power in South America. Its historic centre is a UNESCO World Heritage Site with colonial churches and balconies. Modern Lima sits on cliffs above the Pacific Ocean, with parks and surf beaches below. The city is renowned for its food, with several restaurants ranked among the world's best. It is the main entry point to Peru.

■ Top Attractions

- **Historic Centre** – Plaza Mayor, the cathedral and the Monastery of San Francisco with catacombs.
- **Miraflores and the Malecón** – Clifftop parks and ocean views.
- **Barranco** – A bohemian district with colourful houses and street art.
- **Larco Museum** – Pre-Columbian art, including erotic pottery.
- **Huaca Pucllana** – An adobe pyramid in Miraflores.
- **Magic Water Circuit** – Illuminated fountains.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Miraflores and Barranco are the most popular areas.

■ Food & Drink

Ceviche, lomo saltado, ají de gallina and causa are classics. Pisco sours are the national cocktail. Restaurants like Central and Maido are world-famous.

■ When to Visit

Summer (December–April) is sunny. Winter brings grey skies (garúa).

■ **Getting Around**

Taxis and ride-hailing apps are common. The Metropolitano bus runs through the city.

■ **Day Trips**

Pachacamac ruins and the Palomino Islands (sea lions) are nearby.

■ **Practical Tips**

- Book top restaurants well in advance.
- Use apps for taxis.
- Watch belongings.
- Try ceviche at lunch.

Lisbon

Portugal · Southern Europe

EUROPE

A sun-drenched city of seven hills, historic trams, tiled facades and fado.

Country	Portugal
Region	Southern Europe
Population (approx.)	~550,000 (city); ~2.9 million (metro)
Language(s)	Portuguese
Currency	Euro (EUR)
Main airport	Humberto Delgado Airport (LIS)
Best time to visit	March–June and September–October

■ Overview

Lisbon, the capital of Portugal, is one of Europe's oldest cities, set on hills overlooking the wide Tagus River near the Atlantic. It was the starting point for the great Portuguese voyages of discovery in the 15th and 16th centuries. After a devastating earthquake in 1755, much of the centre was rebuilt in an elegant grid, while older districts kept their medieval layout. Lisbon has become one of Europe's most popular destinations thanks to its mild climate, friendly atmosphere, food and nightlife. Its miradouros (viewpoints), azulejo tiles and tram 28 are iconic.

■ Top Attractions

- **Belém Tower and Jerónimos Monastery** – Masterpieces of Manueline architecture linked to the Age of Discovery, both UNESCO-listed.
- **Alfama** – Lisbon's oldest neighbourhood, with narrow lanes, laundry-hung balconies and fado houses.
- **São Jorge Castle** – A Moorish castle on a hilltop with panoramic city views.
- **Tram 28** – A historic yellow tram rattling through Graça, Alfama and Baixa; it is often very crowded.
- **Praça do Comércio and Baixa** – A grand riverside square leading to the elegant downtown grid.
- **LX Factory and MAAT** – A creative hub in a former industrial complex and a modern art and technology museum.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Baixa and Chiado are central and convenient. Bairro Alto is known for nightlife, and Príncipe Real is chic, with boutiques and gardens. Alfama and Graça offer traditional atmosphere, while Cais do Sodré is lively and close to the Time Out Market.

■ Food & Drink

Pastel de nata, a custard tart, is a must; the famous version in Belém is called pastel de Belém. Bacalhau (salted cod) is prepared in many ways, and grilled sardines are a summer classic. Bifanas (pork sandwiches), seafood and ginjinha, a cherry liqueur, are popular. Portuguese wines such as vinho verde are excellent value.

■ When to Visit

Spring and autumn are ideal, with warm weather and fewer crowds. Summers are hot and busy; June brings the Santo António festival with street parties and grilled sardines. Winters are mild but rainy.

■ Getting Around

Lisbon has a metro, trams, buses, funiculars and ferries; the Viva Viagem card works on all of them. The metro connects the airport to the centre in about 25 minutes. The hills are steep, so comfortable shoes are essential.

■ Day Trips

Sintra, with fairy-tale palaces such as Pena Palace and Quinta da Regaleira, is 40 minutes by train. Cascais and Estoril offer beaches and seaside towns. Óbidos, a walled medieval village, and Évora, with a Roman temple, are also popular.

■ Practical Tips

- Wear shoes with good grip; the limestone pavements are slippery.
- Board Tram 28 at its terminus (Martim Moniz) or take it early to avoid queues.
- Watch out for pickpockets on trams.
- Restaurants may place appetisers (couvert) on the table; they are not free, so decline if you don't want them.

Ljubljana

Slovenia · Central Europe

EUROPE

A small, green, car-free capital full of riverside cafés and dragons.

Country	Slovenia
Region	Central Europe
Population (approx.)	~295,000
Language(s)	Slovenian
Currency	Euro (EUR)
Main airport	Ljubljana Jože Pučnik Airport (LJU)
Best time to visit	May–September

■ Overview

Ljubljana, the capital of Slovenia, is a charming, compact city on the Ljubljanica River. Its old town combines Baroque buildings, Art Nouveau facades and the distinctive work of architect Jože Plečnik, whose designs are UNESCO-listed. The city centre is largely car-free, and it was named European Green Capital in 2016. With a large student population, Ljubljana has a lively café culture and a relaxed pace. It is an ideal base for exploring Lake Bled, the Julian Alps and Slovenia's caves.

■ Top Attractions

- **Prešeren Square and Triple Bridge** – The heart of the city, with a pink Franciscan church and Plečnik's three bridges.
- **Ljubljana Castle** – A hilltop castle reached by funicular, with views to the Alps.
- **Dragon Bridge** – Decorated with bronze dragons, the symbol of the city.
- **Central Market** – Plečnik's riverside market colonnade, with open-air stalls and Open Kitchen street-food Fridays in warmer months.
- **Tivoli Park** – A large park stretching from the city centre to wooded hills.
- **Metelkova** – An autonomous cultural centre in former army barracks, covered with street art.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Most visitors stay in the old town or around the Ljubljanica riverbanks. Trnovo is quiet and green, with a village feel. The area near the train station is practical and a little cheaper.

■ Food & Drink

Slovenian cuisine mixes Alpine, Mediterranean and Balkan influences. Try kranjska klobasa (Carniolan sausage), štruklji (rolled dumplings), jota (bean and sauerkraut soup) and potica, a rolled nut cake. Slovenia produces excellent wines, including orange wines. Riverside cafés are perfect for coffee or a glass of wine.

■ When to Visit

Late spring and summer are best, with outdoor festivals and riverside life. Autumn is colourful and pleasant. December brings festive lights and markets.

■ Getting Around

The centre is walkable and bike-friendly, with the BicikeLJ bike-share. Electric shuttles (Kavalir) carry people around the car-free zone. The airport is about 25 km away, reached by bus or shuttle.

■ Day Trips

Lake Bled, with its island church and cliffside castle, is under an hour away, and Lake Bohinj is quieter and wilder. Postojna Cave and Škocjan Caves are spectacular underground systems, and Predjama Castle is built into a cliff. Piran, on the Adriatic coast, is a Venetian-style seaside town.

■ Practical Tips

- Walk or cycle; cars are not needed in the centre.
- Book Postojna Cave in summer to guarantee your preferred time.
- Tap water is excellent and free-flowing fountains are common.
- Slovenia uses a vignette system on motorways if you rent a car.

London

EUROPE

United Kingdom (England) · Northern Europe

A global capital of history, culture, theatre and diversity.

Country	United Kingdom (England)
Region	Northern Europe
Population (approx.)	~8.9 million (Greater London); ~14 million (metro)
Language(s)	English
Currency	Pound Sterling (GBP)
Main airport	Heathrow (LHR), Gatwick (LGW), Stansted (STN), Luton (LTN), London City (LCY)
Best time to visit	May–September

■ Overview

London, the capital of the United Kingdom, is one of the world's great cities, with a history stretching back to Roman Londinium. It was the centre of the British Empire and remains a global hub of finance, culture, fashion and education. London is enormously diverse, with hundreds of languages spoken and neighbourhoods representing cultures from around the world. Many of its world-class museums are free. From royal palaces and ancient pubs to cutting-edge architecture and West End theatre, London offers endless options.

■ Top Attractions

- **Tower of London** – A historic fortress, royal palace and prison housing the Crown Jewels and guarded by the Beefeaters.
- **British Museum** – A free museum with treasures such as the Rosetta Stone, Egyptian mummies and the Parthenon sculptures.
- **Westminster Abbey, Houses of Parliament and Big Ben** – The political and ceremonial heart of the country.
- **Buckingham Palace** – The monarch's London residence, with the Changing of the Guard ceremony and summer tours of the State Rooms.
- **Tate Modern and the South Bank** – A modern art museum in a former power station, along a riverside walk with Shakespeare's Globe and the London Eye.
- **Natural History Museum and V&A** – Free museums in South Kensington covering dinosaurs, design and decorative arts.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Westminster and the West End are central, close to theatres and shopping. Covent Garden and Soho are lively, while Kensington and Chelsea are elegant. Shoreditch and Hackney are trendy with street art and nightlife, and areas like Southwark and Borough are great for food and river walks.

■ Food & Drink

London's food scene is one of the world's most diverse. Try a traditional Sunday roast, fish and chips, or a full English breakfast, and visit markets like Borough Market, Camden Market and Maltby Street. Brick Lane is famous for curry and bagels, and Chinatown for dim sum. Afternoon tea in a hotel is a classic experience.

■ When to Visit

Late spring and summer offer the best weather and long evenings, with events such as Trooping the Colour and Wimbledon. Autumn and winter are cooler and rainier, but Christmas lights and markets add charm. Rain is possible any time of year.

■ Getting Around

The Underground (Tube), Overground, Elizabeth line, buses and DLR cover the city, and contactless cards cap daily fares. The Elizabeth line and Heathrow Express connect Heathrow with central London. Walking between central sights is often faster than the Tube.

■ Day Trips

Windsor Castle, Oxford, Cambridge, Bath and Stonehenge are popular day trips. Brighton offers a seaside escape, and the Warner Bros. Studio Tour – The Making of Harry Potter is north of London. Canterbury and Dover's white cliffs are to the southeast.

■ Practical Tips

- Use contactless payment instead of buying paper tickets.
- Stand on the right on escalators.
- Many major museums are free; donations are welcome.
- Book West End shows in advance or look for same-day discount tickets at the TKTS booth in Leicester Square.

Los Angeles

AMERICAS

United States (California) · North America

The entertainment capital of the world, with beaches, Hollywood and diverse neighbourhoods.

Country	United States (California)
Region	North America
Population (approx.)	~3.8 million (city); ~13 million (metro)
Language(s)	English (Spanish widely spoken)
Currency	US Dollar (USD)
Main airport	Los Angeles International Airport (LAX)
Best time to visit	March–May and September–November

■ Overview

Los Angeles is the second-largest city in the United States, sprawling across a basin between mountains and the Pacific Ocean. It is the global centre of the film and television industry, with Hollywood as its symbol. LA is incredibly diverse, with large Latino, Asian and other communities, reflected in its food and neighbourhoods. The city offers beaches, museums, hiking and a sunny climate. It will host the 2028 Summer Olympics.

■ Top Attractions

- **Hollywood** – The Walk of Fame, TCL Chinese Theatre and Hollywood Sign.
- **Griffith Observatory** – Views of the city and the Hollywood Sign.
- **Santa Monica and Venice Beach** – The pier, boardwalk and beach culture.
- **Getty Center** – An art museum with gardens and views.
- **Universal Studios Hollywood** – A film studio and theme park.
- **LACMA** – The largest art museum in the western US.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Santa Monica, West Hollywood, Silver Lake and Downtown LA are popular bases.

■ Food & Drink

LA is famous for tacos, Korean BBQ, In-N-Out Burger and diverse cuisines.

■ When to Visit

The weather is pleasant year-round. Summer can be hot inland.

■ Getting Around

LA is car-oriented. The Metro rail system is expanding.

■ Day Trips

Malibu, Disneyland, Joshua Tree and Santa Barbara are popular.

■ Practical Tips

- Allow time for traffic.
- Check wildfire conditions.
- Use sun protection.
- Book theme parks in advance.

Luang Prabang

Laos · Southeast Asia

ASIA

A tranquil UNESCO town of golden temples, saffron-robed monks and Mekong sunsets.

Country	Laos
Region	Southeast Asia
Population (approx.)	~60,000 (town)
Language(s)	Lao
Currency	Lao Kip (LAK)
Main airport	Luang Prabang International Airport (LPQ)
Best time to visit	November–March

■ Overview

Luang Prabang, located at the confluence of the Mekong and Nam Khan rivers in northern Laos, was the royal capital of the Lao kingdom. Its old town, a UNESCO World Heritage Site, is a charming blend of Buddhist temples and French colonial buildings. The town is peaceful, with a slow pace of life and dozens of monasteries. Every morning, monks collect alms along the streets in a centuries-old tradition. The Laos–China Railway has made the town much easier to reach.

■ Top Attractions

- **Wat Xieng Thong** – The most magnificent temple in Luang Prabang, with sweeping roofs and mosaics.
- **Mount Phousi** – A hill with a golden stupa and sunset views over the town and rivers.
- **Alms-giving ceremony (Tak Bat)** – Monks walk silently at dawn to receive rice from locals.
- **Royal Palace Museum** – The former royal residence, including the Prabang Buddha statue.
- **Kuang Si Falls** – Turquoise waterfall pools about 30 km from town, with a bear rescue centre.
- **Night Market** – A market selling handicrafts and textiles.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The old town peninsula is the best place to stay, with guesthouses and boutique hotels. Riverside accommodation offers views of the Mekong.

■ Food & Drink

Lao food includes larb (minced meat salad), sticky rice, khao soi (a local noodle soup different from the Thai version) and Mekong river weed (khai paen). The night market food alley offers cheap buffets. French bakeries serve baguettes and coffee.

■ When to Visit

November to March is dry and pleasant. The hot season follows until May, and the rainy season (June–October) makes the landscape lush. Lao New Year (Pi Mai) in April is celebrated with water fights.

■ Getting Around

The town is walkable, and bicycles are available. Tuk-tuks take visitors to sights outside town. Trains connect Luang Prabang with Vientiane and Kunming in China.

■ Day Trips

Kuang Si Falls and Tad Sae Falls are popular. The Pak Ou Caves contain thousands of Buddha statues and are reached by boat. Slow boats travel to Huay Xai on the Thai border over two days.

■ Practical Tips

- Observe the alms-giving respectfully and quietly; don't use flash or block the monks.
- Dress modestly in temples.
- Carry cash; ATMs can be unreliable.
- Book train tickets in advance.

Lyon

France · Western Europe

EUROPE

France's gastronomic capital, with Roman ruins, Renaissance lanes and secret passageways.

Country	France
Region	Western Europe
Population (approx.)	~520,000 (city); ~2.3 million (metro)
Language(s)	French
Currency	Euro (EUR)
Main airport	Lyon-Saint-Exupéry Airport (LYS)
Best time to visit	April-June and September-October; December for the Festival of Lights

■ Overview

Lyon is France's third-largest city, set at the confluence of the Rhône and Saône rivers. Founded by the Romans as Lugdunum, it became the capital of Gaul and later a centre of silk weaving and banking. Its historic centre, including the Renaissance Vieux Lyon, is a UNESCO World Heritage Site. Lyon is widely considered the gastronomic capital of France, with legendary chefs like Paul Bocuse and traditional bouchons. It is less touristy than Paris and has a relaxed, sophisticated atmosphere.

■ Top Attractions

- **Vieux Lyon** – One of Europe's largest Renaissance districts, with cobbled streets and hidden passageways called traboules.
- **Basilica of Notre-Dame de Fourvière** – A lavish 19th-century basilica on a hill with views over the city and, on clear days, Mont Blanc.
- **Roman theatres of Fourvière** – Ancient amphitheatres still used for summer concerts, next to the Lugdunum museum.
- **Presqu'île** – The peninsula between the rivers, with grand squares such as Place Bellecour and Place des Terreaux.
- **Musée des Confluences** – A futuristic museum of science and anthropology at the meeting point of the rivers.
- **Croix-Rousse** – The former silk workers' hill, with traboules, murals and a village feel.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The Presqu'île is central and ideal for first-time visitors. Vieux Lyon is atmospheric, while Croix-Rousse is bohemian and local. The Confluence district is modern, and Part-Dieu is practical for train travel.

■ Food & Drink

Bouchons are traditional Lyonnais restaurants serving hearty dishes like quenelles (fish dumplings in sauce), andouillette, salade lyonnaise and saucisson. Les Halles de Lyon Paul Bocuse is a gourmet market. Praline tart (tarte aux pralines) is a local pink dessert. Wines from nearby Beaujolais and the Côtes du Rhône are served everywhere.

■ When to Visit

Spring and autumn are ideal. Summers are warm and lively with outdoor festivals such as Les Nuits de Fourvière. The Fête des Lumières (Festival of Lights) in early December transforms the city with light installations and attracts millions of visitors.

■ Getting Around

Lyon has a metro, trams, buses and funiculars up Fourvière hill. The Rhônexpress tram connects the airport with Part-Dieu station in about 30 minutes. TGV trains reach Paris in about two hours.

■ Day Trips

The Beaujolais wine region with its golden-stone villages is just north of the city. Pérouges, a medieval hilltop village, is under an hour away. Annecy and the Alps, and Vienne with Roman ruins, are also popular.

■ Practical Tips

- Book popular bouchons in advance, especially on weekends.
- Look for the "Authentique Bouchon Lyonnais" label.
- Book hotels months ahead for the Festival of Lights.
- The Lyon City Card includes transport and museum entry.

Macau

ASIA

China (Macau SAR) · East Asia

A blend of Portuguese heritage, Chinese culture and glittering casinos.

Country	China (Macau SAR)
Region	East Asia
Population (approx.)	~690,000
Language(s)	Cantonese and Portuguese (Mandarin and English widely used)
Currency	Macanese Pataca (MOP); Hong Kong Dollars widely accepted
Main airport	Macau International Airport (MFM)
Best time to visit	October–December

■ Overview

Macau, a Special Administrative Region of China, was a Portuguese colony for over 400 years until 1999. Its historic centre, a UNESCO World Heritage Site, features Portuguese churches, cobbled squares and Chinese temples. Macau is also the world's largest gambling centre, with huge casino resorts on the Cotai Strip. The territory's unique Macanese culture combines Portuguese and Chinese influences. It is densely populated and one of the world's wealthiest places per capita.

■ Top Attractions

- **Ruins of St. Paul's** – The facade of a 17th-century church, Macau's most famous landmark.
- **Senado Square** – A square with wave-patterned Portuguese tiles and colonial buildings.
- **A-Ma Temple** – One of Macau's oldest temples, dedicated to the goddess of seafarers.
- **Macau Tower** – An observation tower with the world's highest commercial bungee jump.
- **Cotai Strip** – Casino resorts such as The Venetian and Galaxy Macau, with shows and shopping.
- **Taipa Village** – Colonial houses, restaurants and bakeries.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The historic centre is best for culture. Cotai has large resorts, and Taipa and Coloane are quieter.

■ Food & Drink

Macanese cuisine includes minchi (minced meat with potatoes), African chicken and Portuguese egg tarts. Pork chop buns and almond cookies are popular snacks. Portuguese restaurants serve bacalhau and wine.

■ When to Visit

October to December has pleasant weather. The Macau Grand Prix is held in November. Summers are hot, humid and the typhoon season.

■ Getting Around

Free casino shuttle buses run between the ferry terminals and resorts. Macau has a light rail system. Ferries and the Hong Kong-Zhuhai-Macau Bridge connect Macau with Hong Kong.

■ Day Trips

Coloane Village is a quiet escape. Zhuhai in mainland China is across the border.

■ Practical Tips

- Use free casino shuttles for transport.
- Carry some patacas; change is often given in local currency.
- Hong Kong dollars are accepted nearly everywhere.
- Check visa rules for mainland China.

Madrid

Spain · Southern Europe

EUROPE

Spain's energetic capital of art museums, royal grandeur and late nights.

Country	Spain
Region	Southern Europe
Population (approx.)	~3.4 million (city); ~6.8 million (metro)
Language(s)	Spanish
Currency	Euro (EUR)
Main airport	Adolfo Suárez Madrid-Barajas Airport (MAD)
Best time to visit	March–June and September–November

■ Overview

Madrid, the capital of Spain, lies on a high central plateau and is one of Europe's liveliest cities. It became the royal capital in 1561 and grew into a city of grand boulevards, palaces and plazas. Madrid is home to one of the world's great concentrations of art, with the Prado, Reina Sofía and Thyssen-Bornemisza museums forming the "Golden Triangle of Art". The city is famous for its nightlife, tapas culture and passionate football. Madrileños eat late, stay out late and enjoy life on the streets.

■ Top Attractions

- **Prado Museum** – One of the world's finest art museums, with masterpieces by Velázquez, Goya, El Greco, Bosch and Titian.
- **Reina Sofía Museum** – Modern and contemporary art, including Picasso's Guernica.
- **Royal Palace** – The official residence of the Spanish royal family, one of Europe's largest palaces, open for visits.
- **Retiro Park** – A large park with a boating lake, the Crystal Palace and gardens, a UNESCO site together with the Paseo del Prado.
- **Plaza Mayor and Puerta del Sol** – Historic squares in the heart of the city.
- **Santiago Bernabéu Stadium** – Home of Real Madrid, with stadium tours and a museum.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Sol and the Barrio de las Letras are central and close to museums. Malasaña and Chueca are trendy and lively, with bars and boutiques; Chueca is also the LGBTQ+ hub. La Latina is famous for tapas and the Sunday El Rastro flea market, while Salamanca is upscale and elegant.

■ Food & Drink

Madrid's classics include cocido madrileño (a chickpea and meat stew), bocadillo de calamares (fried squid sandwich) and churros with thick hot chocolate, famously served at Chocolatería San Ginés. Tapas-hopping along Cava Baja in La Latina is a local tradition. Mercado de San Miguel is a popular gourmet market. Vermouth and caña (small beer) are common drinks.

■ When to Visit

Spring and autumn are pleasant and lively. July and August are very hot, and many locals leave the city. Winters are cold but sunny. The San Isidro festival in May celebrates the city's patron saint.

■ Getting Around

Madrid has one of Europe's most extensive metro systems, and the airport is connected by metro and express buses. The centre is walkable. High-speed AVE trains connect Madrid with Barcelona, Seville, Valencia and other cities.

■ Day Trips

Toledo, a medieval city of Christian, Muslim and Jewish heritage, is about 30 minutes away by high-speed train. Segovia has a Roman aqueduct and a fairy-tale Alcázar. El Escorial monastery and Ávila's medieval walls are also popular.

■ Practical Tips

- The Prado and Reina Sofía offer free entry during the last hours of the day, but lines can be long.
- Dinner is typically served from 9 pm onward.
- Watch for pickpockets in Sol and on the metro.
- Many shops close for a few hours in the afternoon outside central areas.

Málaga

Spain · Southern Europe

EUROPE

Picasso's sunny birthplace and the gateway to the Costa del Sol.

Country	Spain
Region	Southern Europe
Population (approx.)	~590,000
Language(s)	Spanish
Currency	Euro (EUR)
Main airport	Málaga-Costa del Sol Airport (AGP)
Best time to visit	March–June and September–November

■ Overview

Málaga is a port city on Spain's Costa del Sol and one of the oldest cities in Europe, founded by the Phoenicians about 3,000 years ago. Once seen mainly as an airport for beach resorts, it has reinvented itself as a cultural destination with over 30 museums. Pablo Picasso was born here, and the city now hosts the Picasso Museum and a branch of the Pompidou Centre. Málaga enjoys around 300 days of sunshine a year, urban beaches and a lively old town. It is also a great base for exploring Andalusia.

■ Top Attractions

- **Alcazaba** – An 11th-century Moorish fortress-palace with gardens and fountains overlooking the city.
- **Gibralfaro Castle** – A hilltop castle connected to the Alcazaba, offering the best views of Málaga and its bullring.
- **Picasso Museum Málaga** – Over 200 works by the artist, housed in a Renaissance palace.
- **Málaga Cathedral** – Nicknamed "La Manquita" (the one-armed lady) because its second tower was never completed.
- **Roman Theatre** – Remains of a 1st-century BC theatre at the foot of the Alcazaba.
- **Muelle Uno and Malagueta Beach** – A modern waterfront promenade and the city's main beach.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The historic centre is walkable and full of bars, but can be noisy. Soho is an arts district with murals, and La Malagueta is ideal for beach lovers. El Palo, further east, is a former fishing village known for seafood restaurants.

■ Food & Drink

Try espetos, sardines grilled on skewers over open fires on the beach. Fried fish (pescaíto frito), gazpacho and ajoblanco (a cold almond and garlic soup) are local favourites. The Atarazanas Market is a colourful food hall. Sweet Málaga wine is served at historic bars like Antigua Casa de Guardia.

■ When to Visit

Spring and autumn are ideal, and winters are mild enough for sightseeing. Summer is hot and busy on the beaches. Holy Week (Semana Santa) processions are among Spain's most impressive, and the Feria de Málaga in August is a massive street party.

■ Getting Around

The centre is walkable, and a train connects the airport with the city centre in about 12 minutes. Buses and a metro serve the wider area. High-speed trains reach Madrid in under three hours.

■ Day Trips

Ronda, a dramatic town on a gorge, and the Caminito del Rey, a spectacular cliffside walkway, are popular trips. Granada, Córdoba and Seville are reachable by train or bus. White villages such as Frigiliana and Mijas and beach towns like Nerja are close.

■ Practical Tips

- Book tickets for the Caminito del Rey well in advance.
- Many museums are free on Sunday afternoons.
- Try a "mitad" coffee, a local way of ordering coffee with milk.
- Book accommodation early for Holy Week and August.

Manaus

Brazil · South America

AMERICAS

A city in the heart of the Amazon rainforest, with a famous opera house.

Country	Brazil
Region	South America
Population (approx.)	~2.1 million
Language(s)	Portuguese
Currency	Brazilian Real (BRL)
Main airport	Eduardo Gomes International Airport (MAO)
Best time to visit	June–November

■ Overview

Manaus, the capital of Amazonas state, lies near the confluence of the Rio Negro and the Solimões (Amazon) River. During the rubber boom of the late 19th century, it became one of the richest cities in Brazil. The Teatro Amazonas opera house symbolises that era. Today Manaus is the main gateway to the Amazon rainforest. It is a busy, humid city.

■ Top Attractions

- **Teatro Amazonas** – A grand opera house built with European materials.
- **Meeting of the Waters** – The dark Rio Negro and sandy Solimões flow side by side.
- **Municipal Market Adolpho Lisboa** – A market inspired by Les Halles in Paris.
- **Amazon lodges** – Jungle lodges for wildlife and canoe trips.
- **MUSA** – A botanical garden with a tower.
- **Ponta Negra Beach** – A river beach.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The historic centre and Ponta Negra are popular.

■ Food & Drink

Amazonian fish like tambaqui and pirarucu, açaí and tacacá are local specialities.

■ When to Visit

June to November is drier, while the high-water season offers flooded forests.

■ Getting Around

Taxis and apps are common. Boats connect with river towns.

■ Day Trips

Jungle lodges, Anavilhanas Archipelago and river tours.

■ **Practical Tips**

- Use insect repellent.
- Check vaccination requirements (yellow fever).
- Book lodges in advance.
- Stay hydrated.

Manchester

EUROPE

United Kingdom (England) · Northern Europe

The birthplace of the Industrial Revolution and a powerhouse of football and music.

Country	United Kingdom (England)
Region	Northern Europe
Population (approx.)	~570,000 (city); ~2.9 million (Greater Manchester)
Language(s)	English
Currency	Pound Sterling (GBP)
Main airport	Manchester Airport (MAN)
Best time to visit	May–September

■ Overview

Manchester is a major city in northwest England, often described as the world's first industrial city thanks to its role in the cotton trade in the 19th century. Its red-brick mills and warehouses have been transformed into apartments, bars and cultural spaces. Manchester is famous for football, with Manchester United and Manchester City, and for music, from Joy Division and The Smiths to Oasis. It has a progressive, independent spirit and a vibrant student population. The city is a good base for exploring northern England.

■ Top Attractions

- **Old Trafford and Etihad Stadium** – Stadium tours and museums for Manchester United and Manchester City.
- **Science and Industry Museum** – Tells the story of Manchester's industrial past, located on the site of the world's oldest surviving passenger railway station.
- **John Rylands Library** – A stunning neo-Gothic library with rare books and manuscripts.
- **Manchester Museum and Whitworth Art Gallery** – University museums of natural history, archaeology and art.
- **Northern Quarter** – A creative district of independent shops, street art, record stores and bars.
- **National Football Museum** – An interactive museum dedicated to the history of football.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The city centre and Northern Quarter are lively and convenient. Ancoats is a trendy former mill district with excellent restaurants. Spinningfields is modern and business-oriented, while Didsbury and Chorlton are leafy suburbs with cafés.

■ Food & Drink

Manchester's food scene has grown impressively, with food halls like Mackie Mayor and Hatch. The Curry Mile in Rusholme is famous for South Asian cuisine. Traditional options include Eccles cakes, Manchester tart and pub classics. The city has a thriving craft beer scene.

■ When to Visit

Late spring and summer offer the best weather, though rain is frequent year-round. The Manchester International Festival is held in summer in odd-numbered years, and football season runs from August to May. Christmas markets are popular in December.

■ Getting Around

Manchester has an extensive Metrolink tram network and free city-centre buses on some routes. Trains connect the airport with Piccadilly station in about 15-20 minutes. London is about two hours away by train.

■ Day Trips

The Peak District National Park offers hiking and villages such as Castleton. Liverpool, home of the Beatles, is less than an hour away by train. The Lake District and York are also reachable.

■ Practical Tips

- Book stadium tours in advance, especially on match weeks.
- Bring a raincoat or umbrella.
- Many museums are free.
- Check football fixtures; hotel prices rise on match days.

Manila

Philippines · Southeast Asia

ASIA

A vibrant, chaotic capital of Spanish colonial heritage, malls and warm hospitality.

Country	Philippines
Region	Southeast Asia
Population (approx.)	~1.8 million (city); ~14 million (Metro Manila)
Language(s)	Filipino and English
Currency	Philippine Peso (PHP)
Main airport	Ninoy Aquino International Airport (MNL)
Best time to visit	December–April

■ Overview

Manila, the capital of the Philippines, lies on Manila Bay on the island of Luzon. Founded as a Spanish colonial city in 1571, it became a key hub of the Manila galleon trade between Asia and the Americas. The city was heavily damaged during the Second World War, but its walled historic district, Intramuros, retains Spanish-era churches and fortifications. Metro Manila is a huge, congested megacity made up of several cities, including Makati, Taguig and Quezon City. Filipinos are known for their warmth, humour and love of karaoke, and English is widely spoken.

■ Top Attractions

- **Intramuros** – The walled Spanish city, with Fort Santiago, cobbled streets and restored colonial houses; explore by bike or horse-drawn kalesa.
- **San Agustin Church** – The oldest stone church in the Philippines and a UNESCO World Heritage Site.
- **Rizal Park (Luneta)** – A large park with a monument to national hero José Rizal.
- **National Museum of the Philippines** – Free museums of fine arts, anthropology and natural history.
- **Binondo** – The world's oldest Chinatown, famous for street food tours.
- **Manila Bay sunset** – The bay is famous for its sunsets, viewed from the Baywalk.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Makati is the business district, with hotels, malls and nightlife, while Bonifacio Global City (BGC) in Taguig is modern and walkable. Ermita and Malate are near historic sites but grittier. Pasay has casino resorts near the airport.

■ Food & Drink

Filipino cuisine includes adobo (meat braised in vinegar and soy sauce), sinigang (sour soup), lechon and kare-kare (oxtail in peanut sauce). Halo-halo, a colourful shaved ice dessert, is perfect in the heat. Binondo offers dumplings and Chinese-Filipino specialities. Jollibee, the local fast-food chain, is a national favourite.

■ When to Visit

The dry season from December to April is best. The rainy season (June–November) brings typhoons and flooding. Christmas celebrations in the Philippines start as early as September.

■ Getting Around

Traffic is notoriously heavy. The LRT and MRT rail lines help, and Grab is widely used. Jeepneys and tricycles offer a local experience.

■ Day Trips

Tagaytay, on a ridge overlooking Taal Volcano, offers cooler air. Corregidor Island, a Second World War site, is reached by ferry. Las Casas Filipinas de Acuzar is a heritage resort of restored colonial houses.

■ Practical Tips

- Allow extra time for traffic, especially to the airport.
- Use Grab rather than street taxis.
- Watch your belongings in crowded areas.
- Check typhoon forecasts during the rainy season.

Marseille

France · Western Europe

EUROPE

France's oldest city, a gritty, sun-soaked Mediterranean port with dramatic calanques.

Country	France
Region	Western Europe
Population (approx.)	~870,000 (city); ~1.9 million (metro)
Language(s)	French
Currency	Euro (EUR)
Main airport	Marseille Provence Airport (MRS)
Best time to visit	April-June and September-October

■ Overview

Marseille was founded by Greek sailors around 600 BC, making it France's oldest city. It is the country's second-largest city and its main Mediterranean port, a multicultural crossroads with strong North African and Mediterranean influences. The city has an authentic, sometimes rough-edged character, very different from the glamour of the Riviera. Its regeneration in recent years, including new museums and waterfront areas, has made it a vibrant cultural destination. Marseille is also the gateway to the stunning Calanques National Park.

■ Top Attractions

- **Vieux-Port (Old Port)** – The historic harbour lined with cafés, fish stalls and boats, the centre of city life.
- **Notre-Dame de la Garde** – A basilica on a hill offering panoramic views; its golden Virgin statue watches over the city.
- **MuCEM** – The Museum of European and Mediterranean Civilisations, connected by a footbridge to Fort Saint-Jean.
- **Le Panier** – The oldest neighbourhood, with narrow streets, colourful houses and artisan shops.
- **Calanques National Park** – Limestone cliffs and turquoise coves reached by boat or hiking trails.
- **Château d'If** – The island fortress made famous by Alexandre Dumas's *The Count of Monte Cristo*.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The Vieux-Port area is central and convenient. Le Panier is charming, while Cours Julien is bohemian, with street art and bars. The Corniche and Vallon des Auffes offer seaside views, and the southern districts give access to beaches.

■ Food & Drink

Bouillabaisse, a rich fish stew, is Marseille's most famous dish, traditionally served in two courses; authentic versions are expensive. Panisse (chickpea fritters), navettes (boat-shaped biscuits) and pastis, an anise-flavoured aperitif, are local favourites. The Noailles market offers North African and Mediterranean produce.

■ When to Visit

Late spring and early autumn offer warm weather ideal for hiking and swimming. Summer is hot, and access to the Calanques may be restricted due to fire risk. The strong mistral wind can blow at any time of year.

■ Getting Around

Marseille has a metro, trams and buses. The airport is linked to Saint-Charles station by shuttle bus. TGV trains reach Paris in about three hours.

■ Day Trips

Cassis, a picturesque fishing port, is a gateway to the Calanques. Aix-en-Provence, with its fountains and markets, is about 30 minutes away. Avignon, Arles and the Luberon villages are also popular.

■ Practical Tips

- Check Calanques access conditions in summer; some trails close on high-risk days, and reservations are required for Sugiton in peak season.
- Keep valuables secure in crowded areas.
- For bouillabaisse, choose restaurants that follow the traditional charter.
- Wear sturdy shoes for coastal hikes.

Medellín

Colombia · South America

AMERICAS

The "City of Eternal Spring", famed for innovation, flowers and mountain views.

Country	Colombia
Region	South America
Population (approx.)	~2.6 million (city); ~4 million (metro)
Language(s)	Spanish
Currency	Colombian Peso (COP)
Main airport	José María Córdova International Airport (MDE)
Best time to visit	December–March and June–August

■ Overview

Medellín, the capital of Antioquia, lies in the Aburrá Valley surrounded by green mountains. Once notorious as the home of Pablo Escobar's cartel in the 1980s and 1990s, the city has transformed itself through urban innovation, including cable cars and escalators connecting hillside neighbourhoods. Its mild climate earns it the nickname "City of Eternal Spring". Medellín is now a popular destination for travellers and digital nomads. Paisas, as locals are called, are known for their friendliness and entrepreneurial spirit.

■ Top Attractions

- **Comuna 13** – A once-dangerous neighbourhood transformed by outdoor escalators, street art and hip-hop; best visited with a local guide.
- **Metrocable** – Cable cars integrated into the metro, offering views and access to Parque Arví.
- **Plaza Botero** – A square with 23 bronze sculptures by Fernando Botero, next to the Museum of Antioquia.
- **Parque Arví** – A nature reserve with trails and markets above the city.
- **Pueblito Paisa** – A replica of a traditional Antioquian village on Cerro Nutibara.
- **Museo Casa de la Memoria** – A museum about the region's armed conflict.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

El Poblado is upscale, with hotels and nightlife, while Laureles is more local and relaxed. Envigado is residential.

■ Food & Drink

Bandeja paisa, a hearty platter of beans, rice, meat, chicharrón, egg, plantain and arepa, is the regional dish. Arepas, empanadas and fresh juices are everywhere. Coffee from the region is excellent.

■ When to Visit

The weather is mild year-round. The Flower Festival (Feria de las Flores) in August is a highlight.

■ Getting Around

The metro, tram and cable cars are efficient. Taxis and ride-hailing apps are common.

■ Day Trips

Guatapé, with the Rock of Guatapé (El Peñol) and colourful town, is a popular trip. Coffee farms and Santa Fe de Antioquia are nearby.

■ Practical Tips

- Avoid glorifying Pablo Escobar; locals find narco-tourism offensive.
- Use ride-hailing apps.
- Be cautious with dating apps and drinks; scams targeting foreigners occur.
- Keep valuables hidden.

Mendoza

Argentina · South America

AMERICAS

Argentina's wine capital at the foot of the Andes and Aconcagua.

Country	Argentina
Region	South America
Population (approx.)	~120,000 (city); ~1.1 million (metro)
Language(s)	Spanish
Currency	Argentine Peso (ARS)
Main airport	Governor Francisco Gabrielli International Airport (MDZ)
Best time to visit	March–April (harvest) and October–November

■ Overview

Mendoza, in western Argentina, is the heart of the country's wine industry, producing most of its Malbec. The city was rebuilt after an earthquake in 1861 with wide streets, plazas and irrigation channels (acequias) that keep trees green in the dry climate. Mendoza is surrounded by vineyards with the Andes as a backdrop. It is a base for wine tours, adventure sports and trips to Aconcagua, the highest mountain outside Asia. The city has a relaxed, sunny atmosphere.

■ Top Attractions

- **Wineries in Luján de Cuyo, Maipú and the Uco Valley** – Tastings and vineyard lunches.
- **Plaza Independencia** – The main square.
- **Parque General San Martín** – A large park with a lake and hill views.
- **Cerro de la Gloria** – A monument to the Army of the Andes.
- **Aconcagua Provincial Park** – Views of the 6,961-metre peak.
- **Potrerillos** – A reservoir for rafting and kayaking.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The city centre and Chacras de Coria are popular.

■ Food & Drink

Asado (barbecue) and empanadas pair perfectly with Malbec. Many wineries offer gourmet lunches.

■ When to Visit

The harvest festival (Vendimia) takes place in March. Spring and autumn are ideal.

■ Getting Around

Buses and taxis are available. Bikes are popular in Maipú for winery tours.

■ Day Trips

Uco Valley, Aconcagua and the Andes road to Chile are popular.

■ Practical Tips

- Book winery visits in advance.
- Don't drink and drive; hire a driver or tour.
- Carry cash.
- Protect yourself from the sun.

Mexico City

Mexico · North America

AMERICAS

A vast, vibrant capital of Aztec ruins, murals, museums and street food.

Country	Mexico
Region	North America
Population (approx.)	~9.2 million (city); ~22 million (metro)
Language(s)	Spanish
Currency	Mexican Peso (MXN)
Main airport	Benito Juárez International Airport (MEX); Felipe Ángeles International (NLU)
Best time to visit	October–May

■ Overview

Mexico City (Ciudad de México, CDMX) is built on the ruins of Tenochtitlan, the Aztec capital, which stood on an island in a lake. It is one of the largest cities in the world and the political, cultural and economic heart of Mexico. The city has world-class museums, colonial architecture, leafy neighbourhoods and a legendary food scene. Artists such as Frida Kahlo and Diego Rivera left a lasting legacy. It is a co-host of the 2026 FIFA World Cup, with matches at the Estadio Azteca.

■ Top Attractions

- **Zócalo and the Historic Centre** – The main square, the Metropolitan Cathedral and the National Palace with Rivera's murals.
- **Templo Mayor** – Ruins of the main Aztec temple.
- **National Museum of Anthropology** – One of the world's finest museums of pre-Columbian art, including the Aztec Sun Stone.
- **Frida Kahlo Museum (Casa Azul)** – Frida Kahlo's home in Coyoacán.
- **Chapultepec Park and Castle** – A vast park with museums.
- **Teotihuacan** – An ancient city with the Pyramids of the Sun and Moon.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Roma and Condesa are trendy, Polanco upscale, and Coyoacán bohemian.

■ Food & Drink

Tacos al pastor, tamales, chilaquiles, mole and churros are staples. Pujol and Quintonil are world-famous restaurants.

■ When to Visit

October to May is dry. The Day of the Dead (early November) is spectacular.

■ **Getting Around**

The metro is cheap but crowded. Ride-hailing apps are safe and convenient.

■ **Day Trips**

Teotihuacan, Puebla, Xochimilco and Cholula are popular.

■ **Practical Tips**

- Take it easy at altitude (2,240 m).
- Use apps for taxis.
- Drink bottled water.
- Book Frida Kahlo Museum tickets in advance.

Miami

AMERICAS

United States (Florida) · North America

A sun-soaked city of Art Deco, beaches and Latin American culture.

Country	United States (Florida)
Region	North America
Population (approx.)	~450,000 (city); ~6.1 million (metro)
Language(s)	English and Spanish
Currency	US Dollar (USD)
Main airport	Miami International Airport (MIA); Fort Lauderdale (FLL)
Best time to visit	November–April

■ Overview

Miami, at the southeastern tip of Florida, is a major centre of finance, culture and tourism with strong Latin American and Caribbean influences. Miami Beach is known for its Art Deco Historic District and nightlife. Little Havana reflects the Cuban exile community. Miami is also an art hub, hosting Art Basel Miami Beach. It is a gateway to the Everglades and the Florida Keys.

■ Top Attractions

- **South Beach and Ocean Drive** – Beaches and Art Deco buildings.
- **Wynwood Walls** – Outdoor street art.
- **Little Havana** – Cuban culture on Calle Ocho.
- **Vizcaya Museum and Gardens** – An Italian Renaissance-style villa.
- **Pérez Art Museum Miami** – Contemporary art.
- **Everglades National Park** – Wetlands with alligators.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

South Beach, Brickell, Wynwood and Coconut Grove are popular.

■ Food & Drink

Cuban sandwiches, stone crabs and Latin American cuisine are highlights.

■ When to Visit

Winter is pleasant. Hurricane season runs from June to November.

■ Getting Around

Metrorail, Metromover (free) and buses. A car is useful.

■ Day Trips

The Florida Keys and Everglades.

■ **Practical Tips**

- Use sunscreen.
- Check hurricane forecasts.
- Book early during Art Basel.
- Try Cuban coffee.

Milan

Italy · Southern Europe

EUROPE

Italy's capital of fashion, design and finance, home to The Last Supper.

Country	Italy
Region	Southern Europe
Population (approx.)	~1.4 million (city); ~3.2 million (metro)
Language(s)	Italian
Currency	Euro (EUR)
Main airport	Milan Malpensa (MXP), Linate (LIN), Bergamo Orio al Serio (BGY)
Best time to visit	April-June and September-October

■ Overview

Milan is the capital of Lombardy and Italy's economic powerhouse, known worldwide for fashion, design, finance and football. It has a long history as a Roman capital and later as a powerful duchy under the Visconti and Sforza families. While less romantic than Rome or Venice, Milan offers world-class art, magnificent architecture and stylish shopping. It is a dynamic, international city with excellent restaurants, bars and nightlife. Milan is also the gateway to Lake Como and the Italian Lakes.

■ Top Attractions

- **Milan Cathedral (Duomo)** – A spectacular Gothic cathedral; walk on its rooftop among spires and statues.
- **The Last Supper** – Leonardo da Vinci's mural in the refectory of Santa Maria delle Grazie; tickets must be booked well in advance.
- **Galleria Vittorio Emanuele II** – A 19th-century glass-roofed shopping arcade with luxury boutiques.
- **Sforza Castle** – A castle housing several museums, including Michelangelo's final sculpture, the Rondanini Pietà.
- **Teatro alla Scala** – One of the world's most famous opera houses, with a museum.
- **Navigli** – Canals lined with bars and restaurants, famous for aperitivo.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The area around the Duomo is central and convenient. Brera is artistic and elegant, with galleries and cafés. Navigli is lively in the evening, while Porta Nuova and Isola are modern districts with the Bosco Verticale towers.

■ Food & Drink

Milan's specialities include risotto alla milanese (saffron risotto), cotoletta alla milanese (breaded veal cutlet) and ossobuco. Panettone, a sweet Christmas bread, originated here. Aperitivo culture is strong, with cocktails like the Negroni sbagliato and Campari spritz often served with snacks.

■ When to Visit

Spring and autumn are best. Summer is hot and humid, and many businesses close in August. Milan Fashion Week and Milan Design Week (Salone del Mobile, April) fill hotels quickly.

■ Getting Around

Milan has an efficient metro, trams and buses. The Malpensa Express connects the main airport with the city in about 50 minutes. High-speed trains reach Rome, Florence, Venice and Turin.

■ Day Trips

Lake Como, with towns like Bellagio and Varenna, is about an hour away. Bergamo's upper town and Lake Maggiore with the Borromean Islands are also popular. Verona and Turin are easy trips by high-speed train.

■ Practical Tips

- Book The Last Supper tickets months in advance; slots are limited and tours are only 15 minutes.
- Validate transport tickets before travel.
- Avoid visiting in mid-August when many places are closed.
- Aperitivo typically runs from about 6 to 9 pm.

Montevideo

Uruguay · South America

AMERICAS

A relaxed, safe capital of beaches, Art Deco buildings and grilled meat.

Country	Uruguay
Region	South America
Population (approx.)	~1.4 million (city); ~1.9 million (metro)
Language(s)	Spanish
Currency	Uruguayan Peso (UYU)
Main airport	Carrasco International Airport (MVD)
Best time to visit	November–March

■ Overview

Montevideo, the capital of Uruguay, lies on the Río de la Plata. It is known for its relaxed lifestyle, long waterfront promenade (Rambla) and safety compared with other capitals in the region. The Ciudad Vieja has colonial and Art Deco buildings. Uruguay is progressive, with legal cannabis and same-sex marriage. Locals love mate tea and football.

■ Top Attractions

- **Ciudad Vieja** – The old town with colonial buildings.
- **Rambla** – A long promenade along the water.
- **Mercado del Puerto** – A market with parrillas (grills).
- **Teatro Solís** – A historic theatre.
- **Palacio Salvo** – An iconic building.
- **Football Museum at the Estadio Centenario** – Site of the first World Cup in 1930.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Pocitos, Punta Carretas and Ciudad Vieja are popular.

■ Food & Drink

Asado and chivito (a steak sandwich) are national dishes.

■ When to Visit

Summer is ideal for beaches. Carnival in Montevideo is the world's longest.

■ Getting Around

Buses and taxis are common.

■ Day Trips

Colonia del Sacramento and Punta del Este.

■ **Practical Tips**

- Carry cash and cards.
- Try mate.
- Visit during Carnival.
- Sunday is quiet.

Montreal

AMERICAS

Canada (Quebec) · North America

A bilingual city of European charm, festivals, bagels and joie de vivre.

Country	Canada (Quebec)
Region	North America
Population (approx.)	~1.8 million (city); ~4.3 million (metro)
Language(s)	French (English widely spoken)
Currency	Canadian Dollar (CAD)
Main airport	Montréal-Trudeau International Airport (YUL)
Best time to visit	May–October

■ Overview

Montreal, on an island in the St. Lawrence River, is the largest city in Quebec and the second-largest French-speaking city in the world after Paris. Founded in 1642 as Ville-Marie, it has a historic old town with cobblestone streets and grand churches. The city is known for its creative culture, festivals, food and nightlife. Montreal blends North American energy with European style. Its underground city (RÉSO) connects shopping centres and metro stations, useful in winter.

■ Top Attractions

- **Old Montreal (Vieux-Montréal)** – Cobblestone streets, the Old Port and historic buildings.
- **Notre-Dame Basilica** – A Gothic Revival church with a stunning blue interior and the AURA light show.
- **Mount Royal** – A park designed by Frederick Law Olmsted, with views over the city.
- **Montreal Museum of Fine Arts** – A major art museum.
- **Jean-Talon and Atwater Markets** – Food markets with local produce.
- **Plateau Mont-Royal** – A neighbourhood of colourful houses with outdoor staircases.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Old Montreal is historic, the Plateau and Mile End are bohemian, and Downtown is central.

■ Food & Drink

Poutine (fries with cheese curds and gravy), Montreal-style bagels (from St-Viateur and Fairmount) and smoked meat sandwiches (Schwartz's) are icons. Maple syrup treats are everywhere.

■ When to Visit

Summer is packed with festivals, including the Montreal International Jazz Festival and Just for Laughs. Winters are cold and snowy.

■ Getting Around

The metro is efficient. BIXI bike-share is popular.

■ Day Trips

Quebec City, the Eastern Townships and Mont-Tremblant are popular.

■ Practical Tips

- Greet with "Bonjour" - most people switch to English if needed.
- Dress warmly in winter.
- Tipping 15-20% is expected.
- Book festivals accommodation early.

Mumbai

India · South Asia

ASIA

India's city of dreams, home to Bollywood, colonial architecture and seaside promenades.

Country	India
Region	South Asia
Population (approx.)	~21 million (metro)
Language(s)	Marathi and Hindi (English widely spoken)
Currency	Indian Rupee (INR)
Main airport	Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj International Airport (BOM)
Best time to visit	November–February

■ Overview

Mumbai (formerly Bombay), the capital of Maharashtra, is India's financial capital and most populous city. Originally a group of seven islands, it was developed by the British into a major port. The city combines Victorian Gothic and Art Deco architecture, bustling markets, luxury hotels and vast informal settlements. Mumbai is home to Bollywood, the world's most prolific film industry. It is fast-paced and energetic, yet also known for its spirit of resilience.

■ Top Attractions

- **Gateway of India** – An arch monument on the waterfront built to commemorate a royal visit in 1911.
- **Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj Terminus** – A spectacular Victorian Gothic railway station and UNESCO site.
- **Marine Drive** – A seaside promenade known as the "Queen's Necklace" for its lights at night.
- **Elephanta Caves** – Rock-cut temples dedicated to Shiva on an island reached by ferry.
- **Dhobi Ghat** – A giant open-air laundry.
- **Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj Vastu Sangrahalaya** – The city's main museum, formerly the Prince of Wales Museum.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Colaba is the tourist hub near the Gateway of India. Fort and Kala Ghoda have colonial buildings and galleries, and Bandra is trendy, with cafés and bars. Juhu has beaches and Bollywood homes.

■ Food & Drink

Mumbai's street food includes vada pav (potato fritter in a bun), pav bhaji, bhelpuri and pani puri. Seafood, especially Malvani and Koli dishes, is excellent. Irani cafés serve bun maska and chai. Mumbai has a thriving restaurant and bar scene.

■ When to Visit

November to February is the most pleasant. The monsoon (June–September) brings heavy rain. Ganesh Chaturthi, in August or September, is celebrated with grand processions.

■ Getting Around

Local trains are fast but extremely crowded at rush hour. The metro network is expanding, and taxis, auto-rickshaws (in the suburbs) and ride-hailing apps are available. Traffic is heavy.

■ Day Trips

Elephanta Caves are a short ferry ride away. Kanheri Caves are in Sanjay Gandhi National Park. The hill stations of Lonavala and Matheran offer cooler air.

■ Practical Tips

- Avoid local trains at rush hour.
- Monsoon floods can disrupt travel.
- Carry cash for street food.
- Use ride-hailing apps for convenience.

Munich

Germany · Central Europe

EUROPE

Bavaria's capital of beer gardens, baroque churches and Alpine views.

Country	Germany
Region	Central Europe
Population (approx.)	~1.5 million (city); ~6 million (metro region)
Language(s)	German
Currency	Euro (EUR)
Main airport	Munich Airport (MUC)
Best time to visit	May–October; late September–early October for Oktoberfest

■ Overview

Munich (München), the capital of Bavaria, is one of Germany's wealthiest and most attractive cities. It is known for its traditional Bavarian culture, including beer halls, lederhosen and the world-famous Oktoberfest. The city was the seat of the Wittelsbach dynasty, which left behind palaces, museums and royal gardens. Munich is also a major centre of technology and industry, home to BMW and Siemens. With the Alps close by, it combines urban sophistication with easy access to nature.

■ Top Attractions

- **Marienplatz and the New Town Hall** – The central square, where the Glockenspiel re-enacts historic events daily.
- **English Garden** – One of the world's largest urban parks, with beer gardens and surfers riding the Eisbach wave.
- **Nymphenburg Palace** – A grand baroque summer palace of the Bavarian rulers.
- **Residenz** – The former royal palace in the city centre, with lavish rooms and a treasury.
- **Deutsches Museum** – One of the world's largest museums of science and technology.
- **Hofbräuhaus** – The most famous beer hall in the world, with oompah music and long tables.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The Altstadt is central and walkable. Schwabing is lively, with a student population and cafés near the English Garden, while Glockenbachviertel is trendy and LGBTQ+-friendly. Maxvorstadt is the museum district, and Haidhausen is charming and residential.

■ Food & Drink

Bavarian cuisine includes Weisswurst (white sausage, traditionally eaten before noon), pretzels, roast pork, Obatzda (a cheese spread) and Schweinshaxe (pork knuckle). Beer gardens allow guests to bring their own food if they buy drinks. The Viktualienmarkt is a traditional food market. Munich's six major breweries supply Oktoberfest.

■ When to Visit

Summer is ideal for beer gardens and lakes. Oktoberfest runs for about 16–18 days, usually from mid/late September to the first Sunday in October. December brings traditional Christmas markets, and winter offers easy access to Alpine skiing.

■ Getting Around

Munich has an efficient U-Bahn, S-Bahn, tram and bus network. The S-Bahn connects the airport with the centre in about 40 minutes. The city centre is compact and walkable, and cycling is popular.

■ Day Trips

Neuschwanstein Castle, the fairy-tale castle of King Ludwig II, is about two hours away. The Dachau Concentration Camp Memorial Site is a short train ride away. Salzburg, Garmisch-Partenkirchen and the Zugspitze, and lakes such as Tegernsee are also popular.

■ Practical Tips

- Book Oktoberfest accommodation many months ahead.
- Book Neuschwanstein tickets in advance.
- Beer steins at Oktoberfest are one litre; pace yourself.
- Shops are closed on Sundays.

Muscat

Oman · Middle East

ASIA

A serene Arabian capital of white buildings, forts and rugged mountains by the sea.

Country	Oman
Region	Middle East
Population (approx.)	~1.5 million (metro)
Language(s)	Arabic (English widely spoken)
Currency	Omani Rial (OMR)
Main airport	Muscat International Airport (MCT)
Best time to visit	October–April

■ Overview

Muscat, the capital of Oman, lies between the Gulf of Oman and the rugged Al Hajar Mountains. Unlike its flashier Gulf neighbours, Muscat has preserved a low-rise skyline of white buildings and traditional architecture. The city has a long maritime history, and Oman once controlled an empire stretching to Zanzibar. Muscat is calm, clean and welcoming, with forts, souks and beaches. It is an excellent base for exploring Oman's deserts, wadis and mountains.

■ Top Attractions

- **Sultan Qaboos Grand Mosque** – A magnificent mosque with a giant chandelier and a huge hand-woven carpet; open to non-Muslims in the morning, except Fridays.
- **Mutrah Souq and Corniche** – A traditional market for frankincense, silver and textiles along a waterfront promenade.
- **Royal Opera House Muscat** – An elegant opera house with performances from around the world.
- **Al Alam Palace and Old Muscat** – The ceremonial palace flanked by Portuguese-era forts Al Jalali and Al Mirani.
- **National Museum of Oman** – Exhibits on Omani history and culture.
- **Bait Al Zubair** – A museum of Omani heritage.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Mutrah and Old Muscat are historic. Qurum and Shatti Al Qurum have beaches and hotels, and Al Mouj is a modern marina development.

■ Food & Drink

Omani cuisine includes shuwa (slow-cooked marinated lamb), majboos and halwa (a sticky sweet). Omani coffee (kahwa) is flavoured with cardamom and served with dates. Seafood is excellent.

■ When to Visit

October to April is pleasant. Summers are extremely hot. Ramadan affects opening hours.

■ Getting Around

Taxis and ride-hailing apps are common. Renting a car is ideal for exploring Oman. The city is spread out along the coast.

■ Day Trips

Wadi Shab and Bimmah Sinkhole are popular swimming spots. Nizwa, with its fort and souk, is about 1.5 hours away. The Wahiba Sands desert offers camping.

■ Practical Tips

- Dress modestly, especially in mosques and souks.
- Friday is the holy day.
- Carry water when hiking in wadis.
- Respect local customs.

Naples

Italy · Southern Europe

EUROPE

The chaotic, passionate birthplace of pizza, beneath the shadow of Vesuvius.

Country	Italy
Region	Southern Europe
Population (approx.)	~910,000 (city); ~3 million (metro)
Language(s)	Italian (Neapolitan dialect widely spoken)
Currency	Euro (EUR)
Main airport	Naples International Airport, Capodichino (NAP)
Best time to visit	April-June and September-October

■ Overview

Naples is southern Italy's largest city and one of the oldest continuously inhabited cities in the world, founded by Greek colonists. Its historic centre is a UNESCO World Heritage Site, full of churches, palaces and underground passages. Naples is loud, crowded and full of life, with a strong local identity, street culture and devotion to football and saints. It is the birthplace of pizza and home to some of Italy's best street food. The city is also the gateway to Pompeii, Herculaneum, the Amalfi Coast and the islands of Capri and Ischia.

■ Top Attractions

- **National Archaeological Museum** – One of the world's most important archaeological museums, with treasures from Pompeii and Herculaneum.
- **Spaccanapoli and the historic centre** – A long, straight street cutting through the old town, lined with churches, shops and street vendors.
- **Naples Underground (Napoli Sotterranea)** – Tunnels, cisterns and Greek-Roman ruins beneath the city.
- **Cappella Sansevero** – Home to the Veiled Christ, an astonishing marble sculpture.
- **Castel dell'Ovo and the waterfront** – A seaside castle and promenade with views of Vesuvius.
- **Via San Gregorio Armeno** – A street famous for workshops making nativity scenes.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The historic centre is atmospheric and central. Chiaia is elegant, with shops and seafront views, while Vomero is residential, on a hill with panoramic views. The Quartieri Spagnoli are lively and full of murals, including shrines to Diego Maradona.

■ Food & Drink

Neapolitan pizza, with a soft, puffy crust, is the city's pride; classic pizzerias include Da Michele and Sorbillo. Street foods include pizza frita (fried pizza), cuoppo (paper cones of fried seafood) and sfogliatella pastries. Babà al rum is a local dessert. Espresso in Naples is strong and taken standing at the bar.

■ When to Visit

Spring and autumn are ideal. Summer is hot but great for trips to the coast and islands. Religious festivals include the Feast of San Gennaro, when the saint's blood is said to liquefy.

■ Getting Around

Naples has a metro, funiculars and buses, though traffic is chaotic. The Circumvesuviana train connects Naples to Pompeii, Herculaneum and Sorrento. Ferries depart for Capri, Ischia, Procida and the Amalfi Coast.

■ Day Trips

Pompeii and Herculaneum, Roman towns buried by Vesuvius in AD 79, are unmissable. Hiking to the crater of Mount Vesuvius is possible with a timed ticket. The Amalfi Coast, Capri and the Royal Palace of Caserta are other popular trips.

■ Practical Tips

- Watch your belongings in crowded areas and on public transport.
- Book Vesuvius crater tickets online.
- Cross streets confidently; scooters rarely stop.
- The Campania ArteCard offers transport and museum discounts.

Nara

Japan · East Asia

ASIA

Japan's first permanent capital, famous for friendly deer and a giant bronze Buddha.

Country	Japan
Region	East Asia
Population (approx.)	~350,000
Language(s)	Japanese
Currency	Japanese Yen (JPY)
Main airport	Kansai International Airport (KIX); Osaka Itami (ITM)
Best time to visit	March–May and October–November

■ Overview

Nara was Japan's capital from 710 to 784, during a period when Buddhism and culture flourished. It contains some of Japan's oldest and largest temples, many of which are part of a UNESCO World Heritage Site. Nara is famous for its free-roaming sika deer, considered sacred messengers of the gods. The city is compact and relaxed, making it a popular day trip from Kyoto or Osaka. Staying overnight allows visitors to enjoy its temples in quieter hours.

■ Top Attractions

- **Todai-ji** – A temple housing a 15-metre bronze Buddha in one of the world's largest wooden buildings.
- **Nara Park** – A large park where over 1,000 deer roam freely and bow for deer crackers.
- **Kasuga Taisha** – A Shinto shrine famous for thousands of lanterns.
- **Kofuku-ji** – A temple with a five-storey pagoda.
- **Isuien Garden** – A beautiful traditional garden.
- **Naramachi** – A historic merchant district.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Staying near Nara Park or Kintetsu Nara Station is convenient.

■ Food & Drink

Kakinoha-zushi (sushi wrapped in persimmon leaves) and narazuke (pickles) are local specialities. Mochi from Nakatanidou is famous for its fast pounding.

■ When to Visit

Spring and autumn are beautiful. Lantern festivals take place in February and August.

■ Getting Around

Most sights are walkable from the stations. Kintetsu and JR trains connect Nara with Kyoto and Osaka.

■ Day Trips

Horyu-ji, one of the world's oldest wooden buildings, is nearby. Yoshino is famous for cherry blossoms.

■ Practical Tips

- Deer can nibble or butt; be careful with food.
- Visit early to avoid crowds.
- Buy deer crackers only from official vendors.
- Combine Nara with Kyoto or Osaka.

Nashville

AMERICAS

United States (Tennessee) · North America

"Music City", the home of country music, honky-tonks and hot chicken.

Country	United States (Tennessee)
Region	North America
Population (approx.)	~700,000 (city); ~2 million (metro)
Language(s)	English
Currency	US Dollar (USD)
Main airport	Nashville International Airport (BNA)
Best time to visit	April-June and September-October

■ Overview

Nashville, the capital of Tennessee, is known worldwide as the centre of country music. The Grand Ole Opry radio show, broadcast since 1925, made the city famous. Nashville has a vibrant live music scene across genres. The city has grown rapidly and is popular for bachelor and bachelorette parties. It also has Civil War history and a growing food scene.

■ Top Attractions

- **Broadway honky-tonks** – Bars with live music all day and night.
- **Grand Ole Opry** – The legendary country music show.
- **Country Music Hall of Fame and Museum** – The history of country music.
- **Ryman Auditorium** – The "Mother Church of Country Music".
- **The Parthenon** – A full-scale replica of the Athenian temple in Centennial Park.
- **Johnny Cash Museum** – A museum dedicated to the life and music of the "Man in Black".

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Downtown, The Gulch, East Nashville and 12 South are popular.

■ Food & Drink

Nashville hot chicken, barbecue and Southern comfort food are local favourites.

■ When to Visit

Spring and autumn are ideal. The CMA Fest takes place in June.

■ Getting Around

A car or ride-hailing is useful. Downtown is walkable.

■ Day Trips

The Jack Daniel's Distillery, Franklin and Memphis are popular.

■ **Practical Tips**

- Book Opry tickets in advance.
- Try hot chicken with caution.
- Tip musicians.
- Book hotels early for events.

New Orleans

AMERICAS

United States (Louisiana) · North America

The birthplace of jazz, famous for Mardi Gras, Creole food and French Quarter charm.

Country	United States (Louisiana)
Region	North America
Population (approx.)	~360,000 (city); ~1.3 million (metro)
Language(s)	English
Currency	US Dollar (USD)
Main airport	Louis Armstrong New Orleans International Airport (MSY)
Best time to visit	February–May and October–November

■ Overview

New Orleans, on the Mississippi River in Louisiana, is one of the most unique cities in the United States. Founded by the French in 1718, it later came under Spanish rule, giving it a distinctive Creole culture. The city is the birthplace of jazz and is famous for music, festivals and food. Hurricane Katrina devastated the city in 2005, but it has rebuilt. Its motto "Laissez les bons temps rouler" (Let the good times roll) sums up its spirit.

■ Top Attractions

- **French Quarter** – Historic streets with wrought-iron balconies, Jackson Square and St. Louis Cathedral.
- **Frenchmen Street** – Live jazz clubs.
- **Garden District** – Grand mansions and Lafayette Cemetery.
- **National WWII Museum** – A major museum on the Second World War.
- **Bourbon Street** – A famous party street.
- **Swamp tours** – Tours of the bayous.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The French Quarter, Marigny and Garden District are popular.

■ Food & Drink

Gumbo, jambalaya, po'boys, beignets from Café du Monde and crawfish boils are local classics.

■ When to Visit

Mardi Gras (February/March) and Jazz Fest (April/May) are major events. Summers are hot and humid.

■ **Getting Around**

Streetcars, walking and ride-hailing apps.

■ **Day Trips**

Plantations along River Road and swamp tours.

■ **Practical Tips**

- Book early for Mardi Gras and Jazz Fest.
- Stay aware of your surroundings at night.
- Try beignets.
- Hurricane season runs June–November.

New York City

AMERICAS

United States (New York) · North America

The city that never sleeps – skyscrapers, Broadway, museums and endless energy.

Country	United States (New York)
Region	North America
Population (approx.)	~8.3 million (city); ~19.5 million (metro)
Language(s)	English (hundreds of languages spoken)
Currency	US Dollar (USD)
Main airport	John F. Kennedy (JFK), LaGuardia (LGA), Newark Liberty (EWR)
Best time to visit	April-June and September-November

■ Overview

New York City is the largest city in the United States and one of the world's great cultural and financial capitals. It consists of five boroughs: Manhattan, Brooklyn, Queens, the Bronx and Staten Island. Founded as New Amsterdam by the Dutch, it became the gateway for millions of immigrants through Ellis Island. New York is a global centre of art, fashion, theatre, media and finance. Its iconic skyline and diverse neighbourhoods make it endlessly fascinating.

■ Top Attractions

- **Statue of Liberty and Ellis Island** – Symbols of freedom and immigration.
- **Central Park** – An 843-acre park in the heart of Manhattan.
- **Times Square and Broadway** – Bright lights and theatre.
- **Metropolitan Museum of Art** – One of the world's largest art museums.
- **Empire State Building, Top of the Rock and One World Observatory** – Iconic views.
- **9/11 Memorial and Museum** – Twin reflecting pools on the footprints of the Twin Towers and a museum on the 2001 attacks.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Midtown, Greenwich Village, SoHo, the Lower East Side and Williamsburg in Brooklyn are popular.

■ Food & Drink

New York pizza, bagels, pastrami sandwiches and diverse cuisines are everywhere.

■ When to Visit

Spring and autumn are ideal. Christmas is festive.

■ **Getting Around**

The subway runs 24/7; OMNY contactless payment works.

■ **Day Trips**

The Hudson Valley, the Hamptons and Philadelphia.

■ **Practical Tips**

- Walk on the right; keep moving.
- Book Broadway tickets in advance or use TKTS.
- Tip 18-20%.
- Use the subway rather than taxis.

Nice

France · Western Europe

EUROPE

The sunny capital of the French Riviera, with a famous seafront promenade.

Country	France
Region	Western Europe
Population (approx.)	~345,000 (city); ~1 million (metro)
Language(s)	French
Currency	Euro (EUR)
Main airport	Nice Côte d'Azur Airport (NCE)
Best time to visit	April-June and September-October

■ Overview

Nice is the largest city on the French Riviera (Côte d'Azur), set on the Baie des Anges between the Alps and the Mediterranean. It belonged to the Kingdom of Sardinia until 1860, and its Italian heritage is visible in its colourful architecture and cuisine. In the 19th century, Nice became a winter resort for European aristocracy, and it later attracted artists such as Matisse and Chagall. Its historic centre and the Promenade des Anglais are UNESCO-listed as "Nice, winter resort town of the Riviera". The city is an ideal base for exploring the Riviera.

■ Top Attractions

- **Promenade des Anglais** – A 7-kilometre seafront promenade perfect for walks, cycling and sunsets.
- **Vieux Nice (Old Town)** – Narrow lanes, baroque churches and the Cours Saleya flower and food market.
- **Castle Hill (Colline du Château)** – A park with a waterfall and panoramic views over the bay and old town.
- **Matisse Museum** – A museum in Cimiez dedicated to Henri Matisse, who lived in Nice for many years.
- **Marc Chagall National Museum** – A collection of Chagall's biblical works.
- **Promenade du Paillon** – A long urban park with fountains linking the old town and the modern city.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Vieux Nice is atmospheric and central, while the area around Place Masséna and the Promenade is convenient. The Port area (Lympia) is lively with restaurants, and Cimiez is quiet and residential, home to museums and Roman ruins.

■ Food & Drink

Niçoise cuisine includes *salade niçoise*, *socca* (a chickpea pancake), *pissaladière* (onion tart with anchovies) and *pan bagnat* (a tuna sandwich). *Petits farcis* are stuffed vegetables. Local Bellet wine is produced in the hills above the city. Rosé wine from Provence is a summer staple.

■ When to Visit

Spring and autumn are pleasant and less crowded. Summer is hot and busy, with beach life in full swing. The Nice Carnival in February is one of the world's major carnivals, with flower battles.

■ Getting Around

Nice has a modern tram network linking the airport, city centre and port. Buses and trains connect Nice with other Riviera towns cheaply. The centre is walkable.

■ Day Trips

Monaco and Monte Carlo are 20–30 minutes away by train. Èze, a medieval hilltop village, and Villefranche-sur-Mer are close. Antibes, Cannes, Menton and Saint-Paul-de-Vence are also easy trips.

■ Practical Tips

- Nice's beaches are pebbly; bring water shoes or rent a sunbed at a private beach.
- Use the regional trains to explore the Riviera cheaply.
- Book accommodation early for summer and Carnival.
- Many museums in Nice are free or cheap with a city pass.

Oaxaca

Mexico · North America

AMERICAS

Mexico's culinary and cultural heart, with mole, mezcal and indigenous traditions.

Country	Mexico
Region	North America
Population (approx.)	~270,000 (city); ~700,000 (metro)
Language(s)	Spanish and indigenous languages (Zapotec, Mixtec)
Currency	Mexican Peso (MXN)
Main airport	Oaxaca International Airport (OAX)
Best time to visit	October–April

■ Overview

Oaxaca de Juárez, the capital of the state of Oaxaca in southern Mexico, is a colonial city surrounded by mountains and indigenous communities. Its historic centre, a UNESCO World Heritage Site, is filled with colourful buildings and churches. Oaxaca is famous for its food, especially mole and mezcal, as well as crafts and festivals. The Zapotec ruins of Monte Albán overlook the city. Oaxaca is one of Mexico's most culturally rich destinations.

■ Top Attractions

- **Templo de Santo Domingo de Guzmán** – A baroque church with a gilded interior.
- **Monte Albán** – Ancient Zapotec city on a mountaintop.
- **Mercado 20 de Noviembre** – A market with grilled meats.
- **Hierve el Agua** – Petrified waterfalls.
- **Mezcal distilleries** – Tours in Santiago Matatlán.
- **Guelaguetza** – An indigenous dance festival in July.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Centro and Jalatlaco are charming.

■ Food & Drink

Mole negro, tlayudas, chapulines (grasshoppers) and chocolate are local specialities.

■ When to Visit

October to April is dry. The Day of the Dead is spectacular.

■ Getting Around

The centre is walkable.

■ Day Trips

Hierve el Agua, Mitla and craft villages.

■ Practical Tips

- Book Day of the Dead accommodation early.
- Drink mezcal slowly.
- Try chapulines.
- Respect local customs.

Orlando

AMERICAS

United States (Florida) · North America

The theme park capital of the world.

Country	United States (Florida)
Region	North America
Population (approx.)	~320,000 (city); ~2.8 million (metro)
Language(s)	English (Spanish widely spoken)
Currency	US Dollar (USD)
Main airport	Orlando International Airport (MCO)
Best time to visit	March–May and September–November

■ Overview

Orlando, in central Florida, is one of the most visited cities in the United States thanks to its theme parks, including Walt Disney World, Universal Orlando and SeaWorld. The city grew rapidly after Disney World opened in 1971. Beyond the parks, Orlando has lakes, gardens and a growing food scene. It is a family-friendly destination with countless hotels and attractions. The Kennedy Space Center is about an hour away.

■ Top Attractions

- **Walt Disney World** – Four theme parks (Magic Kingdom, EPCOT, Hollywood Studios and Animal Kingdom) and two water parks.
- **Universal Orlando Resort** – Universal Studios, Islands of Adventure and Epic Universe, which opened in 2025.
- **SeaWorld Orlando** – Marine-themed park with rides.
- **Kennedy Space Center** – NASA's launch site, with rockets and exhibits.
- **ICON Park** – Home to The Wheel, a giant observation wheel.
- **Lake Eola Park** – A downtown park with swan boats.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Lake Buena Vista, International Drive and Kissimmee are near the parks. Downtown and Winter Park are more local.

■ Food & Drink

Theme parks have themed restaurants, while Disney Springs offers dining and shopping. Cuban and Puerto Rican cuisine is common.

■ When to Visit

Spring and autumn are pleasant. Summers are hot and stormy, with hurricane season from June to November.

■ **Getting Around**

A car is useful. Disney and Universal offer transport for hotel guests.

■ **Day Trips**

Kennedy Space Center, Cocoa Beach and the springs are popular.

■ **Practical Tips**

- Buy park tickets online in advance.
- Use park apps for wait times and ride reservations.
- Stay hydrated.
- Visit on weekdays.

Osaka

Japan · East Asia

ASIA

Japan's kitchen, a fun-loving city of street food, neon and nightlife.

Country	Japan
Region	East Asia
Population (approx.)	~2.8 million (city); ~19 million (metro)
Language(s)	Japanese (Kansai dialect)
Currency	Japanese Yen (JPY)
Main airport	Kansai International Airport (KIX); Osaka Itami (ITM)
Best time to visit	March–May and October–November

■ Overview

Osaka is Japan's third-largest city and the commercial heart of the Kansai region. Historically a merchant city, it is known for its outgoing, humorous people and love of food, summed up by the phrase "kuidaore" – eat until you drop. The city combines modern skyscrapers, neon-lit entertainment districts and historic landmarks such as Osaka Castle. Osaka hosted the World Expo in 2025. It is a convenient base for day trips to Kyoto, Nara, Kobe and Himeji.

■ Top Attractions

- **Osaka Castle** – A reconstructed castle with a museum, surrounded by a park with cherry blossoms.
- **Dotonbori** – A neon-lit canal district famous for street food and the Glico Running Man sign.
- **Universal Studios Japan** – A theme park with Super Nintendo World and The Wizarding World of Harry Potter.
- **Shinsekai and Tsutenkaku Tower** – A retro neighbourhood known for kushikatsu (fried skewers).
- **Kuromon Market** – A food market known as "Osaka's Kitchen".
- **Umeda Sky Building** – An observatory with a floating garden and city views.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Namba and Shinsaibashi are lively and central. Umeda is a business and shopping hub, and Tennoji is convenient for transport.

■ Food & Drink

Osaka is famous for takoyaki (octopus balls), okonomiyaki, kushikatsu and kitsune udon. Dotonbori and Kuromon Market are good places to sample street food.

■ When to Visit

Spring and autumn are the best seasons. Summer is hot and humid, and winter is mild.

■ Getting Around

Osaka has an extensive subway and train network. The Nankai and JR lines connect Kansai Airport with the city.

■ Day Trips

Kyoto, Nara, Kobe and Himeji are easy day trips. Mount Koya is a sacred mountain with temple stays.

■ Practical Tips

- Use an ICOCA card for transport.
- Book Universal Studios in advance.
- Try food in Dotonbori at night.
- Avoid rush hour on trains.

Oslo

Norway · Northern Europe

EUROPE

A green fjord-side capital of Viking ships, bold architecture and outdoor life.

Country	Norway
Region	Northern Europe
Population (approx.)	~720,000 (city); ~1.6 million (metro)
Language(s)	Norwegian
Currency	Norwegian Krone (NOK)
Main airport	Oslo Airport, Gardermoen (OSL)
Best time to visit	May–September

■ Overview

Oslo, the capital of Norway, sits at the head of the Oslofjord, surrounded by forested hills. Founded around 1040, it was later rebuilt after a fire and renamed Christiania before returning to its original name in 1925. Today it is a modern, prosperous city with striking waterfront architecture, excellent museums and easy access to nature. Locals love the outdoors, hiking in the forests of Nordmarka and skiing in winter. Oslo is expensive, but many attractions are free or included in a city pass.

■ Top Attractions

- **Oslo Opera House** – A marble-and-glass building sloping into the fjord; visitors can walk on its roof.
- **MUNCH Museum** – A tall waterfront museum with one of the largest collections of Edvard Munch's work, including versions of *The Scream*.
- **Vigeland Sculpture Park** – Over 200 sculptures by Gustav Vigeland in Frogner Park.
- **Bygdøy Peninsula** – Home to museums such as the Fram Museum, Kon-Tiki Museum and the Norwegian Folk Museum.
- **Akershus Fortress** – A medieval castle and fortress overlooking the harbour.
- **National Museum** – The largest art museum in the Nordic countries.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The city centre and Aker Brygge are convenient and close to the waterfront. Grünerløkka is a trendy area with cafés, vintage shops and bars. Frogner is elegant and residential, while Bjørvika is a modern district with the Opera House and MUNCH.

■ Food & Drink

Norwegian food focuses on seafood, especially salmon, cod and shrimp. Traditional dishes include fårikål (mutton and cabbage stew) and brunost (brown cheese). Oslo has a strong New Nordic dining scene and food halls like Mathallen. Eating out is expensive, so lunch deals and bakeries offer good value.

■ When to Visit

Summer brings long days, fjord swimming and outdoor festivals. Spring and early autumn are cooler but pleasant. Winter is cold and dark, but ideal for cross-country skiing and cosy cafés; the Holmenkollen ski jump is a landmark.

■ Getting Around

Oslo has an efficient metro, trams, buses and ferries run by Ruter, and tickets can be bought via app. The Flytoget express train reaches the airport in about 20 minutes. Many sights are walkable.

■ Day Trips

Fjord cruises and island-hopping by public ferry are easy options. Holmenkollen and the forests of Nordmarka are reachable by metro. Fredrikstad, with its fortified old town, is about an hour away.

■ Practical Tips

- The Oslo Pass includes free entry to many museums and public transport.
- Alcohol is expensive; stronger drinks are only sold at Vinmonopolet stores.
- Card payments are accepted almost everywhere.
- Pack layers; weather can change quickly.

Palermo

Italy · Southern Europe

EUROPE

Sicily's vibrant capital of Arab-Norman splendour, markets and street food.

Country	Italy
Region	Southern Europe
Population (approx.)	~630,000 (city); ~1.2 million (metro)
Language(s)	Italian (Sicilian widely spoken)
Currency	Euro (EUR)
Main airport	Falcone Borsellino Airport (PMO)
Best time to visit	April-June and September-October

■ Overview

Palermo, the capital of Sicily, has been shaped by Phoenicians, Greeks, Romans, Arabs, Normans, Spanish and Bourbons over nearly 3,000 years. Its Arab-Norman churches and palaces form a unique UNESCO World Heritage Site. The city is chaotic and intense, with bustling markets, crumbling palaces and magnificent churches. Palermo has undergone a cultural renaissance and was named Italian Capital of Culture in 2018. It is famous for having some of the best street food in Europe.

■ Top Attractions

- **Palermo Cathedral** – A striking building blending Norman, Gothic, Moorish and Baroque styles, with rooftop views.
- **Palatine Chapel** – A jewel of Arab-Norman art inside the Norman Palace, covered in golden mosaics.
- **Monreale Cathedral** – Just outside the city, famous for its dazzling Byzantine mosaics.
- **Quattro Canti** – A baroque crossroads with ornate facades in the heart of the old city.
- **Markets of Ballarò, Vucciria and Capo** – Noisy, colourful markets with food stalls and vendors shouting their offers.
- **Capuchin Catacombs** – Crypts with thousands of mummified bodies, a macabre but fascinating site.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The historic centre is atmospheric, with neighbourhoods such as Kalsa and Albergheria. Via Maqueda and Via Vittorio Emanuele are central pedestrian streets. Politeama and Libertà are modern and elegant, with shopping and theatres.

■ Food & Drink

Street food includes arancine (fried rice balls), panelle (chickpea fritters), sfincione (Sicilian pizza) and pane con la milza (spleen sandwich). Cannoli and cassata are famous desserts, and granita with brioche is a typical summer breakfast. Pasta con le sarde (with sardines and wild fennel) reflects Arab influences.

■ When to Visit

Spring and autumn are pleasant, while summers are very hot. Winter is mild, making Palermo a good year-round destination. The Feast of Santa Rosalia in July is the city's biggest festival.

■ Getting Around

The historic centre is walkable. Buses and taxis are available, and a train and buses connect the airport with the city. Renting a car is useful for exploring Sicily, but driving in Palermo is chaotic.

■ Day Trips

Mondello, a beach resort, is just 30 minutes away. Cefalù, with a Norman cathedral and beach, is an hour by train. The Greek temples of Segesta and the medieval town of Erice are also popular.

■ Practical Tips

- Watch belongings in crowded markets.
- Many churches require modest dress.
- Try a street food tour to navigate the markets.
- Driving in the centre is restricted by ZTL zones.

Panama City

Panama · Central America

AMERICAS

A modern skyline, a colonial old town and the world-famous canal.

Country	Panama
Region	Central America
Population (approx.)	~1 million (city); ~2 million (metro)
Language(s)	Spanish
Currency	Panamanian Balboa (PAB) and US Dollar (USD)
Main airport	Tocumen International Airport (PTY)
Best time to visit	December–April

■ Overview

Panama City, the capital of Panama, is a major financial and transport hub, located at the Pacific entrance of the Panama Canal. Founded in 1519, the original city was destroyed by the pirate Henry Morgan in 1671, and a new city was built nearby, now called Casco Viejo. Today Panama City has a gleaming skyline of skyscrapers, a restored colonial quarter and rainforest within city limits. The US dollar is used alongside the balboa. It is a gateway to the San Blas Islands and Bocas del Toro.

■ Top Attractions

- **Panama Canal and Miraflores Locks** – Watch ships pass through the locks.
- **Casco Viejo** – A UNESCO-listed colonial quarter with plazas, churches and rooftop bars.
- **Biomuseo** – A colourful museum designed by Frank Gehry about biodiversity.
- **Amador Causeway** – A road connecting islands with views of the skyline.
- **Metropolitan Natural Park** – Rainforest in the city.
- **Panamá Viejo** – Ruins of the original city.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Casco Viejo, Marbella and Punta Pacífica are popular.

■ Food & Drink

Sancocho (chicken soup), ceviche and patacones are popular.

■ When to Visit

December to April is the dry season.

■ Getting Around

The metro and ride-hailing apps are available.

■ Day Trips

San Blas Islands, Gamboa Rainforest and Portobelo.

■ Practical Tips

- US dollars are used.
- Book San Blas trips with Guna-run operators.
- Use sunscreen.
- Check canal schedules.

Paris

France · Western Europe

EUROPE

The City of Light, a global icon of art, fashion, food and romance.

Country	France
Region	Western Europe
Population (approx.)	~2.1 million (city); ~12.4 million (metro)
Language(s)	French
Currency	Euro (EUR)
Main airport	Charles de Gaulle (CDG), Orly (ORY); Beauvais (BVA) for some low-cost flights
Best time to visit	April-June and September-October

■ Overview

Paris, the capital of France, is one of the most visited cities in the world and a symbol of art, culture and elegance. Its history stretches from Roman Lutetia through medieval Gothic cathedrals, royal palaces and the French Revolution to Baron Haussmann's grand 19th-century boulevards. Paris is home to the Louvre, the world's most visited museum, and landmarks such as the Eiffel Tower and Notre-Dame. The city is divided into 20 arrondissements, each with its own character. Beyond its monuments, Paris is best enjoyed in its cafés, markets, parks and neighbourhoods.

■ Top Attractions

- **Eiffel Tower** – Built for the 1889 World's Fair, it offers views from three levels; book tickets online.
- **Louvre Museum** – Home to the Mona Lisa, the Venus de Milo and thousands of other works of art.
- **Notre-Dame Cathedral** – The Gothic masterpiece reopened in December 2024 after restoration following the 2019 fire.
- **Musée d'Orsay** – Impressionist and post-Impressionist masterpieces housed in a former railway station.
- **Montmartre and Sacré-Cœur** – A hilltop village of artists, with the white basilica and views across Paris.
- **Palace of Versailles** – The spectacular royal palace and gardens, about 40 minutes from central Paris.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Le Marais is historic and trendy, with boutiques and falafel shops. Saint-Germain-des-Prés and the Latin Quarter are classic Left Bank areas of cafés and bookshops. Montmartre offers village charm, while Canal Saint-Martin and Belleville are hip and multicultural.

■ Food & Drink

Paris is a paradise for food lovers, from croissants and baguettes to fine dining. Try steak frites, French onion soup, crêpes, macarons and cheese from a fromagerie. Bistros serve classic dishes, and markets like Marché des Enfants Rouges offer diverse options. Wine bars and cafés are central to Parisian life.

■ When to Visit

Spring and early autumn are the most pleasant seasons. Summer can be hot and busy, and many Parisians leave in August. Winter is cool and grey, but the city's lights and holiday displays are beautiful.

■ Getting Around

The Paris Métro is extensive and efficient, complemented by RER trains, buses and trams. RER B connects CDG Airport with the city centre. Walking and cycling with the Vélib' bike share are great ways to explore.

■ Day Trips

Versailles, Giverny (Monet's gardens), and the Château de Fontainebleau are popular day trips. Disneyland Paris is about 40 minutes by RER. Reims, in the Champagne region, is 45 minutes away by TGV.

■ Practical Tips

- Book major attractions like the Eiffel Tower, Louvre and Versailles online in advance.
- Many museums are free on the first Sunday of certain months, or for EU residents under 26.
- Say "Bonjour" when entering shops and cafés.
- Beware of pickpockets at tourist sites and on the Métro.

Philadelphia

AMERICAS

United States (Pennsylvania) · North America

The birthplace of American independence, with history, murals and cheesesteaks.

Country	United States (Pennsylvania)
Region	North America
Population (approx.)	~1.55 million (city); ~6.2 million (metro)
Language(s)	English
Currency	US Dollar (USD)
Main airport	Philadelphia International Airport (PHL)
Best time to visit	April-June and September-October

■ Overview

Philadelphia, founded by William Penn in 1682, is where the Declaration of Independence and the US Constitution were signed. It served as the nation's capital during the Revolutionary era. Today Philly is a vibrant city of historic sites, museums, neighbourhoods and food. It has one of the largest public mural programmes in the world. 2026 marks the 250th anniversary of American independence, with major celebrations in the city.

■ Top Attractions

- **Independence Hall and Liberty Bell** – Where the Declaration and Constitution were signed.
- **Philadelphia Museum of Art** – Famous for its "Rocky Steps".
- **Reading Terminal Market** – A historic food market.
- **Eastern State Penitentiary** – A historic prison, once home to Al Capone.
- **Barnes Foundation** – A collection of Impressionist art.
- **Mural Arts tours** – Guided walks and trolley tours of the city's thousands of public murals.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Old City, Center City, Rittenhouse Square and Fishtown are popular.

■ Food & Drink

Philly cheesesteaks, soft pretzels and roast pork sandwiches.

■ When to Visit

Spring and autumn are ideal.

■ **Getting Around**

SEPTA subway, buses and trolleys; the city is walkable.

■ **Day Trips**

Valley Forge, Lancaster County (Amish country) and New York City.

■ **Practical Tips**

- Book Independence Hall tickets.
- Try cheesesteaks from several places.
- Check 250th anniversary events.
- Walk to see murals.

Phnom Penh

Cambodia · Southeast Asia

ASIA

Cambodia's riverside capital of royal palaces, markets and a poignant recent history.

Country	Cambodia
Region	Southeast Asia
Population (approx.)	~2.3 million
Language(s)	Khmer
Currency	Cambodian Riel (KHR); US Dollars widely used
Main airport	Techo International Airport (KTI), which replaced Phnom Penh International (PNH) in 2025
Best time to visit	November–March

■ Overview

Phnom Penh, the capital of Cambodia, sits at the confluence of the Mekong, Tonlé Sap and Bassac rivers. Once called the "Pearl of Asia", it was admired for its French colonial architecture and elegant boulevards. The city was emptied by the Khmer Rouge in 1975, and its museums and memorials document the tragic genocide that followed. Today Phnom Penh is a fast-growing city with a lively riverfront, markets, cafés and a growing arts scene. It offers a mix of history, culture and everyday Cambodian life.

■ Top Attractions

- **Royal Palace and Silver Pagoda** – The residence of the King of Cambodia, with ornate throne halls and a pagoda floored with silver tiles.
- **Tuol Sleng Genocide Museum (S-21)** – A former school turned Khmer Rouge prison, now a sobering museum.
- **Choeung Ek Killing Fields** – A memorial site outside the city, with a stupa containing thousands of skulls; the audio guide is highly recommended.
- **National Museum of Cambodia** – The world's leading collection of Khmer art and sculpture.
- **Central Market (Phsar Thmei)** – An Art Deco market building with a yellow dome.
- **Sisowath Quay** – The riverside promenade, lively in the evenings.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The Riverside area is central, with hotels, restaurants and bars. BKK1 is a leafy upscale district popular with expats, and the area around the Russian Market (Tuol Tom Pong) is trendy.

■ Food & Drink

Cambodian cuisine includes fish amok (a curry steamed in banana leaves), lok lak (stir-fried beef), and kuy teav (noodle soup). Num banh chok, rice noodles with fish curry, is a common breakfast. The Russian Market and night markets offer street food.

■ When to Visit

November to March is dry and relatively cool. April is very hot, and the rainy season runs from May to October. The Water Festival in November features boat races on the river.

■ Getting Around

Tuk-tuks and ride-hailing apps like PassApp and Grab are common. The city is spread out, but central areas are walkable. Buses connect Phnom Penh with Siem Reap and Kampot.

■ Day Trips

Oudong, the former royal capital, has hilltop stupas. Silk Island (Koh Dach) offers weaving villages. Kampot and Kep, with pepper plantations and crab markets, are a few hours away.

■ Practical Tips

- US dollars are widely accepted, with change often given in riel.
- Dress modestly at the Royal Palace (shoulders and knees covered).
- Watch bags and phones on tuk-tuk rides due to snatch theft.
- Visit Tuol Sleng and Choeung Ek with time to reflect.

Phuket

Thailand · Southeast Asia

ASIA

Thailand's largest island, with beaches, nightlife and gateway to the Andaman Sea.

Country	Thailand
Region	Southeast Asia
Population (approx.)	~420,000 (registered); much higher including migrants and seasonal residents
Language(s)	Thai
Currency	Thai Baht (THB)
Main airport	Phuket International Airport (HKT)
Best time to visit	November–April

■ Overview

Phuket is Thailand's largest island, located in the Andaman Sea off the country's southwest coast. It became wealthy through tin mining and rubber, and Phuket Town still reflects this with Sino-Portuguese shophouses. Today tourism dominates, with beaches ranging from party hubs to quiet coves. Phuket is a base for island-hopping to the Phi Phi Islands, Phang Nga Bay and the Similan Islands. It has resorts for every budget.

■ Top Attractions

- **Patong Beach** – Phuket's busiest beach, famous for nightlife on Bangla Road.
- **Phuket Old Town** – Colourful Sino-Portuguese buildings, cafés and a Sunday walking street market.
- **Big Buddha** – A 45-metre white marble statue on a hilltop with views.
- **Wat Chalong** – Phuket's most important Buddhist temple.
- **Promthep Cape** – A popular sunset viewpoint at the island's southern tip.
- **Kata and Karon Beaches** – Family-friendly beaches with good swimming.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Patong is lively, while Kata and Karon are more relaxed. Kamala and Surin are upscale, and Mai Khao is quiet, near the airport. Phuket Town offers culture and food.

■ Food & Drink

Southern Thai food is spicier and influenced by Chinese and Malay cuisines. Try moo hong (braised pork belly), Phuket-style noodles and seafood. Night markets like Naka Market offer street food.

■ When to Visit

November to April is the dry season, with calm seas. The monsoon (May–October) brings rough seas, and some islands close. The Vegetarian Festival in autumn features dramatic processions.

■ Getting Around

Public transport is limited; taxis, tuk-tuks and ride-hailing apps are common. Scooter rental is popular but risky.

■ Day Trips

Phi Phi Islands, James Bond Island in Phang Nga Bay and the Similan Islands are popular. Krabi and Khao Lak are reachable by road or boat.

■ Practical Tips

- Negotiate taxi and tuk-tuk fares in advance, or use apps.
- Heed red flags on beaches during the monsoon.
- Wear a helmet if renting a scooter.
- Book island tours with reputable operators.

Porto

Portugal · Southern Europe

EUROPE

A hilly riverside city famous for port wine, azulejos and bridges.

Country	Portugal
Region	Southern Europe
Population (approx.)	~230,000 (city); ~1.7 million (metro)
Language(s)	Portuguese
Currency	Euro (EUR)
Main airport	Francisco Sá Carneiro Airport (OPO)
Best time to visit	April-June and September-October

■ Overview

Porto is Portugal's second-largest city, built on steep hills along the Douro River near the Atlantic coast. It gave its name to Portugal and to port wine, which is aged in cellars across the river in Vila Nova de Gaia. Porto's historic centre, with its colourful houses, churches covered in blue-and-white tiles and baroque architecture, is a UNESCO World Heritage Site. The city is authentic, affordable and increasingly popular. It is also the gateway to the Douro Valley wine region.

■ Top Attractions

- **Ribeira** – The riverside district with colourful houses, restaurants and views of the Dom Luís I Bridge.
- **Dom Luís I Bridge** – A double-deck iron bridge; walk across the top level for spectacular views.
- **Port wine cellars** – Tours and tastings at historic lodges such as Graham's, Taylor's and Sandeman in Vila Nova de Gaia.
- **São Bento Station** – A railway station with a hall decorated with around 20,000 azulejo tiles.
- **Livraria Lello** – A famous neo-Gothic bookshop with an ornate staircase; entry requires a ticket.
- **Clérigos Tower** – A baroque bell tower with panoramic views of the city.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Ribeira and Baixa are central and close to sights. Cedofeita and the Miguel Bombarda arts district have galleries and shops, while Foz do Douro is an upscale seaside area. Vila Nova de Gaia, across the river, offers views and port lodges.

■ Food & Drink

The francesinha is Porto's famous sandwich, filled with meat, covered in melted cheese and a beer-tomato sauce. Tripas à moda do Porto (tripe stew) is a traditional dish. Seafood, bacalhau and pastel de nata are widely available. Port wine comes in styles such as tawny, ruby and white; a white port and tonic is a popular aperitif.

■ When to Visit

Spring and early autumn are ideal. Summer is warm but less hot than Lisbon, and the São João festival on the night of 23 June is a huge street party with fireworks and plastic hammers. Winter is mild but rainy.

■ Getting Around

Porto has a metro and historic trams, but the centre is walkable, though very hilly. The metro connects the airport with the centre. Funiculars help with steep climbs.

■ Day Trips

The Douro Valley, with terraced vineyards and quintas, is a highlight; visit by train, boat or tour. Guimarães, the birthplace of Portugal, and Braga, with the Bom Jesus sanctuary, are close. Aveiro, known as the "Venice of Portugal", is about an hour away.

■ Practical Tips

- Wear comfortable shoes for steep, cobbled streets.
- Book port cellar tours in advance in summer.
- Try a francesinha at a local café rather than touristy spots.
- The Porto Card offers transport and museum discounts.

Prague

EUROPE

Czech Republic (Czechia) · Central Europe

The "City of a Hundred Spires", a fairy-tale capital of Gothic and Baroque beauty.

Country	Czech Republic (Czechia)
Region	Central Europe
Population (approx.)	~1.4 million
Language(s)	Czech
Currency	Czech Koruna (CZK)
Main airport	Václav Havel Airport Prague (PRG)
Best time to visit	April-June and September-October

■ Overview

Prague, the capital of the Czech Republic, is one of Europe's most beautiful cities, with a remarkably well-preserved historic centre on the Vltava River. It was the seat of Holy Roman Emperors and a major centre of culture and learning in the Middle Ages. Prague's skyline of spires, towers and domes has earned it the nickname "City of a Hundred Spires". The city is famous for its beer, classical music and the legacy of writers like Franz Kafka. It is very popular, so exploring early or late helps avoid crowds.

■ Top Attractions

- **Prague Castle** – One of the largest castle complexes in the world, including St. Vitus Cathedral and Golden Lane.
- **Charles Bridge** – A 14th-century stone bridge lined with baroque statues, best visited at sunrise.
- **Old Town Square and Astronomical Clock** – The medieval heart of the city, with the famous 15th-century clock.
- **Josefov (Jewish Quarter)** – Historic synagogues and the Old Jewish Cemetery.
- **Malá Strana** – A charming baroque district below the castle, with palaces and gardens.
- **Petřín Hill** – A park with a lookout tower resembling the Eiffel Tower and views over the city.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The Old Town and Malá Strana are central and scenic but busy. Vinohrady is elegant and residential, with cafés and parks, and Žižkov is known for its many pubs. Karlín is a trendy, redeveloped area with restaurants.

■ Food & Drink

Czech cuisine is hearty: try *svíčková* (beef in cream sauce with dumplings), goulash, roast pork with sauerkraut and fried cheese (*smažený sýr*). *Trdelník*, a chimney cake sold everywhere, is not traditionally Czech but popular with tourists. Czech beer, including Pilsner Urquell and Budvar, is among the best in the world and very affordable.

■ When to Visit

Spring and autumn are ideal. Summer is warm and crowded, and winter is cold but magical at Christmas markets. The Prague Spring music festival takes place in May and June.

■ Getting Around

Prague has an excellent metro, tram and bus network. Buses and the Airport Express connect the airport with the city. The historic centre is walkable, though cobblestones and hills can be tiring.

■ Day Trips

Kutná Hora, with the Sedlec Ossuary decorated with human bones, is about an hour away. Český Krumlov is a fairy-tale town in South Bohemia. Karlštejn Castle and the Terezín Memorial are also popular.

■ Practical Tips

- Avoid exchange offices with bad rates; use ATMs of major banks and decline dynamic currency conversion.
- Use official taxis or ride-hailing apps.
- Validate transport tickets.
- Visit Charles Bridge early in the morning for fewer crowds.

Puerto Vallarta

Mexico · North America

AMERICAS

A Pacific resort town of jungle-clad mountains, cobblestones and sunsets.

Country	Mexico
Region	North America
Population (approx.)	~300,000
Language(s)	Spanish
Currency	Mexican Peso (MXN)
Main airport	Licenciado Gustavo Díaz Ordaz International Airport (PVR)
Best time to visit	November–April

■ Overview

Puerto Vallarta is a resort city on Banderas Bay on Mexico's Pacific coast, surrounded by the Sierra Madre mountains. Once a small fishing village, it became famous after the 1964 film *The Night of the Iguana*. Its old town has cobbled streets, white houses and a seafront Malecón. Puerto Vallarta is known for its LGBTQ+-friendly atmosphere and beaches. It is a base for whale watching, snorkelling and jungle tours.

■ Top Attractions

- **Malecón** – A seaside promenade with sculptures.
- **Our Lady of Guadalupe Church** – A church with a crown-topped tower.
- **Zona Romántica** – Restaurants, bars and Los Muertos Beach.
- **Los Arcos** – Rock formations for snorkelling.
- **Yelapa** – A village reachable by boat.
- **Whale watching** – Humpback whales visit Banderas Bay from December to March.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Zona Romántica, Centro and Marina Vallarta are popular.

■ Food & Drink

Seafood tacos, pescado zarandeado and raicilla (a local agave spirit).

■ When to Visit

November to April is dry. Summer is hot and rainy.

■ Getting Around

Buses, taxis and water taxis.

■ Day Trips

Sayulita, Yelapa and the Marietas Islands.

■ Practical Tips

- Book Marietas trips in advance (limited permits).
- Use sunscreen.
- Carry cash.
- Check hurricane forecasts.

Quebec City

Canada (Quebec) · North America

AMERICAS

A fortified French-speaking city with a European old town.

Country	Canada (Quebec)
Region	North America
Population (approx.)	~550,000 (city); ~850,000 (metro)
Language(s)	French
Currency	Canadian Dollar (CAD)
Main airport	Québec City Jean Lesage International Airport (YQB)
Best time to visit	June–October; February for Winter Carnival

■ Overview

Quebec City, the capital of Quebec, was founded by Samuel de Champlain in 1608, making it one of the oldest European settlements in North America. It is the only fortified city north of Mexico with its walls intact. Old Quebec is a UNESCO World Heritage Site. The city is predominantly French-speaking and has a European feel. It is famous for the Château Frontenac and its Winter Carnival.

■ Top Attractions

- **Château Frontenac** – A grand hotel overlooking the St. Lawrence River.
- **Old Quebec and Petit-Champlain** – Charming streets.
- **Citadelle of Quebec** – A star-shaped fortress.
- **Plains of Abraham** – A historic battlefield park.
- **Montmorency Falls** – Waterfalls higher than Niagara.
- **Quebec Winter Carnival** – One of the world's largest winter festivals, with an ice palace, parades and snow sculptures in February.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Old Quebec and Saint-Roch are popular.

■ Food & Drink

Poutine, tourtière (meat pie) and maple syrup treats.

■ When to Visit

Summer and autumn are pleasant. Winters are cold but festive.

■ Getting Around

The old town is walkable. A funicular connects the upper and lower town.

■ Day Trips

Montmorency Falls, Île d'Orléans and Charlevoix.

■ Practical Tips

- Dress warmly in winter.
- Learn basic French phrases.
- Book early for Carnival.
- Wear comfortable shoes.

Quito

Ecuador · South America

AMERICAS

A high-altitude capital with one of the best-preserved colonial centres in the Americas.

Country	Ecuador
Region	South America
Population (approx.)	~2.8 million (metro)
Language(s)	Spanish (Kichwa also spoken)
Currency	US Dollar (USD)
Main airport	Mariscal Sucre International Airport (UIO)
Best time to visit	June–September

■ Overview

Quito, the capital of Ecuador, lies in an Andean valley at about 2,850 metres, making it one of the highest capital cities in the world. Its historic centre was one of the first two sites declared UNESCO World Heritage Sites in 1978. The city is surrounded by volcanoes, including the active Pichincha. Quito is located just south of the equator. It is the main gateway to the Galápagos Islands and the Amazon.

■ Top Attractions

- **Historic Centre** – Colonial churches, plazas and monasteries.
- **La Compañía de Jesús** – A church with a gold-covered interior.
- **Basílica del Voto Nacional** – A Gothic basilica with towers you can climb.
- **TelefériQo** – A cable car up Pichincha volcano.
- **Mitad del Mundo** – The equator monument.
- **El Panecillo** – A hill with a statue of the Virgin.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The historic centre, La Floresta and La Mariscal are popular.

■ Food & Drink

Locro de papa (potato soup), empanadas and hornado.

■ When to Visit

June to September is drier.

■ Getting Around

The Quito Metro opened in 2023. Taxis and apps are available.

■ Day Trips

Otavallo market, Cotopaxi National Park and Mindo cloud forest.

■ Practical Tips

- Acclimatise to the altitude.
- Use apps for taxis.
- Bring layers.
- Be cautious at night.

Reykjavik

Iceland · Northern Europe

EUROPE

The world's northernmost capital and a base for volcanoes, glaciers and northern lights.

Country	Iceland
Region	Northern Europe
Population (approx.)	~140,000 (city); ~240,000 (capital region)
Language(s)	Icelandic (English widely spoken)
Currency	Icelandic Króna (ISK)
Main airport	Keflavík International Airport (KEF)
Best time to visit	June–August for midnight sun; September–March for northern lights

■ Overview

Reykjavik, the capital of Iceland, is small, colourful and creative, home to most of the country's population. It is surrounded by dramatic landscapes shaped by volcanoes, glaciers and geothermal activity. The city has a lively arts and music scene, cosy cafés and geothermally heated swimming pools. Most visitors use Reykjavik as a base for exploring Iceland's natural wonders. Iceland is expensive, but its scenery is unlike anywhere else in Europe.

■ Top Attractions

- **Hallgrímskirkja** – A striking church inspired by basalt columns, with a tower offering city views.
- **Harpa Concert Hall** – A glass concert hall on the harbour with a shimmering facade.
- **Sun Voyager** – A steel sculpture resembling a Viking ship on the waterfront.
- **Laugavegur** – The main shopping street, with cafés, bars and boutiques.
- **National Museum of Iceland** – An overview of Icelandic history from settlement to the present.
- **Sky Lagoon and geothermal pools** – Swimming in outdoor thermal pools is a key part of Icelandic culture.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Downtown (101 Reykjavik) is compact and convenient. The Old Harbour has restaurants and whale-watching tours. Staying slightly outside the centre can be cheaper.

■ Food & Drink

Icelandic cuisine features lamb, fish and skyr, a thick dairy product. Hot dogs from Bæjarins Beztu Pylsur are famous. Traditional dishes such as fermented shark (hákarl) are an acquired taste. Seafood soup and lamb soup are warming staples.

■ When to Visit

Summer offers the midnight sun and access to the highlands. Winter brings long nights and the chance to see the northern lights, but daylight is limited. Weather changes quickly year-round.

■ Getting Around

Reykjavik is walkable, with a bus network for longer trips. The Flybus connects Keflavík Airport with the city in about 45 minutes. Renting a car is popular for exploring Iceland, but check road conditions carefully.

■ Day Trips

The Golden Circle includes Þingvellir National Park, the Geysir geothermal area and Gullfoss waterfall. The Blue Lagoon is near the airport. The South Coast offers waterfalls, black-sand beaches and glacier hikes.

■ Practical Tips

- Check weather and road conditions at safetravel.is and road.is.
- Tap water is clean and free.
- Book the Blue Lagoon in advance.
- Aurora forecasts help plan northern lights hunts.

Riga

Latvia · Northern Europe

EUROPE

The Baltic's largest city, famous for Art Nouveau architecture and a medieval old town.

Country	Latvia
Region	Northern Europe
Population (approx.)	~610,000
Language(s)	Latvian
Currency	Euro (EUR)
Main airport	Riga International Airport (RIX)
Best time to visit	May–September

■ Overview

Riga, the capital of Latvia, lies on the Gulf of Riga at the mouth of the Daugava River. Founded in 1201, it became a major Hanseatic trading city. Its historic centre is a UNESCO World Heritage Site, known for its medieval old town and the largest collection of Art Nouveau buildings in the world. Riga has a lively cultural scene, with opera, music and festivals. It is affordable and a good base for exploring the Baltic region.

■ Top Attractions

- **Old Town (Vecrīga)** – Cobbled streets, churches and merchant houses, including the House of the Blackheads.
- **Art Nouveau District** – Elizabetes and Alberta streets have ornate facades by architects such as Mikhail Eisenstein.
- **Riga Central Market** – One of Europe's largest markets, housed in former Zeppelin hangars.
- **St. Peter's Church** – A church with a tower offering views of the city.
- **Freedom Monument** – A symbol of Latvian independence.
- **Latvian National Museum of Art** – A collection of Latvian and Baltic art.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The Old Town is central and compact. The Quiet Centre (Klusais centrs) has Art Nouveau buildings and cafés. Āgenskalns, across the river, is a quieter area with wooden houses.

■ Food & Drink

Latvian cuisine includes rye bread, grey peas with bacon, smoked fish and potato pancakes. Riga Black Balsam, a herbal liqueur, is a local speciality. The Central Market offers smoked fish and local produce. Restaurants range from traditional to modern Nordic-style.

■ When to Visit

Summer brings long days and outdoor festivals, including Midsummer (Jāņi) celebrations in June. Winters are cold and dark, but Christmas markets are charming. Spring and autumn are mild.

■ Getting Around

Riga is walkable, with trams and buses for longer trips. Bus 22 connects the airport with the centre. Trains reach Jūrmala and other nearby towns.

■ Day Trips

Jūrmala, a beach resort with wooden villas, is 30 minutes away. Sigulda, in the Gauja National Park, offers castles and hiking. Rundāle Palace is a baroque palace designed by Rastrelli, the architect of St. Petersburg's Winter Palace.

■ Practical Tips

- Riga's old town is compact; one or two days cover the main sights.
- Some restaurants in the Old Town target tourists with high prices.
- Try Riga Black Balsam mixed with blackcurrant juice.
- Card payments are widely accepted.

Rio de Janeiro

Brazil · South America

AMERICAS

The "Marvellous City" of beaches, mountains, samba and Carnival.

Country	Brazil
Region	South America
Population (approx.)	~6.2 million (city); ~13 million (metro)
Language(s)	Portuguese
Currency	Brazilian Real (BRL)
Main airport	Rio de Janeiro/Galeão International Airport (GIG); Santos Dumont (SDU)
Best time to visit	September–March (but beach weather most of the year)

■ Overview

Rio de Janeiro is one of the world's most spectacularly located cities, set between granite mountains, lush rainforest and the Atlantic Ocean. It was the capital of Brazil until 1960 and the seat of the Portuguese royal court in the early 19th century. Rio is famous for Carnival, samba, bossa nova and its beach culture. The city's landscapes are a UNESCO World Heritage Site. Inequality is visible, with favelas on the hills next to wealthy neighbourhoods.

■ Top Attractions

- **Christ the Redeemer** – The giant statue on Corcovado mountain, one of the New Seven Wonders.
- **Sugarloaf Mountain** – Cable cars to the summit.
- **Copacabana and Ipanema beaches** – Famous beaches.
- **Selaron Steps** – Colourful tiled stairway in Lapa.
- **Tijuca National Park** – Urban rainforest.
- **Maracanã Stadium** – Legendary football stadium.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Ipanema, Leblon, Copacabana and Santa Teresa are popular.

■ Food & Drink

Feijoada (black bean stew), churrasco, pão de queijo and açaí. Caipirinha is the national cocktail.

■ When to Visit

Carnival takes place in February or March. Summers are hot.

■ Getting Around

The metro, buses and ride-hailing apps.

■ Day Trips

Petrópolis, Ilha Grande and Paraty.

■ Practical Tips

- Don't carry valuables on the beach.
- Use apps for taxis.
- Book Carnival early.
- Avoid favela tours without reputable guides.

Riyadh

Saudi Arabia · Middle East

ASIA

Saudi Arabia's rapidly transforming capital of mud-brick heritage and modern towers.

Country	Saudi Arabia
Region	Middle East
Population (approx.)	~7.5 million
Language(s)	Arabic (English widely used in business)
Currency	Saudi Riyal (SAR)
Main airport	King Khalid International Airport (RUH)
Best time to visit	November–March

■ Overview

Riyadh, the capital of Saudi Arabia, lies in the heart of the Arabian Peninsula. It grew from a mud-brick oasis town into a modern metropolis after the discovery of oil. The city is changing rapidly under the Vision 2030 programme, with new entertainment venues, museums and tourism projects. The historic district of Diriyah, the birthplace of the first Saudi state, is a UNESCO World Heritage Site. Tourist visas have made Saudi Arabia accessible to international visitors since 2019.

■ Top Attractions

- **Diriyah (At-Turaif)** – A restored mud-brick district and UNESCO site, with museums and restaurants in Bujairi Terrace.
- **Kingdom Centre Tower** – A skyscraper with a sky bridge offering views.
- **Masmak Fortress** – A clay fort central to the founding of modern Saudi Arabia.
- **National Museum of Saudi Arabia** – Exhibitions on Arabian history and Islamic culture.
- **Edge of the World (Jebel Fihrayn)** – Dramatic cliffs overlooking a vast plain, about 1.5 hours from the city.
- **Boulevard City** – An entertainment zone during Riyadh Season.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Olaya is the business district, with hotels and malls. Diriyah is historic, and the Diplomatic Quarter is green and quiet.

■ Food & Drink

Kabsa, spiced rice with meat, is the national dish. Dates and Arabic coffee are served everywhere. Riyadh has a large international restaurant scene.

■ When to Visit

November to March is pleasant. Summers are extremely hot. Riyadh Season, a festival of entertainment, runs in winter.

■ Getting Around

The Riyadh Metro opened in stages from late 2024. Taxis and ride-hailing apps are widely used. The city is car-oriented.

■ Day Trips

Edge of the World and the Red Sand Dunes are popular desert trips.

■ Practical Tips

- Dress modestly; women are no longer required to wear an abaya but should cover shoulders and knees.
- Alcohol is prohibited.
- Friday is the holy day.
- Obtain an e-visa before travelling.

Rome

Italy · Southern Europe

EUROPE

The Eternal City, where nearly 3,000 years of history fill every piazza.

Country	Italy
Region	Southern Europe
Population (approx.)	~2.8 million (city); ~4.3 million (metro)
Language(s)	Italian
Currency	Euro (EUR)
Main airport	Leonardo da Vinci-Fiumicino (FCO), Ciampino (CIA)
Best time to visit	April-June and September-October

■ Overview

Rome, the capital of Italy, was the centre of the Roman Empire and later of the Catholic Church, leaving an extraordinary legacy of monuments, art and architecture. Ancient ruins sit beside Renaissance palaces, baroque fountains and lively modern streets. Vatican City, an independent state within Rome, is home to St. Peter's Basilica and the Sistine Chapel. Rome is a city to explore slowly, enjoying its piazzas, trattorias and street life. It is busy year-round, especially during Jubilee years and religious holidays.

■ Top Attractions

- **Colosseum** – The largest amphitheatre ever built, where gladiators fought; combined tickets include the Roman Forum and Palatine Hill.
- **Roman Forum and Palatine Hill** – The political heart of ancient Rome and the hill where emperors built their palaces.
- **Vatican Museums and Sistine Chapel** – Vast collections culminating in Michelangelo's famous ceiling.
- **St. Peter's Basilica** – The world's largest church, with Michelangelo's Pietà and a dome you can climb.
- **Pantheon** – A remarkably preserved Roman temple with a massive concrete dome, now a church.
- **Trevi Fountain** – A baroque fountain where visitors throw a coin to ensure their return to Rome.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The Centro Storico, around Piazza Navona and the Pantheon, is central and walkable. Trastevere is charming, with ivy-covered streets and lively nightlife. Monti is trendy and close to the Colosseum, while Prati near the Vatican is quieter and elegant.

■ Food & Drink

Roman classics include carbonara, cacio e pepe, amatriciana and gricia. Supplì (fried rice balls), pizza al taglio and carciofi alla giudia (fried artichokes) in the Jewish Ghetto are must-tries. Gelato and espresso are daily pleasures. Testaccio is known for traditional cuisine and its covered market.

■ When to Visit

Spring and autumn are the best seasons. Summer is very hot and crowded, and many locals leave in August. Easter and Christmas bring special religious events at the Vatican.

■ Getting Around

Rome has a limited metro, but buses and trams cover the city. The Leonardo Express train connects Fiumicino Airport with Termini station. Walking is the best way to explore the historic centre.

■ Day Trips

Ostia Antica, an ancient Roman port city, is easily reachable by train. Tivoli has Hadrian's Villa and Villa d'Este with its fountains. Orvieto, Florence and Naples are also reachable by train.

■ Practical Tips

- Book the Colosseum and Vatican Museums well in advance.
- Dress modestly for churches and the Vatican (shoulders and knees covered).
- Drink from the free "nasoni" water fountains around the city.
- Rome charges an access fee for the Trevi Fountain basin area in some periods; check current rules.

Salvador

Brazil · South America

AMERICAS

The heart of Afro-Brazilian culture, with a colourful colonial old town.

Country	Brazil
Region	South America
Population (approx.)	~2.4 million
Language(s)	Portuguese
Currency	Brazilian Real (BRL)
Main airport	Deputado Luís Eduardo Magalhães International Airport (SSA)
Best time to visit	September–March

■ Overview

Salvador, the capital of Bahia, was Brazil's first capital (1549–1763) and a major port of the transatlantic slave trade. Today it is the centre of Afro-Brazilian culture, visible in its music, religion (Candomblé), capoeira and food. The historic centre, Pelourinho, is a UNESCO site with colourful colonial buildings. Salvador's Carnival is one of the largest street parties in the world.

■ Top Attractions

- **Pelourinho** – Colonial centre with churches and music.
- **Elevador Lacerda** – Connects the upper and lower city.
- **São Francisco Church** – Baroque gold interiors.
- **Mercado Modelo** – Crafts market.
- **Barra** – Beach with a lighthouse.
- **Capoeira performances** – Displays of the Afro-Brazilian martial art that combines dance, acrobatics and music.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Pelourinho, Barra and Rio Vermelho.

■ Food & Drink

Acarajé (bean fritters), moqueca baiana (seafood stew).

■ When to Visit

September–March is dry; Carnival is huge.

■ Getting Around

Taxis and apps.

■ Day Trips

Morro de São Paulo and Praia do Forte.

■ Practical Tips

- Watch belongings.
- Book Carnival early.
- Try acarajé.
- Respect religious traditions.

Salzburg

Austria · Central Europe

EUROPE

Mozart's baroque birthplace, framed by the Alps and The Sound of Music.

Country	Austria
Region	Central Europe
Population (approx.)	~155,000
Language(s)	German
Currency	Euro (EUR)
Main airport	Salzburg Airport W. A. Mozart (SZG); Munich Airport (MUC) is about 2 hours away
Best time to visit	May–September; December for Christmas markets

■ Overview

Salzburg is a beautiful baroque city on the Salzach River near the German border, surrounded by Alpine peaks. For centuries it was ruled by powerful prince-archbishops whose wealth from salt mining funded magnificent churches and palaces. Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart was born here in 1756, and music remains central to the city's identity. The historic centre is a UNESCO World Heritage Site, and the city was a filming location for *The Sound of Music*. Salzburg is compact, elegant and ideal for a short stay.

■ Top Attractions

- **Hohensalzburg Fortress** – One of the largest medieval castles in Europe, reached by funicular, with panoramic views.
- **Mozart's Birthplace and Residence** – Museums dedicated to the life and work of the composer.
- **Salzburg Cathedral** – A baroque cathedral where Mozart was baptised.
- **Mirabell Palace and Gardens** – Formal gardens featured in *The Sound of Music*.
- **Getreidegasse** – A narrow shopping street with wrought-iron guild signs.
- **Hellbrunn Palace** – A palace with playful trick fountains, a short trip from the city.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The Altstadt (Old Town) on the left bank is the most picturesque area. The right bank around Linzergasse and Mirabell is slightly quieter. Staying outside the centre is cheaper and well connected by bus.

■ Food & Drink

Austrian classics include Wiener Schnitzel, Kaiserschmarrn (shredded pancake) and apple strudel. Salzburger Nockerl is a sweet soufflé representing the city's mountains. Mozartkugeln, chocolate-covered marzipan balls, are a famous souvenir. Augustiner Bräu is a monastic brewery with a large beer garden.

■ When to Visit

Summer brings the world-famous Salzburg Festival of music and theatre in July and August. Christmas markets and Advent concerts create a festive atmosphere in December. Spring and autumn are quieter and pleasant.

■ Getting Around

Salzburg's centre is walkable, and trolleybuses cover the city. Trains connect Salzburg with Vienna (about 2.5 hours) and Munich (about 1.5 hours). The Salzburg Card includes transport and attraction entry.

■ Day Trips

Hallstatt, a picturesque lakeside village, is a popular trip, though it is very crowded. The Eagle's Nest near Berchtesgaden, in Germany, and the salt mines of Hallein offer history and views. Werfen has the world's largest ice cave, Eisriesenwelt.

■ Practical Tips

- Book Salzburg Festival tickets months ahead.
- The Salzburg Card is good value if visiting several sights.
- Visit Hallstatt early or late to avoid tour groups.
- Many shops close early on Saturdays and all day Sunday.

Samarkand

Uzbekistan · Central Asia

ASIA

A legendary Silk Road city of blue domes, madrasas and Timurid splendour.

Country	Uzbekistan
Region	Central Asia
Population (approx.)	~570,000
Language(s)	Uzbek (Tajik and Russian widely spoken)
Currency	Uzbekistani Som (UZS)
Main airport	Samarkand International Airport (SKD)
Best time to visit	April-June and September-October

■ Overview

Samarkand is one of the oldest cities in Central Asia, with a history of over 2,500 years. It flourished as a key stop on the Silk Road and became the capital of Timur (Tamerlane) in the 14th century. His dynasty built magnificent mosques, madrasas and mausoleums decorated with turquoise tiles. Samarkand is a UNESCO World Heritage Site, often called the "Crossroads of Cultures". It is easily reached from Tashkent by high-speed train.

■ Top Attractions

- **Registan** – A square framed by three grand madrasas, one of the most spectacular architectural ensembles in the world.
- **Gur-e-Amir** – The mausoleum of Timur, with a ribbed azure dome.
- **Shah-i-Zinda** – An avenue of mausoleums with dazzling tilework.
- **Bibi-Khanym Mosque** – A huge mosque built by Timur.
- **Ulugh Beg Observatory** – Remains of a 15th-century observatory.
- **Siab Bazaar** – A market selling bread, dried fruits and spices.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Staying near the Registan is convenient. Guesthouses in the old town offer hospitality.

■ Food & Drink

Plov, rice with meat and carrots, is the national dish. Samarkand bread (non) is famous. Shashlik (grilled meat) and samsa (baked pastries) are common.

■ When to Visit

Spring and autumn are ideal. Summers are hot, and winters are cold.

■ **Getting Around**

Taxis and ride-hailing apps are cheap. Afrosiyob high-speed trains connect Samarkand with Tashkent and Bukhara.

■ **Day Trips**

Shahrisabz, Timur's birthplace, is a few hours away. Urgut has a large market.

■ **Practical Tips**

- Book train tickets in advance.
- Dress modestly at religious sites.
- Carry cash.
- Visit the Registan at night for the light show.

San Diego

AMERICAS

United States (California) · North America

America's finest city, with beaches, parks and a perfect climate.

Country	United States (California)
Region	North America
Population (approx.)	~1.4 million (city); ~3.3 million (metro)
Language(s)	English (Spanish widely spoken)
Currency	US Dollar (USD)
Main airport	San Diego International Airport (SAN)
Best time to visit	Year-round; September–November is especially pleasant

■ Overview

San Diego, in southern California near the Mexican border, is known for its mild climate, beaches and relaxed lifestyle. It was the site of the first Spanish mission in California in 1769. The city is home to a large US Navy presence, Balboa Park and the famous San Diego Zoo. San Diego has a strong craft beer scene. It is ideal for outdoor activities year-round.

■ Top Attractions

- **Balboa Park** – Museums, gardens and architecture.
- **San Diego Zoo** – One of the world's best zoos.
- **USS Midway Museum** – An aircraft carrier museum.
- **La Jolla Cove** – Sea lions and snorkelling.
- **Old Town San Diego** – History and Mexican food.
- **Coronado Beach** – A wide, sparkling beach in front of the historic Hotel del Coronado.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Gaslamp Quarter, Little Italy, La Jolla and Pacific Beach.

■ Food & Drink

Fish tacos, California burritos and craft beer.

■ When to Visit

Mild year-round; "June Gloom" brings overcast mornings.

■ Getting Around

Trolley and buses; a car is useful.

■ Day Trips

Tijuana, Temecula and Anza-Borrego.

■ **Practical Tips**

- Book zoo tickets online.
- Use sunscreen.
- Respect sea lions.
- Try fish tacos.

San Francisco

AMERICAS

United States (California) · North America

A hilly city of cable cars, the Golden Gate Bridge and tech innovation.

Country	United States (California)
Region	North America
Population (approx.)	~810,000 (city); ~7.5 million (Bay Area)
Language(s)	English
Currency	US Dollar (USD)
Main airport	San Francisco International Airport (SFO); Oakland (OAK)
Best time to visit	September–November

■ Overview

San Francisco is a compact city on a peninsula between the Pacific and San Francisco Bay. It grew during the 1849 Gold Rush and was rebuilt after the 1906 earthquake. The city is famous for its hills, Victorian houses, cable cars and the Golden Gate Bridge. It is a centre of counterculture, LGBTQ+ rights and technology. Nearby Silicon Valley is the global tech hub.

■ Top Attractions

- **Golden Gate Bridge** – The iconic bridge.
- **Alcatraz Island** – Former federal prison.
- **Cable cars** – Historic transport.
- **Fisherman's Wharf and Pier 39** – Sea lions and seafood.
- **Golden Gate Park** – Museums and gardens.
- **Chinatown** – One of the oldest in North America.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Union Square, North Beach, the Mission and Hayes Valley.

■ Food & Drink

Sourdough bread, clam chowder in bread bowls, Mission burritos and Dungeness crab.

■ When to Visit

Autumn is warmest; summers can be foggy and cool.

■ Getting Around

Muni, BART and cable cars.

■ Day Trips

Napa and Sonoma, Muir Woods and Sausalito.

■ **Practical Tips**

- Bring layers.
- Book Alcatraz early.
- Don't leave valuables in cars.
- Use Clipper card.

San José

Costa Rica · Central America

AMERICAS

Costa Rica's capital and the hub for exploring volcanoes, cloud forests and beaches.

Country	Costa Rica
Region	Central America
Population (approx.)	~350,000 (city); ~2.2 million (Greater Metropolitan Area)
Language(s)	Spanish
Currency	Costa Rican Colón (CRC); US Dollars widely accepted
Main airport	Juan Santamaría International Airport (SJO)
Best time to visit	December–April (dry season)

■ Overview

San José, the capital of Costa Rica, sits in the fertile Central Valley at about 1,150 metres above sea level, surrounded by volcanoes and coffee plantations. It became the capital in 1823 and grew wealthy from the coffee trade in the 19th century, which funded elegant buildings such as the National Theatre. Many travellers pass through quickly on their way to the rainforests and beaches, but the city offers good museums, markets and a lively café and food scene. Costa Rica is known for its commitment to conservation, political stability and the national motto "Pura Vida". San José's central location makes it a practical base for day trips across the country.

■ Top Attractions

- **National Theatre of Costa Rica** – An opulent neoclassical theatre from 1897 with marble, gold leaf and painted ceilings, and a café inside.
- **Pre-Columbian Gold Museum** – An underground museum beneath the Plaza de la Cultura, with thousands of indigenous gold artefacts.
- **National Museum of Costa Rica** – Housed in a former military barracks (the Bellavista Fortress) with a butterfly garden; Costa Rica abolished its army in 1948.
- **Central Market (Mercado Central)** – A historic market with small sodas (eateries), spices, coffee and crafts.
- **Barrio Amón and Barrio Escalante** – Neighbourhoods with colonial mansions, street art, galleries and trendy restaurants.
- **Jade Museum** – A modern museum with the world's largest collection of American jade.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Barrio Escalante is the city's gastronomic district, with restaurants and craft beer bars. Barrio Amón is historic and central. Escazú and Santa Ana, in the western suburbs, are upscale areas with modern hotels and malls, while Alajuela, near the airport, is convenient for early flights.

■ Food & Drink

Gallo pinto, rice and beans often served with eggs, plantains and sour cream, is the national breakfast. Casados, set plates of rice, beans, salad, plantain and meat or fish, are served in sodas at lunchtime. Costa Rican coffee is among the world's best, and many cafés offer single-origin brews. Salsa Lizano is the ubiquitous local sauce.

■ When to Visit

The dry season from December to April offers sunny days and is the peak tourist season. The green season (May–November) brings afternoon rains, lush landscapes and lower prices. The Central Valley has a spring-like climate year-round.

■ Getting Around

Buses are cheap but can be confusing; Uber and official red taxis are widely used. Traffic can be heavy during rush hours. Shuttle services and domestic flights connect San José with beaches and national parks.

■ Day Trips

Poás and Irazú volcanoes, with crater viewpoints, are within 1–2 hours. La Paz Waterfall Gardens, coffee plantation tours (such as Doka Estate or Britt) and white-water rafting on the Pacuare River are popular. Manuel Antonio National Park and Monteverde are longer trips.

■ Practical Tips

- Carry small change; colones and US dollars are both widely accepted.
- Avoid walking alone in quiet areas at night and keep valuables hidden.
- Check volcano park reservations online before visiting.
- Pack a light rain jacket, especially in the green season.

San Juan

Puerto Rico (US territory) · Caribbean

AMERICAS

A colourful colonial city of forts, beaches and salsa rhythm.

Country	Puerto Rico (US territory)
Region	Caribbean
Population (approx.)	~340,000 (city); ~2 million (metro)
Language(s)	Spanish and English
Currency	US Dollar (USD)
Main airport	Luis Muñoz Marín International Airport (SJU)
Best time to visit	December–April

■ Overview

San Juan, the capital of Puerto Rico, is one of the oldest European-founded cities in the Americas, established by the Spanish in 1521. Its historic district, Old San Juan, has pastel-coloured buildings, blue cobblestone streets and massive fortifications, part of a UNESCO World Heritage Site. Puerto Rico is a US territory, so US citizens do not need a passport, and the US dollar is the currency. The city blends Spanish colonial heritage, Caribbean culture and American influences. It is famous for its beaches, nightlife, salsa and reggaeton music.

■ Top Attractions

- **Castillo San Felipe del Morro (El Morro)** – A 16th-century fortress guarding the entrance to San Juan Bay, with sweeping ocean views.
- **Castillo San Cristóbal** – The largest fortress built by the Spanish in the Americas, with tunnels and ramparts.
- **Old San Juan** – Colourful streets, plazas, the Cathedral of San Juan Bautista and shops.
- **Condado and Isla Verde beaches** – Urban beaches with resorts and water sports.
- **La Placita de Santurce** – A market square that turns into a lively nightlife spot.
- **Paseo de la Princesa** – A promenade along the city walls.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Old San Juan is historic and charming. Condado is upscale, with beachfront hotels, while Isla Verde is near the airport. Santurce is known for street art and nightlife.

■ Food & Drink

Puerto Rican cuisine includes mofongo (mashed fried plantains with garlic), lechón (roast pork), arroz con gandules and alcapurrias (fritters). The piña colada was reportedly invented in San Juan. Local rum is excellent, and Bacardí's distillery is across the bay.

■ When to Visit

December to April is the dry season. Hurricane season runs from June to November. The San Sebastián Street Festival in January is a huge celebration.

■ Getting Around

Old San Juan is walkable, and free trolleys run in some periods. Uber and taxis are widely used. Renting a car is ideal for exploring the island.

■ Day Trips

El Yunque National Forest, the only tropical rainforest in the US National Forest System, is about 45 minutes away. Bioluminescent bays at Fajardo, Vieques and La Parguera glow at night. Culebra's Flamenco Beach is one of the Caribbean's most beautiful beaches.

■ Practical Tips

- US citizens do not need a passport.
- Check hurricane forecasts in the rainy season.
- Use reef-safe sunscreen.
- Book bioluminescent bay tours in advance, ideally around the new moon.

San Miguel de Allende

Mexico · North America

AMERICAS

A colonial highland town of pink spires, art and cobblestone streets.

Country	Mexico
Region	North America
Population (approx.)	~175,000 (municipality)
Language(s)	Spanish (English widely spoken)
Currency	Mexican Peso (MXN)
Main airport	León/Bajío International Airport (BJX); Querétaro International Airport (QRO)
Best time to visit	October–April

■ Overview

San Miguel de Allende is a colonial town in the state of Guanajuato in central Mexico, located about 1,900 metres above sea level. It played an important role in Mexico's War of Independence, and it is named after Ignacio Allende, one of the independence heroes. Its historic centre, with baroque churches and colourful houses, is a UNESCO World Heritage Site. The town has attracted artists and foreign residents since the mid-20th century, creating a vibrant arts and expat community. San Miguel is often ranked among the world's best small cities by travel magazines.

■ Top Attractions

- **Parroquia de San Miguel Arcángel** – A neo-Gothic pink parish church, the town's iconic landmark.
- **El Jardín** – The main square, where locals and visitors gather.
- **Fábrica La Aurora** – A former textile factory turned into an art and design centre.
- **El Charco del Ingenio** – A botanical garden with cacti and canyon views.
- **Mercado de Artesanías** – A market for crafts.
- **Hot springs** – Natural thermal pools near town, such as La Gruta.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

El Centro is the best area to stay. Guadiana and San Antonio are quieter residential areas nearby.

■ Food & Drink

The town has a sophisticated restaurant scene, with rooftop bars and Mexican fusion. Street food includes tacos, gorditas and elotes (corn). Local wines from Guanajuato's vineyards are gaining a reputation.

■ When to Visit

October to April is dry and pleasant. Festivals include Día de los Muertos and the Alborada in late September.

■ Getting Around

The centre is walkable, but the cobblestones and hills require good shoes. Taxis are inexpensive.

■ Day Trips

Guanajuato, a colourful colonial city of tunnels, is about 1.5 hours away. The Sanctuary of Atotonilco is a UNESCO-listed church with frescoes. Vineyards and the town of Dolores Hidalgo are nearby.

■ Practical Tips

- Wear comfortable shoes.
- Book accommodation early for festivals.
- Evenings can be cool; bring layers.
- Try local wines.

Santiago

Chile · South America

AMERICAS

A modern capital framed by the Andes, with wineries and ski slopes nearby.

Country	Chile
Region	South America
Population (approx.)	~6.9 million (metro)
Language(s)	Spanish
Currency	Chilean Peso (CLP)
Main airport	Arturo Merino Benítez International Airport (SCL)
Best time to visit	September–November and March–May

■ Overview

Santiago, the capital of Chile, lies in a valley between the Andes and the Chilean Coastal Range. Founded by Spanish conquistador Pedro de Valdivia in 1541, it is now one of South America's most modern and prosperous cities. The snow-capped Andes provide a dramatic backdrop on clear days. Santiago has excellent museums, a growing food scene and lively neighbourhoods. It is the gateway to Chile's wine valleys, ski resorts, Valparaíso and further destinations such as Patagonia and the Atacama Desert.

■ Top Attractions

- **Cerro San Cristóbal** – A hill in the Parque Metropolitano with a funicular, cable car and a statue of the Virgin Mary, offering views over the city.
- **Plaza de Armas** – The historic main square, with the Metropolitan Cathedral and the Central Post Office.
- **La Moneda Palace** – The presidential palace, with a changing of the guard ceremony and a cultural centre below.
- **Museum of Memory and Human Rights** – A moving museum on the Pinochet dictatorship (1973–1990).
- **Chilean Museum of Pre-Columbian Art** – A superb collection of indigenous art from across the Americas.
- **Sky Costanera** – The observation deck of the tallest building in South America.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Providencia and Las Condes are safe, modern areas with hotels and restaurants. Lastarria and Bellas Artes are bohemian, with cafés and galleries, while Barrio Italia has boutiques and design shops. Bellavista is known for nightlife and Pablo Neruda's house, La Chascona.

■ Food & Drink

Chilean dishes include empanadas de pino (beef, onion, egg and olive), pastel de choclo (corn pie), completos (loaded hot dogs) and seafood from the long coastline. The Mercado Central is famous for seafood. Pisco sour and wine, especially Carménère, are national favourites. Once (afternoon tea) is a Chilean tradition.

■ When to Visit

Spring and autumn are ideal. Summers are hot and dry, and winters are cool, with smog but good skiing. The Fiestas Patrias in September celebrate independence.

■ Getting Around

Santiago has an efficient metro system. Buses and ride-hailing apps are common. The airport is about 30 minutes from the centre.

■ Day Trips

Valparaíso and Viña del Mar are about 1.5 hours away. The Maipo, Casablanca and Colchagua wine valleys offer tastings. Ski resorts such as Valle Nevado and Farellones are close in winter, and the Cajón del Maipo canyon is good for hiking.

■ Practical Tips

- Keep an eye on belongings in crowded areas.
- Book wine tours in advance.
- Check air quality in winter.
- Earthquakes are common; learn basic safety procedures.

Santo Domingo

Dominican Republic · Caribbean

AMERICAS

The oldest European city in the Americas, with a vibrant colonial zone and merengue rhythms.

Country	Dominican Republic
Region	Caribbean
Population (approx.)	~1 million (National District); ~3.9 million (metro)
Language(s)	Spanish
Currency	Dominican Peso (DOP)
Main airport	Las Américas International Airport (SDQ)
Best time to visit	December–April

■ Overview

Santo Domingo, the capital of the Dominican Republic, was founded in 1496 by Bartholomew Columbus, making it the oldest continuously inhabited European settlement in the Americas. Its Ciudad Colonial is a UNESCO World Heritage Site, with the first cathedral, hospital, university and fortress built by Europeans in the New World. The city is a bustling Caribbean capital with lively music, especially merengue and bachata. While most tourists head to resorts in Punta Cana, Santo Domingo offers history and authentic urban culture. The Malecón seafront boulevard is the city's social heart.

■ Top Attractions

- **Ciudad Colonial** – The historic zone with cobbled streets and colonial buildings.
- **Catedral Primada de América** – The first cathedral in the Americas, completed in 1541.
- **Alcázar de Colón** – The palace of Diego Columbus, son of Christopher Columbus.
- **Fortaleza Ozama** – The oldest European military building in the Americas.
- **Los Tres Ojos** – A series of cave lakes in a national park.
- **Malecón** – A seafront promenade with restaurants and nightlife.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The Ciudad Colonial is atmospheric. Piantini and Naco are modern upscale areas.

■ Food & Drink

La bandera dominicana (rice, beans and meat), mangú (mashed plantains), sancocho (stew) and tostones. Presidente beer and rum are popular.

■ **When to Visit**

December to April is dry. Hurricane season runs June–November. Carnival takes place in February.

■ **Getting Around**

Taxis, ride-hailing apps and a metro system are available. The colonial zone is walkable.

■ **Day Trips**

Boca Chica beach, Juan Dolio and the city of La Romana (Altos de Chavón) are popular.

■ **Practical Tips**

- Use Uber for safety.
- Carry cash.
- Dress modestly in churches.
- Try merengue dancing.

São Paulo

Brazil · South America

AMERICAS

South America's largest city, a cosmopolitan powerhouse of food, art and nightlife.

Country	Brazil
Region	South America
Population (approx.)	~11.5 million (city); ~22 million (metro)
Language(s)	Portuguese
Currency	Brazilian Real (BRL)
Main airport	São Paulo/Guarulhos International Airport (GRU); Congonhas (CGH)
Best time to visit	April-May and September-November

■ Overview

São Paulo is the largest city in South America and Brazil's economic engine. It is a vast, diverse metropolis shaped by immigrants from Italy, Japan, Lebanon, Portugal, Germany and elsewhere; it has the largest Japanese community outside Japan. While it lacks beaches, São Paulo offers world-class restaurants, museums, nightlife and shopping. The city has a vibrant arts scene, including street art and major cultural institutions. Locals, called Paulistanos, are known for their work ethic and love of food.

■ Top Attractions

- **Avenida Paulista** – The city's main avenue, closed to cars on Sundays, with MASP (São Paulo Museum of Art).
- **Ibirapuera Park** – A large park with museums designed by Oscar Niemeyer.
- **Mercado Municipal** – A historic market famous for mortadella sandwiches.
- **Beco do Batman** – An alley covered in street art in Vila Madalena.
- **Liberdade** – The Japanese district.
- **Pinacoteca** – An art museum.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Jardins, Vila Madalena and Pinheiros are popular.

■ Food & Drink

São Paulo has thousands of restaurants, with Italian, Japanese and Brazilian cuisines. Try pizza, pastel and feijoada.

■ When to Visit

Autumn and spring are pleasant.

■ **Getting Around**

The metro is efficient. Traffic is heavy.

■ **Day Trips**

Santos, Paraty and Campos do Jordão.

■ **Practical Tips**

- Use apps for taxis.
- Watch belongings.
- Book popular restaurants.
- Avoid rush hour.

Sapporo

Japan · East Asia

ASIA

Hokkaido's capital of snow festivals, beer, ramen and nearby ski resorts.

Country	Japan
Region	East Asia
Population (approx.)	~1.95 million
Language(s)	Japanese
Currency	Japanese Yen (JPY)
Main airport	New Chitose Airport (CTS)
Best time to visit	December–February for snow; June–August for summer

■ Overview

Sapporo is the capital of Hokkaido, Japan's northernmost main island. Founded in the 19th century, it has a grid layout and wide streets unlike most Japanese cities. The city hosted the 1972 Winter Olympics and is famous for its Snow Festival. Sapporo is known for its beer, miso ramen and seafood. It is a base for skiing in Niseko and exploring Hokkaido's nature.

■ Top Attractions

- **Sapporo Snow Festival** – Giant snow and ice sculptures in February.
- **Odori Park** – A long park in the city centre.
- **Sapporo Beer Museum** – The history of Japan's oldest beer brand.
- **Mount Moiwa** – Views over the city.
- **Susukino** – The nightlife district.
- **Shiroi Koibito Park** – A chocolate factory and theme park.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Staying near Sapporo Station, Odori or Susukino is convenient.

■ Food & Drink

Miso ramen, soup curry and Genghis Khan (grilled lamb) are local specialities. Seafood, especially crab and sea urchin, is excellent.

■ When to Visit

Winter brings snow and the festival. Summer is cool and pleasant.

■ Getting Around

Sapporo has a subway and trams. Trains connect with New Chitose Airport.

■ Day Trips

Otaru, a canal town, is 30 minutes away. Niseko is a ski resort. Furano has lavender fields.

■ Practical Tips

- Book accommodation early for the Snow Festival.
- Wear warm clothing in winter.
- Try ramen in Ramen Yokocho.
- Get an IC card.

Sarajevo

EUROPE

Bosnia and Herzegovina · Southeastern Europe

A city where East meets West, with Ottoman bazaars, Austro-Hungarian avenues and a resilient spirit.

Country	Bosnia and Herzegovina
Region	Southeastern Europe
Population (approx.)	~275,000 (city); ~550,000 (metro)
Language(s)	Bosnian, Croatian and Serbian
Currency	Convertible Mark (BAM)
Main airport	Sarajevo International Airport (SJJ)
Best time to visit	May–September

■ Overview

Sarajevo, the capital of Bosnia and Herzegovina, lies in a valley surrounded by mountains. It has long been a meeting point of cultures, with mosques, Orthodox and Catholic churches and synagogues within a short walk of each other. The assassination of Archduke Franz Ferdinand here in 1914 triggered the First World War, and the city hosted the 1984 Winter Olympics. During the 1992–1996 siege, Sarajevo suffered greatly, and memorials recall this history. Today it is a welcoming, affordable city with a vibrant café culture.

■ Top Attractions

- **Baščaršija** – The old Ottoman bazaar with copper workshops, the Sebilj fountain and cafés.
- **Gazi Husrev-beg Mosque** – The most important Ottoman mosque in Bosnia.
- **Latin Bridge** – The site of the 1914 assassination, with a small museum nearby.
- **War Tunnel Museum (Tunnel of Hope)** – A tunnel dug under the airport during the siege to supply the city.
- **Yellow Fortress** – A viewpoint popular at sunset.
- **Trebević Cable Car** – A cable car to Mount Trebević, with the abandoned Olympic bobsled track.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Staying near Baščaršija or Ferhadija Street is convenient for sightseeing. Marijin Dvor is a more modern area, and the hills around the old town offer guesthouses with views. The city is compact and walkable.

■ Food & Drink

Ćevapi, grilled minced meat in flatbread with onions and kajmak, is Sarajevo's signature dish. Burek and other pies (pita) are also popular. Bosnian coffee is served in a copper pot (džezva) with Turkish delight. Sweets such as baklava and tufahija (stuffed apples) are common.

■ When to Visit

Late spring through early autumn is ideal. The Sarajevo Film Festival in August is a major event. Winters are cold and snowy, and nearby mountains offer skiing.

■ Getting Around

The old town is walkable, and trams run along the main avenue. Taxis are affordable; agree on the fare or use the meter. Buses and trains connect Sarajevo with Mostar.

■ Day Trips

Mostar, with its iconic Old Bridge, is about two hours away by train. The Kravica waterfalls and Počitelj village are nearby. Jahorina and Bjelašnica, Olympic ski resorts, offer winter sports and summer hiking.

■ Practical Tips

- Dress modestly when visiting mosques.
- Cash is useful in smaller shops.
- Stay on marked paths when hiking, as landmines remain in some rural areas.
- Learn about recent history with a guided tour.

Savannah

AMERICAS

United States (Georgia) · North America

A Southern charmer of oak-shaded squares, Spanish moss and historic mansions.

Country	United States (Georgia)
Region	North America
Population (approx.)	~150,000 (city); ~420,000 (metro)
Language(s)	English
Currency	US Dollar (USD)
Main airport	Savannah/Hilton Head International Airport (SAV)
Best time to visit	March–May and October–November

■ Overview

Savannah, founded in 1733 by General James Oglethorpe, is Georgia's oldest city and one of the best-preserved historic cities in the United States. Its unique town plan of 22 leafy squares, shaded by live oaks draped in Spanish moss, creates a romantic atmosphere. The city was spared destruction during the Civil War, when General Sherman presented it to President Lincoln as a "Christmas gift". Savannah is known for its antebellum architecture, ghost stories and Southern hospitality. The Savannah College of Art and Design (SCAD) adds a creative, youthful energy.

■ Top Attractions

- **Historic District squares** – Walk through squares such as Chippewa, Lafayette and Madison, each with monuments and fountains.
- **Forsyth Park** – A large park with a famous white fountain.
- **River Street** – Cobblestone waterfront with shops and restaurants in old cotton warehouses.
- **Cathedral of St. John the Baptist** – A French Gothic-style cathedral with stained glass.
- **Bonaventure Cemetery** – A hauntingly beautiful cemetery made famous by the book *Midnight in the Garden of Good and Evil*.
- **Owens-Thomas House & Slave Quarters** – A house museum that presents the lives of both the owners and the enslaved.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The Historic District is the best place to stay. The Starland District is artsy and trendy, and Tybee Island offers beaches nearby.

■ Food & Drink

Southern cuisine includes shrimp and grits, fried chicken, Lowcountry boil and pecan pralines. Family-style restaurants like Mrs. Wilkes' Dining Room are institutions. Savannah allows open containers of alcohol in plastic cups in the Historic District.

■ When to Visit

Spring (with blooming azaleas) and autumn are ideal. Summers are hot and humid. St. Patrick's Day is one of the largest celebrations in the US.

■ Getting Around

The Historic District is walkable. A free DOT shuttle and ferry serve downtown. Trolley tours are popular.

■ Day Trips

Tybee Island, Hilton Head Island and Charleston (about two hours) are popular.

■ Practical Tips

- Take a ghost tour at night.
- Book early for St. Patrick's Day.
- Wear comfortable shoes.
- Carry insect repellent in warm months.

Seattle

AMERICAS

United States (Washington) · North America

The Emerald City of coffee, tech, music and mountain views.

Country	United States (Washington)
Region	North America
Population (approx.)	~760,000 (city); ~4 million (metro)
Language(s)	English
Currency	US Dollar (USD)
Main airport	Seattle-Tacoma International Airport (SEA)
Best time to visit	June–September

■ Overview

Seattle, in the Pacific Northwest, lies between Puget Sound and Lake Washington, with Mount Rainier towering on clear days. The city grew as a gateway to the Klondike Gold Rush and later became a hub for aviation (Boeing) and technology (Microsoft, Amazon). Seattle is the birthplace of Starbucks and grunge music, with bands like Nirvana and Pearl Jam. Its surroundings offer forests, mountains, islands and water sports. It has a reputation for rain, though summers are dry and sunny.

■ Top Attractions

- **Pike Place Market** – A historic market famous for fish throwing and the original Starbucks.
- **Space Needle** – An observation tower built for the 1962 World's Fair.
- **Chihuly Garden and Glass** – Stunning glass art by Dale Chihuly.
- **Museum of Pop Culture (MoPOP)** – A museum of music and pop culture.
- **Kerry Park** – The classic view of the skyline and Mount Rainier.
- **Seattle Waterfront** – A redesigned promenade with the aquarium and ferries.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Downtown, Capitol Hill, Ballard and Fremont are popular.

■ Food & Drink

Seafood, especially salmon, oysters and clam chowder, is excellent. Coffee culture is strong. Seattle-style hot dogs with cream cheese are a local quirk.

■ When to Visit

Summer is sunny and dry. Autumn to spring is rainy and grey.

■ Getting Around

Light rail connects the airport with downtown. Buses and ferries are useful.

■ Day Trips

Mount Rainier National Park, Olympic National Park, Bainbridge Island and the San Juan Islands.

■ Practical Tips

- Bring a rain jacket.
- Use the ORCA card.
- Take the ferry for views.
- Visit Pike Place early.

Seoul

South Korea · East Asia

ASIA

A high-tech capital of palaces, K-culture, street food and mountain trails.

Country	South Korea
Region	East Asia
Population (approx.)	~9.4 million (city); ~26 million (Seoul Capital Area)
Language(s)	Korean
Currency	South Korean Won (KRW)
Main airport	Incheon International Airport (ICN); Gimpo International Airport (GMP)
Best time to visit	April–June and September–November

■ Overview

Seoul, the capital of South Korea, has been the country's political and cultural centre for over 600 years since the Joseon dynasty made it its capital in 1394. It is a dynamic megacity where ancient palaces and Buddhist temples sit among skyscrapers, neon-lit shopping districts and cutting-edge technology. Seoul is at the heart of the global popularity of K-pop, K-dramas, Korean beauty and cuisine. The city is surrounded by mountains, with hiking trails accessible by subway, and divided by the Han River. It is safe, efficient and full of energy day and night.

■ Top Attractions

- **Gyeongbokgung Palace** – The largest of Seoul's five grand palaces, with a changing of the guard ceremony; entry is free if you wear a hanbok (traditional dress).
- **Bukchon Hanok Village** – A neighbourhood of traditional wooden houses between palaces; visiting hours are restricted to respect residents.
- **Changdeokgung and the Secret Garden** – A UNESCO-listed palace with a beautiful rear garden visited by guided tour.
- **N Seoul Tower** – A tower on Namsan Mountain with views over the city, reached by cable car or on foot.
- **Myeongdong and Insadong** – Shopping districts for cosmetics, street food, crafts and tea houses.
- **DMZ (Demilitarized Zone)** – Guided tours to the border with North Korea, including tunnels and observation points; check availability as tours may be suspended.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Myeongdong and Jongno are central and close to palaces. Hongdae is a youthful area with music, clubs and street performers, while Itaewon is international. Gangnam is upscale and business-oriented, and Seongsu is a trendy area of cafés in converted factories.

■ Food & Drink

Korean barbecue (samgyeopsal, bulgogi), bibimbap, kimchi stew and fried chicken with beer (chimaek) are must-tries. Gwangjang Market is famous for bindaetteok (mung bean pancakes) and mayak gimhap. Tteokbokki (spicy rice cakes) and hotteok (sweet pancakes) are popular street foods. Soju is the national drink.

■ When to Visit

Spring cherry blossoms and autumn foliage are beautiful. Summers are hot, humid and rainy during the monsoon, while winters are cold and dry. Chuseok (harvest festival) and Seollal (Lunar New Year) are major holidays when some businesses close.

■ Getting Around

Seoul's subway is extensive, clean and efficient. The T-money card works on subways, buses and in convenience stores. The AREX train connects Incheon Airport with Seoul Station.

■ Day Trips

The DMZ, Suwon's Hwaseong Fortress and Nami Island are popular. Bukhansan National Park offers hiking within the city limits. Jeonju's hanok village is reachable by train.

■ Practical Tips

- Use Naver Map or KakaoMap; Google Maps navigation is limited.
- Get a T-money card at the airport or convenience stores.
- Tipping is not customary.
- Many restaurants have minimum orders for two people.

Seville

Spain · Southern Europe

EUROPE

The passionate heart of Andalusia, home of flamenco, orange trees and grand Moorish palaces.

Country	Spain
Region	Southern Europe
Population (approx.)	~680,000 (city); ~1.5 million (metro)
Language(s)	Spanish
Currency	Euro (EUR)
Main airport	Seville Airport, San Pablo (SVQ)
Best time to visit	March–May and October–November

■ Overview

Seville, the capital of Andalusia, is one of Spain's most romantic cities, known for its flamenco, colourful festivals and Moorish-influenced architecture. It was a major city of Al-Andalus and later the monopoly port for trade with the Americas, bringing immense wealth. The cathedral, the Alcázar and the Archive of the Indies form a UNESCO World Heritage Site. Seville's streets are lined with orange trees, and its plazas are full of life. It is one of the hottest cities in Europe in summer.

■ Top Attractions

- **Real Alcázar** – A royal palace blending Mudéjar, Gothic and Renaissance styles, with beautiful gardens.
- **Seville Cathedral and Giralda** – The world's largest Gothic cathedral, with the tomb of Christopher Columbus and a tower you can climb via ramps.
- **Plaza de España** – A monumental semicircular plaza with tiled alcoves representing Spanish provinces.
- **Barrio Santa Cruz** – The former Jewish quarter of narrow lanes and flower-filled courtyards.
- **Metropol Parasol (Las Setas)** – A modern wooden structure with a rooftop walkway.
- **Triana** – A traditional neighbourhood across the river known for ceramics and flamenco.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Santa Cruz and the area near the cathedral are central and atmospheric. Triana is authentic and lively, while Alameda de Hércules is trendy, with bars. El Arenal is close to the bullring and the river.

■ Food & Drink

Seville is a tapas city: try salmorejo (a thick cold tomato soup), espinacas con garbanzos, pringá, and fried fish. Jamón ibérico and olives are everywhere. Tinto de verano and sherry from nearby Jerez are popular drinks. Late-night tapas crawls are part of local life.

■ When to Visit

Spring is the best time, with Holy Week (Semana Santa) processions and the April Fair (Feria de Abril). Summer temperatures often exceed 40°C. Autumn and winter are mild and pleasant.

■ Getting Around

The historic centre is walkable, and trams, buses and a metro line serve the city. The airport bus connects with the centre in about 35 minutes. High-speed trains reach Madrid in about 2.5 hours.

■ Day Trips

Córdoba, with its Mezquita-Catedral, is 45 minutes away by high-speed train. Cádiz and Jerez de la Frontera, the home of sherry, are also close. The white villages (pueblos blancos) and Ronda are popular by car.

■ Practical Tips

- Book the Alcázar and cathedral online in advance.
- Avoid sightseeing in the midday summer heat.
- Watch a flamenco show at a small tablao or peña.
- Book early for Holy Week and the April Fair.

Shanghai

China · East Asia

ASIA

China's cosmopolitan megacity of colonial boulevards and a futuristic skyline.

Country	China
Region	East Asia
Population (approx.)	~24.8 million
Language(s)	Mandarin Chinese (Shanghainese locally)
Currency	Chinese Yuan Renminbi (CNY)
Main airport	Shanghai Pudong International (PVG); Shanghai Hongqiao International (SHA)
Best time to visit	March–May and September–November

■ Overview

Shanghai, on the Yangtze River Delta, is China's largest city and its financial centre. It grew from a fishing town into a major port after the First Opium War, when foreign concessions were established. Its Bund waterfront showcases colonial-era buildings, while across the Huangpu River, Pudong's skyline features some of the world's tallest buildings. Shanghai is cosmopolitan, stylish and fast-paced, with world-class dining, shopping and nightlife. It is also a gateway to the canal towns of the Yangtze Delta.

■ Top Attractions

- **The Bund** – A riverside promenade lined with colonial buildings, facing Pudong's skyline.
- **Shanghai Tower** – The tallest building in China, with one of the world's highest observation decks.
- **Yu Garden** – A classical Chinese garden from the Ming dynasty, surrounded by a bazaar.
- **French Concession** – Tree-lined streets with villas, cafés and boutiques.
- **Shanghai Museum** – Collections of ancient Chinese art, bronzes and ceramics.
- **Tianzifang and Xintiandi** – Restored shikumen (stone-gate) houses with shops and restaurants.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The Bund and People's Square are central. The former French Concession is charming, with cafés and nightlife, and Jing'an is upscale and modern. Pudong is the business district.

■ Food & Drink

Shanghai's specialities include xiaolongbao (soup dumplings), shengjian bao (pan-fried buns), hairy crab in autumn and red-braised pork. Street food and dumpling shops are everywhere. The city also has an excellent international dining scene.

■ When to Visit

Spring and autumn are best. Summers are hot, humid and rainy, and winters are damp and cold. Avoid the October Golden Week holiday.

■ Getting Around

Shanghai has one of the world's largest metro systems. The Maglev train connects Pudong Airport with the city at over 300 km/h. DiDi is widely used.

■ Day Trips

Water towns such as Zhujiajiao, Zhouzhuang and Wuzhen are popular. Suzhou, with classical gardens, and Hangzhou are short trips by high-speed train.

■ Practical Tips

- Set up Alipay or WeChat Pay before arrival.
- Many foreign apps are blocked; plan internet access.
- Carry your passport.
- Visit the Bund at night to see the skyline illuminated.

Siem Reap

Cambodia · Southeast Asia

ASIA

The gateway to Angkor, the world's largest religious monument.

Country	Cambodia
Region	Southeast Asia
Population (approx.)	~250,000
Language(s)	Khmer
Currency	Cambodian Riel (KHR); US Dollars widely used
Main airport	Siem Reap-Angkor International Airport (SAI)
Best time to visit	November-March

■ Overview

Siem Reap is a town in northwestern Cambodia and the base for visiting the temples of Angkor, the capital of the Khmer Empire from the 9th to 15th centuries. The Angkor Archaeological Park, a UNESCO World Heritage Site, contains hundreds of temples spread across a vast area. Siem Reap itself has grown into a lively town with markets, restaurants, spas and nightlife. It is also a centre for traditional arts and crafts. The new international airport opened in 2023.

■ Top Attractions

- **Angkor Wat** – The largest religious monument in the world, famous for sunrise views.
- **Angkor Thom and Bayon** – A walled city with the Bayon temple and its giant stone faces.
- **Ta Prohm** – A temple overgrown by giant tree roots, featured in Tomb Raider.
- **Banteay Srei** – A small temple with exquisite pink sandstone carvings.
- **Phare, the Cambodian Circus** – Performances by artists trained at a social enterprise.
- **Tonlé Sap Lake** – Southeast Asia's largest freshwater lake, with floating villages.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The area around Pub Street and the Old Market is lively. Quieter hotels are found along the river and in the countryside.

■ Food & Drink

Fish amok, lok lak and Khmer curries are staples. Street food and night markets offer cheap meals. Many restaurants support training programmes for disadvantaged youth.

■ **When to Visit**

November to March is best. April and May are very hot, and the rainy season brings lush scenery.

■ **Getting Around**

Tuk-tuks are the main way to visit temples. Bicycles and e-bikes are also available.

■ **Day Trips**

Kulen Mountain, Beng Mealea and the floating villages of Tonlé Sap are popular.

■ **Practical Tips**

- Buy Angkor passes at the official ticket office or online.
- Dress modestly for temples; shoulders and knees must be covered.
- Start early to avoid heat.
- Hire a licensed guide.

Singapore

Singapore · Southeast Asia

ASIA

A clean, green city-state of futuristic gardens, hawker food and multicultural neighbourhoods.

Country	Singapore
Region	Southeast Asia
Population (approx.)	~6 million
Language(s)	English, Malay, Mandarin and Tamil
Currency	Singapore Dollar (SGD)
Main airport	Singapore Changi Airport (SIN)
Best time to visit	February–April (hot and humid year-round)

■ Overview

Singapore is a small island city-state at the southern tip of the Malay Peninsula. Founded as a British trading post in 1819, it became independent in 1965 and transformed into one of the world's wealthiest and most developed countries. Singapore is known for its efficiency, cleanliness, safety and strict laws. It is a multicultural society with Chinese, Malay, Indian and Eurasian communities. The city combines futuristic architecture with lush gardens and heritage districts.

■ Top Attractions

- **Gardens by the Bay** – Futuristic Supertree Grove, Cloud Forest and Flower Dome conservatories, with a nightly light show.
- **Marina Bay Sands** – An iconic hotel with a rooftop SkyPark and infinity pool.
- **Sentosa Island** – Beaches, Universal Studios Singapore and S.E.A. Aquarium.
- **Chinatown, Little India and Kampong Glam** – Colourful neighbourhoods with temples, mosques and markets.
- **Singapore Botanic Gardens** – A UNESCO site with the National Orchid Garden.
- **Jewel Changi Airport** – A shopping and entertainment complex with the world's tallest indoor waterfall.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Marina Bay is central, with luxury hotels. Chinatown and Little India offer affordable accommodation, and Orchard Road is the shopping district. Tiong Bahru is trendy, with cafés.

■ Food & Drink

Hawker centres serve affordable local dishes such as Hainanese chicken rice, laksa, chilli crab, satay and char kway teow. Singapore's hawker culture is inscribed by UNESCO. Some hawker stalls have received Michelin recognition.

■ When to Visit

Singapore is hot and humid year-round, with frequent rain. Festivals such as Chinese New Year, Deepavali and Hari Raya are celebrated.

■ Getting Around

The MRT is efficient and clean. Contactless cards work on public transport. Grab is widely used.

■ Day Trips

Pulau Ubin offers rustic island life. Johor Bahru in Malaysia is across the causeway. Bintan and Batam in Indonesia are reached by ferry.

■ Practical Tips

- Chewing gum sales are restricted, and littering is fined.
- Drink tap water; it's safe.
- Carry an umbrella for sudden rain.
- Complete the SG Arrival Card before arrival.

Sofia

EUROPE

Bulgaria · Southeastern Europe

An affordable capital with golden domes, Roman ruins and a mountain on its doorstep.

Country	Bulgaria
Region	Southeastern Europe
Population (approx.)	~1.3 million
Language(s)	Bulgarian
Currency	Euro (EUR) since 1 January 2026 (formerly the Bulgarian Lev, BGN)
Main airport	Sofia Airport (SOF)
Best time to visit	May–June and September–October

■ Overview

Sofia, the capital of Bulgaria, is one of Europe's oldest cities, founded as the Thracian settlement of Serdica. Its layered history includes Roman ruins, Byzantine churches, Ottoman mosques and communist-era monuments. The city sits at the foot of Mount Vitosha, offering quick access to hiking and skiing. Sofia is affordable, with a relaxed atmosphere, café culture and lively nightlife. It is also a gateway to Bulgaria's monasteries and mountains.

■ Top Attractions

- **Alexander Nevsky Cathedral** – One of the largest Orthodox cathedrals in the world, with golden domes.
- **Serdica archaeological complex** – Roman ruins visible in the centre, including streets and buildings.
- **Boyana Church** – A UNESCO-listed medieval church with remarkable 13th-century frescoes.
- **Vitosha Boulevard** – The main pedestrian street, with shops and cafés and views of Mount Vitosha.
- **Church of St. George (Rotunda)** – A 4th-century Roman rotunda, one of the oldest buildings in Sofia.
- **National Palace of Culture (NDK)** – A large conference centre with a park and fountains.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The city centre is compact and convenient. The area around Vitosha Boulevard is lively, and Lozenets is residential and pleasant. Oborishte, near the cathedral, has cafés and a local feel.

■ Food & Drink

Bulgarian cuisine includes shopska salad, banitsa (cheese pastry), kebapche (grilled minced meat) and tarator (cold yoghurt and cucumber soup). Bulgarian yoghurt is famous. Rakia, a fruit brandy, is widely drunk. Mehanas are traditional taverns.

■ When to Visit

Spring and autumn are pleasant. Summers are warm, and winters are cold with skiing nearby. Festivals and outdoor events take place in summer.

■ Getting Around

Sofia has a metro that connects the airport with the centre. Trams and buses cover the city. Taxis are affordable; use reputable companies.

■ Day Trips

Rila Monastery, Bulgaria's most important monastery, is about two hours away. Plovdiv, one of Europe's oldest cities, is a popular trip. Mount Vitosha offers hiking and skiing.

■ Practical Tips

- Bulgarians nod for "no" and shake their heads for "yes", which can be confusing.
- Cyrillic script is used; learn a few letters to read signs.
- Taxi scams exist at the airport; use official taxi desks or apps.
- Bulgaria switched from the lev to the euro in 2026; some older price tags may still show both currencies.

Split

Croatia · Southeastern Europe

EUROPE

A lively Adriatic city built inside a Roman emperor's palace.

Country	Croatia
Region	Southeastern Europe
Population (approx.)	~160,000
Language(s)	Croatian
Currency	Euro (EUR)
Main airport	Split Airport (SPU)
Best time to visit	May-June and September-October

■ Overview

Split is Croatia's second-largest city and the main hub of the Dalmatian coast. Its heart is Diocletian's Palace, built by the Roman emperor around AD 300, which is now a living part of the city with shops, homes and bars inside its walls. The palace is a UNESCO World Heritage Site. Split is a gateway to the islands of Hvar, Brač and Vis. It combines history, beaches and nightlife.

■ Top Attractions

- **Diocletian's Palace** – A Roman palace complex forming the old town, with the Peristyle, cellars and the Cathedral of St. Domnius.
- **Riva Promenade** – A palm-lined seafront promenade with cafés.
- **Marjan Hill** – A forested hill with trails, viewpoints and beaches.
- **Bačvice Beach** – A sandy city beach famous for the game of picigin.
- **Cathedral bell tower** – Climb for views over the old town and harbour.
- **Gregory of Nin statue** – A large bronze statue; rubbing its toe is said to bring luck.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The old town is atmospheric but noisy in summer. Varoš is a quieter neighbourhood near Marjan, and Bačvice is close to the beach and nightlife. Apartments are common accommodation.

■ Food & Drink

Dalmatian cuisine includes grilled fish, octopus salad, paštica (beef stew) and soparnik (a Swiss chard pie). Seafood is fresh and abundant. Croatian wines, including Plavac Mali, are excellent. Konobas serve traditional dishes.

■ When to Visit

Late spring and early autumn are ideal. July and August are hot and crowded, with festivals and nightlife. Winter is quiet.

■ Getting Around

The old town is walkable. Ferries and catamarans depart from the harbour to the islands. Buses connect Split with Dubrovnik and Zagreb.

■ Day Trips

Hvar, Brač (with Zlatni Rat beach) and Vis are popular island trips. Krka National Park and Trogir are close. The Blue Cave on Biševo is reached by speedboat.

■ Practical Tips

- Book ferries in advance in summer.
- Wear water shoes on rocky beaches.
- Some restaurants in the palace are expensive; explore side streets.
- Split can be busy with cruise passengers.

Stockholm

Sweden · Northern Europe

EUROPE

A capital built on 14 islands, blending royal history, design and nature.

Country	Sweden
Region	Northern Europe
Population (approx.)	~990,000 (city); ~2.4 million (metro)
Language(s)	Swedish (English widely spoken)
Currency	Swedish Krona (SEK)
Main airport	Stockholm Arlanda Airport (ARN)
Best time to visit	May–September

■ Overview

Stockholm, the capital of Sweden, is spread across 14 islands where Lake Mälaren meets the Baltic Sea. Founded in the 13th century, it has a beautifully preserved old town and a modern, innovative culture. The city is known for design, music and technology, and it hosts the Nobel Prize ceremony every December. Water and green spaces are everywhere, and the archipelago contains around 30,000 islands. Stockholm is clean, safe and expensive.

■ Top Attractions

- **Gamla Stan** – The medieval old town with narrow streets, the Royal Palace and Stortorget square.
- **Vasa Museum** – A museum built around a 17th-century warship that sank on its maiden voyage and was salvaged almost intact.
- **Skansen** – The world's oldest open-air museum, showing traditional Swedish life, with a zoo.
- **ABBA The Museum** – An interactive museum dedicated to Sweden's most famous band.
- **Royal Palace** – One of the largest palaces in Europe, with royal apartments and museums.
- **Stockholm City Hall** – The venue for the Nobel Banquet, with a tower offering views.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Gamla Stan is charming and historic. Södermalm is trendy, with vintage shops and bars, while Östermalm is upscale. Djurgården is a green island with museums and parks.

■ Food & Drink

Swedish food includes meatballs with lingonberries, gravlax (cured salmon) and pickled herring. Fika, a coffee break with pastries such as cinnamon buns (kanelbullar), is a cherished tradition. Smörgåsbord is a buffet of traditional dishes. Östermalm Market Hall is a gourmet food market.

■ When to Visit

Summer brings long days and archipelago trips; Midsummer in June is a major celebration. Winter is dark and cold but festive in December. Spring and autumn are cooler.

■ Getting Around

Stockholm has an excellent metro (tunnelbana), whose stations are decorated with art. The Arlanda Express train reaches the airport in about 20 minutes. Ferries connect the islands.

■ Day Trips

The Stockholm archipelago offers island escapes such as Vaxholm and Sandhamn. Drottningholm Palace, the royal family's residence, is a UNESCO site. Uppsala, a historic university town, is 40 minutes by train.

■ Practical Tips

- Sweden is nearly cashless; cards are accepted almost everywhere.
- The SL app is useful for public transport tickets.
- Many museums are closed on Mondays.
- Alcohol stronger than 3.5% is sold only at Systembolaget stores.

Taipei

Taiwan · East Asia

ASIA

A friendly capital of night markets, temples, hot springs and mountains.

Country	Taiwan
Region	East Asia
Population (approx.)	~2.5 million (city); ~7 million (metro)
Language(s)	Mandarin Chinese (Taiwanese Hokkien widely spoken)
Currency	New Taiwan Dollar (TWD)
Main airport	Taoyuan International Airport (TPE); Songshan Airport (TSA)
Best time to visit	October–April

■ Overview

Taipei, the capital of Taiwan, is located in a basin surrounded by mountains in the north of the island. It combines Chinese traditions, Japanese colonial heritage and a modern, democratic culture. Taipei is famous for its night markets, bubble tea and friendly people. The city is safe, clean and easy to navigate. Nature is close, with hot springs, hiking trails and tea plantations.

■ Top Attractions

- **Taipei 101** – Once the world's tallest building, with an observatory.
- **National Palace Museum** – One of the world's largest collections of Chinese art.
- **Chiang Kai-shek Memorial Hall** – A monument with a changing of the guard.
- **Longshan Temple** – A historic temple.
- **Shilin Night Market** – Taipei's largest night market.
- **Elephant Mountain** – A hike with views of Taipei 101.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Xinyi is modern, Ximending is youthful and Da'an is residential.

■ Food & Drink

Beef noodle soup, xiaolongbao at Din Tai Fung, stinky tofu and bubble tea are must-tries.

■ When to Visit

Autumn and spring are best. Summers are hot, with typhoons.

■ Getting Around

The MRT is efficient. The EasyCard works on transport.

■ Day Trips

Jiufen, Beitou hot springs and Yehliu Geopark are popular.

■ Practical Tips

- Carry an umbrella.
- Use an EasyCard.
- Try night markets.
- Taipei is very safe.

Tallinn

Estonia · Northern Europe

EUROPE

A fairy-tale medieval old town with a cutting-edge digital society.

Country	Estonia
Region	Northern Europe
Population (approx.)	~460,000
Language(s)	Estonian
Currency	Euro (EUR)
Main airport	Tallinn Airport, Lennart Meri (TLL)
Best time to visit	May–September; December for Christmas market

■ Overview

Tallinn, the capital of Estonia, has one of the best-preserved medieval old towns in Europe, a UNESCO World Heritage Site. Founded as a Hanseatic trading city, it has towers, walls and cobbled streets that look almost unchanged since the Middle Ages. Estonia is one of the world's most digitally advanced countries, birthplace of Skype. The city blends medieval charm with modern creativity. It is easy to visit from Helsinki by ferry.

■ Top Attractions

- **Old Town** – Cobbled streets, Town Hall Square and medieval walls with towers.
- **Toompea Hill** – A hill with viewpoints, Toompea Castle and Alexander Nevsky Cathedral.
- **Kadriorg Palace and Park** – A baroque palace built by Peter the Great, with the KUMU Art Museum nearby.
- **Telliskivi Creative City** – A former industrial area with shops, cafés and street art.
- **Seaplane Harbour** – A maritime museum in a historic seaplane hangar.
- **St. Olaf's Church** – A church whose tower was once among the tallest buildings in the world.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The Old Town is central. Kalamaja is a trendy neighbourhood of wooden houses, and Rotermann Quarter is a modern district with shops and restaurants. Kadriorg is green and elegant.

■ Food & Drink

Estonian cuisine includes black bread, smoked fish and hearty dishes. Kama, a mix of roasted grain flours, is a traditional food. Vana Tallinn is a local liqueur. Medieval-themed restaurants like Olde Hansa serve historic dishes.

■ When to Visit

Summer brings long days and festivals. Winter is cold, but the Christmas market in Town Hall Square is famous. Spring and autumn are quieter.

■ Getting Around

The Old Town is walkable. Trams and buses cover the city, and a tram connects the airport. Ferries link Tallinn with Helsinki in about two hours.

■ Day Trips

Lahemaa National Park offers bogs, forests and manor houses. Helsinki is an easy ferry trip. Tartu, a university town, is about 2.5 hours away.

■ Practical Tips

- Wear comfortable shoes for cobblestones.
- The Tallinn Card includes museum entry and public transport.
- Cruise ship days can make the old town crowded.
- Card payments are accepted almost everywhere.

Tashkent

Uzbekistan · Central Asia

ASIA

Central Asia's largest city, a blend of Soviet boulevards, ornate metro stations and bazaars.

Country	Uzbekistan
Region	Central Asia
Population (approx.)	~3 million
Language(s)	Uzbek (Russian widely spoken)
Currency	Uzbekistani Som (UZS)
Main airport	Islam Karimov Tashkent International Airport (TAS)
Best time to visit	April-June and September-October

■ Overview

Tashkent, the capital of Uzbekistan, is the largest city in Central Asia and an important stop on the ancient Silk Road. Much of the old city was destroyed by an earthquake in 1966 and rebuilt in a Soviet style, with wide avenues, parks and monumental buildings. Today Tashkent is modernising quickly, with new business districts, cafés and cultural venues. The city is the main international gateway to Uzbekistan's Silk Road cities of Samarkand, Bukhara and Khiva. It offers a fascinating mix of Islamic heritage, Soviet architecture and warm Uzbek hospitality.

■ Top Attractions

- **Tashkent Metro** – Each station is uniquely decorated with chandeliers, mosaics and marble; photography is now permitted.
- **Chorsu Bazaar** – A huge market under a green dome, selling spices, bread, dried fruits and fresh produce.
- **Khast Imam Complex** – The religious centre of the city, with madrasas, mosques and a library holding what is believed to be one of the oldest Qurans in the world, the Uthman Quran.
- **Amir Timur Square and Museum** – A square with a statue of Timur and a blue-domed museum dedicated to his era.
- **State Museum of Applied Arts** – A beautiful mansion displaying Uzbek crafts such as ceramics, embroidery and woodcarving.
- **Tashkent City Park and Magic City** – Modern leisure areas with fountains, restaurants and evening lights.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The city centre around Amir Timur Square has most hotels and restaurants. The Old City near Chorsu Bazaar offers a more traditional atmosphere. Tashkent City is a new business district with modern hotels and towers.

■ Food & Drink

Plov is the heart of Uzbek cuisine, and the Central Asian Plov Centre cooks it in giant cauldrons, usually around lunchtime. Other favourites include shashlik (grilled meat skewers), samsa (baked pastries), lagman (hand-pulled noodles) and manti (steamed dumplings). Uzbek bread (non) is considered sacred and should never be placed upside down. Green tea is served with every meal.

■ When to Visit

Spring and autumn are the most pleasant seasons, with blossoms in spring and harvest produce in autumn. Summers are very hot and dry, often above 40°C. Winters are cold but short.

■ Getting Around

The metro is cheap and efficient, and ride-hailing apps like Yandex Go are widely used. The Afrosiyob high-speed train connects Tashkent with Samarkand in about two hours and continues to Bukhara. The city is spread out, so walking between areas can take time.

■ Day Trips

Samarkand is an easy day trip by high-speed train, though an overnight stay is better. The Chimgan mountains and Charvak Reservoir offer hiking, skiing and lakeside resorts about 1.5 hours away. Bukhara and Khiva are best visited on longer trips.

■ Practical Tips

- Many nationalities can enter Uzbekistan visa-free; check current rules.
- Carry cash, as card acceptance is improving but still limited in bazaars.
- Book high-speed train tickets early, as they sell out.
- Dress modestly at religious sites.

Tbilisi

Georgia · Caucasus

ASIA

A charming Caucasus capital of sulphur baths, balconied houses and wine culture.

Country	Georgia
Region	Caucasus
Population (approx.)	~1.2 million
Language(s)	Georgian
Currency	Georgian Lari (GEL)
Main airport	Tbilisi International Airport (TBS)
Best time to visit	May-June and September-October

■ Overview

Tbilisi, the capital of Georgia, lies in a valley along the Mtkvari (Kura) River, surrounded by hills. Founded in the 5th century by King Vakhtang Gorgasali, it has been a crossroads of Persian, Ottoman, Russian and European influences. The old town is famous for its colourful wooden balconies, churches, synagogues and mosques standing side by side. Tbilisi has a creative, bohemian spirit, with a thriving café, art and techno club scene. Georgian hospitality, food and wine make the city especially memorable.

■ Top Attractions

- **Old Tbilisi** – Narrow streets with houses decorated with carved wooden balconies, around Sioni Cathedral and the Clock Tower of the Rezo Gabriadze Theatre.
- **Narikala Fortress** – A 4th-century fortress on a hill, reached by cable car, with views over the city.
- **Abanotubani sulphur baths** – Domed bathhouses fed by natural hot springs, which gave the city its name (tbili means "warm").
- **Holy Trinity Cathedral (Sameba)** – One of the largest Orthodox cathedrals in the world.
- **Rustaveli Avenue** – The main boulevard, with theatres, museums and the Parliament.
- **Fabrika** – A former Soviet sewing factory transformed into a hostel, bars and creative space.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Old Tbilisi is atmospheric and close to the main sights. Sololaki has beautiful Art Nouveau buildings, while Vake and Vera are leafy and upscale. Marjanishvili and the area around Fabrika are trendy.

■ Food & Drink

Georgian cuisine includes khachapuri (cheese-filled bread, especially the boat-shaped Adjarian version with egg), khinkali (juicy dumplings), badrijani (eggplant rolls with walnut paste) and mtsvadi (grilled meat). Georgia is one of the world's oldest wine regions, with the traditional qvevri clay-vessel method listed by UNESCO. A supra (feast) is led by a toastmaster called a tamada. Churchkhela, strings of nuts dipped in grape juice, is a popular snack.

■ When to Visit

Spring and autumn are the best seasons. Summers are hot, but mountain escapes are close. The grape harvest (rtveli) in September and October is a great time for wine tours.

■ Getting Around

Tbilisi has a metro, buses and cable cars. Taxis are cheap, especially via apps like Bolt and Yandex Go. The old town is walkable but hilly.

■ Day Trips

Mtskheta, Georgia's ancient capital with Jvari Monastery and Svetitskhoveli Cathedral, is 30 minutes away. The Kakheti wine region, including Signaghi, is about two hours away. Kazbegi (Stepantsminda), with Gergeti Trinity Church below Mount Kazbek, is a spectacular mountain trip along the Georgian Military Road.

■ Practical Tips

- Many nationalities can stay in Georgia visa-free for up to a year.
- Pace yourself at a supra; toasts are frequent.
- Use Bolt to avoid taxi overcharging.
- Dress modestly in churches; women should cover their heads.

Tel Aviv

Israel · Middle East

ASIA

A lively Mediterranean city of beaches, Bauhaus architecture and nightlife.

Country	Israel
Region	Middle East
Population (approx.)	~480,000 (city); ~4 million (Gush Dan metro)
Language(s)	Hebrew (English widely spoken)
Currency	Israeli New Shekel (ILS)
Main airport	Ben Gurion International Airport (TLV)
Best time to visit	April–June and September–November

■ Overview

Tel Aviv, founded in 1909 on the sand dunes north of the ancient port of Jaffa, is Israel's cultural and economic centre. Its "White City", with over 4,000 Bauhaus and International Style buildings, is a UNESCO World Heritage Site. The city is known for its beaches, café culture, startups and vibrant nightlife. Tel Aviv–Yafo includes the historic port city of Jaffa, one of the oldest ports in the world. Visitors should check current travel advisories due to the regional security situation.

■ Top Attractions

- **Old Jaffa** – An ancient port with stone alleys, galleries, the Jaffa Flea Market and views of Tel Aviv.
- **Tel Aviv beaches** – A continuous stretch of sandy beaches with promenades.
- **White City** – Bauhaus buildings along Rothschild Boulevard and Dizengoff Street.
- **Carmel Market (Shuk HaCarmel)** – A bustling market of food and goods.
- **Tel Aviv Museum of Art** – Israeli and international art.
- **Neve Tzedek** – The city's first neighbourhood outside Jaffa, with boutiques and cafés.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The beachfront is ideal for hotels. Neve Tzedek and Florentin are trendy, and Old North is residential.

■ Food & Drink

Try hummus, falafel, shakshuka and sabich. Tel Aviv has a strong vegan scene and fine dining.

■ When to Visit

Spring and autumn are ideal. Summers are hot and humid. Pride Week in June is one of the largest in the region.

■ **Getting Around**

Buses, a light rail line and bike-share (Tel-O-Fun) serve the city. Trains connect with the airport and Jerusalem.

■ **Day Trips**

Jerusalem, Caesarea and Haifa are popular. The Dead Sea is further.

■ **Practical Tips**

- Check current travel advisories.
- Public transport is limited on Shabbat.
- Carry sunscreen.
- Expect strict airport security.

Tokyo

Japan · East Asia

ASIA

The world's largest metropolis, blending ancient temples with neon-lit futurism.

Country	Japan
Region	East Asia
Population (approx.)	~14 million (city); ~37 million (Greater Tokyo)
Language(s)	Japanese
Currency	Japanese Yen (JPY)
Main airport	Haneda (HND); Narita International (NRT)
Best time to visit	March–May and October–November

■ Overview

Tokyo, the capital of Japan, is the world's largest metropolitan area and one of its most exciting cities. Formerly known as Edo, it became the seat of the Tokugawa shogunate in 1603 and the imperial capital in 1868. The city is a patchwork of distinct neighbourhoods, from traditional temples and gardens to futuristic skyscrapers and pop-culture districts. Tokyo is famous for its safety, efficiency and exceptional food, with more Michelin-starred restaurants than any other city. It can be enjoyed on any budget.

■ Top Attractions

- **Senso-ji** – Tokyo's oldest temple in Asakusa, approached through Kaminarimon Gate and Nakamise shopping street.
- **Shibuya Crossing** – The world's busiest pedestrian crossing, with views from Shibuya Sky.
- **Meiji Shrine** – A peaceful Shinto shrine surrounded by forest near Harajuku.
- **Tokyo Skytree** – The tallest tower in Japan, with observation decks.
- **Tsukiji Outer Market and Toyosu Market** – Food markets for sushi and seafood.
- **teamLab Planets and teamLab Borderless** – Immersive digital art museums.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Shinjuku is a hub of nightlife and transport, while Shibuya and Harajuku are youthful and fashionable. Ginza is upscale, Asakusa is traditional, and Akihabara is the centre of anime and electronics.

■ Food & Drink

Sushi, ramen, tempura, tonkatsu and yakitori are everywhere. Izakayas are casual pubs, and convenience stores offer surprisingly good food. Depachika (department store food halls) are worth exploring.

■ When to Visit

Spring cherry blossoms and autumn leaves are beautiful. Summer is hot and humid, and winter is dry and sunny.

■ Getting Around

Tokyo's rail and subway network is extensive. Suica and Pasma cards work on all transport.

■ Day Trips

Nikko, Kamakura, Hakone and Mount Fuji are popular.

■ Practical Tips

- Get a Suica or Pasma card.
- Avoid rush hour.
- Carry cash for smaller establishments.
- Tipping is not customary.

Toronto

Canada (Ontario) · North America

AMERICAS

Canada's largest and most multicultural city, on the shores of Lake Ontario.

Country	Canada (Ontario)
Region	North America
Population (approx.)	~3 million (city); ~6.7 million (metro)
Language(s)	English (over 200 languages spoken)
Currency	Canadian Dollar (CAD)
Main airport	Toronto Pearson International Airport (YYZ); Billy Bishop (YTZ)
Best time to visit	May–October

■ Overview

Toronto, the capital of Ontario, is Canada's largest city and its financial and cultural centre. Over half of its residents were born outside Canada, making it one of the most diverse cities in the world. Toronto has a striking skyline dominated by the CN Tower, and neighbourhoods reflecting cultures from around the globe. The city hosts the Toronto International Film Festival (TIFF), one of the world's major film festivals. Its waterfront, islands and parks offer relief from the busy downtown.

■ Top Attractions

- **CN Tower** – A 553-metre tower with an observation deck and the EdgeWalk.
- **Royal Ontario Museum** – Natural history and world cultures.
- **Toronto Islands** – Car-free islands with beaches and skyline views.
- **St. Lawrence Market** – A historic food market.
- **Distillery District** – Victorian industrial buildings with shops and restaurants.
- **Kensington Market** – A bohemian neighbourhood.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Downtown, the Annex, Queen West and Yorkville are popular.

■ Food & Drink

Peameal bacon sandwiches, butter tarts and diverse cuisines.

■ When to Visit

Summer and autumn are pleasant. Winters are cold.

■ Getting Around

The TTC subway, streetcars and buses; UP Express connects the airport with downtown.

■ Day Trips

Niagara Falls, Niagara-on-the-Lake wineries and Algonquin Park.

■ Practical Tips

- Use a PRESTO card or contactless payment.
- Book CN Tower tickets online.
- Bring layers.
- Visit Niagara on a weekday.

Tulum

AMERICAS

Mexico · North America (Caribbean coast)

Mayan ruins on a Caribbean cliff, cenotes and bohemian beach life.

Country	Mexico
Region	North America (Caribbean coast)
Population (approx.)	~50,000
Language(s)	Spanish (Maya also spoken; English common in tourist areas)
Currency	Mexican Peso (MXN)
Main airport	Tulum International Airport (TQO); Cancún International Airport (CUN) is about 2 hours away
Best time to visit	November–April

■ Overview

Tulum is a town on the Riviera Maya coast of Mexico's Yucatán Peninsula, famous for its Mayan ruins perched on a cliff above turquoise waters. Once a quiet backpacker destination, it has become a trendy hub for boutique hotels, wellness retreats, beach clubs and eco-chic design. The area is surrounded by jungle, cenotes (natural sinkholes) and the Sian Ka'an Biosphere Reserve. Rapid development has brought concerns about the environment, rising prices and safety, so choosing where to stay is important. A new airport and the Tren Maya railway have improved access.

■ Top Attractions

- **Tulum Archaeological Site** – A walled Mayan port city with El Castillo overlooking the Caribbean; arrive at opening time to avoid heat and crowds.
- **Cenotes** – Gran Cenote, Cenote Dos Ojos and Calavera Cenote are ideal for swimming, snorkelling and diving.
- **Sian Ka'an Biosphere Reserve** – A UNESCO-listed reserve with lagoons, mangroves and wildlife, explored by boat.
- **Playa Paraíso and Playa Ruinas** – Beautiful beaches near the ruins.
- **Cobá** – Mayan ruins in the jungle with the Nohoch Mul pyramid, best explored by bike.
- **Tulum National Park (Parque del Jaguar)** – Protected coastline with beaches and the ruins.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The Hotel Zone along the beach has boutique eco-hotels and beach clubs, but is expensive. Tulum Pueblo (town) is more affordable, with local restaurants. Aldea Zamá and La Veleta are newer residential areas.

■ Food & Drink

Tulum offers Mexican and international cuisine, from tacos al pastor in town to high-end restaurants in the jungle. Yucatecan dishes like cochinita pibil and panuchos are local specialities. Fresh seafood and ceviche are popular.

■ When to Visit

November to April is the dry season, with pleasant weather. Hurricane season runs from June to November, and sargassum seaweed can affect beaches from spring to autumn.

■ Getting Around

Bicycles are a popular way to move between the town, beach and ruins. Taxis are expensive; agree on the fare first. The Tren Maya connects Tulum with Cancún, Playa del Carmen and other Yucatán cities.

■ Day Trips

Cobá, Chichén Itzá, Valladolid and Bacalar's Lagoon of Seven Colours are popular. Akumal is known for swimming with sea turtles.

■ Practical Tips

- Bring cash in pesos; card payments sometimes carry surcharges.
- Use biodegradable sunscreen in cenotes.
- Check sargassum reports.
- Be cautious at night and follow local safety advice.

Udaipur

India · South Asia

ASIA

The romantic "City of Lakes", with palaces reflected in shimmering water.

Country	India
Region	South Asia
Population (approx.)	~600,000
Language(s)	Hindi and Mewari
Currency	Indian Rupee (INR)
Main airport	Maharana Pratap Airport (UDR)
Best time to visit	September–March

■ Overview

Udaipur, in the Indian state of Rajasthan, was founded in 1559 by Maharana Udai Singh II as the capital of the Mewar kingdom. It is set around a series of artificial lakes and surrounded by the Aravalli Hills. The city is famous for its palaces, havelis and romantic atmosphere, often called the "Venice of the East". Udaipur was a setting for the James Bond film Octopussy. It is one of India's most popular destinations for weddings.

■ Top Attractions

- **City Palace** – A vast palace complex overlooking Lake Pichola, with museums and courtyards.
- **Lake Pichola** – Boat rides with views of palaces and ghats.
- **Jag Mandir** – A palace on an island in the lake.
- **Jagdish Temple** – A large Hindu temple in the old city.
- **Saheliyon-ki-Bari** – A garden with fountains.
- **Monsoon Palace (Sajjangarh)** – A hilltop palace with sunset views.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The old city near Lake Pichola has many heritage hotels. Luxury hotels include the Taj Lake Palace.

■ Food & Drink

Rajasthani dishes such as dal baati churma and gatte ki sabzi are local favourites. Rooftop restaurants offer lake views.

■ When to Visit

September to March is ideal. Summers are hot.

■ **Getting Around**

Auto-rickshaws and taxis are common. The old city is walkable.

■ **Day Trips**

Kumbhalgarh Fort and Ranakpur Jain Temple are popular.

■ **Practical Tips**

- Book lakeside rooms in advance.
- Watch sunset from a rooftop.
- Dress modestly at temples.
- Bargain in markets.

Ulaanbaatar

Mongolia · East Asia

ASIA

The world's coldest capital and the gateway to Mongolia's vast steppe.

Country	Mongolia
Region	East Asia
Population (approx.)	~1.7 million
Language(s)	Mongolian
Currency	Mongolian Tögrög (MNT)
Main airport	Chinggis Khaan International Airport (UBN)
Best time to visit	June–August; July for the Naadam Festival

■ Overview

Ulaanbaatar, the capital of Mongolia, is home to nearly half of the country's population. Originally a mobile Buddhist monastery settlement, it moved many times before settling in the Tuul River valley in the 18th century. The city mixes Soviet-era apartment blocks, modern glass towers, Buddhist monasteries and sprawling ger (yurt) districts on the outskirts. It is often described as the coldest national capital in the world, with winter temperatures regularly below -30°C . Most travellers use Ulaanbaatar as a starting point for adventures in the Gobi Desert, the steppe and the mountains.

■ Top Attractions

- **Gandan Monastery** – Mongolia's largest and most important Buddhist monastery, with a 26-metre statue of Avalokiteshvara.
- **Sükhbaatar Square (Chinggis Square)** – The central square, with a monumental statue of Chinggis Khaan in front of the Government Palace.
- **Chinggis Khaan National Museum** – A modern museum covering Mongolian history from prehistory through the Mongol Empire.
- **Zaisan Memorial** – A Soviet-era hilltop monument with panoramic views over the city.
- **Choijin Lama Temple Museum** – A beautiful temple complex with Buddhist art and masks.
- **Bogd Khan Winter Palace** – The residence of Mongolia's last king, with a collection of royal artefacts.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Most hotels are in the city centre around Sükhbaatar Square and Peace Avenue, within walking distance of main sights. The Zaisan area in the south is quieter and more upscale. Staying in a ger camp just outside the city is a popular alternative.

■ Food & Drink

Mongolian cuisine is based on meat and dairy, reflecting nomadic traditions. Try buuz (steamed dumplings), khuushuur (fried meat pastries) and tsuivan (stir-fried noodles with meat). Airag, fermented mare's milk, is a traditional summer drink. The city also has Korean, Russian and international restaurants.

■ When to Visit

Summer (June–August) is the best time to visit, with mild temperatures and green steppe. The Naadam Festival, held around 11–15 July, features wrestling, horse racing and archery. Winters are extremely cold, and air pollution from coal heating can be severe.

■ Getting Around

Traffic congestion is heavy, and public buses are crowded, so taxis and ride-hailing apps are common. The city centre is walkable. The Trans-Mongolian Railway connects Ulaanbaatar with Beijing and Russia.

■ Day Trips

Gorkhi-Terelj National Park, about 1.5 hours away, offers rock formations, hiking, horse riding and ger stays. The giant stainless steel Chinggis Khaan Equestrian Statue at Tsonjin Boldog is on the way. Khustai National Park is home to wild Przewalski's horses.

■ Practical Tips

- Book accommodation early for Naadam.
- Carry warm layers even in summer, as nights can be cold.
- Carry cash for rural trips.
- Watch for pickpockets in crowded areas.

Ushuaia

Argentina · South America

AMERICAS

The "End of the World", gateway to Tierra del Fuego and Antarctica.

Country	Argentina
Region	South America
Population (approx.)	~80,000
Language(s)	Spanish
Currency	Argentine Peso (ARS)
Main airport	Malvinas Argentinas International Airport (USH)
Best time to visit	November–March; June–September for skiing

■ Overview

Ushuaia, the capital of Argentina's Tierra del Fuego province, is often described as the southernmost city in the world. It lies on the Beagle Channel, framed by the snow-capped Martial Mountains. Founded as a penal colony, the town now thrives on tourism, fishing and Antarctic expeditions. Ushuaia is the main departure point for cruises to Antarctica. Its wild landscapes offer hiking, sailing and wildlife.

■ Top Attractions

- **Tierra del Fuego National Park** – Forests, lakes and coastal trails at the end of the Pan-American Highway.
- **Beagle Channel cruise** – Boat trips to see sea lions, cormorants and the Les Éclaireurs Lighthouse.
- **End of the World Train (Tren del Fin del Mundo)** – A historic railway once used by prisoners.
- **Maritime and Prison Museum** – A museum in the former prison.
- **Martial Glacier** – A hike with views over the channel.
- **Laguna Esmeralda** – A popular hike to an emerald lake.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The town centre along San Martín Street is convenient. Hotels on the hillside offer views.

■ Food & Drink

King crab (centolla), Patagonian lamb and hake are local specialities.

■ When to Visit

Summer (November–March) has long days. Winter brings skiing at Cerro Castor.

■ Getting Around

Taxis and tours. The town is walkable.

■ Day Trips

Penguin colonies on Isla Martillo (Oct–March), the national park, and the Harberton ranch.

■ Practical Tips

- Weather changes fast; pack layers.
- Book Antarctic cruises early.
- Carry cash.
- Book penguin walks in advance.

Valencia

Spain · Southern Europe

EUROPE

The birthplace of paella, with futuristic architecture and long sandy beaches.

Country	Spain
Region	Southern Europe
Population (approx.)	~800,000 (city); ~1.6 million (metro)
Language(s)	Spanish and Valencian
Currency	Euro (EUR)
Main airport	Valencia Airport (VLC)
Best time to visit	March–June and September–October

■ Overview

Valencia is Spain's third-largest city, located on the Mediterranean coast. Founded by the Romans in 138 BC, it later flourished under Moorish rule and during a 15th-century golden age of trade. The city combines a charming historic centre with the futuristic City of Arts and Sciences and a huge riverbed park. Valencia is famous as the home of paella and for the spectacular Fallas festival. It offers a relaxed lifestyle, great beaches and excellent value.

■ Top Attractions

- **City of Arts and Sciences** – A futuristic complex by Santiago Calatrava and Félix Candela, including a science museum, aquarium (Oceanogràfic) and opera house.
- **Turia Gardens** – A 9-kilometre park built in a former riverbed, ideal for walking and cycling.
- **Valencia Cathedral and the Holy Grail** – The cathedral holds a chalice venerated as the Holy Grail, and its Miguelete tower offers views.
- **Central Market** – One of the largest fresh-food markets in Europe, housed in a modernist building.
- **La Lonja de la Seda** – A Gothic silk exchange and UNESCO World Heritage Site.
- **Malvarrosa Beach** – A long sandy beach with seafront restaurants.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

El Carmen is the historic heart, full of street art and bars. Ruzafa is trendy, with cafés and restaurants, and El Cabanyal is a former fishing village near the beach with colourful tiled houses. The Ciutat Vella is convenient for first-time visitors.

■ Food & Drink

Paella valenciana is traditionally made with chicken, rabbit and beans, while seafood versions are also popular; it is eaten at lunchtime. Horchata, a sweet drink made from tiger nuts, is served with fartons (long pastries). Agua de Valencia is a cocktail of cava and orange juice. Arroz a banda and fideuà are other rice and noodle dishes.

■ When to Visit

Spring and autumn are pleasant. Fallas, held in mid-March, features giant satirical sculptures that are burned on the final night. Summer is hot and humid but perfect for the beach.

■ Getting Around

Valencia has a metro and tram network, and the airport is linked by metro. The city is flat and bike-friendly, with the Valenbisi bike-share. High-speed trains reach Madrid in under two hours.

■ Day Trips

Albufera Natural Park, a lagoon surrounded by rice fields, is the birthplace of paella and offers sunset boat rides. Sagunto has a Roman theatre and castle. Xàtiva and Peñíscola are also popular.

■ Practical Tips

- Book accommodation early for Fallas.
- Eat paella at lunchtime, as locals do.
- Rent a bike to explore the Turia Gardens.
- The Valencia Tourist Card includes public transport and discounts.

Valletta

Malta · Southern Europe

EUROPE

A tiny, fortified baroque capital on the Mediterranean.

Country	Malta
Region	Southern Europe
Population (approx.)	~6,000 (city); ~480,000 (Malta's urban area)
Language(s)	Maltese and English
Currency	Euro (EUR)
Main airport	Malta International Airport (MLA)
Best time to visit	April-June and September-October

■ Overview

Valletta, the capital of Malta, is one of Europe's smallest capitals, built by the Knights of St. John after the Great Siege of 1565. The entire city is a UNESCO World Heritage Site, filled with baroque churches, palaces and fortifications. Valletta overlooks the Grand Harbour, one of the most beautiful natural harbours in the Mediterranean. Malta's long history includes prehistoric temples, Roman, Arab, Norman and British rule. English is an official language, making it easy for visitors.

■ Top Attractions

- **St. John's Co-Cathedral** – A lavish baroque interior with Caravaggio's The Beheading of Saint John the Baptist.
- **Upper Barrakka Gardens** – Gardens with views over the Grand Harbour and a daily noon gun salute.
- **Grandmaster's Palace** – The former seat of the Knights, now the office of the President, with armoury and state rooms.
- **Fort St. Elmo and National War Museum** – A star-shaped fort covering Malta's military history.
- **Three Cities** – Birgu, Senglea and Cospicua across the harbour, reached by traditional dghajsa boats or ferry.
- **Hypogeum of Hal Saflieni** – A prehistoric underground burial complex; tickets are limited and must be booked well ahead.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Staying in Valletta is atmospheric and quiet in the evenings. Sliema and St. Julian's offer more hotels, restaurants and nightlife, connected by ferry. The Three Cities are charming and less touristy.

■ Food & Drink

Maltese cuisine includes pastizzi (flaky pastries with ricotta or peas), rabbit stew (stuffat tal-fenek) and ftira (a stuffed flatbread). Kinnie is a local bitter-orange soft drink. Seafood is excellent, and Cisk is the local beer.

■ When to Visit

Spring and autumn are ideal. Summers are hot and busy, with festas (village feasts) and fireworks. Winters are mild, making Malta a year-round destination.

■ Getting Around

Valletta is walkable, and buses connect the capital with the rest of Malta. Ferries link Valletta with Sliema and the Three Cities. The Barrakka Lift connects the waterfront with the city.

■ Day Trips

Mdina, the "Silent City", is a medieval walled town in the centre of the island. Gozo, Malta's sister island, is reached by ferry. The Blue Lagoon on Comino is famous for turquoise water.

■ Practical Tips

- Book the Hypogeum weeks or months in advance.
- Traffic drives on the left.
- Wear comfortable shoes; Valletta has many steps.
- Dress modestly in churches.

Valparaíso

Chile · South America

AMERICAS

A bohemian port city of colourful hillside houses, funiculars and street art.

Country	Chile
Region	South America
Population (approx.)	~300,000 (city); ~1 million (Greater Valparaíso)
Language(s)	Spanish
Currency	Chilean Peso (CLP)
Main airport	Arturo Merino Benítez International Airport (SCL) in Santiago, about 1.5 hours away
Best time to visit	October–April

■ Overview

Valparaíso, on Chile's Pacific coast, was the most important port in South America in the 19th century, before the Panama Canal opened. Its historic quarter, built on 42 hills overlooking the bay, is a UNESCO World Heritage Site. The city is famous for its maze of colourful houses, steep stairways and historic funiculars (ascensores). Valparaíso is a creative, bohemian city with street art everywhere. It was home to poet Pablo Neruda.

■ Top Attractions

- **Cerro Alegre and Cerro Concepción** – Colourful hills with street art, cafés and boutique hotels.
- **Ascensores** – Historic funiculars such as Ascensor Reina Victoria.
- **La Sebastiana** – Pablo Neruda's house with views.
- **Street art tours** – Guided walks through the murals covering the city's hills.
- **Plaza Sotomayor and the port** – The historic main square near the harbour, with the Chilean Navy headquarters and boat tours of the bay.
- **Paseo Gervasoni and Paseo Atkinson** – Viewpoints.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Cerro Alegre and Cerro Concepción.

■ Food & Drink

Seafood, chorrillana (fries with meat and eggs) and empanadas.

■ When to Visit

Spring and summer. New Year's Eve fireworks are famous.

■ Getting Around

Walking, funiculars and trolleybuses.

■ Day Trips

Viña del Mar, Casablanca Valley wineries.

■ Practical Tips

- Watch belongings.
- Wear good shoes.
- Book New Year's early.
- Take a street art tour.

Vancouver

AMERICAS

Canada (British Columbia) · North America

A spectacular city between mountains and sea, perfect for outdoor lovers.

Country	Canada (British Columbia)
Region	North America
Population (approx.)	~700,000 (city); ~2.8 million (metro)
Language(s)	English
Currency	Canadian Dollar (CAD)
Main airport	Vancouver International Airport (YVR)
Best time to visit	June–September; December–March for skiing

■ Overview

Vancouver, on Canada's Pacific coast, is surrounded by mountains, forests and ocean, consistently ranking among the world's most liveable cities. It is a young city, founded in 1886 as the terminus of the Canadian Pacific Railway, built on the traditional territories of the Musqueam, Squamish and Tsleil-Waututh Nations. Vancouver is known for its outdoor lifestyle: you can ski in the morning and kayak in the afternoon. The city has a large Asian community and an excellent food scene. It hosted the 2010 Winter Olympics and is a host city of the 2026 FIFA World Cup.

■ Top Attractions

- **Stanley Park** – A 400-hectare park with the seawall, totem poles and forest trails.
- **Granville Island** – A public market, artisan shops and theatres.
- **Capilano Suspension Bridge** – A swaying bridge over a canyon in North Vancouver.
- **Grouse Mountain** – Skiing in winter and hiking (the Grouse Grind) in summer.
- **Gastown** – The historic district with the steam clock.
- **Vancouver Aquarium and Museum of Anthropology** – A leading aquarium in Stanley Park and a renowned museum of First Nations art at the University of British Columbia.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Downtown, Yaletown, Kitsilano and Gastown are popular.

■ Food & Drink

Pacific salmon, sushi (the California roll was popularised here), dim sum in Richmond and food trucks.

■ When to Visit

Summer is dry and sunny. Winters are rainy but mild, with skiing nearby.

■ **Getting Around**

The SkyTrain connects the airport with downtown. SeaBus and buses are useful.

■ **Day Trips**

Whistler, the Sea-to-Sky Highway, Victoria on Vancouver Island and Squamish.

■ **Practical Tips**

- Bring rain gear from October to April.
- Use a Compass card or contactless payment.
- Book Whistler early.
- Respect Indigenous heritage.

Varanasi

India · South Asia

ASIA

India's holiest city, where life and death unfold on the ghats of the Ganges.

Country	India
Region	South Asia
Population (approx.)	~1.5 million (metro)
Language(s)	Hindi
Currency	Indian Rupee (INR)
Main airport	Lal Bahadur Shastri International Airport (VNS)
Best time to visit	October–March

■ Overview

Varanasi, also known as Benares or Kashi, is one of the oldest continuously inhabited cities in the world and the spiritual capital of Hinduism. Located on the banks of the Ganges River in Uttar Pradesh, it attracts pilgrims who come to bathe in the sacred waters and seek liberation (moksha). Dying and being cremated in Varanasi is believed to break the cycle of rebirth. The city's ghats, riverside steps, are the stage for rituals, cremations and daily life. Varanasi is intense, spiritual and unforgettable.

■ Top Attractions

- **Dashashwamedh Ghat** – The main ghat, where the spectacular Ganga Aarti ceremony takes place every evening with fire, bells and chanting.
- **Manikarnika Ghat** – The main cremation ghat, where funeral pyres burn day and night; photography is not appropriate.
- **Sunrise boat ride on the Ganges** – The best way to see the ghats come to life at dawn.
- **Kashi Vishwanath Temple** – One of the most sacred Shiva temples, with a new corridor linking it to the river.
- **Sarnath** – The place where the Buddha gave his first sermon, just outside the city.
- **Old city lanes** – A maze of narrow alleys with shrines, shops, cows and sweet stalls.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Guesthouses along the ghats offer river views and atmosphere. Assi Ghat is a more relaxed area popular with long-term travellers. Cantonment has larger hotels.

■ Food & Drink

Varanasi is famous for its street food: kachori sabzi for breakfast, tamatar chaat, and malaiyo, a frothy winter dessert. Banarasi paan (betel leaf) is legendary, and lassi is served in clay cups. Food is mostly vegetarian, especially near temples.

■ When to Visit

October to March is the best time. Dev Deepawali, in November, sees the ghats lit with thousands of lamps. Summers are extremely hot, and the monsoon floods the ghats.

■ Getting Around

Cycle-rickshaws and auto-rickshaws are common. The old city is best explored on foot. Boats travel along the ghats.

■ Day Trips

Sarnath is close by. Bodh Gaya, where the Buddha attained enlightenment, is a longer trip.

■ Practical Tips

- Be respectful at cremation ghats and do not take photos.
- Beware of touts offering "free" tours.
- Dress modestly.
- Take a boat ride at sunrise.

Venice

Italy · Southern Europe

EUROPE

A unique floating city of canals, palaces and gondolas.

Country	Italy
Region	Southern Europe
Population (approx.)	~250,000 (municipality); ~50,000 in the historic centre
Language(s)	Italian (Venetian dialect)
Currency	Euro (EUR)
Main airport	Venice Marco Polo Airport (VCE); Treviso Airport (TSF)
Best time to visit	April–June and September–November

■ Overview

Venice is built on more than 100 small islands in a lagoon in northeastern Italy, connected by bridges and canals instead of roads. It was the capital of the powerful Republic of Venice for over a thousand years, a maritime empire that dominated trade between Europe and the East. The city is a UNESCO World Heritage Site and one of the most beautiful places in the world. Venice faces challenges from over-tourism and rising water levels. Staying overnight and exploring quieter areas makes a visit much more rewarding.

■ Top Attractions

- **St. Mark's Basilica and Square** – The heart of Venice, with a golden Byzantine basilica and the Campanile.
- **Doge's Palace** – The former seat of Venetian government, with the Bridge of Sighs leading to the prisons.
- **Grand Canal** – The main waterway, best seen from a vaporetto (water bus) or gondola.
- **Rialto Bridge and Market** – A famous bridge and a lively fish and produce market.
- **Gallerie dell'Accademia and Peggy Guggenheim Collection** – Venetian masterpieces and modern art.
- **Murano and Burano** – Islands known for glassmaking and colourful houses with lace-making traditions.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

San Marco is central but crowded. Dorsoduro is artistic, with museums and a student atmosphere, and Cannaregio is residential, with the Jewish Ghetto and lively canalside bars. Castello is quieter and authentic.

■ Food & Drink

Venetian cuisine includes *sarde in saor* (sweet-and-sour sardines), *risotto al nero di seppia* and *fegato alla veneziana* (liver with onions). *Cicchetti*, small snacks served in *bàcari* (wine bars), are best enjoyed with an *ombra* (small glass of wine). The Spritz is said to have originated in the Veneto region. Tiramisu also comes from the Veneto.

■ When to Visit

Spring and autumn are ideal, though still busy. The Carnival of Venice, with masks and costumes, takes place before Lent. The *acqua alta* (high water) floods occur mostly in late autumn and winter, though the MOSE barrier now protects the city in major events.

■ Getting Around

There are no cars; transport is by foot, *vaporetto* or water taxi. Buses and *Alilaguna* boats connect the airport with the city. Walking is the best way to explore, but expect to get lost.

■ Day Trips

The islands of Murano, Burano and Torcello are easy by *vaporetto*. Padua and Verona are close by train. The Prosecco hills and Lido beaches are also popular.

■ Practical Tips

- Venice charges an access fee for day-trippers on peak days; check the official rules before visiting.
- Book St. Mark's Basilica and Doge's Palace in advance.
- Buy a multi-day *vaporetto* pass if you plan to use boats often.
- Avoid restaurants with touts and menus in many languages.

Vienna

Austria · Central Europe

EUROPE

An imperial capital of music, coffeehouses and grand palaces.

Country	Austria
Region	Central Europe
Population (approx.)	~2 million (city); ~2.9 million (metro)
Language(s)	German
Currency	Euro (EUR)
Main airport	Vienna International Airport (VIE)
Best time to visit	April–June and September–October; December for Christmas markets

■ Overview

Vienna, the capital of Austria, was the centre of the Habsburg Empire for centuries and remains one of Europe's most elegant cities. It is famous for classical music, having been home to Mozart, Beethoven, Haydn, Schubert and Strauss. The city's historic centre is a UNESCO World Heritage Site, with the Ringstrasse lined with palaces, museums and parks. Vienna regularly tops global rankings for quality of life. Its coffeehouse culture is recognised by UNESCO as intangible heritage.

■ Top Attractions

- **Schönbrunn Palace** – The Habsburg summer residence, with lavish rooms, gardens and the world's oldest zoo.
- **Hofburg Palace** – The former imperial palace, housing the Sisi Museum, Imperial Apartments and the Spanish Riding School.
- **St. Stephen's Cathedral** – A Gothic cathedral with a colourful tiled roof in the city centre.
- **Belvedere Palace** – Baroque palaces with Klimt's *The Kiss*.
- **Kunsthistorisches Museum** – One of the world's great art museums, with works by Bruegel, Vermeer and Rubens.
- **Vienna State Opera** – One of the world's leading opera houses; cheap standing tickets are available.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The Innere Stadt (1st district) is central and historic. Neubau (7th) and Mariahilf (6th) are trendy, with shops and cafés. Leopoldstadt (2nd) includes the Prater park, and Wieden (4th) is near the Naschmarkt.

■ Food & Drink

Vienna's classics include Wiener Schnitzel, Tafelspitz (boiled beef), Sachertorte and apple strudel. Coffeehouses like Café Central, Café Sacher and Café Sperl are institutions. Heurigen, wine taverns on the city's outskirts, serve local wine. The Naschmarkt is a popular food market.

■ When to Visit

Spring and autumn are pleasant. Summer brings outdoor concerts and festivals, while the ball season peaks in January and February. Christmas markets in December are among Europe's best.

■ Getting Around

Vienna has an excellent U-Bahn, tram and bus network. The City Airport Train (CAT) and S-Bahn connect the airport with the centre. The city is walkable and bike-friendly.

■ Day Trips

The Wachau Valley, with vineyards and the Melk Abbey, is a scenic trip. Bratislava is an hour away by train or boat. Salzburg and Budapest are reachable by train.

■ Practical Tips

- Buy standing tickets for the State Opera on the day of the performance.
- Book the Spanish Riding School in advance.
- The Vienna City Card offers transport and discounts.
- Many shops are closed on Sundays.

Vilnius

Lithuania · Northern Europe

EUROPE

A baroque old town with a bohemian spirit and a self-declared republic of artists.

Country	Lithuania
Region	Northern Europe
Population (approx.)	~600,000
Language(s)	Lithuanian
Currency	Euro (EUR)
Main airport	Vilnius International Airport (VNO)
Best time to visit	May–September

■ Overview

Vilnius, the capital of Lithuania, has one of the largest surviving medieval old towns in Northern Europe, a UNESCO World Heritage Site. It was the capital of the Grand Duchy of Lithuania, once one of the largest states in Europe. The city has a rich Jewish heritage and was known as the "Jerusalem of the North". Vilnius has a creative, youthful vibe and affordable prices. The quirky Užupis district has declared itself an independent republic with its own constitution.

■ Top Attractions

- **Old Town** – Baroque churches, cobbled streets and courtyards.
- **Gediminas Tower** – A hilltop tower with views over the city.
- **Vilnius Cathedral and Palace of the Grand Dukes** – Symbols of Lithuanian statehood.
- **Užupis** – An artists' district with a constitution displayed on a wall in many languages.
- **Gate of Dawn** – A city gate with a chapel housing a revered icon of the Virgin Mary.
- **Museum of Occupations and Freedom Fights** – Located in the former KGB headquarters.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The Old Town is central and charming. Užupis is bohemian, and Naujamiestis is a revitalised area with cafés. Žvėrynas is a green neighbourhood with wooden houses.

■ Food & Drink

Lithuanian cuisine includes cepelinai (potato dumplings stuffed with meat), šaltibarščiai (cold pink beetroot soup) and kibinai (pastries). Rye bread and local beer are staples. Šakotis, a tree-shaped cake, is traditional for celebrations.

■ When to Visit

Summer is ideal, with festivals and outdoor cafés. Winter is cold and snowy, with Christmas markets. Spring and autumn are cooler.

■ Getting Around

Vilnius is walkable, with buses and trolleybuses for longer distances. A train and buses connect the airport with the centre. Trains reach Kaunas in about an hour.

■ Day Trips

Trakai Island Castle, on a lake, is 30 minutes away. Kaunas, Lithuania's second city, has interwar modernist architecture. The Hill of Crosses near Šiauliai is a unique pilgrimage site.

■ Practical Tips

- Vilnius is compact; two days cover the main sights.
- Try cepelinai at a traditional restaurant.
- Card payments are widely accepted.
- Check out the Užupis constitution in your own language.

Warsaw

Poland · Central Europe

EUROPE

A resilient capital rebuilt from ruins into a dynamic modern city.

Country	Poland
Region	Central Europe
Population (approx.)	~1.8 million (city); ~3.1 million (metro)
Language(s)	Polish
Currency	Polish Złoty (PLN)
Main airport	Warsaw Chopin Airport (WAW); Warsaw Modlin Airport (WMI)
Best time to visit	May–September

■ Overview

Warsaw, the capital of Poland, was almost completely destroyed during the Second World War, especially after the Warsaw Uprising in 1944. Its Old Town was meticulously rebuilt using paintings and records and is now a UNESCO World Heritage Site. Today Warsaw is a dynamic, fast-growing city with skyscrapers, green parks and a thriving food and culture scene. It was the birthplace of Frédéric Chopin and Marie Curie. The city offers excellent museums that tell the story of Poland's turbulent history.

■ Top Attractions

- **Old Town and Royal Castle** – The rebuilt historic centre with the Royal Castle and Market Square.
- **Warsaw Uprising Museum** – An immersive museum about the 1944 uprising against Nazi occupation.
- **POLIN Museum of the History of Polish Jews** – An award-winning museum covering 1,000 years of Jewish history in Poland.
- **Łazienki Park** – A royal park with the Palace on the Isle and free Chopin concerts in summer.
- **Palace of Culture and Science** – A Stalinist skyscraper with a viewing terrace.
- **Wilanów Palace** – A baroque royal residence often called the "Polish Versailles".

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Śródmieście (city centre) is convenient. The Old Town is charming, while Praga across the Vistula River is gritty and creative. Powiśle is trendy, with cafés and riverside bars.

■ Food & Drink

Polish classics include pierogi, żurek, bigos and pączki (doughnuts). Milk bars (bar mleczny) offer cheap traditional meals. Warsaw has a growing fine dining and vegan scene. Vodka is traditional, and craft beer is popular.

■ When to Visit

Summer is ideal, with outdoor concerts and riverside life. Winter is cold, with Christmas markets. Spring and autumn are mild.

■ Getting Around

Warsaw has a metro, trams and buses. Trains connect Chopin Airport with the centre. The city is spread out, but central areas are walkable.

■ Day Trips

Żelazowa Wola, Chopin's birthplace, is about an hour away. Kampinos National Park offers forests and dunes. Łódź, with its industrial heritage, is about 1.5 hours by train.

■ Practical Tips

- Many museums are free one day a week.
- Use ride-hailing apps for taxis.
- Book the Uprising Museum in advance in summer.
- Card payments are accepted almost everywhere.

Washington, D.C.

AMERICAS

United States (District of Columbia) · North America

The US capital of monuments, free museums and political power.

Country	United States (District of Columbia)
Region	North America
Population (approx.)	~700,000 (city); ~6.3 million (metro)
Language(s)	English
Currency	US Dollar (USD)
Main airport	Ronald Reagan Washington National (DCA); Washington Dulles (IAD); Baltimore/Washington (BWI)
Best time to visit	March–May and September–November

■ Overview

Washington, D.C., the capital of the United States, was founded in 1790 on land along the Potomac River. Planned by Pierre L'Enfant, it features wide avenues, grand monuments and the National Mall. The city is home to the White House, the US Capitol and the Supreme Court. The Smithsonian Institution operates many free world-class museums. Beyond politics, D.C. has diverse neighbourhoods and a thriving food scene.

■ Top Attractions

- **National Mall** – Lincoln Memorial, Washington Monument and war memorials.
- **US Capitol** – Tours of the seat of Congress.
- **Smithsonian museums** – Including Air and Space, Natural History and the National Museum of African American History and Culture.
- **White House** – Exterior views; tours by request.
- **Library of Congress** – A beautiful library.
- **Arlington National Cemetery** – The resting place of over 400,000 service members, with the Tomb of the Unknown Soldier and John F. Kennedy's grave.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Georgetown, Dupont Circle, Capitol Hill and Adams Morgan.

■ Food & Drink

Half-smoke sausages, Ethiopian cuisine and diverse restaurants.

■ When to Visit

Cherry blossoms in spring (late March–early April). Summers are hot and humid.

■ Getting Around

The Metro is efficient. Walking and bike-share on the Mall.

■ Day Trips

Mount Vernon, Annapolis and Shenandoah National Park.

■ Practical Tips

- Museums are free.
- Book Capitol tours online.
- Visit monuments at night.
- Check for events and closures.

Wrocław

Poland · Central Europe

EUROPE

A city of islands, bridges and hundreds of tiny bronze dwarfs.

Country	Poland
Region	Central Europe
Population (approx.)	~670,000
Language(s)	Polish
Currency	Polish Złoty (PLN)
Main airport	Wrocław Copernicus Airport (WRO)
Best time to visit	May–September; December for the Christmas market

■ Overview

Wrocław is the historic capital of Silesia in western Poland, built on the Oder River and spread across 12 islands connected by over 100 bridges. It has belonged to Bohemia, the Habsburgs, Prussia and Germany (as Breslau) before becoming Polish after 1945. The city has a beautiful market square and a lively student population. Wrocław is famous for its hundreds of small bronze dwarf statues hidden around the city. It is one of Poland's most attractive and liveable cities.

■ Top Attractions

- **Market Square (Rynek)** – One of the largest market squares in Europe, with the Gothic Old Town Hall.
- **Ostrów Tumski (Cathedral Island)** – The oldest part of the city, with the cathedral and gas lamps lit by hand every evening.
- **Wrocław dwarfs** – More than 600 bronze dwarf statues scattered throughout the city.
- **Panorama of Raclawice** – A huge 19th-century panoramic painting of a 1794 battle.
- **Centennial Hall** – A UNESCO-listed reinforced concrete structure, with a multimedia fountain nearby.
- **University of Wrocław** – The baroque Aula Leopoldina and Mathematical Tower.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The Old Town is central and lively. Nadodrze is a revitalised area with street art and cafés, and Ołbin is a student district. The riverside areas are pleasant for walks.

■ Food & Drink

Polish cuisine is widely available, and the market square has many restaurants. Wrocław has an excellent craft beer scene. Pierogi, żurek and local specialities are served in traditional restaurants. Hala Targowa is a historic market hall.

■ When to Visit

Summer is lively with outdoor events. Winter brings one of Poland's best Christmas markets. Spring and autumn are pleasant.

■ Getting Around

Wrocław is walkable, with trams and buses. The airport is connected by bus. Trains reach Kraków, Warsaw, Berlin and Prague.

■ Day Trips

Książ Castle, one of the largest castles in Poland, is about an hour away. The Churches of Peace in Świdnica and Jawor are UNESCO sites. The Karkonosze Mountains offer hiking and skiing.

■ Practical Tips

- Collect dwarf photos using a map from the tourist office.
- Book the Panorama of Racławice in advance.
- Try local craft beers.
- Many restaurants in the Rynek are pricier.

Xi'an

China · East Asia

ASIA

An ancient capital and the start of the Silk Road, home to the Terracotta Army.

Country	China
Region	East Asia
Population (approx.)	~13 million (municipality)
Language(s)	Mandarin Chinese
Currency	Chinese Yuan Renminbi (CNY)
Main airport	Xi'an Xianyang International Airport (XIY)
Best time to visit	March–May and September–November

■ Overview

Xi'an, the capital of Shaanxi Province, was the capital of 13 Chinese dynasties, including the Qin, Han and Tang. As Chang'an, it was the eastern starting point of the Silk Road and one of the largest cities in the world. The city is famous for the Terracotta Army, discovered by farmers in 1974. Xi'an's well-preserved city walls, Muslim Quarter and pagodas make it a fascinating destination. It is a key stop on any China itinerary.

■ Top Attractions

- **Terracotta Army** – Thousands of life-size clay soldiers guarding the tomb of Emperor Qin Shi Huang.
- **City Wall** – The best-preserved ancient city wall in China; rent a bike to ride along the top.
- **Muslim Quarter** – A lively area of food stalls, the Great Mosque and shops.
- **Big Wild Goose Pagoda** – A Tang dynasty pagoda built to house Buddhist scriptures.
- **Bell Tower and Drum Tower** – Landmarks in the centre of the old city.
- **Shaanxi History Museum** – A museum with treasures from Chinese dynasties.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Staying inside the city walls is convenient. The area around the Big Wild Goose Pagoda is lively at night.

■ Food & Drink

Xi'an is known for roujiamo (Chinese "burger"), biangbiang noodles, yangrou paomo (lamb soup with bread) and liangpi (cold noodles). The Muslim Quarter is the best place to try street food.

■ **When to Visit**

Spring and autumn are ideal. Summers are hot, and winters are cold.

■ **Getting Around**

Xi'an has a metro, including a line towards the Terracotta Army area. High-speed trains connect with Beijing and other cities.

■ **Day Trips**

Mount Huashan, known for its dramatic cliffside trails, is reachable by high-speed train. Huaqing Palace is near the Terracotta Army.

■ **Practical Tips**

- Book Terracotta Army tickets in advance with your passport.
- Hire a guide at the site.
- Rent a bike on the city wall.
- Avoid national holidays.

Yerevan

Armenia · Caucasus

ASIA

The "Pink City" of volcanic stone, café culture and views of Mount Ararat.

Country	Armenia
Region	Caucasus
Population (approx.)	~1.1 million
Language(s)	Armenian (Russian widely spoken)
Currency	Armenian Dram (AMD)
Main airport	Zvartnots International Airport (EVN)
Best time to visit	May-June and September-October

■ Overview

Yerevan, the capital of Armenia, is one of the world's oldest continuously inhabited cities, founded as the fortress of Erebuni in 782 BC. Much of the city was rebuilt in the 20th century using pink volcanic tuff stone, giving it the nickname "Pink City". Yerevan has a lively café culture, excellent museums and warm hospitality. On clear days, Mount Ararat, a national symbol, towers over the city. Armenia was the first country to adopt Christianity as a state religion, in 301 AD.

■ Top Attractions

- **Cascade Complex** – A giant limestone stairway with art, the Cafesjian Center and views of Ararat.
- **Republic Square** – The central square with fountains that dance to music in the evening.
- **Matenadaran** – A museum of ancient manuscripts.
- **Armenian Genocide Memorial and Museum (Tsitsernakaberd)** – A memorial to the victims of 1915.
- **Vernissage Market** – An open-air market for crafts and souvenirs.
- **Erebuni Fortress** – Ruins of the Urartian fortress.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The Kentron district is central and walkable.

■ Food & Drink

Armenian cuisine includes khorovats (barbecue), dolma, lavash bread (UNESCO heritage) and ghapama (stuffed pumpkin). Armenian brandy (cognac) and wine are famous.

■ When to Visit

Spring and autumn are best. Summers are hot, and winters are cold.

■ **Getting Around**

Taxis via apps like Yandex Go and GG are cheap. The metro is limited.

■ **Day Trips**

Garni Temple, Geghard Monastery, Khor Virap and Lake Sevan are popular.

■ **Practical Tips**

- Many nationalities enter visa-free.
- Visit the Cascade at sunset.
- Try Armenian brandy.
- Dress modestly at churches.

Yogyakarta

Indonesia · Southeast Asia

ASIA

Java's cultural heart and the gateway to Borobudur and Prambanan.

Country	Indonesia
Region	Southeast Asia
Population (approx.)	~420,000 (city); ~4 million (special region)
Language(s)	Indonesian and Javanese
Currency	Indonesian Rupiah (IDR)
Main airport	Yogyakarta International Airport (YIA)
Best time to visit	April–October

■ Overview

Yogyakarta, often called Jogja, is the cultural capital of Java and the only Indonesian region still ruled by a sultan. It is a centre for Javanese arts, including batik, gamelan music, shadow puppetry (wayang kulit) and classical dance. The city is also a university town with a young population. Yogyakarta is the base for visiting Borobudur, the world's largest Buddhist temple, and Prambanan, a magnificent Hindu temple complex. It is affordable and friendly.

■ Top Attractions

- **Borobudur** – A 9th-century Buddhist temple with hundreds of stupas and relief panels; climbing access is limited.
- **Prambanan** – A 9th-century Hindu temple complex with tall spires, with Ramayana ballet performances.
- **Kraton** – The Sultan's Palace, with cultural performances.
- **Taman Sari** – The Water Castle, a former royal garden.
- **Malioboro Street** – A shopping street with batik and street food.
- **Mount Merapi** – An active volcano with jeep tours.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

Malioboro and Prawirotaman are popular areas.

■ Food & Drink

Gudeg, jackfruit stew, is the local speciality. Angkringan street stalls serve cheap snacks and coffee.

■ When to Visit

The dry season (April–October) is best.

■ **Getting Around**

Becaks (pedicabs), taxis and ride-hailing apps are common.

■ **Day Trips**

Borobudur, Prambanan and Merapi are essential.

■ **Practical Tips**

- Book Borobudur tickets in advance.
- Dress modestly.
- Bargain in markets.
- Carry cash.

Zagreb

Croatia · Southeastern Europe

EUROPE

A relaxed Central European capital of cafés, museums and award-winning Advent markets.

Country	Croatia
Region	Southeastern Europe
Population (approx.)	~770,000
Language(s)	Croatian
Currency	Euro (EUR)
Main airport	Franjo Tuđman Airport (ZAG)
Best time to visit	May–September; December for Advent

■ Overview

Zagreb, the capital of Croatia, is often overlooked in favour of the coast, but it rewards visitors with a charming mix of Austro-Hungarian architecture, café culture and quirky museums. The city has a medieval Upper Town (Gornji Grad) and a 19th-century Lower Town (Donji Grad). Zagreb is compact, green and friendly. Its Advent Christmas market has won awards as one of Europe's best. The city is a good base for exploring Plitvice Lakes and northern Croatia.

■ Top Attractions

- **Upper Town** – Medieval streets with St. Mark's Church, known for its colourful tiled roof.
- **Museum of Broken Relationships** – A unique museum displaying objects from failed relationships.
- **Zagreb Cathedral** – A Gothic cathedral with twin spires, undergoing restoration after the 2020 earthquake.
- **Dolac Market** – A lively market with red umbrellas selling fresh produce.
- **Lotrščak Tower** – A tower from which a cannon is fired every day at noon.
- **Mirogoj Cemetery** – A beautiful cemetery with arcades and domes.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The Lower Town is central and elegant. The Upper Town is historic and quiet. Tkalčićeva Street is lively with bars and cafés.

■ Food & Drink

Croatian cuisine in Zagreb includes štrukli (cheese-filled pastry), purica s mlincima (turkey with pasta) and kremšnita (cream cake). Coffee culture is strong. Local wines and craft beers are popular.

■ When to Visit

Spring and summer are pleasant. December brings the Advent market. Winters are cold.

■ Getting Around

Zagreb has an extensive tram network. The Upper Town can be reached by the funicular, one of the shortest in the world. Buses connect the airport with the city.

■ Day Trips

Plitvice Lakes National Park, with cascading lakes and waterfalls, is about two hours away. Samobor is a charming town known for cream cakes. Varaždin is a baroque town north of Zagreb.

■ Practical Tips

- Book Plitvice tickets in advance in summer.
- Enjoy coffee on terraces, a key part of local life.
- The Zagreb Card offers transport and discounts.
- Wear comfortable shoes for the Upper Town.

Zurich

Switzerland · Western Europe

EUROPE

A wealthy lakeside city of banks, art and Alpine views.

Country	Switzerland
Region	Western Europe
Population (approx.)	~440,000 (city); ~1.5 million (metro)
Language(s)	German (Swiss German)
Currency	Swiss Franc (CHF)
Main airport	Zurich Airport (ZRH)
Best time to visit	May–September; December–March for skiing trips

■ Overview

Zurich is Switzerland's largest city and financial centre, located on Lake Zurich with the Alps on the horizon. It combines a medieval old town with modern culture, art and nightlife. The city is famous for banking, watchmaking and a very high quality of life. Zurich was the birthplace of the Dada art movement and has many museums and galleries. It is expensive but clean, safe and efficient.

■ Top Attractions

- **Old Town (Altstadt)** – Medieval streets on both sides of the Limmat River.
- **Grossmünster and Fraumünster** – The Grossmünster's twin towers and the Fraumünster's Chagall stained-glass windows.
- **Bahnhofstrasse** – One of the world's most exclusive shopping streets.
- **Lake Zurich** – Boat cruises, swimming and lakeside promenades.
- **Kunsthaus Zürich** – An art museum with works by Swiss and international artists.
- **Uetliberg** – Zurich's local mountain with views over the city, lake and Alps.

■ Neighbourhoods & Where to Stay

The Old Town is central and charming. Zurich West is a former industrial area with bars and clubs. Seefeld is upscale and close to the lake.

■ Food & Drink

Zürcher Geschnetzeltes (sliced veal in cream sauce) with rösti is the local speciality. Cheese fondue and raclette are popular. Swiss chocolate from Sprüngli and Läderach is famous. Eating out is expensive.

■ When to Visit

Summer is ideal for lake swimming and outdoor events. Winter brings Christmas markets and easy access to skiing. Street Parade in August is a massive techno festival.

■ Getting Around

Zurich has an excellent tram and bus network. Trains reach the airport in about 10 minutes. The Swiss Travel Pass covers transport.

■ Day Trips

Lucerne and Mount Pilatus, Rhine Falls, and the Alpine resorts are popular. The mountain Rigi offers views. Appenzell is a traditional village.

■ Practical Tips

- Tap water is excellent, and fountains are safe.
- The Zurich Card includes transport and discounts.
- Expect high prices.
- Shops are closed on Sundays.

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